In So Many Ways (In So Many Worlds)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/59380588.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
Multi

Fandoms:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018), Five Nights at Freddy's, Spider-Man - All Media Types, Lunar Chronicles - Marissa Meyer, Pokemon Mystery Dungeon, Avatar: The Last Airbender (Cartoon 2005), The Owl House (Cartoon), Persona 5

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Kyle/Rogelio (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Melog (She-Ra), Swift Wind | Spirit, Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Rogelio (She-Ra), Tallstar (She-Ra), Jewelstar (She-Ra), Starla (She-Ra), Glory (She-Ra), He-Man | Adam, Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
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In So Many Ways (In So Many Worlds)

by BluefireBlaze

Summary

Thirty-one days,

thirty-one universes,

thirty-one snippets of the same lives led in not quite the same ways.

OR

My drawing tablet broke so now I'm gonna write a bunch of different stories either making these guys suffer, have a good time, or something in the middle

Notes

REAL QUICK IF YOU'RE CURIOUS ABOUT ETHERIAN EFFLUX IT'S NOT DEAD I SWEAR
I've gotten a little stuck on trying to figure out how to proceed, and between that and being exhausted from work I haven't gotten all that much further, but more chapters ARE coming, I promise

With that said, please enjoy the first short story!

See the end of the work for more notes

College - Dormmates

At twenty years old, Catra knew for certainty that there were five things she'd be permanently stuck with for the rest of her life. The first three things she'd reluctantly come to accept in the past few years, but the latter two… yeah those would take her some getting used to.

What handful of things was she saddled with, you ask?

1- Trauma and everything that came with it. Nightmares, crippling anxiety, even more crippling PTSD, the whole shebang. Absolutely lovely parting gifts from the horrifically wonderful wonderfully horrific childhood spent with her beloved foster mother.
2- Scars leftover from said trauma and said mother. Honestly, this probably fit under the aforementioned "whole shebang" but whatever, she had enough of 'em on her they deserved their own category.
3- The world's clingiest emotional support therapy cat. Like seriously, she thought cats were supposed to be aloof and uncaring of your existence so long as you fed them in time. Her cat, a massive maine coone, was faulty in that regard. He was never not purring or happy to see her and the fact that she was apparently a slave to his cuteness disgusted her (nevermind that he actually was insanely helpful).

Those three things she'd gotten used to. For the most part. There were still days when the nightmares lingered, days when her body screamed at her, days when she couldn't handle a twenty pound furry creature trying to tell her to take a chill pill. But those days were finally starting to come by less and less frequently, and she knew how to handle them when they did come.

What she didn't know how to handle but had quickly figured out were just as inescapable as the first three things, were the final two.

4- The world's most annoyingly chipper, bright-eyed, and bushy-tailed blonde jock of an athlete, who woke up way too early, had a smile that was way too genuine and eyes that were way too pretty, had the gall to be neighborly to her even on her grumpiest days when she just wanted to argue, and even had days where she was willing to argue but always wound up brightening the world anyway by the end of it.
5- Her freaking dog.

"Do you think he knows how cute he is?" Adora asks, the latter half of her sentence trailing into a coo as she flicks the cat toy and Melog trills happily, batting at it. There's a clear flicker of adoration in her eyes that normally would cause Catra's heart to combust.

Too bad she was currently being distracted by number five of her list.

"He knows," she grumbles, pulling her hand back from where it had been buried in Swift Wind's fur. Like he's done every time she's tried this in the past hour, however, he whips his head around the moment he can't feel her touch, and whimpers at her obnoxiously and increasingly loudly until she rolls her eyes and gives in to his demands, petting him yet again and continuing the cycle. She can't help an amused smirk. "He's a lot like your mutt. He fully knows how cute he is, and he weaponizes it."

"And now there are two of them," the blonde snorts, giving the attention-hog O.G. a few more scratches under the chin before pushing herself up and plopping down on Catra's bed, nudging her where she sat on the floor with the canine. "A dynamic duo, just like us."

Catra laughs and shoves Adora's leg away. "Gross. I don't affiliate with jocks."

"Riiight. Just their slobbery service dogs with no sense of boundaries."

“Don’t insult my best friend Swift Taylor like that,” she tsks, ignoring Adora’s correction of “it’s Swift *Wind*” as she shakes her head in disapproval. “He’s way better at the concept of boundaries than you are, and he doesn’t pester me for every second that he’s around me.”

Adora’s smirk is downright infuriating. “Yeah but when I do it you like it.”

She, unfortunately, was correct.

“Not kicking you out of the dorm every time you bother me does not equate to me liking you. Sorry.”

Adora rolls her eyes and flops down on Catra’s bed, her smile growing wider when Melog hops up to join her with a happy trill and flops down on top of her stomach. It earns him another adoring coo as the athlete happily gives into blessing him with more pets and scratches.

“Told ya,” Catra laughs. “Master of the mind games, this one.”

“Okay, so could *he* convince you to come with me tonight?”

Catra huffs, amused. She figured they’d eventually wind up back on this topic. “You assume he wants me to leave his side. If we’re both gone who’ll give him treats?”

Adora groaned. “Come on, there’s gotta be *something* I can do to get you to come with me. What if I did your homework for a week?”

“Tempting, but I’d rather not sink my grades, thanks.”

“I could buy your favorite snack while we’re out?”

“So I could sit and watch you eat it, right?”

“It was one time and you were the one to offer it to me!”

Catra leans her head back as she laughs, both at the blonde's stupidly adorable pout and at the way Swift Wind burrows further into her side. If you had told her even a month ago that her stupid roommate and her even worse dog would be such highlights in her life, that she could walk into her dorm today after having the crappiest day to ever crap and wind up smiling and laughing as lighthearted as ever, she'd have flung a bag of used cat litter at you and called you an idiot.

She *had* done that to Adora, once, but in her defense she'd started it. No she would not clarify how.

This whole week, Adora had been hyping up some sort of activity or something that she wanted to go to tonight, and every time she'd brought it up she'd made it clear as day she wanted Catra to go with her. Each and every time, Catra had turned her down, incredibly uninterested in spending an entire evening with a hyperactive jock and her just as hyperactive friends, regardless of how begrudgingly fond of any of them she had grown. Her resolve had been chipped at each time, but she was determined to protect her evening and keep her precious relaxing downtime, especially after the day she'd had. She'd love nothing better than to lay back with two soothing animals both freely loving on her as she unwound.

"Is there anything I can do to convince you?" Adora finally asks after a moment, her voice much more… quiet and subdued than before. Almost like she was on the verge of giving up.

Catra wasn't sure why the thought saddened her.

She also wasn't sure why, after a glance at Swift Wind and a quiet sigh, she gave her an actual answer. "Get your weird sparkly friends to leave us alone and I'll *maybe* consider it. *Maybe*."

"Wait, you…" Adora slowly sits up, her bright stormy blue eyes twinkling (ew) down at the magicat. "Do you mean Bow and Glimmer?"

Catra shrugs. Couldn't they just go back to teasing each other until the blonde had to leave? "And, you know, whoever else you usually hang out with."

Oh geez, that didn't sound mean *at all*.

"I mean… they might be there tonight too but if they are they'll be doing their own things." Again she feels those piercing blue eyes on her. "Is that why you kept saying 'no?' You don't want to be around them?"

"I…" she sighs again and lets her head hang backward. She *really* just wanted to go back to the teasing. "Look, I like 'em just fine, I just…" She licks her teeth and buries her fingers in Swift Wind's thick fur. "It's kind of been a long week for me. I'd rather not deal with a ton of people."

"Oh." She sounded a little surprised, and… a little relieved? "Okay, that's… more than fine, actually. Uh, we don't have to do… a ton of people. But, um… is… me still okay?"

Frowning, Catra finally glances over her shoulder. Why is Adora blushing? "What do you mean?"

"I uh…" Adora blows a heavy breath out and clasps her hands together, sucking in another breath to ramble anxiously, "I've kinda sorta been trying to ask you out for a while and at first I didn't know if you were gay or not so that made it hard but then I found out you are so that was fine, and then I worried you wouldn't like the idea of dating your roommate but you sounded fine with the idea so I thought maybe I had a shot, so when I found out about the haunted mansion and corn maze happening tonight I remembered that you'd mentioned wanting to go to one again sometime so that's why I've been trying to invite you all week but you kept poking fun at it and me and I don't mind that I think it's fun but I was starting to worry that you were trying to say no without being rude because you… didn't like me… back, so…" she finally trails off, shrinking into herself in a way that didn't seem possible.

Catra just stared at her, wide-eyed.

That… *all of that*… was exactly the *last* thing she'd been expecting.

"What?" she says again with the eloquence of a goldfish being flushed down the toilet. As Adora takes another breath to explain again, Catra quickly shakes her head and waves her hand as she sits up on her knees and turns to face her roommate. "Wait, don't, stop, I heard you, I just… you've been trying to ask me out?"

"…yes?" the response ekes out with no small hint of barely restrained terror.

"You… like me?" The question spills out softer than she'd intended. The way her voice shakes as she continues is very unappreciated. "*Me*?"

Adora's blush grows in tandem with Catra's, but her fluster and panic retreat as her eyes dance over the magicat's face. "Yes," she answers much more confidently, a fond smile slowly growing on her face. "Yes, I like you, Catra. A lot, actually."

Oh.

Well then.

"What was that you said about a maze tonight?"

Adora lit up like a thousand fireflies chasing stars in the nighttime sky, and as Catra's blush grew brighter she realized…

Maybe numbers 4 and 5 wouldn't take all that long to get used to after all.

College - Professor From Hell

Chapter Notes

> It's gonna bug me for eternity knowing the site officially says this fic was started the 2nd of October even though I posted on the 1st >:|
>
> Anywho, here's some shenanigans in these trying times 💦👉☁️

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Oh, she was *never* going to live this down.

"What is—" the magicat hisses, a hand wrapping tight around her side as Adora finishes helping her up. "What is *wrong* with you?!"

"I am so so so sorry!" she warbles, all but yanking her hands away the moment she was sure the other was steady. "We're running late for class and with all the puddles around my bike couldn't break in time—!"

"And what, you couldn't have swerved or something?"

Well… she'd tried to. But going however-freaking-fast mph down a steep hill when already scrambling to catch up to her friends and get to class before the lesson began, only for two people to seemingly emerge out of nowhere just as she was zooming to the bottom trying not to skid and die from a puddle, didn't leave her too many options. She had slammed on the brakes, and she *had* swerved, in all fairness…

But that hadn't stopped her from colliding head on with the unfairly attractive magicat in the duo.

If her scorpioni friend glares any harder at the blonde she would soon be joining the other puddles scattered along the pavement.

"Are you gonna be okay, Wildcat?" she asks, not moving away from her side the way Adora had. "Remember, you're way more important than your class, so if we need to call it off today…"

The magicat sighs, the sound tight and pained as she slowly stands up, a hand wrapped tightly around her torso. Her voice is just as strained. "I'll be fine, Scorp, just need a minute." She glances down at her now painfully filthy outfit, a sharp black polo shirt and burgundy dress slacks, and grimaces as she lifts a leg and shakes it, muddy puddle water flinging from the fabric. "Ugh, and a change of clothes."

"Can I…" Adora starts, freezing when two cold gazes find her again. "Can I like… pay for an Uber for you guys or something? I'm *really* sorry about this."

"Yeah, I got that," the magicat grumbles. She shakes her head and goes to say something, when a loud shrill voice interrupts her.

"Adora!" Glimmer calls, her and Bow speedily biking back to find her. "There you are! Come on, if we were gonna be late before we're definitely gonna be late now!"

The magicat and scorpioni both look over as the other two skid to a halt. Adora's not entirely surprised when both their expressions sour at the signs of even more disturbance.

She *is* surprised when the magicat sneers and addresses Glimmer with a growled "Sparkles."

Glimmer whips around, at first gaping at the magicat before her surprise also morphs into annoyance.

"Catra. What do *you* want?"

"To not be roadkill," she rolls her eyes. "Don't look at me like I started something, your buddy here's the one who crashed into *me*."

"Maybe she was distracted by how awful of a person you are."

"*Glimmer*!" Adora balks, at the same time as Catra rolls her eyes.

"Yeah cuz *that* makes sense," the magicat mutters crossly, her tail lashing.

"Glimmer, I *ran her over*," Adora insists. "What is with you? Look, you guys go on without me, you don't have to wait up, but I wanna make sure she's okay."

"She's fine, she thrives off of being a pain, it's her super power."

"You're one to talk," Scorpia snarls, tail rattling angrily.

"Nice to see you too," the magicat grumbles. She shifts her weight to her other foot and flinches, immediately shifting back as a low growl permeates the air.

"Hi, Catra," Bow timidly waves, clearly just as uncomfortable with Glimmer's hostility as Adora. The growling stops as he draws Catra's attention. "Hi, Scorpia."

Catra grunts in turn, but the friendly greeting at least makes Scorpia a little happier, and she returns the friendly wave.

"Hi, Bow," she greets in turn. She glares at Glimmer. "Nice to see one of you isn't a raging hypocritical jerk."

"Oh, *I'm* the raging hypocritical jerk?!"

Adora glares at her. "You've got the jerk part down, you're yelling at her and she just got run over! By me!"

With a hand still wrapped around her torso and a limp in her step, Catra growls at the three of them before Glimmer can get in another word, shutting them all up. She lets out a winded huff and snaps, "Look, just piss off and leave us alone. You're all running late, right? Then get out of here. Thanks to you, you're not the *only* ones who are gonna be late for class. Thanks for that."

Feeling another surge of guilt, Adora goes to apologize again, but is interrupted by Glimmer's scoff.

"Fine by me," she sneers, readjusting her bike. "Come on, Adora, let's go. If we hurry we still might be able to get most of the lecture."

Bow awkwardly pedals after her as she races away, but Adora still hesitates. She turns to again attempt reconciliation, only to find Catra already limping off with Scorpia's help.

Biting her lip and struggling to stay afloat in her guilt, Adora pushes off to keep up with the other two.

. . .

"What was that all about? With Catra and Scorpia?" Adora asks once they've all found their seats in the lecture hall, about halfway up the rows in the dead center of the room.

Bow grimaces and sinks a little in his seat as Glimmer glares at nothing on his other side, muttering a string of profanities under her breath. "There's um… some… *history* between Glimmer and Catra."

Adora eyes the muttering gremlin she called one of her best friends. "I gathered. Can I ask what happened or is that kind of thing off limits?"

"We were friends until she decided to become a literal monster and stab me in the back," the glittery female grits out between clenched teeth, gripping a pencil so tightly it was clearly moments from snapping.

"You know it wasn't as simple as that," Bow gently admonishes, but Glimmer clearly isn't interested in listening. The man rolls his eyes and turns back to Adora. "They both made some… questionable decisions during high school," he murmurs. "They both had their reasons, but they wound up hurting each other in the process. The fallout was—"

“Messy?” Adora offers.

“*Ugly*,” Bow shudders. “Honestly, I’m kinda shocked Catra didn’t react more when we ran into her.”

Adora winces at the accidental reminder. “Still not on the friendliest of terms, I’ve taken it?”

“Oh no. They *hated* each other.”

“Go ahead, keep talking like I’m not literally *right next to you*,” Glimmer mutters, waving off their sputtered apologies. “It’s fine. It’s not like the professor is gonna care, they’re not even here.”

“Yeah, where are they anyway?” a student nearby ponders aloud, her poofy blond curls bouncing as she turns back to look at them like she hadn’t been eavesdropping the entire time. “We’re like almost an hour into class.”

“It’s only been thirty-five minutes, Starla,” the man next to her sighs, scratching his goatee. “Maybe they ran into traffic or something.”

“Whatever the reason, at least we’re not technically late anymore,” Glimmer snorts.

Adora eyes the clock. “I mean…”

“Nope. Not late. If I get to class before the literal professional it means I’m perfectly on time.”

“Just because that worked for you most of the time in high school doesn’t necessarily mean it’ll work just as well here,” Bow warns.

“Shut up, yes it will.”

Adora rolls her eyes and slumps against the table, eyes wandering from the clock to the door just as someone walks in.

Her eyes widen.

“Uhh, guys?”

Bow and Glimmer momentarily pause their bickering to glance over at her, then follow her line of sight down to the entrance where Scorpia just walked in.

They both gawk at the sight of the scorpioni, then Glimmer groans maybe a little too loudly and buries her face in her hands.

“Oh. Great. She’s in this class too. If Catra walks in next I’m leaving, I refuse to take the same class as her.”

“This is a mandatory class for all of our majors, Glim,” Bow gently reminds her.

“Dammit, Bow, can you please be wrong for once? For my sake?”

Bow sympathetically pats her head. “Afraid not. One of us needs to be the smart one.”

“Hey,” Adora snorts, not actually offended. Bow holds up his hands in surrender, a white-toothed grin on his face.

Scorpia finally moves away from the doorway, and curious, Adora’s eyes follow. For some reason, the scorpioni sets the bags she’d been carrying down by the professor’s desk, not one of the spectator seats, and Adora frowns.

“Wait… she’s not our professor, is she?” she asks. Glimmer goes wide-eyed.

“Stars above, I *hope* not,” she gripes. “She’d probably fail me instantly for fighting with Catra.”

Adors frowns. “Teachers aren’t allowed to do that, are they?”

“Not… technically,” Bow hums. “But Scorpia is… pretty dang protective of Catra. Like… a lot.”

Memories of crashing into the magicat again start looping through her mind, and Adora sinks lower into her seat, hoping the scorpioni doesn't spot her as she finishes setting up at the front.

Starla raises her hand. The man next to her gently lowers it and mumbles softly to just ask, and she nods. "Um, Ma'am?" she calls out. "Are you our professor?"

"Hmm?" Scorpia's head whips around from where she'd been writing on the whiteboard. "Oh! Me? Heh, nah, I'm not the professor, I'm just the assistant. She should be right—" She perks up and beams as the doors open again, and in stiffly walks a neatly dressed figure wearing a black turtleneck under a gorgeous open green flannel with the sleeves rolled up to her elbows and only the last few buttons done up, both tucked into a sleek pair of light brown suit slacks.

Adora, Bow, and Glimmer's jaws all slam into the floor.

"Thank you for setting up for me, Ms. Tenebris," the figure hums, pausing as she eyes the board. She levels a deadpan look at the towering scorpioni. "I can write my own name, Scorp."

Scorpia snorts. "Well, duh, but as your assistant I gotta do *something*."

The pencil in Glimmer's hand finally snaps, and she drops another curse.

The magicat chuckles, shaking her head. "Fair enough," she concedes, before turning to face the class at large. "Welcome to Social Sciences. This is my assistant, Scorpia Tenebris. I am Professor D'riluth. Call me that or don't, call me Professor, call me D, call me by my first name for all I care, I'm not too picky about any of that."

Scorpia hurriedly jots down D'riluth's first name too, and any hopes that this was somehow a *different* magicat with heterochromatic eyes and an alluring raspy voice and a stifled limp are *violently* torpedoed out the window.

"Oh no," Bow croaks, and if Adora hadn't gone pale as a sheet of paper and just lost her entire ability to vocalize, she would have said the same thing, though probably with half of Glimmer's profanities thrown in.

The board now reads "Catra D'riluth," with the way to pronounce the name written below. Catra D'riluth. The same Catra D'riluth that Glimmer had a violent falling out with, and the same Catra D'riluth that Adora had slammed into head on with her bike. The only actual difference between the Catra she ran into and the Catra somehow looming over her from the front of the room was her outfit.

Adora feels her insides all playing musical chairs and she sinks even lower into her seat.

"I'd like to apologize for my tardiness," Catra continues as she trails over to her desk, her steps more sure than they were right after the collision but still clearly stiff and pained. She carefully sits herself down on the desktop, and relaxes some now that she's not on her feet anymore. Her eyes surf the classroom full of students as she speaks. "We *were* going to be on time, but we had to double back for new clothes and some supplies after we ran into some… *trouble* on the way here."

Just as she emphasizes the word, her eyes land on the three people most desperately hoping to avoid them, and they widen in recognition. An almost imperceptible grin pulls at her lips, and somewhere Adora swears she hears a danger motif playing.

Welp. Guess she was failing this class.

"What happened?" Starla questions, and never had Adora wanted to chloroform someone more than in that moment.

"Oh," Catra trills, her eyes as dangerous as her smirk. "Just a couple bikers who weren't watching where they were going."

A collective wince spreads through the room. Some people even audibly grimace.

Adora craves the sweet release of death.

Starla croons sympathetically. “Are you gonna be okay?”

“I’ll be fine,” the young professor waves a hand, finally looking away and freeing the trio from the inescapable eyes of a hunter who’d found her prey. “But I’m not quite feeling up to the lesson I’d had planned for today anymore. Instead…” and suddenly her eyes were on the three again, that smirk back in its place, and all three tense. “I thought we could just sit back and watch a random little video. Have a chill first day of classes. Anyone opposed?”

Obviously, she received no complaints, and even got a few tired but ecstatic cheers from students already exhausted from the burdens brought on in other classes. With a pleased shrug, Catra moves from her desk to her chair and pulls up a video on her computer as Scorpia dims the lights and pulls down the projector. With the video already pulled up, ready and waiting for the projector to turn on, Catra waits for her cue and hits “play” as soon as Scorpia’s sat at her side.

A road safety video starts playing. Some students chuckle and snort. The cheesy instructor goes over important safety tips such as looking both ways before crossing the street, waiting for the sign to turn green before crossing at a busy intersection, and waiting for the pedestrians to cross when it’s their turn. With the laughs and giggles had, everyone else goes about their business, taking this now free period to either get started on other homework, take a much needed nap, or just talk quietly amongst their peers.

For Adora, Bow, and Glimmer, all that’s left for them to do is sit quietly in shame and embarrassment and humiliation, Catra’s glowing eyes laser focused on them and a quiet little smirk still playing at her lips as she leans back in her chair with an ice pack Scorpia had passed her.

“I hate her,” Glimmer grumbles, though it’s clear she’s also been subdued by the now glaringly obvious fact that the person she’s

likely pissed off more than anyone was in charge of her grades.

"I'm too terrified to hate her," Bow eeps, his hushed voice cracking.

Adora just stares back at the professor in a frazzled mix of awe, fear… and definitely more than a little respect.

Chapter End Notes

Catra is still the same age as the BFS, she just graduated early

Scorpia's not in her class, she's literally just happy to be there

College - Awkward Party

Chapter Notes

> TW: Catra has a not so great time and slips into panic in this one. I don't know if the warning is going to be necessary, but better safe than sorry.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra was both incredibly grateful for the backyard pavilion the King's had and also incredibly not grateful. She was grateful for it because the pavilion kept her dry and out of the damn rain, sure.

But there were way too many people here and one of them was bound to be Adora.

That was the last thing she needed right now. She was already extremely on edge from the storm that had come out of nowhere and only seemed to be growing worse by the minute, it felt like every person present was either staring at her or breathing on her or both, and she honestly felt seconds from just racing for her car and high-tailing it out of there, Entrapta be damned.

Stars, where even is the little nerd? she wonders grumpily, ducking around shuffling elbows and jostling arms as an uncomfortable energy continues to course through her veins. When her roommate had asked her for a ride, she didn't think she'd be signing herself up for *this*. A thunderstorm, annoying people, and the promise of what was bound to be an unpleasant reunion? If she'd have known ahead of time she'd have just chucked the keys at the shorter woman and hoped she'd still have a car in the morning.

Thunder rumbles through the sky and she feels her breathing hitch, her tail lashing. An ache sparks across her shoulders, through her back and down her spine. She swallows and rubs her neck, hoping to soothe it and her shot nerves, aware of how her hackles have yet to truly relax again.

She would not break down here, certainly not because of a stupid storm.

"Entrapta!" she hisses harshly but without shouting, scanning the throng for her signature purple pig tails. Her body was telling her to get out, get out before something bad happened, and she was all too eager to comply. She wanted to leave before she was too shaky to drive, before the storm got bad enough that she wouldn't be able to drive regardless of how much she was or was not trembling. "Entrapta, where are you?!"

She pushes through a gathered herd of sweaty whiny gym rats and jocks, busy mourning the lost opportunity to do… sports stuff, or something, now that it was raining so hard. Any other day she would have laughed at the misfortune of it, finding it at least somewhat amusing how so much effort had been put into this outdoor party only for it to wind up completely inaccessible to the masses, but right now she really just wanted to get out as soon as physically possible.

"I'm so sorry, everyone," she hears a voice call above the din of the storm and the crowd, quieting at least the latter. Her ears prick at its familiar melody. "I don't think *anyone* was expecting the weather to turn like this."

It's only when Catra actually registers the voice that she remembers she's supposed to be *avoiding* this particular person, but she remembers too late and squeezes out from the crowd to see her just a few feet away, way too close for her comfort when she's already so frazzled, and she freezes.

Thankfully, however, Adora doesn't notice her, and quickly she begins to slink off to the side as the blonde continues to address the group at large. "We're gonna wait a little to see if the storm lets up. If it doesn't, all the snacks are inside and we can all head in to wait out the weather. We've got games and movies waiting downstairs, so don't worry! I know this isn't what any of us were hoping for but we can still make the most of it!"

Classic Adora, honestly. Always able to make the most out of a dour situation. The familiarity and comfort of that particular aspect of her old friend having not changed a bit is actually a little comforting in a weird way.

She still isn't planning on going up and saying "hi" or anything stupid like that. If she could slip out with her friend without being noticed, that would be great actually.

Naturally, that's when another flash of lightning brightens the sky, and she violently flinches as thunder claps and an ache lances along her back again. She hadn't quite made it to the edge of the crowd before the strike, and while most faces were drawn to the sky, one had seen her flinch and had locked on her, stormy blue eyes widening.

Catra fights to keep her breathing under control, a tremble starting in her hands that she really wishes weren't, and its a long enough moment before she notices the concerned stare that she quickly regrets it, when a gentle hand touches her shoulder and she flinches back with a hiss.

Only to blanch as she finds Adora looking down at her.

Her heart was still madly racing in her chest, she did *not* have the bandwidth to deal with anymore unwelcomed pulse-racing/stopping moments. Before Adora can say anything, Catra ducks away and back into the melting pot of sweaty bodies.

"Catra, wait!" she hears the blonde call. She ignores her, near frantically searching for Entrapta. The ache in her back was still throbbing, duller than it could be but still clearly present. Hating how there was already a rasp in her breathing and fighting to calm down again, she rubs at a point on her shoulder where the ache was most noticeable, her temper running hotter and her patience thinning more and more with every passing second.

The salt in the air from the sweat and the rain made her want to gag. She hears Adora call out for her again, searchingly, hears her

apologize as she squeezes past people left and right to try and catch up, to find her.

Part of her wants to let her, wants to hide in her arms and breathe in her comforting presence as her words and scent and touch drown out the terror of the storm.

The rest of her knows that that comfort wouldn't be accessible. Not now.

They were little more than strangers to each other now. What kind of stranger would be comfortable doing all of that for a magicat clearly on the verge of a breakdown?

Not gonna break down, not gonna break down.

She hears Adora sigh. "Catra, come on! Please?"

Biting back tears with a snarl, Catra whips out her phone, her patience about to snap. She quickly pulls up Entrapta's number and holds the device to her ear, still shuffling through the crowd as the dial tone drones in one ear while the sound of voices and rain lash at her everywhere else, making it even harder to maintain decent and even breaths as she instinctively waits for another bolt of thunder and lightning.

It hits just as Entrapta finally picks up, leaving Catra to struggle through her breathless panic and paralytic terror, gaping for breath as echoes of white hot *pain* smuggle in with the aches in her back.

"Catra!" she hears the chipper voice exclaim, completely unaware of the magicat's growing panic. "I was just discussing some of my more interesting findings with Bow when you called! Oh, thank you for the ride, by the way, I know you weren't pleased with needing to bring me so it means a lot."

"I… *Traps*," she forces out, trying hard to swallow back the shaking and the nauseating fear. This was stupid, it was a *storm*, it couldn't hurt her here. What were the chances of something like

that happening to someone twice? And under a pavilion? "Look, I… I gotta go, are you ready?"

"Ready? To leave? But we've only been here for twenty minutes!" A muffled voice—Bow, maybe?—corrects her. "Oh. My mistake, it's been forty minutes. But I don't think I'm ready to leave yet! Bow and I are so close to uncovering something that could be monumental!"

She grits her teeth so hard a part of her wonders if they could snap. "Entrapta, I need to leave. *Now*. Either save it for another time or get a ride with someone else."

"But our findings—!"

"Entrapta!" she barks into the phone, startling a few people around her. "I'm not kidding, I—!"

Lightning arcs across the gray sky, and not even a full second later, thunder *crashes* after it.

Catra's phone hits the ground.

Her back was on *fire*. It wouldn't fade, she could feel it burning like a pyre beneath her skin, feeling it race through the bumps and stretches of her scars that hadn't faded like the lichtenberg figures, igniting the furless patches over and over and over again, choking the breath from her lungs, her body as paralyzed as it had been before, when she'd woken on the pavement dazed and pained and confused and scared, it had happened again it was going to happen again and she wouldn't make it this time because who could ever be lucky enough to survive being struck a *second time*—

A pair of large, cold hands broke through the fire, one at her back and one on her arm. A gentle voice urges her to breathe as she's carefully led forward, across the wet grass and in through a sliding glass door, something draped over her head to keep the rain from reaching her. A distant part of her recognizes what was happening, recognizes that everyone else was also scrambling to

get inside and out of the suddenly much worse storm, but the rest of her was still swallowed up in terror.

She doesn't fully follow what happens next, not completely. A part of her remembered being led down a flight of stairs, then the soothingly cold hands pulling away for a moment before coming back to pull her into a body, an embrace, where she felt those hands holding her tight and comforting, one rubbing up and down her back, across the starburst scars hidden underneath her clothes, as the other cradled her head.

By the time she resurfaces, she isn't sure how long Adora's been holding her, how long she's been shaking in her arms in her bed, how long her tears have silently soaked her shirt, or how long the other girl's soft reassurances and whispers have been spilling forth in an effort to comfort her.

She also isn't sure what it means that Adora is *still holding her*.

But the sparking flames dancing beneath her skin have calmed under her touch. The rumbling thunder outside still makes her flinch, but it's softer. She's inside, she's dry, and—*somehow*—she's with Adora.

"Are you okay?" Adora asks, and why wouldn't she? People don't normally completely fall apart just because lightning struck. Of course she would have questions.

All of them would be about her, in some way, she knew that. But if she hadn't been able to handle questions before, she *really* wasn't able to handle them now. Another shudder races through her, and she buries her face in Adora's neck, trying to muster up the strength and the words she needed to either brush everything off or just plead with her to save it for later.

To her surprise, though, she doesn't have to say anything at all.

Adora's fingers softly card through her mane, and her other arm tightens from where it's wrapped around Catra's middle.

“You don’t have to talk yet,” she reassures, and the immediate relief Catra feels is so overwhelming she can’t help another few tears from leaking out. Adora hugs her even tighter, a blissful comfort she never thought she’d get to feel again. “We can do that later. I just… I want to know that you’re okay. Or… at least *going* to be.”

Catra breathes in shakily and lets it back out just as unsteady. She nuzzles Adora’s neck… and she nods.

Adora relaxes beneath her.

“Okay. Okay good.”

She hesitates a moment, her gentle pets slowing to a stop. Then her arm lowers to join the other in squeezing Catra close, fingers clutching the fabric of her shirt. She buries her face in the crook of Catra’s neck.

“I missed you so much.”

Wow. Okay.

A purr surges from Catra’s chest, and she works her limp arms into circling tight around Adora in turn.

So heart fluctuation was still going to be a thing, apparently.

Good to know.

Chapter End Notes

> *in a sing-songy voice* I STRUGGLED WITH THIS ONE BESTIEEEEESSS~
>
> And honestly I’m probably gonna struggle with tomorrow’s too lol oh well
>
> COUPLE OTHER THINGS I WANTED TO MENTION

- “King” is Glimmer’s family’s last name in this one because it was right there and I’ve read it used as her last name before and I liked it so yeah
- Catra did done got hit by lightning in the past because why not; for a character who canonically gets hit by lightning a LOT, I don’t think I’ve read a single fic where she’s a lightning strike survivor in any AUs or even just in general, and I’ve been wanting to do something with that concept, so… *jazz hands*

College - Best Friends Reunited

Chapter Notes

> These things keep getting longer and longer and they need to s t a h p

See the end of the chapter for more notes

For a kiss to simultaneously be the best thing to ever happen to her and the worst was simply diabolical.

After so long of wanting nothing more, Adora had finally gotten it. A kiss under the bleachers at Catra's graduation, blissful and wonderful and enchanting and… it was everything. The two had been ecstatic; not many graduated high school as a sophomore, but Catra had always been special like that. Adora had never been more proud of her, beaming in her crimson cap and gown, cords showing off her many accomplishments draped around her neck.

But not everything had been perfect. Adora just wished she knew why. One moment, Catra's hands are cupping her face, the two are holding one another close and smiling into a kiss they'd both wanted for so long. Foreheads touched, it truly felt like things were. Perfect.

And then Catra spotted something over Adora's shoulder, and that perfect moment ended. She'd gasped, ears pinned and horror in her eyes. But when Adora had turned to see what she'd seen, Catra had stopped her with another hug, this one a tinge more desperate.

"I'm sorry," she'd whispered. Eyes shut tight, she'd nuzzled into Adora's neck and promised, "Whatever happens next… it was worth it."

The next day, Catra was gone.

You should have been here, Adora had thought to herself as she'd fidgeted with her own cap, blue instead of the crimson she would have worn had she and her family not moved, two years later. *You should have been by my side, cheering as loud as I cheered for you*.

Now I don't even know where you are.

She'd spent a year looking, after her graduation. A year trying to hunt down Catherine Weaver, along with however long she'd spent looking while still in high school. But no matter how hard she'd looked, how long…

Catra was still missing.

"Adora?"

Adora turns at the soothing voice, and finds it in her to smile.

"Hi, Spinnerella."

"Hello, my dear," she greets with a much needed embrace, squeezing her tight and only stepping away when she pulls back first. "It's good to have you back in town. How have you been?"

She sighs, shrugging limply. "Um… alright, I guess. How about you and Netossa? Adopt any kids while I was away?"

She says it mostly as a joke. The two wives had both shown more maternal tendencies in the three years Adora had known them than her own mother at times, and harmless teasing about them finally acting on those tendencies was seemingly a common thing amidst *all* the Bright Moon students.

But instead of playfully rolling her eyes as she had many times before, Spinnerella just laughs. "Actually…"

Adora's eyes widen, and her smile softens. "Really? Spinny, that's wonderful!"

"I certainly think so," the older woman beams. "She's such an amazing girl, Adora. She's older, and we only started fostering her a few years ago, but I truly believe we made the right choice in bringing her into our little family. I only wish we'd found her sooner. I know Netossa feels the same."

"I'm happy for you guys," she hums, genuine. "It's about time you both found someone to officially parent to death."

Another musical laugh. "I'm glad you're at least grateful for it. Stars, I'm sure we've been so overbearing at times she's been tempted to flee the first chance she gets. There are days I'm honestly shocked to find her still home the next morning." She shrugs, amusement dancing in her eyes. "She'll spout off all the time about how we're annoying old crones, but I'm fairly confident she loves us as much as we love her."

I wonder if Catra would have liked them, she wonders, the thought immediately sinking her tentative chipperness faster than a ship with a hole blown in its side.

Spinnerella notices unfortunately quickly. "Are you alright?"

"Just… wishing my friend was here. I bet she'd have loved you guys."

The woman's smile is sympathetic, but Adora doesn't want to linger on this topic anymore and shakes her head with a sharp inhale, plastering on a smile again.

"So, what brings you out here?"

She was glad Spinnerella was so good at people and knowing when not to push something. She smiles and readjusts her bag. "Some last minute shopping. We weren't able to throw a celebration for our daughter's *actual* Gotcha Day since she'd fallen sick at the time, so we're throwing one tonight instead." She lights up after a moment. "Say! Would you like to come? We're trying to help her get more… reacclimated with people her age before she leaves for college."

Adora snorts. “Netossa’s idea?”

She grins. “I think she just wants an excuse to throw a huge party for our kid. And honestly, I’m the same way. Still, the invite’s there, if you’d like.”

The blonde scuffs her boot along the path. “Thank you, for the offer, but… I’m gonna have to pass. Um…” she scrambles for a halfway decent excuse that wasn’t *I don’t feel like socializing when I’m feeling especially hung up on my missing friend*. “I… actually have some shopping of my own to do. Gotta get ready to move into my new place, you know?”

“Oh! You’re moving again?”

She nods. “Yeah, but it’s just into the college dorms.” She snorts. “Adam was getting a little too unbearable for my tastes.”

Spinnerella giggles. “Oh, that boy. I can only imagine. He’ll mature eventually, dear, don’t worry.”

Adora snickers. “Are we sure about that?” She sighs and looks down at her watch. She really does have to get going soon, she needs to get quite a few things still. “I’d better get a move on. These groceries aren’t gonna buy themselves.”

Spinnerella sighs. “Wouldn’t that be nice?” She opens her arms for another hug, and Adora happily accepts the invitation. “Good luck, my dear. I hope to see you again soon.”

“You too,” she hums back, giving the kind woman one last squeeze. With a final wave, the two say goodbye, and turn to set off.

. . .

Adora huffs for breath as she finally makes it into her dorm.

Even from just a glance, it looks surprisingly nice, definitely cozy. With two beds, a cordoned off bathroom—the sight filled her with

more joy than seeing a bathroom normally brought a person; it would be so nice to only have to share with one other person—along with two closets and dressers, she felt confident it wouldn't take her long to get settled in.

It would have been better if she were here with Catra.

She forcefully shakes her head. No use thinking of that—of *her*—right now. Her roommate, who had already claimed one of the beds and even decorated a little, could be home any time now. She'd hate for their first meeting to be the other person walking in on her sobbing over memories.

She could save the tears for when she'd gotten everything set up and was able to take a shower.

Setting down her suitcases and bags, she fishes out her phone and her speaker from one of the duffels. Putting on a playlist she and Catra had made and listened to frequently, she sets the speaker down on the bedside table of the unclaimed bed and gets to work unpacking.

It isn't long before she's humming along to some of Catra's favorite songs and getting teary-eyed as she unpacks. Still, she doesn't skip any of the songs, and definitely won't choose a different playlist.

This was supposed to be something she did *with* Catra, after all.

She's about eleven songs in when her roommate gets home, the door creaking open behind her. Currently struggling to get her fitted sheet actually on her mattress, she can't actually turn to greet the person just yet, and so calls a semi-strangled greeting over her shoulder.

"Hi! If you give me just—!" the sheet almost whisks back across the mattress, but she manages to stop it just in time and stretch it back into place, "—just *one* second and I'll be right with you!"

The person seems to hesitate in the doorway a moment, before snickering a soft, raspy laugh. “Need any help, dork?”

“No, no! Don’t worry, I’ve just about got—” she startles, eyes widening. The person behind her shuffles, and she cranes her neck to peer over her shoulder. Why did that voice sound so familiar? “Wha—”

Looking back costs her the tentative control she has over the fitted sheet, and all four corners spring loose and snap back to trap her inside with a startled yelp. She groans, and again she hears that laugh. She starts wriggling around in an attempt to escape the sheet, trying to find the exit.

She hears footsteps, then feels the mattress bend under another’s weight. The person finds the sheet’s opening for her, and peels it back to free her with a smile caught between something smug and something… emotional.

The tears that Adora had so desperately been holding back all begin to fall.

“Hey, Adora,” Catra purrs, her own mismatched eyes shimmering wetly.

Suffice it to say, the sheet is momentarily forgotten about entirely. The two are pulled so fast into an embrace neither are sure who initiated it, and neither care. Catra and Adora hold each other close, so so close, clinging to one another with the ferocity of pent-up emotion left to build for years without the other to set it loose. Tears are shed wildly and messily, laughter relieved and aching colors the air, as the two disconnected hearts are finally brought together once again.

It takes four of their songs playing out on Adora’s speaker for them both to have calmed down. Neither pull away, but their near desperate hold on one another has relaxed. Adora lays flat on her naked mattress, Catra cuddled to her chest atop her with her face buried in her neck and her tail snaked around her leg.

Stars, it was simultaneously like an eternity had gone by and like no time had passed at all since they last held each other like this.

It was so good to have it back, Adora almost didn't bother dredging up the age-old questions that have been needing answers for years.

"What happened, Catra?" she asks in little more than a whisper, carding her fingers through Catra's mane rhythmically.

Catra lets out a sigh and nuzzles her neck. "What else? Shadow Weaver. She saw me kissing you that day."

"That's why you disappeared?"

She nods. "I didn't want you to look because I didn't want her to know it was you. I'd hoped… if she just saw me kissing a girl, maybe it wouldn't be as bad as if she'd realized who that girl was." She sniffs, a humorless mirth in her tone. "She's always been weirdly obsessed with you, you know that? She figured it out pretty easily. To find out her mongrel street rat of a charge had kissed the world's most perfect prodigy drove her off the edge, I guess." The energy in her voice dies down some. "I think I knew it would, when it happened. I didn't want to care."

Adora holds her tighter, and Catra revels in the pressure. "What did she do to you?"

"Nothing she hasn't done before," the magicat shrugs. She pauses. "Well. Up until she threw me out in the middle of the night."

"She *what?!*" Adora barks, shooting upright but somehow without launching Catra across the room. Catra just shrugs, and the blonde balks. "Wh— why didn't you come to me? We could have helped!"

"You were moving," Catra scratches the back of her head, and Adora blanches. "I was a mess, and after the fresh 'scolding' from the witch I didn't… I felt like I shouldn't bother you guys."

“You knew we were moving?” her voice comes out quiet.

Catra nods, wearing a reserved and tired grin. “Heard it through the grapevine.”

“I’m…” she sighs and takes Catra’s hand. “I’m sorry. I was going to tell you, but I didn’t want to say anything until after your graduation. I didn’t want to ruin such a happy moment with such crappy news.”

The magicat bumps her head against Adora’s and cuddles against her again. “It’s okay, dummy,” she chuffs, a hint of amusement seeping back in. “Things worked out eventually.”

“Were you okay?” she can’t help but ask.

Catra hums. “Not at first. I was on the streets for a bit. I could have called the cops and gotten the old hag in trouble, but I was worried they’d just make her take me in again. It was rough, but,” she huffs and rolls her eyes, a genuine smile back on her face, “that’s how I found my family.”

Adora perks up. “Yeah?”

Catra nods. “Yeah.” Her smile shifts into a smirk and she playfully shoves her shoulder. “And you would’ve found that out a lot sooner if you’d actually accepted Spinnerella’s invitation.”

Adora frowns. “Wait, what? How’d you know Spinnerella—” Her words trail off and her jaw drops. “W— you don’t mean—?!”

Catra snickers. “Netossa’s the one who found me. Turns out, she was a close friend of my parents before they’d passed, and I was actually supposed to wind up in her and her wife’s care all along. Took ‘em a little while, but… here we are.”

Adora’s shock slowly shifts into genuine, all-encompassing joy, and with an ecstatic cheer she scoops Catra up again, eliciting a startled yelp and amused cackle.

“Adora!”

“Catra, that’s wonderful! I’m so glad you finally got a real family!” She gasps and sharply pulls back. “Did you change your name? Is that why I couldn’t find you? Are you a Gaelstrom now?”

Catra smiles. “I did change my name, but I didn’t take theirs. They might be my guardians now but I chose something else.” Her hand again comes up to sheepishly rub the back of her neck. “I mean, okay, technically I was just changing my name back, but still. It’s uh… my name before I wound up with Weaver, before my parents died… I was ‘C’yra D’riluth’. I just took back that part of me.”

“‘C’yra D’riluth,’” Adora sounds out. It was a little odd, but… She smiles. “Definitely way more fitting than ‘Catherine Weaver,’ I’d say.”

Catra shudders, earning a snicker. “And I’d agree. It feels *so* good to not be tied to that monster anymore.”

“Yeah, duh, I wonder why,” Adora huffs, still smiling. It fades a little as a question comes to mind. “Wait, so, are you still okay with ‘Catra’ then?”

“No, I actually go by ‘Firestorm The Unbreakable’ now,” she snorts. She shoves Adora again. “If even the witch couldn’t get me to stop using that nickname why would getting adopted be what does it?”

“Hey, come on, I just wanted to make sure,” she laughs, shoving her back. She beams at Catra’s returning peal of laughter, so lighthearted and free in ways she so rarely got to hear when they were younger. When she catches her best friend’s eyes again, she softens, and slowly reaches for her hand. Catra happily takes it, and Adora’s smile grows.

“Hey Adora?” she asks quietly.

Adora hums, tilting her head.

Catra's smile softens next. "I meant it. Back then. I still do."

Adora's heart races, and she scoots closer. "Meant what?" she asks, just wanting to hear her say it.

Catra scoots closer too. Her free hand comes up, and in a mirror of that day under the bleachers, she tenderly cups Adora's face, and she leans into the touch.

"What we did… it was worth it. I haven't changed my mind about that." Her eyes dart to Adora's lips, and Adora's trail down to hers.

"Could we do it again?" Adora asks, her voice barely a breath.

Catra responds by pulling her in for a kiss.

It was even more perfect than the first.

"I missed you so much," Adora murmurs against her lips after a moment, her other hand coming up to cradle the back of Catra's head as she pulls her in for another kiss, and another, and another. When they finally part, they press their foreheads together, Catra's purr rumbling peacefully in the air. "I missed you so so *so* much, Catra, you have no idea."

Catra chuffs. "I might have some idea." She caresses Adora's cheek with her thumb, soft and tender and warm. She sighs under her breath. "You know what really sucks about this, though?"

Adora frowns and opens her eyes. "What?"

The magicat's signature smirk is back. "We could have done all this a whole lot sooner if you'd just said yes to Spinnerella's invite __"

Adora interrupts her with a pillow to the kisser, and when Catra goes down cackling she's quick to continue the onslaught, laughing right alongside her.

This… *this* was perfect.

Chapter End Notes

Momma Spinnetossa FTW 🙌

College - Sports/Rivals

Chapter Notes

> And with this we've reached the end of AU-tober Week 1: College
> AND
> Have ALSO reached the first chapter focused on an AU I had planned BEFORE AU-tober was announced! I had to change the ending of this little chapter from how I wanted it because it was getting *too freaking long again* and I do still need sleep tonight, but if I ever make a full fledged fic on this AU I'll be able to put in the part I didn't get to here
>
> Hope you all enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Who's gonna nail these auditions?!" Glimmer hollers as she bounces her way down the hall.

"*We're* gonna nail these auditions!" Bow responds just as enthusiastically and just as bouncy, pumping both fists in the air.

"Hell *yeah* we are!"

The two swing their hands into a mighty high-five, the clap of their palms echoing through the halls the same as their speedy footsteps. Auditions were happening in five minutes, and the two had hardly been able to sit through their classes all day—all *week* really—with so much excitement and anticipation bubbling in their veins.

"Haa!" Glimmer cheers again, clenching her fists. "I still can't believe Halfmoon U is *actually* doing it! I thought I'd have to wait for Broadway before I'd get to audition for this!"

Bow squeaks. "I know!! Gosh, no *wonder* Aunt Casta has been so smug lately, I bet she's been *dying* to tell us!"

"Ugh, my mom has been *just* as unbearable, I bet she knew too." Despite the groan, she wasn't put out even slightly. She was still too excited.

"Has Adora gotten back to you yet?"

Slowing her bouncy jog just a smidge, Glimmer whips out her phone so fast she almost drops it, but with a quick unrehearsed juggling act manages to avoid such a fate. She and Bow let out twin sighs of relief, and she checks for any new texts.

She frowns with a disappointed sound. "Aw man, she won't be able to make it until way later tonight." She pockets her phone and picks up her lost speed. "Good thing auditions go until 8:30, she might still make it in."

Bow laughs. "With how much she's been practicing? She'd better."

"We'd *all* better!" she laughs. The two dart around the final bend, sneakered feet squeaking on the tile floor. As they near the auditorium doors, she declares, "It'll be nothing short of a criminal offense if all three of us don't make it in!"

"Agreed," he nods, and with that, the two reach the grand double doors.

Plastered on its front are two posters, one a notice for auditions being held tonight, the other the exact same poster all three of the Best Friend Squad members have hanging up in their dorm rooms.

"SO MUCH HAPPENED BEFORE DOROTHY DROPPED IN.

W I C K E D

THE UNTOLD STORY OF THE WITCHES OF OZ"

Glimmer and Bow both beam bright as stars at each other. Both taking deep breaths, Bow holds out his hand, and Glimmer takes it.

“Ready, Fiyero?” Glimmer smirks.

Bow’s smile sends her heart a flutter. “Ready, Elphaba.”

With that, the two confidently march through the doors.

. . .

“I’m so sorry, my dears, but the role for Elphaba has already been filled.”

Glimmer and Bow’s jaws both drop, the audition papers in their hands almost slipping away in their shock.

“I— bu— auditions just barely started!” Glimmer babbles helplessly, hopelessly confused and disappointed.

Casta, the appointed director for the upcoming play, shrugs sympathetically. “I’m afraid there’s not much I can do, loves. The moment we found our Elphaba we knew we had to give her the part. But worry not! The two of you may still audition! There are many other roles still available, and I have full confidence the both of you can and will get roles that you will both absolutely *shine* in.”

Casta’s assistant director, an elf woman named Juliet, clears her throat to draw the standing woman’s attention. She lifts an eyebrow at her, a warning, and Castaspella scoffs and waves her off.

“Oh, don’t give me that look, you know as well as I that if these two make it in it will have nothing to do with my being their aunt. You’ve seen their talent, you know I’m right.”

Juliet hums and looks back to her clipboard, a small amused grin on her face. When she looks back up, she lifts her pen at the two onstage.

“As Ms. King has already stated, the two of you are still free to audition. If you’d both still like to go through with auditioning, we

may begin whenever one of you decides you're ready."

Still feeling a wave of disappointment at missing out on Elphaba (somehow; were they even allowed to close auditions for the literal main character this early?) Glimmer looks to Bow. He seems a little down, too, his eyes already on Glimmer, and it warms her heart to see him disappointed on her behalf. He was always such a sweetheart like that. Still displaying symptoms of said sweet-heartedness, the young man smiles at her and shrugs a shoulder.

"You know what? I still say let's go for it," he says. "There was never any guarantee we'd land the parts we initially wanted anyway. Now we just know ahead of time, is all."

Smiling, Glimmer sighs. "You're right. Why throw away this opportunity just because one part isn't available?"

Bow beams. He steps off to the side, gesturing for her to go first, and again Glimmer finds herself smiling softly at him.

Stars, she loved her dorky gentleman.

Stepping forward, brimming with confidence as Bow eagerly shoots her a double thumbs up from the side, Glimmer takes her place at center stage and takes a deep breath. Casta claps her hands excitedly as she retakes her seat, scooting it forward and absolutely bursting at the seams with pride.

Juliet softly rolls her eyes, the amused grin back on her face for but a moment. She meets Glimmer's gaze, and nods her head.

"Whenever you're ready."

With that, she begins to sing.

For her audition, she'd chosen to sing one of the arguably more popular songs of the musical, *Loathing*. Even despite knowing Elphaba's role was taken, she still chose to sing her part of the song along with Glinda's. It was easy enough to, the two characters had no overlapping lines and when they did they were

singing the same words anyway, just in different harmonies. For those parts, she went with Glinda. She struggled not to laugh when, during the part of the song where other characters were singing, Bow chimed in to cover them, but soon enough it was her turn again.

With the end of the song came a round of applause from Bow, Casta and Juliet, and other people who had filed in during the song to also audition. Giving in to giddy desire, Glimmer bows before taking her leave. Bow spreads his arms wide as his smile as she passes and she darts in for a quick hug before he could head up next.

"Good luck," she tells him as she pulls away with a grin. "Not that you'll need it, of course."

He laughs.

Just as she'd expected, he really doesn't need the luck at all. He goes up there just as confidently as she had, and when he starts singing his voice comes out as the softest song she's ever heard. She loves it when Bow sings. He's never been too confident in his singing abilities, and maybe objectively he wasn't the greatest at it, but so what?

Any song immediately became her favorite so long as he was the one singing it.

Glimmer cheers as loud as she can when he reaches the end of his song and takes a bow of his own, and she's thrilled to see an adorable blush bloom on his smile-stretched cheeks. She pulls him in for a kiss the moment he's off stage and close enough for her to do so, and his gentle laugh blows against her lips as his shaking hands wrap around her waist.

"Well," he clears his throat to get rid of the pitched squeak, "I think that went well."

"You were amazing," she states powerfully, because it was true. He blushes at the compliment, but she's proud to see him accept

it instead of waving it off.

Casta stands to see them out. She probably isn't supposed to, there's still more auditions to be held, but no one was going to stop her, even if Juliet did still roll her eyes again. "That you were, darling! Both of you were! I obviously can't make any final decisions here and now, but I'd say you both have fantastic chances of getting the roles you desire!"

The two share excited smiles again as they get closer to the doors. They both thank Casta for the chance to audition (and the early heads up she most definitely had gotten in trouble with Juliet for giving them) and turn to leave to celebrate with ice cream and pizza.

"One more thing, my dear Glimmer?"

Surprised, Glimmer halts and turns back around.

Casta is once again nearly vibrating with excitement. "I probably shouldn't be telling you this…" she looks around conspiratorially, then bends over to whisper behind her hand, "You have a better shot at landing Glinda than most." She winks. "Our Elphaba made it quite clear how well she'd thought you do with the part, and after your audition I'm more than confident she was right. Juliet is, too."

Glimmer *really* hoped the floors were as clean as she'd been led to believe, because that's where her jaw currently sat.

Casta giggles ecstatically as she straightens and eyes the two with clear and near overwhelming pride in her eyes. "I'll let the two of you know if you made it the moment I find out. Best of luck, my loves," she says as she pulls them both into a mighty embrace.

Glimmer's jaw is still on the floor by the time Casta's retreated back into the auditorium and the doors have eased themselves shut. In her peripherals, she can tell Bow is in the exact same boat.

. . .

"Okay, it *has* to be Adora, right?"

After a near half an hour of excitedly squealing with Bow, the two had managed to calm down and fulfill their mission of ice cream and pizza. The night had been filled with nothing but energetic "what if"s and "who could it be"s and "I bet you totally nailed it, you'll definitely get a part," amidst other just as smoothly delivered questions and declarations. The second day had been nothing but the exact same thing.

As had the next week.

Munching on a fry and leaning back into the couch the BFS had long since claimed in the campus living room as theirs, she continues, "She has to be the one who got Elphaba and suggested me for Glinda's role. It explains why she wasn't able to come to auditions with us and why I was recommended."

Bow hums, sitting with his legs in her lap as he tinkered with something. Glimmer was pretty sure it was for a project he was working on with Entrapta. "That would make the most sense. And if she's already landed that role that also explains why she's been too busy to hang out or answer many texts, she's probably been rehearsing non-stop to make sure she's perfect."

"Ughh, I just wish she'd answer her stupid phone once in a blue moon so we could know for sure." Reaching for another fry and finding none, she groans again and begrudgingly (gently) shoves Bow's legs off so she can stand up. "Come on. I ate all our food and I need more."

Bow snorts but gets up to follow after her. "Let's maybe actually save some for our dearest maybe-possibly Elphaba this time? She promised she'd be here as soon as she could be."

"If she actually shows up in time there'll still be plenty left over for her."

“Not if you keep eating it all!” he laughs, linking his fingers with hers and happily swinging their hands.

Glimmer feels herself melt at the action, smiling adoringly, but still steadfastly harrumphs in response to his statement. “I’m not the one with two hollow legs and a bottomless pit for a stomach, I actually have a limit.”

She also apparently had no sense of spatial awareness anymore, as not even a full second later she rams right into another individual with a startled grunt and almost topples them both to the ground. Letting out a rapid string of curses, she straightens as quick as she can and scrambles to apologize.

“Stars and skies, I’m sorry! I’m a little distracted right now and—” her apology comes to a screeching halt as she finally registers who she’d just barreled into, and the rest of the sentence shrivels and dies on her tongue as her expression of shock sinks down into a glare. “Oh. It’s you.”

Dusting off her clothes as if Glimmer had actually gotten anything on them, Catra sneers down at her with annoyance clear as day in her stance and eyes both. “Sparkles,” she greets crossly, readjusting the bag she has slung over her shoulder. “I guess I shouldn’t be surprised. When are you *not* ‘a little distracted?’”

She scoffs. “Says the girl who can never look at anything else whenever your girlfriend is within a fifty foot radius of you.”

Catra folds her arms, tail swinging behind her. “Yet somehow I’ve never crashed into anyone even once.” Her sneer slowly morphs into a smirk. “You know, maybe it’s a height thing. Have you tried platform boots? I’m sure Double Trouble would be willing to lend you a pair for the right price.”

“Okay, don’t *even*,” Glimmer fumes. “You are *not* that much taller than me.”

“We could test that, actually, cuz I just so happen to be bringing some of Entrapta’s things to her and I know she has a measuring

stick in here somewhere."

"Please do! Then we can see how far we can shove it up your—"

"Ookkayy!" Bow interjects speedily, literally placing himself between them. "Let's not go there, actually. Catra, I really am sorry we bumped into you, I promise we'll be more careful from now on."

Glimmer kinda hates that when confronted with Bow Catra actually does soften and back down. Like yeah, he was genuinely good at that kind of thing and everyone kinda loved him, but it still drove her a little mad to know that he had the jerk's respect and she didn't. The magicat shrugs a shoulder as if she hadn't just been pushing every single one of Glimmer's buttons and says smoothly, "It's whatever, Arrows. I'm sure Scorpia's bumped into me way more often than you two." She smirks down at Glimmer again, and her fury spikes through the roof. "So maybe it really is a height thing."

Just before Glimmer could threaten murder or some other fate equally as deserved, a bubbly voice pierces the air, and all three look up just in time to see Adora barreling towards them and throwing herself at Bow and Glimmer for an excited embrace.

"You guys!" she cheers excitedly, "Check your phones, they've finally announced who made the auditions!"

Feeling every ounce of anger drain out of her faster than a popped water balloon as excitement takes its place, Glimmer whips out her phone alongside Bow, neither noticing the curious expression gracing the magicat's features.

After some frantic searching for the notification and pulling it up to quickly skim through it, Glimmer feels that same excitement spilling over until she can't hold it back.

"I got Glinda!" she gasps, then squeals. "I got Glinda I'm *Glinda*!!"

Adora squeals right alongside her and scoops her up to swing her around, the two laughing loudly and happily.

Glimmer gasps again as Adora slows, and she quickly turns to face Bow. “Bow, what did you get? What did you get?? Did you get Fiyero?” She gasps a third time, bouncing in place. “You totally got Fiyero tell me you got Fiyero!”

Adora winces and shares a look with Catra, but Glimmer doesn’t notice, too focused on Bow who… isn’t as excited as she’d hoped he be.

“Well,” he says after a minute, still smiling though not as brightly as he should have been as he meets her eyes. He waves his phone in the air and says, “I’m not Fiyero, but I figure I can pull off a tin-man fairly decently.”

“Oh. You got Boq?”

He shrugs, his smile more genuine now at least. “I mean I’m pretty happy with that, honestly. I don’t know if I could have kept up with Fiyero’s role.” Before they can linger on his role any further, he turns to Adora. “Hey, what role did you get by the way? Are you our elusive Elphaba after all?”

Glimmer brightens a little and turns to face their friend.

Adora shuffles awkwardly and shares another look with Catra. “Um… okay so I feel really bad about this now, but…”

Catra evidently takes pity on her and sighs. “She’s Fiyero. Or… Fiyera? Did they tell you if they were changing the gender or not?”

Adora shakes her head, biting her lip. She turns to Bow again, sheepish. “I’m really sorry, Bow, I didn’t know you wanted the role so bad or I wouldn’t have auditioned.”

But Bow’s quick to wave her off, his energy slowly returning full force. “No, no! It’s okay, you guys, I promise! Look the more I

think about it the more I'm positive I wouldn't have been a good Fiyero, he's basically another lead and I don't think I'm ready for that." His smile is finally as ecstatic as Glimmer was hoping for. "Adora, you're going to be *perfect*. And besides, do you realize what this means?? We're all gonna be in this musical! We get to do it together after all!"

With the reassurance that he wasn't upset, Adora's excitement tentatively makes a return as well, as does Glimmer's, even if she is still a little bummed that Bow didn't get the part he wanted.

A spike of annoyance digs through her again at Catra's amused snicker.

"Of course the two of of you are also musical nerds," she shakes her head, amused. "As if I didn't have to put up with that enough from this dolt already."

Adora scoffs and smirks at the magicat. "Oh like you're one to talk." She looks to Bow and Glimmer with a near triumphant grin and declares, "This deserves celebratory ice cream and pizza!"

Glimmer rolls her eyes and laughs. "We already did that. Let's do something different this time."

"Wait, huh?" Adora's eyes find hers. "What do you mean? When did you celebrate?"

She sympathetically pats the blonde's back. "Right after we auditioned. We waited for you but you never showed up or responded."

The blonde's corresponding sad puppy pout almost gets her to feel bad. Almost. But Adora doesn't give her the chance to before she's popping back up like a daisy and saying, "Okay, something else then. What sounds good? McDonald's?" She gasps, ignoring the gags she gets from Bow, Glimmer, *and* Catra, and turns to the latter. "Catra, you should join us!"

Thankfully, before Glimmer can veto, Catra raises her hands and takes a noticeable step back. “For McDonald’s? No thanks, I’d rather take my chances with the cafeteria food.” She chuckles at Adora’s sad whine and shakes her head as she turns to leave. “Dummy. Look, I really do need to get this all to Entrapta but I’ll hunt you down later and we can have whatever gross fake food you want, alright?”

Glimmer isn’t really sure how Adora doesn’t give herself whiplash with how fast she perks back up yet again and rapidly nods her head.

“Okay!” she agrees happily, then calls out gooishly, “I love yoou!”

Catra snickers again. “Love you too, you dork.” She turns to leave, but her ear flicks at Glimmer’s continued exaggerated gagging, and after only a few steps she turns back. “Oh, and Sparkles?”

Her call stops the trio in their tracks, and they all look back to see the magicat grinning knowingly.

“Do me a favor and bring your best pointy hat to practice. I’m afraid I’ve misplaced mine.” Her tail coils with the same sly and mischievous energy she carries in her expression. She salutes farewell, and leaves the Best Friend Squad behind with two of the three’s jaws on the (still hopefully clean) floors.

Slowly, Bow and Glimmer turn to Adora, who doesn’t seem surprised in the slightest.

“Adora?” Glimmer asks slowly.

“Yeah?”

“Did Catra also get a part in the musical?”

The blonde lights up proudly. “Yep! She’s the one and only Elphaba!” Her brow furrows, and she frowns. “Hey, what’s with that look on your face—”

Glimmer turns on a dime, marching after the magicat with a heated fury powering her steps the likes of which she hasn't felt in a long time. With the confirmation of who actually had the lead, there was only one thing she could focus on anymore.

"What the hell did you mean when you said I'd be the perfect Glinda?! Catra, you get *back here right now!*"

Chapter End Notes

> Listen every time I listen to Wicked literally all I imagine is this AU with Glimmer and Catra slowburning their way to friendship as they practice being Glinda and Elphaba respectively
>
> Casta, Juliet, and literally everyone else in charge of casting and directing are sold on their choices for Elphaba and Glinda the moment they have Catra and Glimmer rehearse "Loathing" together, they're a little *too* good at it

Medieval/Fantasy - Mercenaries

Chapter Notes

> CW: Catra's mental health is completely shot in this one, and Adora really isn't much better; please tread carefully, I'll add a recap of what happens in the end notes if you'd rather not read this one
>
> Lmbo I really hope this is written well enough that my exhaustion isn't completely obvious
>
> EDIT: It was 🤦 I apologize, there is now a content warning and I will do my best to apply those in the future

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Don't give me that look, sweetheart. I'd strongly advise that you accept this mission. After all… she *already has."*

Those words, the knowledge that *she'd* already accepted to hunt her to the death no matter the cost, haunted Adora's every move, fueled her every breath. It gave her the strength to push forward even in moments of complete exhaustion, knowing that one minor slip up was all it would take for *her* to get the upper hand and take her life.

It was how they'd been raised, it was something *she* had always *excelled* at.

It was how Adora was going to get *her* first.

It was how she was… it was how she was going to kill her.

Kill… Catra.

Darting around another corner, she all but slams herself against the wall, not quite holding her breath but not allowing herself to emit a single sound with it. The problem with being hunted by your own target was if you had know idea where they were, *you had no idea where they were*. And considering her target was *Catra* of all people…

Well, she was kind of exceptionally screwed.

After waiting a few moments, she sticks her head out and looks around from beneath her hood. Sensing no predatory eyes on her, she carefully extracts herself from the alleyway, but keeps her sword partially out of her scabbard. She knew from experience she'd need it at the ready at a moment's notice, and even the slightest hindrance would cost her.

She remains vigilant as she slowly makes her way through the rather quaint little village, once more forcibly tamping down any and all reminders of the life she and Catra used to lead. She couldn't think of how they used to run through towns together, how they used to just barely scrape by together in the days before Lady Weaver, how while under the cruel mistress' dreadful ire they stuck together like the stickiest of glues.

She couldn't think about how one fateful day had ruined a lifetime spent *together*. She couldn't think about how from that day forth there was only anger and hatred and pain.

She couldn't think about how hunting the one she lov— cared for more than anyone was slowly killing her too.

She could only focus on killing Catra first. If she thought about anything else, about any of their past or any of their joy or any of their lo— care for each other, the grief would surely do her in first, long before the magicat had a chance to claim her life for her own.

Part of her wondered if that would really be so terrible.

With a shudder, she shakes off the thought. No. She could not allow herself to die, not yet at least. Too many people were counting on her to provide for them. Too many people were counting on her to keep them safe.

She wouldn't have accepted this mission, to hunt the other down and end her life at any and all costs, if Catra hadn't accepted it first. Even then, even when she'd found out Catra had accepted the mission to *kill her*, she still hadn't wanted to take the mission to hunt her in turn.

But Catra was the best, the most efficient and world-renown mercenary in the world. No one escaped her.

Adora had seen that first hand.

Her breath hitches and she curses, hurriedly brushing away the lone tear that made it past her stoic mask. She couldn't afford that. She couldn't afford to care.

Not anymore.

A clatter on the rooftops has her whipping around and drawing her sword. She doesn't see anyone or anything but for a few shingles falling to the ground, just barely disturbed.

Furrowing her brow, she hides her sword under her cloak but keeps it hidden. Tugging her hood down further over her face, she listens for anything more to guide her to her pursuer.

The soft, almost inaudible sound of claws scraping along more tile.

Gritting her teeth, she rushes forward, following the sounds and keeping to the shadows. Catra was here. She was hunting her.

And soon… Adora swallows dryly and steels herself, her eyes flashing dangerously…

Her corpse would be lying at the blonde's feet.

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"No. No way in hell. Matter of fact, you can go there yourself. I am not *hunting* her.*"*

"You may want to reconsider, kitten."

"And why should I?"

"Oh, darling," their smile sent shivers down her spine, making her tail lash. Their words make her heart plummet. "Because she's *already accepted it herself."*

Catra never thought there'd be a world where she and Adora weren't just at odds with one another… but were actively trying to kill each other.

They hadn't been on the best of terms for a good few years before she'd been given her latest mission. One thing had led to another, sparks and tempers had ignited and flared on both ends, and things once beautiful between them became ugly as sin.

But never in her life had she wanted this.

When she'd first found out Adora had taken on a mission to hunt her, she was livid, and used that fury to give her the strength she needed to hunt her in turn, the person she was once closest with in all the world.

She had a reputation as the best mercenary there is for a reason. She simply never failed when she set out to accomplish something. She wasn't always tasked with killing, really it was hardly ever, but no matter if it was an assassination or not, she always succeeded. Sure, some missions were harder, some even seemed downright impossible. Multiple had taken years for her to fulfill. But she still had. Every single time. She was good at what she did. The *best* at what she did.

Only three days after accepting *this* mission, she could have ended it and moved onto the next.

Instead, she'd let her prey escape.

Adora was good. She wasn't the best. She'd been hunting Catra the same time the magicat was hunting the human, but hadn't even realized how close to death she'd come. Not just that day, either. Catra came so close, over and over and over again, to taking her life. And every single time…

At first she'd told herself she let her go because it was too easy. She told herself she needed to enjoy the thrill of the hunt before she could take out her target. She told herself that she'd wait until Adora was as good as she was before she actually tried to take her life and save her own.

She wasn't sure when the lies she told herself stopped being convincing. Well, no, she knew.

They'd never been convincing. And eventually, she'd lost the energy to keep trying to make them.

Eventually, the fury had faded. And all that was left was pain.

She'd tracked Adora to a rather quaint little village. As she watches the human dart between alleyways and homes, she can't help but let her tired mind wander, instead of paying the same rapt attention to her target she had at the start of all this. It's a cozy little place. She detects many different scents all mingling together, any and all species gathered here as a community from anywhere and everywhere. She hears laughter from children as they race through the streets, and looks away from Adora for a moment to watch as a young duo run up to what appears to be a bakery, and eagerly exchange a few tokens for a fresh, steaming loaf of soft, delicious smelling bread.

This place was so bright and joyful. She wonders if maybe, had things been different, she'd be here as a villager, instead of a passerby on the hunt. Maybe, in another life, they could have even lived here *together*, set up a life here together. Maybe had they both been brave enough to find one another again, before

this whole stupid hunt had the chance to happen, maybe they could have reclaimed the joy and peace they'd once known in each other's presence.

Her eyes slowly trail back to where she'd last seen Adora. The human is gone. She sighs.

Once, she would have cursed herself out for letting herself get distracted, for losing her target so infuriatingly easily.

Oh how her past self would hate watching her *let it happen on purpose*.

Pushing herself up from where she'd been slouched on the roof, she doesn't bother trying to scan her surroundings to find her again. She makes her way across the wobbly shingles, letting her claws catch on them on purpose, knocking a few off and watching them fall and crash below, as she reaches the edge and leaps to the ground. She lands as gracefully as always. Eyeing the dust rising from the broken tiles, she readjusts her scarf and walks back out into the sunlight.

Anyone else wouldn't be able to hear the soft footfalls trailing after her. Anyone else wouldn't be able to hear the subtle rustle of fabric as a weapon is concealed underneath.

Anyone else would turn and fight a moment too late.

As she walks through the streets, hints of envy stirring in the broken shards of her heart as she lets the sounds of quaint village life wash over her, she instinctively takes note of all her advantages, all the things she could use to get the drop on her stalker. Her hunter. Her *reaper*.

The weight of several hidden daggers sags gently against her hip from where they hang at her belt. Her claws slink in and out of her fingers and toes. She runs her tongue along the sharp edge of her fangs.

She had everything she needed to take a life. To take any life.

But she wasn't sure anymore if she could actually take *hers*, even with her own on the line.

She wasn't sure if she ever could have.

Anyone else wouldn't have noticed the near-silent figure getting closer. Anyone else wouldn't have noticed the flutter of her cloak as brushes it aside to expose her sword. Anyone else wouldn't have noticed her slowly moving to grip the hilt with both hands to prepare for a blow.

Anyone else who *had* managed to notice any one of those things would have rested their hand on their own weapon, just in case.

But Catra wasn't just anyone.

Adora was finally almost as good at this as she was. Maybe she'd be the new best. Catra told herself she'd be alright with losing this time, if that were the case.

It wasn't a lie.

She'd run out of energy for those ages ago.

No one else would have slowed to a stop with an assassin on their heels. No one else would have slowly tilted their head back to look at the sky, perfectly exposing their naked throat to a master swordswoman with perfect aim.

No one else would dare have *those* words as their last, with their killer behind them and not a soul in the world who cared for them.

But she isn't anyone else.

She's just no one.

She doesn't know if Adora will hear her or not. She's not sure if she cares anymore.

She hears the other mercenary lift her blade, and all she does is close her eyes and sigh out the three words she—a perfect no one—had chosen as her last.

"I love you," she breathes out softly.

No one else hears it.

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"You might as well accept this mission yourself. After all, she *already has. If* you *don't kill* her*,* she *will kill* you*."*

While the statement hadn't been delivered quite the same way both times they'd said it, the message had been the same.

The blatant lie had served its purpose well, and Double Trouble had never been more endlessly amused at what had followed.

Catra of D'riluth and Adora of House Grayskull. Two wonderfully efficient mercenaries with a deep and alluring history to both their names, one the ever curious caimisk had happily dug up with greater and greater glee the more juicy details they'd uncovered.

Both hunters had tried to make it clear as day that they were forever and always done with one another, after the scandal that had very nearly shaken the kingdom itself to its core. And to anyone else, it was a believable lie. But to Double Trouble?

Oh, they *knew* there was more to it than that. They had the paper trail to prove it.

And oh, how tempting it was, to dig their claws in as deep as they could and have some fun with the tangled clump of cataclysmic drama that had practically fallen right into their lap. To make an even grander event of it, a story better than any novel an author could piece together.

If they were to give into such a temptation, surely the already chaotic mess that was these two's lives would only get worse.

And… well, what could they say? As the saying went, temptation was a hell of a drug.

Setting up a game of cat and mouse with a literal cat in the mix was yet another layer of amusement to this whole silly event, but it wasn't the most endearing aspect to them by far.

Before setting up this little game of theirs, they'd known there could only be one victor. What they wanted to know, what had inspired this all in the first place, was who the victor would be.

Both would go at it with all their might, no doubt. There was so much pain between them, and so much on the line with the belief and then reality that both their lives were in danger, that neither could afford not to, and neither *would* want not to. But eventually, one would falter. One would collapse under the weight of hunting down someone they loved, someone they loved more than anything or anyone.

Double Trouble finds themself grinning ear to ear when the first signs of who that one would be first appear, much quicker than anticipated but no less thrilling to see happen.

They'd had a feeling it would be D'riluth.

Toward the beginning, had anyone else been watching the event play out as raptly as Double Trouble had, they'd have assumed Grayskull would be the one to fall. After all, she was soft-hearted and kind, nowhere near the perfect machine that D'riluth was, angry and skilled and stoic. Had this been a betting event, Double Trouble was certain all bets would be placed on the magicat as the winner.

And clearly, the chaotic puppeteer notes to themself with pure glee as they watch from the shadows Adora raise her sword and Catra raise her head, they would have lost.

After all, how would anyone else have known what to really look for? How would they have known that Adora, loved by many and lover of many, would find the determination to see this mission

through, and take Catra's life? How would they have known that Catra, loved by no one and lover of one, would find only the truth she'd been desperately trying to ignore, and the unwillingness to take Adora's life?

Double Trouble's smile all but splits their face in two. They oh so loved when their predictions came true.

The blade swings down.

Chapter End Notes

> RECAP: Double Trouble manipulates both Catra and Adora into thinking the other is hunting them down, tricking them both into a self-fulfilling prophesy. Adora has reason to fight to stay alive, but Catra feels she does not, and gives up the hunt right at the end, giving Adora a shot at a killing blow. It is up to interpretation whether or not she kills her.
>
> *Gasps*
>
> Did Adora hear what Catra said?
>
> Did she actually kill Catra??
>
> FIND OUT NEXT TIME ON CARTOON NETWO—
>
> Jk I don't actually know lol

Medieval/Fantasy - Tournament

Chapter Notes

> I'm freaking wheezing, I'm working on tomorrow's chapter and it's already over 5k words long lmbo whoops

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Lonnie holds out a full canteen, the lid already off.

"And here I thought cats couldn't sweat," she grins, letting Catra snatch the bottle and throw it back almost instantly, throat bobbing as she chugs greedily. She holds up a finger, keeping it up until she's drained the bottle.

She swallows and wipes her mouth, grinning back as she lifts the neck of her tunic to wipe the perspiration from her face. "Call me a cat again, see where that gets you."

"Cats *can* sweat, actually!" Kyle chirps as he hurries over with a fresh towel, one Catra takes just as gratefully as she had the canteen. "Unlike magicats, who have sweat glands in most of the same places humans do and therefore can sweat similarly to us, cats themselves only have sweat glands in a few areas, like their paw pads!"

Catra hums and hangs the towel around her neck, looking down at her hands and feet. The pads on those definitely got sweaty and gross the quickest, the matches she'd had today had made that plenty obvious.

"*Good thing you never wear shoes anyway*," Rogelio snickers with a caimisk grumble of a laugh, chortling when Catra chucks the now empty canteen at him.

You're just jealous, Mister 'I need an actual barrel of ice anytime there's a slight uptick in temperature.'"

Rogelio rolls his eyes and Catra snickers. "*I'm not* that *bad*."

"Lay off the lug," Lonnie scorns with a gentle slap to Catra's shoulder. "He's sensitive."

"Ignore them both," Kyle soothes as he stands to quickly give the caimisk a kiss. "They're *both* just jealous they're single."

The women *both* roll their eyes at that.

"Still not sure how to feel about you suddenly having a backbone," the human of the two sniffs, shaking her head.

"Ditto," the magicat of the two huffs.

Catra's ears perk up as the sound of shuffling footsteps echo down the hall. A moment later, one of the tournament assistants pokes her head in, knocking on the doorframe and drawing everyone's attention. She smiles, then finds the champion's eyes.

"Ten more minutes until showtime, D'riluth!" she announces, clearly excited. "Will that be enough time?"

Catra snorts and moves to stand, stretching out her arms. "More than enough. Thanks for the heads up."

The assistant nods and ducks back out, leaving the fighter and her crew to prepare. As Kyle and Rogelio get back to bustling about the room collecting supplies to assist the magicat, Lonnie trails after the woman in question as she towels off as much sweat as she can.

"You sure ten minutes is enough?" she asks, her voice little more than a murmur, though one Catra obviously heard just fine.

The trace of concern and care didn't escape her notice either. "I'll be fine," she promises, her voice also softer. As she runs through another series of stretches, she smiles, ignoring the ache pulling at each limb. "It's just one more match, then we'll all head out to

celebrate and unwind. I'm not an idiot, Lon, I know my limits now."

She sighs softly. "I know that. But I'm allowed to worry anyway. We know nothing about your last opponent, and I can tell you're almost to the point of running on nothing but fumes."

Catra's smile spreads into a confident smirk, even as her heart warms. She was glad she'd taken the time to make amends with the trio, after everything that had happened. She wasn't sure where she'd be without them.

Even if it did mean she now had to deal with Lonnie actually *caring* about her. "I'll be careful, *Mom*," she teases with a punch to the shoulder.

Lonnie's lip curls, but she at least seems amused. "You'd better," she warns as the boys approach with more water and a handful of nutrient bars. "I'm holding you to your promise."

Catra nods, and the two turn to the others. Each taking a nutrient bar, they look to the fighter, who hoists hers in the air and says with a grin, "Now who's ready for one last victory, and then a mighty victory dine?"

The other three all cheer, and the four bring the nutrient bars together in a toast.

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Raucous cheers and thundering applause immediately roar to life as Catra sets foot back onto the battlefield for one last performance. The sounds rumble through the stadium and rattle through her chest, filling her to the brim with excitement and delight. Unable to help herself, she raises her arms in the air, encouraging more joyous cries and shouts to surge addictingly.

She *breathes* it in, reveling in the affection meant for her, affection she'd fought for and earned after so long of wanting and needing nothing more than someone to care.

Now people did. They cared about *her*. They loved *her*.

And she knew that no matter the outcome of any tournament she found herself in, that love would linger, feeding her endlessly. She knew it, was confident in it even.

Because the times that she had fallen, the times that she'd been defeated or hurt, the people had still cheered for her, had still loved her.

Even if she didn't have them, though, she'd be alright.

The three idiots now unfortunately stuck to her like glue wouldn't let her forget it.

"GO CATRAAAA!!!" She hears Kyle screech from the spectators' seats, the ones reserved for those close to the fighters. All three of them were there, all three enthusiastically encouraging the cheers of her name. Rogelio lets out a mighty roar that many other hybrids in the stands add to, and even Lonnie was feeling festive enough to throw in her own whoops and hollers.

Beaming wide as the oceans and high off of the cries of her name, Catra almost forgets that she had an actual opponent she needed to face, until the shuffle of boots just barely snags her attention. The cheers die down as the other fighter approaches, and Catra turns to face them, a grin and a challenge on her tongue.

Both die as fast as the ambience the moment she sees who it is standing across from her.

She freezes, despite the way her blood begins to boil, despite the way her claws instinctively start to poke out, despite the way her hackles raise and her tail twitches with the urge to thrash about unhinged and wild.

It couldn't be… she wouldn't *dare*…

But the other woman slowly pulls back her hood, letting it fall at her shoulders to free her blonde hair, half up in a ponytail and half down, blowing in the gentle breeze as those stormy gray-blue eyes find pin-pricked blue and yellow.

And it was. And she *did* dare.

Catra isn't the first to voice her outrage, still frozen in a mix of heated emotions.

Lonnie is.

"GET *OUT!!*" she *howls*, breaking the silence and freeing the rage everyone was starting to feel. "Get *OUT* you *TRAITOR!!*"

Like her cry had been the permission everyone was looking for, other outraged voices and shouts and even screams rise up one by one, until the stadium is alive with venomous spat out hellfire, all directed at the woman standing apart from Catra. Rogelio lets loose an earsplitting roar of fury, Kyle all but goes manic beside him as he looses a string of curses and hate that go unheard in the face of the caimisk's roar, people throw things both physical and verbal down at the blonde, and all the while she stands, a strange, almost broken look of heartache and despair in her eyes.

Still Catra remains frozen, as she stares disbelievingly at the phantasm before her, the thing that surely had to be a hallucination, because how could *she* be back? How *dare* she be back? It had to be fake. It couldn't be real.

That woman simply couldn't be Adora.

And then Adora steps towards Catra. The strange spell over her shatters, and her claws all but violently eject. With a near strangled hiss she lunges back, away from *her*, and finally her own venom is spat forth at its target as her cloak billows around her.

"What the *hell* are *you* doing here?" she growls, her voice strained and her tail lashing furiously. Before Adora can answer she lifts

her head and barks, "What the *HELL* do you think *you're doing* here, Adora?!"

Adora flinches back, even as the din of the crowd's rage finally dies down some in response to Catra's anger, as though she hadn't been expecting such a pure and vile hatred from the magicat of all people.

"Catra," she murmurs, taking another tentative step forward until Catra hisses at her again and she stops, hurt in her eyes. "I… I came to find you. I need your help."

Catra scoffs, bewildered and incredulous, and another chorus of booing runs through the stadium. Her ears pin, and a monster of a growl rumbles through her throat.

"My *help*?" she seethes. "After everything you did, you really think you get to come crawling back here, and ask for *my help*?!"

Again, that pain flashes across Adora's face, and Catra can't help but bitterly think *good; she deserves to hurt for what she did*.

But the hurt doesn't diminish her determination. She doesn't step forward again, instead she lowers her hands and lets her voice soften.

"Catra," she begins, and Catra's lips curl as another growl rumbles from her throat. Adora's brows tighten, but she continues. "I'm sorry."

And Catra's growl dies.

Encouraged by the quiet, Adora keeps going. "I'm so, *so* sorry. I never wanted to leave you behind. I never wanted to leave *any* of you behind."

Huffing angrily, Catra whips around and paces away, but still Adora keeps going.

"I mean it," she insists, her words echoing across the field, tears clear by the strain in her voice. "If I could have taken you with me, I would have in a heartbeat. Catra, you've always meant the world to me, and every moment I had to spend without you was torture. I *missed* you, you jerk."

Catra stops pacing, but doesn't turn to face her.

"I still want you with me," Adora's voice softens further. "I *need* you with me. I came back here for *you*."

There was a time, once, when her words would have softened the jagged edges of Catra's scarred over heart. There was a time when being told she was wanted by her would have been enough to send her packing into the blonde's arms without a care in the world. And maybe, for a moment, that time could have been now.

If not for what Adora had already said, and repeated again now.

"I need your help, Catra."

The crowd watches intently as Catra steels her shoulders with a deep breath, and slowly turns back around, her expression blank but for the furrow of her brows, even as Adora's expression lights up.

She prowls towards the blonde, and with each step closer Adora lights up brighter and brighter, and the crowd grows more and more tense.

She stops right before the human, and Adora beams. She holds out a hand, and Catra stares at it.

"Come with me," she begs, hope and light shining like a flickering ember in her voice, tentative but able to grow if encouraged. She waves her free hand at where Catra's friends sat and lets her gaze wander to them. "All of you can, you and Lonnie and Rogelio and Kyle. You can get out of this place. You don't have to keep fighting for these people, you can be free. We can be together again."

The ember in her eyes sizzles out, doused with confusion and shock when she looks back to see Catra gawking at her incredulously. The magicat's careful mask of stoicism fades, her ears pin, her eyes tighten, and another growl thunders deep in her chest. She bats away Adora's hand to the apparent delight of the crowd, and Adora's eyes widen as she jabs a claw in her chest.

"If you didn't want to fight," she snarls, "you shouldn't have entered the ring."

This time, Adora's hurt expression only fuels the blazing pyre of Catra's anger. She turns on her heel to march away, gritting her teeth when the blonde again tries to follow after her and get her to just listen. She drops to all fours and bounds across the field to her starting marker, getting away from her old friend before she tore the human to shreds ahead of time.

She was done listening. There was nothing important for her to hear.

"Catra, *please*!" the traitor begs, going to run after her before she's stopped by the announcers' horns blaring.

Those overseeing the match *finally* step forward onto their little balcony, drawing all eyes for a moment.

"Welcome, one and all, to the fifth and final match of the day!" the man bellows, hands outstretched to bring focus back to the fighters. "Our challenger, one going by the name She-Ra, will face our reigning champion, the Wildcat, for the honor of the Grayskull Glory!"

The audience once more erupts in near violent cheers and ecstatic cries. Adora flinches at the overwhelming sound. Catra stands and soaks it in, fuel for the pyre in her heart.

Shaking her head and clearly desperate, Adora turns and again cries out for the magicat. "Catra!"

But Catra just sneers.

“Fighters!” the female announcer cries.

“Catra, *please*, we don’t have to do this!”

“Ready your weapons, and take your positions!”

Catra flexes her claws and takes up a crouch, standing on her toes as her hackles and the fur along her spine raise further, her pupils dilating. She sees Adora’s expression crumble further, and her hand seems to subconsciously float to the hilt of her sword.

“Please,” she begs again, no longer shouting. Only Catra could hear her now. “I don’t want— I *can’t* fight you.”

“Fighters ready?!”

Catra’s lip curls. “Then you shouldn’t have come back.”

The horns blare, the crowd’s voices collide into one and surge, and before Adora even has the chance to gasp, Catra advances.

Chapter End Notes

> Listen I am SO soft for a Horde Squad friendship between Catra and her squadmates you have no idea

Medieval/Fantasy - Power Dynamic (Part 1)

Chapter Notes

> Yunno… each prompt I wrote for was SUPPOSED to be 1-2k each, give or take a couple hundred words
>
> I accidentally pumped out 8-9k in one sitting for this prompt alone, yes that is almost the same length as Ch1 of Etherian Efflux, no I don't know what happened either blame Jewelstar and/or Kyle one or both of them made me do it
>
> Anywho, chapter count has up to 32 now cuz I lost control and need to split this into two chapters have fun GRERELKWRJL

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"A*gain, dammit*?!"

Adora pounds her fist against the table, growling as she surges to her feet to pace. This was the seventeenth time in not even twice as many days. How were they all so bad at this?? It was *one* thief!

One of her three advisors, a man named Jewelstar, sighs at his sister's report and his leige's fury. "Are we truly surprised? She's been running circles around us for years."

Tallstar, another of Adora's advisors, rubs circles into her temples. "Yes, but don't forget she's been slowing down. We have been improving our methods, she isn't as easily capable of the same scale of thievery she once was. The fact that she's been getting away with more as of late is a testament to nothing but her increasing frequency, is all."

Starla, Adora's third advisor and the one who had sheepishly delivered the report that had sparked the monarch's fury, tentatively clears her throat as she reaches for the ladle for the

potatoes. “I have to wonder what her motives are. It can’t be just that it’s thrilling for her, can it?”

Tallstar sniffs, amused. “Our dearest brother was once the finest example of a man fueled by nothing but adrenaline, remember? Some people really are simply performing for the rush and little more.”

“Thank you, sister mine, for once more refusing to let my past be buried.” Jewelstar deadpans, only just barely not glaring at her as she politely passes him the turkey and gravy with a subtle smirk.

“You’re so welcome, brother mine.”

Adora huffs. Normally she’d be plenty amused by the siblings’ slights and digs, would even participate herself as they enjoyed the full course prepared by the royal chefs. But this latest development was eating at her far more than usual. For some reason, she just couldn’t drop it.

“Regardless of her reasoning,” she spits, “she’s still a criminal, one who has gotten away with her crimes for far too long. How have we never found her? She works alone, that much we’ve deduced, so where does she go to rest? It has to be within the kingdom limits, her thievery happens far too frequently for her to be holed up beyond the borders. She must have a hideout of some sort nearby.”

Tallstar rolls her eyes. “As Jewelstar reminded us, she’s been doing this for years. Just as we’ve learned her habits, she’s likely learned ours.” Reaching for another helping herself, she continues. “A simple solution is available to combat this. We can slightly alter the routes and patrol times of the guards we send out to search for her, throwing her off and increasing the chances of her making a crucial mistake, thereby ensuring her capture.”

Adora scoffs. “She’ll just improvise and adapt again. And even if we do manage to catch her, who’s to say she won’t just squirrel her way back out?”

“Well for one thing, she’s a cat.”

Three pairs of eyes turn to glare with varying degrees of disappointment at the youngest star sibling, who smiles even as she sinks in her chair. Someone snorts but it certainly isn’t any of them.

“Get it?” she whispers, still sinking. “Cuz’ she’s a magicat and not a squirrel?” She sinks even lower. “Get it?”

Adora rubs the bridge of her nose and sighs gruffly. “Amusing, Starla. Can we focus, please?” She turns to the eldest sibling and nods. “I like your idea of switching up the patrols. But I still think we need to set up more measures than just that. Got anything else for me?”

Tallstar hums as she takes a meat bun from the center. “I have some advice, at least.” Adora’s head lifts, and the other woman snorts. “Take a seat and eat before the food is gone. You’ve barely touched your own plate and I’ve heard your stomach rumble twice now.”

The monarch frowns and grumbles her way back to her seat like a petulant child. “Fine, I’m eating,” she grumps, forking some pork and beans onto her plate before going for the salad. “But I still say we discuss further options while I do.”

“Don’t talk with your mouth full, Majesty,” the eldest advisor teases gently, and Adora sticks her tongue out at her. She rolls her eyes and delicately scoops up another mouthful of food. “Honestly, you’re lucky none of us ever blab to the public about how indecent you truly are behind closed doors. Your reputation would be ruined in seconds.”

She scoffs, but honestly she was regrettably cheering up against her will. Shaking her head and unable to deny the small smirk, she herself reaches for a meat bun next and finally starts to actually eat.

Tallstar was right, she really *was* hungry.

“I may have an idea,” Jewelstar hums, finally lifting his gaze from where he’d been staring into space at his wine glass, lost in thought. “Perhaps you yourself could join in the searches for our mysterious rogue.”

Adora lifts an eyebrow as she shovels in a spoonful of soup. She swallows, mindful of Tallstar’s little tease, then asks, “Do you really think that would aid our efforts?”

“You’re definitely determined enough for such a thing to be true,” the man chuckles. “But even aside from that, I do think it would help. Not only would you be able to feel more involved in this mess, but you’d be able to get out of the palace more often, and would be able to interact with the people more frequently. I know how much you’ve missed your trips through town.”

Her shoulders slowly lift as Jewelstar’s idea takes root in her mind. She truly had missed the time she could spend among her people, amidst the children especially. She loved running about and playing with them, forgetting the weight of the crown for a time and just enjoying life.

“Why did those even stop to begin with?” she asks quietly, not really sure if she was anticipating an answer.

Tallstar’s expression softens. “You’ve gotten so wrapped up in your work lately you haven’t had time.” She nods at her brother. “I think your idea is a wonderful one. I too believe it would be most beneficial to you to reclaim those moments.”

She smiles, the first real smile of the night. “You know… you’re right. Maybe it would be good for me to be out and about from time to time again.” She cuts another slab of her meat and dips it in her gravy. “And I like the idea of being able to help search for our criminal. Maybe it’ll help put my mind at ease to witness first-hand her skill. At worst, it’ll help me come up with a new plan to finally stop her, should our other efforts fail.”

Starla hums. “I still wish to know *why* she’s doing all this. There has to be a method to her madness.”

Adora sighs. Her earlier storm of frustration was finally passing. “Right now, I truly don’t think I can care all that much. That’s a matter we’ll have to save for once she’s found and detained. I’ll care about it then.” She polishes off the last of her serving and turns to her side. “Tali, would you please pass the buns my way?”

She smiles and nods her head, turning to secure the bowl. “My pleasu—” Her eyes widen and her jaw drops. “Huh. Did we really go through *all* of those that quickly?”

“Are we out already?” she frowns. “Aw, man. I really *should* have sat back down sooner.” She turns to scoop some more potatoes onto her plate, and startles when she finds the bowl just straight up missing. “I… wha—?”

“Hey, where’d the pork roast go?” Starla pipes in, frowning at where the tray had sat just a moment ago.

Adora’s brow furrows. “What in the world?”

“There is… significantly less turkey on this tray than there was a moment ago,” Jewelstar scoffs, glaring at the one slice that remained like it had personally offended him.

Adora catches something darting out of sight in her peripherals and whips around to find the last of the lobster risotto now missing. Her jaw drops.

“Who just took the lobster??” she balks, shooting up again from her seat. “What is—?!”

A loud crash has all four heads whipping around to see the tray cover of one of the dishes clanking along the tile floor as it rolls steadily to a stop.

“What in the hell…?”

Starla yelps. “The second course table!”

They all whip around and gawk at the sight. The once fully stocked display was now completely empty.

Adora’s jaw clenches. It couldn’t be, she couldn’t be *that* cocky, could she?

Another clank of a dish lid sounds from the other side of the room, but while the advisors all are distracted by it Adora doesn’t move.

There, she catches movement in the corner of her eye, and only then whips around, just in time to see a smug, scruffy face grinning at her, a bulging tablecloth full of stolen goodies hanging from her back.

“Hey, Adora,” the figure rasps coyly, her tail coiling mischievously, before twisting her hand in a half-hearted salute and tipping backward out the open window, quickly adding as she falls, “By the way Poofy Hair’s ‘she’s a cat’ joke was funny your sense of humor just suuucks.”

“It’s *her*!” Adora barks furiously, scrambling for the window to try and stop her before she could escape. The siblings all dart away from the table to join her, but she reaches the sill too late, catching herself on the ledge and glaring at the retreating magicat, who’s apparently feeling smug enough to risk turning back for half a second to blow the queen a kiss and wink at her before racing off.

Adora sees *red*.

“Guards!” she barks, turning on her heel and storming for the doors. She throws them open, startling the two women posted outside. They’re quick to fall in line after her, confused as they may be, as she snarls, “Both of you ready a patrol and meet me at the stables in five minutes. We are *not* letting her get away.”

Needing no clarification for who the person in question was, the two guards briskly salute and dart off, leaving the fuming queen to march down to the stables and ready her stallion.

In all honesty, she could care less about the food she'd just lost. It wasn't all that much, just enough for her and her advisors to enjoy for lunch with some extra for the two guards if they'd wanted. No, she didn't care about her loss.

She cared about the fact that this thief had been ballsy enough to steal from right under her nose, and to make matters worse, she might've just gotten away with it.

"No," she seethes, yanking on her riding gloves as she enters the stables, approaching her horse. "She is *not* getting away. Not this time. Not again."

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She got away again, and Adora almost tore down a wall with her bare hands.

The very next day, she stood before each of her patrols, five groups of two soldiers each, giving them their new orders. There was no way the thief hadn't overheard all of the plans, but she was still one person against ten soldiers and one very angry and very determined queen. The thief could only run and hide for so long from so many eyes, no matter how adept at running away she'd become.

Unfortunately, she was very *very* good at it.

Painfully so.

With so many people out searching for her, it wasn't long before they finally did find her. But finding her had never been the issue.

As Adora is swiftly reminded over the course of the following week.

“We found her while circling the marketplace,” the lead of the first duo reported, both clearly shamefaced. “We followed after her and very nearly had her, but then—like it was nothing—she slipped away in only a moment.”

“With a good third of one of the merchants’ wares,” her partner grumbled.

Adora after that had placed two more guards to be on permanent lookout in the marketplace.

“We found her by the docks,” the second patrol lead reported. “We chased her through rows of boats and rafts, but just when we thought we had her…”

“We rammed straight into one another instead,” her partner stated, rubbing the back of his head as a blush overtook them both.

Two more guards were positioned at the docks.

The third patrol found her in a nobles’ garden. Chasing after her resulted in her getting away and them both falling into the pond.

The fourth patrol found her in town. The fifth patrol found her in town. Both teams chasing after her somehow resulted in them eventually just pursuing one another until they realized they’d been tricked almost three hours later.

Adora herself, so angry she was on the verge of blowing something up, found her last. She was out in the open, leaning against a wall looking *directly at* the queen, lounging around as if she’d had nothing better to do. Adora, for a moment, had been so shocked to just see her *standing* there that she too had stopped and just stared. Then the thief had waggled her fingers at her, her eyes crinkled at the corners with a cheeky grin, and Adora’s temper had flared. She’d given chase, mindful of the cuffs hooked to her belt as she ran, ready to slap them on the criminal’s wrists the moment she finally caught up to her.

Just like all the other patrols, she'd eventually lost her, and this time had actually punched a wall in rage. She'd yelped and wagged her throbbing hand, biting back the tears of frustration and pain, when she'd heard footsteps approach and had turned to see the thief again just *standing* there, barely a few feet away, peering over her shoulder and eyeing her hand with an almost sympathetic wince. She'd lifted her gaze and pouted at Adora.

"Aw, I'm sure your majesty could find something softer than a *wall* to beat to death," she'd cooed as she'd danced closer, Adora's rage building yet again. She didn't know why she was apparently incapable of moving as the magicat drew closer, closer, closer still, but it was like she was under a spell of incapacitating rage.

The magicat had touched a finger to her forehead, and her mind had blanked in stupefaction.

"Hey, Adora," the ragged feline had practically purred (it wouldn't surprise her if that was something she actually could do, being a magicat and all). "How's it hanging?"

Her rage finally reached its boiling point, and with an outraged cry she'd reached for the cuffs… only to find them already on *her own wrists* and trapping her to a fence.

Her sword belt and satchel were also missing, she'd realized upon a double take down at her waist. A whistle had her head snapping back up, and she'd watched as the feline—now wearing *her* belt and satchel—had again taken a moment to pause long enough to catch her eye, then blow a kiss and wink before darting off to the shadows.

She'd had to wait for one of the other patrols to race in and skid to a halt at the sight of their queen chained pathetically to a fence—she found out later they'd seen Catra with the queen's sword and satchel and had given chase, only to lose her again mere moments before finding her—so red in the face it was clear if they had arrived any later the fence would have been gone.

After returning to the palace for a nice long rage fit in the training room, she'd calmed down enough to seek out her advisors to continue strategizing.

"Well, you were right about one thing," Tallstar hums as she wraps the bandages around the queen's bleeding fists. "Leading this assignment yourself has helped you learn plenty about your target."

Jewelstar sighs, his frustration as clear as Adora's. "Okay. Lemme just… go over what we know again. She's clearly skilled enough to evade being actively hunted by multiple people."

"She's been *allowing* you all to keep track of her for as long as you do," Tallstar adds.

"She very obviously enjoys messing with all of you," Starla hums, running a special brush through Glory's feathers and enjoying her happy cooes. "Especially Adora."

"That last one is just evidence that she's an annoying twerp," Jewelstar grumbles.

Tallstar hums again. "It sounds to me like she's trying to distract you all from something."

"From what?" Adora laughs incredulously, her leg bouncing madly. "She works alone, and she actively stole in front of *all* of us. What could she be trying to keep hidden?"

The advisor shrugs, eyes never leaving her current task. "Maybe there *is* someone else involved, and she's upping her own dramatics to ensure no one ever knows."

"But then people would notice stuff going missing even when she wasn't around," she sneers. She flinches when another layer of wrapping goes around some of the more tender areas.

Starla frowns. "What if the other person involved isn't a thief?"

“What would this hypothetical person be, then?” her brother questions. “A baker?” Shaking his head, he continues, “She has to still be working solo.”

Adora grits her teeth. “I’m going to increase patrols,” she declares as Tallstar finishes the wrapping on her left hand and moves onto her right. “Twenty soldiers should at least give her a decent sized headache, if nothing else.”

“There has to be more we can do than just that,” Jewelstar groans, rubbing his palms down his face. “There has to be—” His head snaps up, eyes wide with an idea. “Bounty!”

Adora’s eyes fall on the man, brow raised. “A bounty?”

“Yes!” he cheers, shooting to his feet. “Glory, how did I not think of it before?”

The owl hoots, head tilted in confusion as if asking “*how should I know?*”

“No, sorry, not you Glory,” he explains before clearing his throat and turning back to the monarch. “If we put out wanted posters, *and* go with the increased patrols, it could drastically improve our chances of weeding the thief out, especially if the reward is high enough!”

Adora’s eyes widen. How had none of them thought of that before? “That’s brilliant! Even more eyes keeping an eye out for her will give her far less opportunities to hide!” She abruptly stands, eager to get a head start on this, until she remembers her hands were kind of literally tied at the moment when Tallstar loudly clears her throat and tugs her back down.

“It is a good idea,” the eldest agrees, then eyes the queen with a harrowing look that convinces her to actually stay seated. “Posters can wait until you’re not getting blood on my rugs.”

Sitting still for those last few minutes waiting for Tallstar to finish the delicate craft was near agony, but she did it. With her hands

and arms all taken care of, Adora all but sprints from the room.

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Well… one of the plans worked.

For some reason, it wasn't the wanted posters.

Adora had thought that with an official bounty put in place along with posters slung over half the surfaces in the kingdom depicting that sneaky blue and yellow eyed feline, it would only be a matter of time before someone managed to get the upper hand on the thief and brought her in. Money was a fairly convincing thing, there wasn't much people wouldn't do for it when the price was right.

And truthfully, it had worked. *Kind of*. But really, the only thing that had come of it was Adora and her soldiers somehow wound up on even *more* ridiculous wild goose chases, when pissed off nobles and other such rich snobs either looking to snake away even *more* money or just complain about getting robbed again—or both, sometimes it was both—started coming in even more frequently than they already were with tall tales about how they had the magicat cornered and could lead them to her once presented with the money (Adora was honestly beginning to feel less and less sympathetic for the thief's victims).

But to her surprise, none of the villagers or townsfolk ever once came forward with even so much as a hint.

Thankfully, the increased patrols seemed to be doing something at least.

The thief was still getting away all the time, but now the patrols sometimes managed to either stop her from escaping with any loot, or were able to apprehend her long enough to confiscate what she'd stolen before she'd squirmed away and bolted.

Some patrols finally started having more to report than just "we almost had her but she got away." Some patrols finally started

having some good news to report back to Adora with.

“I think she’s starting to realize she’s running out of luck,” one patrol had laughed, having carefully driven the magicat into a corner and caught her off guard with the help of three other patrols, preventing her from stealing anything that day.

“She freaked out when she realized she was still being tailed,” another had reported smugly. “For once, she actually was running away and wasn’t just leading us on another chase.”

Most of the patrols were still having a fair bit of trouble, but even they were starting to notice their efforts paying off.

“I haven’t seen that awful smirk on her face in a week,” one soldier had said as they’d grinned. “It’s about time she realized this isn’t just some game.”

Even Adora had begun to notice satisfying changes in her own encounters with the criminal. She was far less flirtatious, eyeing the queen with less mischief in her eyes and more wariness. She didn’t wink or kiss her goodbye anymore, simply focused on escaping with what little she’d secured.

Adora wasn’t really sure why many of those satisfying changes didn’t actually… feel all that satisfying.

Still, she was grateful it was working. It was slow going, but finally they were getting closer and closer to actually putting a stop to this. They’d been doing such an efficient job, between the increased numbers and the increased awareness, that the magicat’s thieving frequency had begun to slow, little by little. Some days, the kingdom went without a single sign of the magicat’s interference.

She felt silly when she realized a part of her was sad about that.

“You’re looking for Catra, aren’t you?”

Adora startles, turning to face the old voice. An elderly elkryn stands beside her, seemingly perusing the same stall as her. Having finally felt at ease enough to attend without worry about the criminal, she'd decided a little trip was in order. She hadn't been expecting this, however. The elkryn kept their eyes on the proffered wares, but was paying far too much attention to the monarch while also trying to be casual to be normal.

"'Catra?'" she repeats the name after a moment to overcome her confusion. "Who's…" Her brow furrows into a glare as realization strikes. "Is that the name of the magicat who's been going around stealing for moons now?"

The elkryn's face melts into something too close to heartbreak for the queen's comfort, eyes squeezing shut and ears drooping beneath their antlers. "Please," they turn to look at her as they beg quietly, softening the monarch's fury for a moment. Why were their eyes so sad? "Please, leave her be. She never meant any harm."

"Never meant any harm?!" she scoffs. "She's stolen from nearly every soul in the kingdom! How is that not harmful?"

The elder shuffles uncomfortably on their hooves, conflict written all over their body language. "She wouldn't like me giving details. Please, your majesty, she has her reasons. They are good ones!"

"What good reasons could there be for that much crime?" she asks in turn, before another realization hits her. "You know her. You know where she is."

The elkryn flinches and looks away far too quickly. Feeling her temper rise again, she struggles to tamp it down and soften her voice. No need to frighten or threaten one of her own people.

"Please," she's the one to ask this time. "Tell me where she is. Tell me where she's hiding. I won't hurt her but she needs to be stopped."

Whatever she'd been expecting, it certainly wasn't for the elkryn to suddenly look… disappointed. "Stopped?" they croak. "Why? Has she really done that much harm to your precious penny pinchers?"

"She's robbed nearly every person in my kingdom!" she insists, ruffled at the term. "As queen it is my duty to ensure such criminal behavior is stopped!"

"I mean no disrespect, your majesty," the elkryn bows their head without looking away. "But I must ask… who has told you she's robbed from every person in the kingdom? Because I can assure you, whoever it was is wrong."

"I have people telling me daily that they've had something or other taken from them," she fires back, trying hard not to absolutely lose it on this person, "and every time, it's always the same. A magicat with two different colored eyes, the right one blue and the left one gold, with orange fur and a brown mane. Do you mean to tell me so many of my people are liars?"

The elkryn frowns. "All I mean for you to get from my words is this; not everything is so simple." They bow their head again, and turn to walk away. "Please keep my request in mind, majesty. That girl is not the heartless monster you seem to believe she is."

Adora frowns, watching the elkryn leave. She didn't think Catra was a monster, just… a really annoying thief who got on people's nerves for the fun of it.

Except… she didn't seem to be having a very fun time as of late.

Sighing, she shakes her head and turns back to finish perusing before she'd head back to the palace. No need to ruin her one day of peace, she could discuss things with her advisors once she'd returned.

Catra. At least now she had a name for that stupidly attractive smug face.

Chapter End Notes

FRET NOT I’M GETTING THE SECOND PART UP RIGHT AFTER THIS ONE

I may be terrible at planning out fics and getting things uploaded on a decent schedule but I am no ✨monster💅✨ (I actively beat up and torture fictional characters on the regular)

Medieval/Fantasy - Power Dynamic (Part 2)

Chapter Notes

> CW: A character gets *very* close to death in this one and other characters react accordingly

See the end of the chapter for more notes

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Catra was starting to go days without showing up, and the times that she did, she seemed… off somehow. She was more jumpy around the patrols, scattering before they could even say a word. She was somehow both more hesitant and more daring when it came to what she stole, going only for the easiest of things to grab, which more often than not wound up being simple foodstuff.

She was also fighting back a lot more whenever the guards managed to catch her. She didn't used to fight back, she'd just… run.

"She almost looked scared," one of the more gentle soldiers had quietly reported, detailing her concern with a confused furrow to her brow. "Or… worried?"

"She's been so much more paranoid of being followed lately," another had added, just as soft with her tone. "So much so she dropped everything she'd managed to snag and just ran after she noticed I was following her."

Adora had frowned. "What all did she steal?"

The two guards had looked… uncomfortable at the question.

She'd apparently stolen nothing but a blanket, bread, and a handful of jerky strips. What was even more odd than the meager load, however, was just how fiercely she'd fought to acquire those things.

"She's getting desperate," one of the more boisterous and proud guards had laughed at the realization. "She *knows* she's losing. That's why she's fighting dirty now when we take her stuff back. She *knows* we're gonna get her eventually."

She knows she's losing. The words felt true but at the same time wrong. Losing what? This wasn't supposed to be a game. That had been the entire point.

This was starting to get really strange, even without the elkryn's peculiar hesitance and clear favoritism of the magicat looping through the queen's mind.

Even her advisors weren't quite sure what to make of it all.

Starla was the only one to ask any questions. All she had were two. "Did she seem tired to you? When you last saw her?"

Tired? She'd never really thought to look, truth be told. She was always distracted by those eyes.

Eyes that… now that she thought about it… had always seemed to have an odd weight concealed behind them. Something in her expressions, always more tightly worn than Adora had realized before, spoke of a tense stress she'd never truly paid any mind to. As if all of this was taking a toll on her she was constantly doing her best to keep hidden.

"Adora," Starla says quietly, drawing her attention again. Her golden eyes were focused on the sleeping bird in her lap, laced with confusion and… concern. "Why has she been doing all this?"

…Adora didn't know how to answer either question.

She would ask the magicat herself, after all Catra had before entertained a few questions before fleeing the premises. But the next time Adora finds Catra, neither of them speak.

Neither of them have a chance to.

She finds the magicat darting down an alley, eyes frantic and scared, a blanket barely bulging with supplies cradled to her chest. Seeing her chance, Adora stands her ground at the alley's opening, blocking Catra's only real way out. The magicat turns around after making sure she was no longer being followed, and gasps at the sight of the queen, skidding to an immediate halt.

Her features were mostly hidden by a tattered old cloak, but Adora still made out the way her scared eyes narrow with something she's never seen in the thief's gaze, never directed at her.

She sees hatred.

The burning anger shocks her silent, stilling her tongue against her will, and before she can steal it back, Catra's turned on a dime and skittered up the walls, using the cracks to ascend. She falters at the top, her leg slipping and causing her to ram into the tiles with a pained grunt, but after that she's gone.

If Adora hadn't been confused before, she sure was now.

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"Ma'am, I'm afraid we've still yet to find any sign of the magicat."

Adora frowns and leans back into her throne, dismissing the final patrol with split attention. This was so… weird. She couldn't place her finger on why, but something in her gut was screaming at her that something was wrong.

Catra hadn't been seen for eleven days.

She was apparently the last one to spot her, that day when she'd glared at her with all the fury of the sun (and wasn't that still a most puzzling riddle; why had the literal *thief* looked at her as though she'd killed her first born?). Before that, she'd been missing for five days.

That was the fourth time she'd gone missing for so long.

But eleven days?

Had she finally given up her thieving ways? Had she fled the kingdom to thief another day somewhere else?

Had something happened to her?

She didn't want to consider it a possibility. Catra had evaded twenty-one people actively and consistently hunting her down for months now, and had never been caught and remained captive.

But she'd been getting more desperate. She'd been getting sloppy in her thievery and escapes both. She'd been stealing less and less in order to get away with anything at all.

"Did she seem tired to you?"

…Yes.

She'd looked *so* tired. And angry. And…

She'd looked scared.

"Why has she been doing all this?"

"She has her reasons. They are good ones."

…Why was Catra a thief?

The doors to the throne room open again, and one of the kind guards from before walks in, her face once more pinched with concern.

"Your majesty," she greets with a bow. Her expression doesn't change when she straightens. "There is someone here to see you."

Adora frowns, glancing at the mechanical clock ticking away on the wall.

“I know what time it is,” the guard reassures, brow furrowing deeper. “But… I figured you’d make an exception.”

“Why is that?” she asks, genuinely curious.

“Because they say they know where Catra is.”

Adora’s frown deepens, and she fights back a scowl. She hadn’t had to deal with *this* for a while.

The frown fades when she realizes that might mean it wasn’t fake this time.

“Send them in,” she commands, and feels her eyes widen and her heart skip a beat at who is led inside.

The old elkryn from before.

“It’s you,” Adora marvels softly, before registering the look on the elder’s face.

They looked terrified.

And… angry.

“I need you to understand that I hate myself for doing this,” they state, their voice shaking from fear but somehow strong as well from fury. The statement alone is enough to give the queen whiplash, but their conflicting emotions only worsen the effect.

“Why?” she finally asks. “You are doing the right thing.”

“I am,” they agree, and they don’t seem happy about it. “But not for the reasons you think.”

Adora’s frown deepens with her confusion.

The elkryn takes in a trembling breath, blinking away the tears in their eyes. “She may never forgive me for doing this, but… I fear what will happen if I don’t.” They lift their head higher. “I will take you to her, on *one* condition.”

“Name it,” she declares almost instantly, rising to her feet.

They ball their hands into fists, breathing deep once more. They steel themself, and tell the queen, “I will only lead *you* to her. If even so much as one guard follows us, I will stop.”

Adora’s eyes widen, and the guards on duty both stare incredulously at the elder, defenses clearly rising.

The queen frowns. “Surely you must understand how suspicious of a request that is, Mx.…?”

“You may call me Mottle,” they throw a quick glare over their shoulder at the guards before returning their gaze to the queen. “And I do understand. But I swear on the life of my late love, I will not lead you to harm. The reason behind my condition is that I cannot say the same of the guards’ intentions.” Their eyes narrow. “Or yours, for that matter.”

“If you don’t trust me,” she asks, folding her arms, “why come to me with such an offer in the first place?”

Mottle’s breath wavers again, their jaw shaking with clear emotion.

“Because we don’t know what else to do.”

Adora’s eyes widen. “‘We?’” she repeats.

Mottle says nothing, but clenches their jaw.

The queen stares at the elder for a moment, considering their offer, their price, and what any of it could mean. What “we” meant. Had they been wrong? Did Catra have a secret partner in crime this whole time, and was it Mottle all along? Or was *that* wrong, and it was something else entirely? No one in the kingdom had responded to the wanted posters. Was there a reason? Was Mottle involved in that kind of way? Had something happened to Catra, and that was why Mottle had arrived?

So many questions. Too many, maybe. And finally, she could find the answers.

Was it worth it to find out?

She knew her answer, even before Mottle's voice hitches and they sob out hoarsely, "*Please*, your majesty."

Adora lifts her head to the guards, and with a nod she dismisses them. They exchange a wary look, and finally one turns back.

"My queen," she mutters. "Are you sure about this?"

"I'm more than capable of handling myself, should a problem arise," she reminds, a hand coming to rest at her sword. Catra had, for some reason, willingly returned the scabbard and belt herself, leaving it behind on purpose (though she'd kept the satchel). There had to be a reason. "I will be quite alright on my own."

The guards both hesitate a moment longer, making Mottle fidget in place anxiously, before finally they both bow their heads, and retreat.

Mottle lets out a quivering breath, and meets Adora's gaze as she approaches. They do not return her soft smile, but at least their brow relaxes some.

"Tell me where she is," she asks, the second time she'd requested such from the elkryn.

Mottle lowers their chin, holding Adora's gaze. "I will take you there."

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Adora insisted they stop by the stables first to retrieve a pair of horses. The elder had hesitated, unsure, but an unheard realization seems to convince them.

"Well," the queen hums as she steers her personal steed, Swift Wind, to come to rest beside Mottle and the horse they'd chosen. When the elkryn looks up from the horse, Adora nods to them, and guides Swift Wind aside. "After you."

Mottle makes a face at the gesture, but does as requested, gently flicking the reins and coaxing their steed forward.

They're quiet for most of the journey through the kingdom, but for how anxious they'd been—and clearly still were—it made plenty of sense why, and so the monarch doesn't push. The longer they ride, however, the more confused she gets. Every time she thinks Mottle is going to stop and steer their horses towards where Catra has to be holed up, she's proven wrong, and instead is forced to just continue following behind. So much of the kingdom, so many areas they'd found Catra in, Mottle trots straight past, continuing on without so much as a second glance.

Adora bites her tongue over and over, unable to keep from wondering if this was just another wild goose chase after all.

She'd been missing for eleven days.

They start getting closer and closer to the edges of the kingdom, and Adora wonders still. Had Catra been hiding along the borders? Was that where Mottle was leading her? Was that why the thief had been impossible to keep track of in the kingdom, because sometimes she simply wasn't in it?

But then Mottle veers from the path that would lead out of the kingdom, and down one that distantly Adora recognized as a path leading to an old, run-down, abandoned village.

Except that fact is disproven in seconds, and her jaw drops.

The village is still old and decrepit, but it's far from abandoned. Hybrids, humans, elves, nymphs, all of them live here, in a part of her kingdom she'd known so little about she'd had no idea.

Was *this* where Catra was?

Was this why she was a thief?

If so… Adora could see why she'd fallen down such a path.

As Mottle and her head deeper into the village, they begin to attract more attention. Stares fall on Adora and they don't go away, drawn in by her fresh clothes and healthy horses that practically gleamed in the sunlight. She starts to hear whispers of her name, of "it's her majesty!" or "what in the world is the queen doing here?" or, by far the one that hurts the most, "I didn't think she knew this place existed."

She hates that whoever muttered that wasn't even wrong to think such a thing.

"Over here," Mottle calls, and Adora tears her gaze away from the village that more closely resembled a wreckage to urge her mount into a quick trot to catch up. As she sidles up next to the other horse, Mottle already dismounting, she looks around for anywhere that would clearly be housing a criminal magicat.

The longer she looks, the more her heart hurts, and the more her already smoldering ember of lingering resentment for Catra fades into nothingness.

She finally dismounts herself, and allows Mottle to take Swifty's reins and tie both the horses to a pole. With that finished, Mottle takes in another stabilizing breath, their fists once more clenching.

"I will take you to her," they state again, almost as if they needed to remind themself what to do. Their eyes find the queen's again, and again there's little more than anger and wariness and fear in their dulled green eyes. "But I need you to promise me one last thing before I do."

Adora frowns. "And… what would that be?"

"Don't…" they swallow, blinking back tears. "Don't hurt *anyone*. Please."

She hates that it wasn't already clear she never had any intention to harm anyone. It was something she'd have to work on, apparently. "I promise."

Mottle's eyes tighten, but after a long moment… finally they nod.

"Okay," they all but whisper. They sniff, and nod their head to the side. "This way."

Adora lets her gaze wander as they walk. The state of this place was tearing her to shreds. There were few buildings that were still standing, and even fewer that could serve as legitimate shelter. The eyes that follow her bore into her with the mistrust and fear held within them, and even as she turns and follows the elkryn down a street, the gazes linger, piercing into her back like daggers. One person even stops Mottle, asking them while eyeing Adora with clear distrust if this was really the best option.

"It doesn't matter anymore," they remind the man, both weighed down with grief and worry. "It's our last."

Finally, after what felt like hours of walking but could only have been at most seven minutes, Mottle stops, and Adora stops with them. Before them lies a building so run down it was little more than three walls held together out of spite, and next to the dilapidated home lay a dead end street.

Adora feels her breath get caught in her throat as it closes up.

Inside what remained of the house was Catra. Or… what little of her remained. Slumped on the ground tucked against the shadowy corner where two of the walls intersected, lay a battered heap of nothing more than fur, skin, and bones. A filthy tattered blanket had been softly draped over her, but there was no way it was actually keeping her warm. Even from a distance, Adora can see just how sharply her skeleton jutted out—she'd always been thin, but had she always been this bad? She was always wearing a cloak, Adora had never seen just how skinny she was and never thought to check—from beneath her ragged pelt, how the rise and

fall of her ribcage is far too labored and slow, how her cheeks are so gaunt and her half-masted and unfocused eyes so dragged down into the shadows she looked…

She looked like she was…

"She's…" Adora chokes out, hands trembling. "She's not… she can't be…"

Mottle looks away. "She… stopped trying to leave this place seven days ago. Four days ago, she collapsed, and didn't get up for several hours. Two days ago…" They swallow and sniff again. "Two days ago she stopped moving from that spot."

Adora's breath rips from her lungs like a knife slicing through skin. "She's…"

"Starving to death," Mottle confirms, ears drooping as low as they go.

Before Adora could figure out what to even say or do in response to something as horrifying as that, before she can piece two thoughts together and realize *this* was why Catra had been getting so desperate and scared, she hears the clatter of pebbles falling against stone, and looks away from the near corpse that was the object of her entire attention span for months on end to try and find the sound. She looks over just in time to see something small and furry clamber through what was left of a window sill, land on all fours on the ground inside the structure, and immediately beeline for the dying magicat.

And when Adora realizes what she's seeing, she almost vomits on the spot.

A cub, one who couldn't be more than six or seven years old, not nearly as thin or weak as the grown magicat laying limp but clearly also hungry, toting around a familiar looking satchel as they scramble to Catra's side. They reach inside the bag—they could probably fit inside the dang thing and go completely

unnoticed—and pull out a moldy looking bun, and a small square of jerky.

They press both to Catra's mouth, chirping insistently and encouragingly.

But Catra's sunken, glazed over eyes don't look away from the far stone wall, her lips don't move. She doesn't respond at all.

"Please," Adora hears the cub whisper, clearly as much on the verge of tears as the queen was. "Mama, *please*, you need to eat too."

The tip of Catra's tail twitches. That's it.

Oh stars, what had Adora done?

She'd gotten her answers, and she hated it.

Catra was a thief because she was starving.

Catra was a thief because she was in pain.

Catra was a thief because she was a *mother*.

She was dying, and she had a child, and Adora had allowed things to get this far.

"Mama?" the cub whimpers. Sniffling as big fat tears start rolling down their cheeks, the cub stuffs the food back into the satchel, and crawls closer to their mother. "Mama," their voice comes out softer than a whisper, their ears pinned and their tail tucked between their legs. They press themself to Catra's stomach, then nuzzle their way under her limp twig of an arm to cuddle against her chest and push their head under her chin, their little hands clinging to the ratty tunic that hung from her bony body. They drape the satchel against themself like a cheap imitation of a blanket, and Adora's heart gave another painful lurch (she was so going to have heart problems after this) as she realizes it probably worked better than the actual blanket covering Catra.

Something in Catra's eyes sparks as her cub clings to her. With probably every last bit of energy she had left in her, she shakily tucks her arm around the cub, holding them even closer to herself. Her tail languidly sweeps up to wrap around the cub's foot, and with so little done she's spent, having only the energy to close her eyes and press a weak kiss to the child's forehead before going limp again.

Stars *above*.

This was why Catra hadn't wanted anyone to follow her. This was why Catra had been so over the top with making sure the guards noticed her but never found out where she would disappear to. This was why she stole. This was why she'd kept the satchel but returned the belt.

This was why she'd gotten so scared.

This was why she'd gotten so desperate.

This was why she'd looked at Adora like she'd killed her first born.

She might have doomed the poor thing to a fate much worse.

"Why did…" she swallows, but her voice doesn't come out any stronger. "Why did no one tell me? About— *any* of this? I could have prevented this!"

"No one here trusts you," Mottle states point blank, unable to watch the mother and child a moment longer. "And who could blame them? You inherited your throne from the person that allowed this place to fall to ruin, and then you continued to stand by and let it rot." They sigh. "No one thought you would care. And when Catra began stealing from you and you reacted so poorly, they were sure of it. Even now, I'm not sure anyone here is pleased to see you finally grace them with your presence."

Mottle never spoke cruelly, even if the words they said hurt like no physical wound ever could. Of course. *Of course* things had wound up like this, with Catra turning to petty thievery to provide

for those like her who were hurting, to provide for herself and her cub. Of course no one trusted Adora, who had been queen for so long now and yet did nothing to help her people.

Of course they wouldn't trust the ignorant monarch who'd gone on a mad witch hunt for a mother just trying to survive.

She had to fix things.

Slowly, she steps into the ramshackle structure, and carefully moves over to the two cuddled in the corner.

The cub's ear flicks attentively as her boot crushes gravel beneath it, and they slowly turn their head to look up.

Immediate terror seizes them. Puffing up like a spiky cactus, the cub sits up and arches their spine as they spit and hiss at the queen, pupils mere slits amidst seas of unsteady blue, ears pinned tight to their skull and claws digging into the gravel beneath them. They hover protectively over Catra, growling and spitting and hissing louder and louder the closer Adora gets.

Their movement and their trembling stirs their dying mother. Catra's eyes blearily crack open, and again Adora's heart painfully tugs.

"It's okay," she soothes, kneeling down before the cub. "It's okay, I promise. I'm here to help, I won't hurt you or your mo—" she swallows. "Your mother."

The cub doesn't back down, doesn't move aside to let Adora get to their mother, and Adora can't blame them. She can't blame Catra, either, for the way her tired eyes narrow or the way she lifts her weary head as much as she's able to sneer or the way her weak arm hugs her cub closer, protective anger flashing in her eyes with more life than she's probably been able to display in days.

It costs her. With no energy to spare, her eyes flutter as they roll back in her skull, her head drops and her body goes limp,

consciousness fleeing her.

The cub immediately notices the difference, and looks back at her frantically.

"Mama?" Their eyes dart between Catra's slowing chest and the arm that slowly slips from the cub's shoulders, flitting finally to her face as they cup it desperately. "Mama? Mama, wake up. Mama? Mama, *please*."

Sobs overtake them as they try over and over again to wake the magicat up. They shake her by the shoulder, by the cheeks. They crawl up and bite her ear, tugging it and yanking it in their teeth, but nothing. And with every passing moment, Catra's breaths only grew weaker and weaker.

Adora wanted to help. She *needs* to help. But she doesn't want to make the cub panic any more than they already were. What should she do?

"Finn," Mottle's voice rattles softly, and the cub whips around to face them, tears streaming down their thin cheeks.

"Mottle," they sob, scrubbing the tears away as they keep coming. "Mottle, she's not waking up!"

"I know, sweetheart, I know," the elder croons, trailing over on shaky hooves to kneel beside the three. "She's really sick. She needs help." This last part, they say directly to Adora, their eyes shattered and frantic and intense.

This was what they'd meant when they'd made her promise not to hurt anyone.

Sucking in a shuddering breath, she turns back to the cub. "Finn, was it?" she speaks softly, and the cub's eyes land on her again. Their little sobbing breaths don't stop, but their hackles still raise. Adora swallows again and continues, "Finn, my name is Adora. I really do want to help you, and your mom. I want to help

everyone here, but Finn, we need to get Catra some help. Will you let me take you two to the palace?"

Finn's eyes narrow, confused and caught off guard. "T-the palace?" they hiccup, then recognition hits and their eyes bug out. "Are… are you the *princess*?"

Adora nods, hoping desperately this wasn't the exact wrong move to make. "I am. Well, sort of. I'm the queen. Finn, I can help you, and your mom. Will you please let me?"

Finn's lip wobbles. They look like they want to, they want their mom to be okay after all, but of course they were still scared. For a moment, they look to their mother, watching as her breathing only continues to weaken further and further. Then, they look up to Mottle.

The old elkryn eyes the monarch beside them, then lets their gaze soften as it falls to the cub again. "She promised me she wouldn't hurt you or Catra. And I'm promising you that I'll make sure she keeps it."

Finn's eyes slowly find Adora's again. They sniff, wiping their nose with the back of their little hand, but they don't look away. Their brow furrowing, they ask one thing. "You promise?"

And oh, how Adora's shattered heart just *melts*.

"I promise."

It takes the cub a moment to let the weight of her words sink in. With one final glance to the elder, and one more to their mother, they hiccup again… and finally nod slowly, not meeting her eyes. They crawl closer to Catra again and press their head against her cheek.

"You gotta be okay, okay?" they whisper. "You promised me you would be."

Slowly, hesitantly, they crawl away from Catra's body, tears spilling out with renewed strength and shaking their skinny frame with the force of their sobs. Mottle is quick to offer up an embrace, one they quickly accept, allowing the elkryn to stand up with the cub in their arms. Their eyes fall to Adora expectantly, and she nods.

With more care than she's ever handled anything in her life, she gently slips her hands under the crook of Catra's knees and around her back, and slowly stands up with her cradled to her chest.

She knew it would be easy. She was strong and the magicat was a twig.

Her stomach still heaves when it winds up being *far* easier than she'd expected.

Holding Catra close, repeating the same promise she'd made to Mottle to the unconscious dying feline and meaning it with every fiber in her being, she turns to hurry back to the horses, feeling the eyes of the village boring holes into her back as she rushes down cobblestone and dirt streets.

She had so much to make up for, so much to change.

And she'd start with the magicat in her arms, and the cub she mothered.

Chapter End Notes

> Congratulations Adora you're a father
>
> …Mottle made me do it please don't come at me for the ending lmbo
>
> Speaking of! Mottle was supposed to have like two speaking lines and that's it, they were not supposed to suddenly have a name or be emotionally involved

And also even tho that ending was planned it was *not* supposed to get quite *that* heavy

But then again this was supposed to be one chapter that capped at 3k words so…

Fun fact, this story was (kind of) inspired by another AU I read some time ago! I don't remember the name of it right now (I'll edit this when I find it) but basically the only thing that I took as inspiration was Adora as the one in power and Catra as the one… not lol

Like the Wicked AU, I might one day stretch this into it's own fic (I make no promises) but if I do it probably won't be for a *while*, I've got Etherian Efflux (and all that that entails) plus another AU I'm far more invested in making its own thing, but we shall see I suppose

Anyway this is long enough and I still need to get tomorrow's prompt written up so BYYYEEE~

Medieval/Fantasy - TTRPG

Chapter Notes

> CW: Someone actually does die in this one and it might be described just a wee bit graphically but it's fine

See the end of the chapter for more notes

They called her "Spineless."

Apparently, the name had nothing to do with her courage or her bravery. The misleading title, instead, had a much different origin. Rumors had long since spread to lands far beyond about her ruthlessness, how if you dared to seek her out—for assistance or revenge or what have you, it mattered not—and in some way, shape, or form upset her, your spine is what she would tear right out of your body.

And the B.F.S. had just hunted her down with hopes of recruiting her to the team.

"I'm sorry," she wheezes, wiping away the last of the tears she'd shed in her all consuming laughter. "Lemme just… lemme just get this straight. You want me to *join you*. For a *quest*. To go take down a big bad baddie that's giving you all a hard time."

Selene's face twitches, the mage's placating smile threatening to slip. "It's a little more than just a 'hard time' he's giving us, but *sure*."

The rogue leans back on her palms and laughs again, her tail flicking against the stone she was lazily perched atop. "Oh, sure. No, I—I can imagine. I mean, if a half-naked archer, a girl with a sword way too big to actually use, and the personification of a bottle of glitter spilling everywhere couldn't take down this guy, he *must* be a big deal."

A vein pops on Selene's reddening forehead, and Arbalest scrambles to usher her back behind Estella before she could do anything that would *definitely* lessen their chances of success here.

"As you can see," Arbalest explains with a pleading grin, "We are in fact a little outmatched against this guy."

"Mm, just a little?" the feline purrs, her smirk fully amused and condescending.

"I'm really gonna need her to stop doing that," Estella mutters bitterly.

Ignoring her and Selene both, Arbalest turns back to the rogue. "Please. Your matchless wit and cunning could be exactly what we need to save our home. We'll repay you in whatever way you see fit for your time and effort, if only you would help us."

Spineless lifts a brow, intrigue and interest dancing in her mismatched eyes that, for a moment, linger intentionally on Estella, who freezes under the gaze.

"In whatever way I see fit, huh?" she trills, her smirk stretching wider as her eyes slowly trace the warrior's figure top to bottom. Estella blushes, and Spineless' tail curls in satisfaction of the reaction. She snickers and looks back to the archer. "You know what… why not."

The trio all share a look of surprise before all jumping back in shock as the feline jumps down and lands right before them.

"W-wait, really?" Estella stammers, her blush slowly fading until Spineless meets her gaze again and it drenches her face in red. Spineless hums approvingly and nods her head.

"Sure," she says. Her amusement softens into seriousness for a moment. "But if we really are doing this, you all need to *actually* listen to me if and when I tell you to do things. I'm not getting

eaten alive by a damn slime because a bunch of hapless morons decided to try speedrunning death with an obvious trap. Got it?"

The three all nod, buzzing with excitement and relief at having successfully recruited the rogue to their team.

"I mean it," she warns. She lifts a brow, folding her arms. "I'm hoping you all do, too."

"We do! We do!" Arbalest is quick to reassure. "We promise!"

Spineless' brow lifts higher, and she eyes the two women, who are quick to echo Arbalest's nodding and his promise. With all three of their words sealed under promises, Spineless' smile slowly comes back.

"Good," she says, satisfied.

• 🔪 🏹 🗡️ •

"What did I literally *just* say."

"'Hey how about we not go charging into the very obvious death trap?'" Estella echoes her earlier words even as she continues climbing the steep cliffside.

"Right so what the *hell* do you all thing you're doing?!"

Right now, they were all apparently thinking "hey let's climb this super steep cliffside to reach a pretty looking run-down mystery ruin that leads into a cave at the top," because that's exactly what they were at that very moment doing.

"Come on, *Spineless*," Selene teases, looking down at the feline from her place on the cliff. "This place clearly hasn't been touched

in years, it's perfectly safe. Besides, think of all the goodies inside!"

Arbalest squeals. "What if they have enchanted weapons inside?"

"I might be able to find an even bigger sword!" Estella cheers excitedly.

Spineless crushes the heels of her palms into her eyes, muttering a slew of profanities before cupping her mouth and calling back up, "This is a *Masters' Den*! These things are *known* for being full of traps! And wyverns! Lots and *lots* of wyverns!"

Selene *pffs*, pulling a hand away from the cliff just to wave her off. "We've faced plenty of traps before. And if there were any wyverns here, my detection spell would have already sniffed 'em out."

"Yeah, unless your detection spell *failed*!"

Selene smirks down at the very pissed off rogue. "Aww, is someone feeling a little *spineless*? Is it the wittle pussycat?"

"Leave her alone, Selene," Arbalest gently reprimands, just a few stones away from the final ledge. "She doesn't have to join us if she doesn't want to. Besides, now we have someone on lookout!"

"I kinda thought you all *wanted* to live long enough to get back home and liberate your families."

"We're alright, Spineless," the archer calls back, grinning ecstatically as he pulls himself up onto the last ledge, before straightening up to reach the top. "You heard Selene, there's no one else here but us."

With a grunt of effort, he hefts himself up onto the top of the cliff face, and turns to wave encouragingly at the others.

Spineless is too far away for him to clearly see her expression change from one of annoyance to one of sheer horror.

“See?” he announces giddily. “It’s perfectly—”

He feels a large, warm, damp puff of breath blow against his back, and he freezes, eyes widening. Slowly, hesitantly, he looks over his shoulder, and he feels his heart immediately plummet all the way back down the cliff to rest at Spineless’ feet.

He didn’t want to know the exact number of how many wyverns there were staring directly at him.

“Oh no,” he has time to meep, before the wyvern barely two feet away shakes its head, screeches, and *lunges*, its massive fangs sinking into his armored chest plate and taking him for a swan dive off the cliff. The last things he registers are the frantic screams of his friends crying out his name, and the sight of the ground approaching *way too quickly*.

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“The wyvern’s jaws break through your armor and brutally crush your ribcage and spine, before the beast tosses your now dying body into the air. Spineless, Selene, Estella, and the wyvern all watch as you fall to your death. It is unclear what killed you first, the fall, or the crushing. The wyvern that caused your death then proceeds to fly down to where you’d landed, and starts eating you.” With that, the dungeon master leans over and tips Bow’s figurine over.

The silence is broken by Catra’s head hitting the table with a muffled *thunk*.

“WHAT?!” Glimmer shrieks, head whipping around to face the dungeon master, who just shrugs.

“You had like, *twenty* separate opportunities to turn back and avoid this.”

“Arbalest!” Bow wails, hands shaking as they timidly scoop up the tiny figurine. Legitimate *tears* well up in his eyes, and he throws his head back and cries, “Noooo!”

“I told you all *how many times* to turn back?!” Catra’s head whips back up to glare at them all, hands motioning her disbelief.

Adora just stares wide-eyed and frozen at the miniature fallen hero. “You just… he just…”

“I cast like five different kinds of spells to see if there was any danger and *nothing* came up!”

“He’s *dead*.” The blonde has never in her life sounded so traumatized.

“You only rolled a two!!”

“And?!”

Catra pushes away from the table to pace away from them all, driving the heels of her palms into her eyes while her middle fingers rub circles into her temples as she runs through every curse word and insult in her personal dictionary, her tail lashing so furiously it smacks against the nearby couch.

“You would have needed to roll *at least* a fourteen to detect any of the wyverns from that distance,” the dungeon master explains, almost bored.

“I— okay but we can get him back, right?” Glimmer warbles, eyeing her emotionally distressed boyfriend as he continues to mourn his alter ego. “We’re too far in for you to *actually* kill one of us off, right?”

The master places an elbow on the table and slumps against it, resting their chin in their palm. “Oh you sweet summer child.”

“Okay *none* of the words you just used to describe me are true.”

"I am going to kill *all* of you," Catra laughs, crazed and mirthless.

This was the last time she ever invited any of her stupid friends or her girlfriend to a DnD night.

Chapter End Notes

Okay I lied not everything's fine

Catra has a massive headache now

But hey no one (technically) died!

Also I know almost nothing about DnD or TTRPGs so almost all of this was just pulled right out my bootyhole

Medieval/Fantasy - Rescue Mission

Chapter Notes

> Shout-out to literally everyone who's left a comment or otherwise commented about my little blurbs, y'all are giving gifts giving life rn and I'm so incredibly grateful to all of you
>
> I don't think this one needs any warnings, but if any of you disagree please let me know!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Screaming, Adora *sprints* for one of the few standing stone pillars, all but throwing herself forward to get behind it just as a blast of fire incinerates everything in its path.

She was glad she'd snatched these papers before they were lost to the flames. Letting out a heavy, disgruntled breath as she lets her head fall against the pillar with a *clunk*, she turns and shouts back over her shoulder an annoyed, "Do you *mind?!*"

An earth-shattering roar is her response, but she's at the point where all it elicits from her is an exhausted eye-roll as she heaves herself back to her feet.

She'd known going in that the dragon was going to be a problem. She just didn't think it was going to be because it hated reading.

Clutching the papers to her chest, she chances a glance around the structure, hearing the heavy footfalls of the beast prowling around but unsure where it currently was. She hadn't really been paying much attention while scrambling to snatch the parchment and dive for shelter.

Luckily, unlike herself, the dragon wasn't trying to hide. Peeking out from the pillar grants Adora a perfect view of what was once likely the ballroom, now crumbling and semi-destroyed and absolutely filthy, and in the center sat the massive beast, its head

swiveling around in search of the knight. Its tail flicks side to side rhythmically, and its tattered wings ruffle at its sides as it sniffs around.

Adora's eyes widen as she spots something trapped beneath one of its paws. It's another paper. She couldn't read it from here, but it appeared to be scrawled out by the same neat yet shaky hand that had written the messages in her possession.

Prince Catra's hand.

She needed to get that paper. Even having just skimmed over what little of the missing prince's writings she'd been able to find thus far, she knew each page she got her hands on would at the very least be beneficial to locating her. She groans and rolls her neck as she realizes that meant she needed to let the dragon find her again.

Stars above, Bow and Glimmer had better thank her with her own castle for doing all this for them. And Catra, too, once she found her. And… okay, she would have done this anyway, but still. She'd almost gotten all her hair burnt off twice now. Watching the dragon's massive snout get closer and closer to where she was hiding, she grimaces as she prepares for a third go.

Just a little closer…

The dragon's snout appears, the patterned red, burnt-orange, and pale yellow scales occasionally disrupted by deep gashes of pink exposed flesh from random wounds. The beast had likely received them from its prisoner. Adora holds her breath as it snuffs the air, jaws somewhat open to taste her scent. The muscles in her legs tense as she readies to bolt again…

And then she almost pisses herself in terror.

In all fairness, yes she was prepared for the dragon to get closer. She was also very much *not* ready for its humongous head—almost as big as she was tall—to poke around her pillar, a giant blue eye immediately finding her and staring right at her.

Watching its scaly lips pull back into what was clearly an excited grin—despite the fact that should not be possible—was yet another thing she was not expecting.

With a rattling war cry, she swings her shield at the beast, thwacking it right on the muzzle. It screeches in pain, and she ducks under its furry maned neck to scramble for the paper, dancing around thrashing limbs to snag it from the floor before hauling to get literally anywhere but here.

The dragon roars again, but she makes it to the other side of the ballroom—"more like ballruin," she'd snark if asked—and through the gap in the wall that probably used to be a doorway to scamper madly down the hall. Darting past cobwebs and creepy crawlies, she reaches a section with several doors on either side of her, and after hearing another violent roar she picks one at random and scrambles inside, slamming the door shut behind her. Knowing that wouldn't be enough to stop the beast from tracking her down and breaking in, she scans the room she'd broken into—a study of some kind—and rushes over to the broken table in the center to secure the largest plank of wood. Sliding that through the door's handles, she steps back and lets herself breathe a moment.

Honestly, the wood wouldn't help much either, but it would maybe buy her a few extra seconds. The room had a second set of doors on the opposite end to where she'd just entered. Once she'd looked at the papers and scanned the room for anything useful, she had her exit.

Looking around briefly doesn't reward her with anything obviously helpful. Sighing, she unclenches her fist and straightens out the four papers she'd managed to find.

She'd already read over one of them completely, but goes over it again just to make sure she hadn't missed anything.

"*The witch still won't tell me where I am,*" began Catra's writing, the script unsteady. Going off of the dried blood splotches and the

rest of the paragraph, Adora had a feeling she knew the reason. "*I hate to admit it, even to a sheet of paper, but I think I'm starting to lose hope that one day I'll escape. I still don't know why she took me. She hates me, that much is certain, so why not just kill me? I think she wants something from me. I'm not sure what that is or why. I just know she isn't afraid of doing whatever it takes to get it from me.*

I'm holding out still. I have to at least try. I'm not telling her anything (not that she's asking all that many questions) and I'm still fighting back every chance I get. But I'm not gonna lie, sheet of paper… it's getting really hard."

Adora frowns and folds the paper up carefully before tucking it inside her inner jacket pocket. Going through the note again didn't do anything but add fuel to the fire that was her absolute hatred for the person responsible for all this. She hadn't gotten the chance to know Catra personally before being knighted, but Bow and Glimmer loved her, and her mothers were the kindest souls Adora had ever met. She wanted to help the missing magicat, even more than she already would have had she not known anyone who was personally attached.

She picks one of the other three papers to read next, noting curiously that not only was it written much more steadily and didn't have any bloodstains on it, but also that it must have been written before the one she'd tucked away, going off of what it said.

"*This will likely not remain the case for much longer, and I can't believe I'm saying this (writing this?), but honestly right now I'm almost disgustingly bored. The witch has harmed me a few times, I think she wants my blood for some creepy rituals or spells or something (she's incredibly rude, she never even said please), or maybe she's just sadistic and needed someone to beat up to bring some light to her sad life, but for the most part she just leaves me alone. It's only the two of us here, as far as I'm aware.*

I'm a little tempted to ask her to kidnap someone else just so I have someone to talk to. What I wouldn't give to hear my brother or Entrapta rattling off about some stupid science project right now. The second I get out of here, I'm hunting down Scorpia to get crushed in a hug that lasts a full week, this is ridiculous.

…I really hope everyone else is okay."

She jumps as something big and heavy *thuds* down the hall. Tucking the second note in with the first, she does another quick scan of the room. Just as she goes to leave through the unbarricaded doors, the dappled sunlight catches on something red laying in the wreckage, and she wanders over to see what it was. Brushing the debris off of it and lifting it up, she gasps softly.

It was Catra's crown.

It was badly damaged, bent and broken and bloodied, but if at the end of all this it wound up being the only casualty, Adora would be grateful. She tucks it into her small satchel bag, snatches another plank of wood, and hurries out of the room. With those doors barricaded as well, the dragon would hopefully be held back for at least a *little* longer, giving her time to find the witch and the prince.

There are more rooms on this side. She didn't like that she'd been unable to explore the ones before or after the study, knowing full well the witch and/or the prince could be in one of them, but she couldn't get to those anymore at the moment. Instead she goes for the first door on this side, and hurries in.

The first few rooms she scavenges leave her with nothing but a lung full of dust. As she searches, she thinks over the second note. Going off of that, and what little she'd already known of Shadow Weaver, taking Catra's blood for some kind of spell was definitely in the realm of possibility. Glimmer's own father, King Micah, had experience aplenty when it came to being unwillingly involved in the old hag's schemes, and blood magic was unfortunately some of her favorite to use.

If she really were trying to get something from the magicat, blood magic had likely been one of her go-to methods.

Adora grits her teeth as she exits the last door. She hadn't found anything worthwhile in this hallway, no new papers and no sign of the prince or her captor, and her time was again running out. A spiral staircase bookended this part of the wrecked palace, and seeing no other way forward, Adora begins the trek upward to the next floor. As she hikes, she holds up a third parchment, this one being the one she'd snatched from under the dragon's paw.

She swallows anxiously at the contents, with writing so unstable it was nearly illegible, and a tale so grim it told an entire haunting story with only two short sentences and another spattering of dried blood.

"*She's done something to me.*

It hurts."

Clenching her jaw, she hurries her pace, and reaches the next floor. This one was just as much a wreck as the one below it, if not more so. The dragon had clearly been through here, entire walls smashed through as though it had been rampaging uncontrollably.

She thinks she sees something in one of the exposed rooms, and cautiously steps towards it as she puts away the paper.

"Prince Catra?" she calls out tentatively. She sees no movement, but she knew magicats had excellent hearing, and hoped that, if she were on this floor, she could hear her. "My name is Adora, knight of the house of Grayskull! I'm here to help you!"

She receives no response, but that wasn't entirely awful. There were still two beings here whom she'd really rather not have heard her announcing herself.

She reaches the exposed room, stepping over the remains of the crumbled wall, and before her second foot is even fully on the

floor, she freezes, gawking at what she sees laying sprawled in the center of the room. Apparently, the only threat she had to worry about anymore was just the dragon, actually.

Shadow Weaver lays decimated and very much dead in a pool of what was probably her own blood, long since dried as a stain, scattered papers haphazardly and chaotically spread throughout the room around her. Going off of the massive gashes tearing up her body like shredded cheese, the dragon had liked her about as much as Micah and Catra did.

This was… certainly a development.

Adora tentatively steps around the body and slowly takes in the full of the room, her grimace growing and growing the more she finds.

The papers were more of Catra's writings, and the reason all of them were loose is made clear when she sees the journal cover they were originally part of sat in the thickest pile of the papers. It looked as though the journal had been thrown, quite violently at that, and the force had caused the papers to explode out.

There was a simple bed in the corner, an odd book on the sheets and a chamber pot tucked underneath the bed frame. The smell wasn't what made her gut churn (though between that and the very dead body she was impressed with herself for not having at least gagged yet), it was the sight of the cuff chained to the foot of the bed. The manacle was broken, at least. Something powerful had snapped it off.

So… this was unfortunately very clearly Catra's room. Or where she'd been contained, at least.

She didn't seem the type of royal to throw a fit over living arrangements not being up to snuff enough, but this was just bad in general.

Kneeling by the unruly whirlwind of papers, she reads the last one she'd already had on her.

"*She broke something this time. I'm not quite sure what, I think it might've been a couple of my ribs because my chest hurts the worst right now. She's getting impatient and I'm getting worried. Fighting back isn't stopping her anymore, but I don't know what else to do.*"

Adora glares at the corpse. Maybe she'd give the dragon a few pets on the way out once she'd secured the prince. She huffs and quickly starts gathering up the journal entries, carefully tucking them into the cover despite knowing they were definitely not in order anymore. It hardly mattered, but she at least wanted to present the prince with all of the pages, just in case she wished to do something with them.

Burn them, probably, but if so that would be Catra's choice to make.

The scattered papers lead out through the somehow still fully intact double doors, the left one cracked open a touch. Picking them up as she goes, she lets herself skim through the entries, hoping to find something of use to help her find the prince. If Shadow Weaver had locked her in a dungeon or something, maybe she'd written about that before being carted off.

But all she finds is more and more reason to further butcher the witch's body.

"*I think my ankle is officially completely naked now. If there somehow is still any fur there, I bet it smells* awesome.

Note: I don't think sarcasm comes across super well on paper."

"*I feel like I'm on fire. I don't know if it's because of what she's doing to me, or if I'm coming down with a fever, or if I'm coming down with a fever because of what she's doing to me, or if it's something else entirely. It hurts. I don't think fevers usually hurt.*"

"*I pissed her off so much today she didn't even know how to respond. She just stared at me, completely dumbfounded.*

I've never been so proud of me."

"*I want to* kill *her.*"

"*I'd like to imagine this journal somehow gets back to my friends and family. I've tried to be funny when I write, even when things really suck sometimes.*

I hope it'll make them laugh.

If I am dead and someone did find this and gave it to my family… Glimmer, I'm haunting you first, have fun."

"*I did something. I didn't know what else to do.*"

" *s o m e t h i n g s w r o n g w i t h m e* "

If Adora grits her teeth any harder they'll shatter.

She found it strange that there was never any mention of the dragon, but if Weaver kept her locked up in that room for the majority of the time she's been trapped here, it made sense that she'd never have encountered it while she still had her journal to write with.

With the last of the papers secured, she starts down the hallway again, her steps much quicker and much more anxious. To say that last paper she'd read was concerning didn't even remotely cover it. It was terrifying. The writing was chicken scratch, the entire lower half of the paper was soaked in blood (so were half of the other pages, but something told her it wasn't Weaver's), and the words themselves seemed to contain all the horror Catra had felt when writing it.

"Prince Catra?!" she tries calling again, darting from room to room and growing increasingly frustrated every time she opens the doors to find a disappointing lack of cat inside. The worry that Catra was as dead as Weaver was one she'd been desperately trying to suppress since learning of the dragon's existence, but

with each passing second it's a worry that slowly overtakes her again. "Prince Catra, please respond! I'm here to take you home!"

No one answers her call, but she hears another heavy thud coming from downstairs and bites out a curse. She leafs through the journal's pages again as she runs from door to door, desperate for a clue of some kind to guide her. But all she finds is pain, pain, more and more pain…

Wait!

Slowing to a halt and keeping her finger on the page that snared her attention, she flips back to it and quickly looks it over.

"*I stole one of her stupid books when she wasn't looking. I don't think she noticed, and she definitely wasn't expecting me to even be able to move enough to do anything considering… all of that. I'm back in this stupid room again. I'm gonna look through the book and see if I can find anything. I don't know if I'll even be able to use anything, but I need to do SOMETHING.*"

A book?

There was a book on the bed, back in the room with Weaver's body.

Before she shuts the journal, the entry on the page directly opposite the one she'd just read jumps out at her.

And her heart sinks at what she sees.

"*It wasn't supposed to be me.*

She wanted someone else. She kidnapped the wrong person.

…I don't understand. If she wanted someone else all this time… why couldn't she just let me go?"

How heartless did someone have to be to do all this?

She shakes it off. No point in getting riled up any further, Shadow Weaver was dead, and Catra needed help. Knowing she'd hate herself for eternity if she accidentally left the prince to die in one of the rooms she didn't check because she'd darted back for a useless book, Adora quickly checks the last few rooms left on this floor, then sprints to get back to find the book.

She feels her heart skip a beat when she races past the stairs to see a giant golden eye glowing from inside.

Again the dragon grins.

Almost choking on her spit, Adora makes the maddest dash of her life to get to the room before the dragon could crawl out from the stairs. Nearly tripping on Weaver's body, she snatches the tome from the bed and races back out, only to find the beast already half-emerged and following her with its piercing gaze. Its furry shoulders roll powerfully under its pelt as it pulls the rest of its body free, and Adora doesn't waste a second longer lingering.

She somehow escapes the massive beast and finds her way inside what was probably supposed to be the library. Knowing it was only a matter of time before the dragon got in again, she starts looking for her way out, albeit a bit distracted. She was glancing between the book's pages and her surroundings as she briskly wandered the area while trying to figure out what it was Catra had found.

Because she *had* to have found something.

The image was starting to form clearer and clearer in her mind's eye, and she felt like if she could just piece together this last part, she'd figure out where to go to find the prince.

Shadow Weaver had kidnapped Catra, having wanted someone else originally but settling anyway, possibly because kidnapping another person after having just stolen away with a well-known and well-loved prince would be nearly impossible. She used the prince as a blood bag and a tool for experimentation, and possibly

as something to get her anger out on. After having suffered for so long at her hands, Catra had stolen a tome from her as a final attempt at finding some way to get out. Shadow Weaver had found her with the book and gotten mad, throwing her journal at the wall and presumably attacking her at the same time. Something happened that enabled Catra to escape, and left Shadow Weaver to be killed by the dragon.

Did it have to do with the book?

Adora sees that there was blood staining the pages of this, as well, but it almost seemed purposeful this time. Following the stains to where they sat heaviest leads her to a part of the book that focused on transformations using blood magic. She's quick to find the spell Catra must have used, one that promises heightened strength, senses, and abilities, blood needed and used for its activation.

A bloody thumbprint is haphazardly smeared where the spell requires it. Had Catra been trying to do it quickly, because Weaver had found out and she was running out of time?

Regardless of the reason behind the messy smear, this was the final piece of Adora's puzzle. Catra had used her blood to cast a transformation spell to break out. Unless the dragon had found her, she was still alive, somewhere in this castle.

Adora stops in her tracks.

Her moment of startled realization is interrupted by something big and heavy smashing against the library doors. She whips around, startled and afraid, as with one more crash the doors smash inward, and the dragon pokes her head inside.

Her blue and gold eyes are quick to find Adora's, and once more a grin stretches across her face.

Adora's breathing halts altogether.

The room that had been Catra's cell had been smashed through by the dragon, but the damage had spread outward, as if the dragon had already been in the room before breaking through. But the doors to that room were smaller, the dragon couldn't have gotten inside unless it were the same size as a human.

The spell Catra had found had promised heightened strength, sense, and abilities.

The dragon had come because Adora had called her name.

The beast opens her mouth, fire lighting up the inside of her throat as she draws back onto her hind legs to prepare a mighty blast.

Adora takes a chance.

"Catra?"

The fire stops building. The dragon's mouth closes. She lowers herself to all fours, and after a moment, her head slowly lowers to be on the same level as the knight. A soft rumble, curious in nature, rumbles from the dragon's throat.

Adora swallows, noticing how once the dragon's gaze finds the tome she carried it narrows, as if in disgust. She tucks the book in her bag, swapping it out for the broken and bent crown from before, and tries again.

"I… I am here to rescue the prince, and return her to her family and friends. Are you…" she tentatively steps forward, holding the crown high and hoping against all hope that she hadn't just made the most severe miscalculation of her life. The dragon's eyes widen at the sight of the crown, pupils dilating, and Adora carefully breathes. "Are you… Prince Catra?"

The dragon's eyes linger on the crown a moment, something indecipherable stirring behind them. But finally, in response to the question, blue and gold find stormy gray again. The dragon rests her haunches, sitting at her full, towering height before the

knight. She lifts one paw, and places it at Adora's side, bringing her leaning forward as her long tail, lined with fur and scales alike, swings around to rest beside her. Her wings flare just so, not extended but not fully held to her sides, either.

With her face mere inches from the warrior's, and while maintaining the knight's gaze… Prince Catra slowly blinks.

Chapter End Notes

Dragon Catra go brrr

This is another one of my AUs that was partially inspired by someone else's AU! It was one I saw on Instagram some time ago, where Catra was both the princess and the dragon, but honestly I remember even less about that one so it might be a little longer before I find it again

Completely unrelated but why are allergies a thing? I actually rather enjoy the company of dogs and cats, I'd prefer not to die every time I'm around them smh (disclaimer I do not mean literal death)

Medieval/Fantasy - Thieves Guild

Chapter Notes

Hey remember when I said I struggled with that one prompt

laughs in unhinged and needing sleep

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Getting new letters from her friends was the highlight of Adora's entire week.

The letters came in every morning late Sunday, sent by way of magical teleportation from Glimmer's hand to Angella's at exactly 6pm every two weeks. Adora was always the first to the queen's side to discover alongside the woman the findings of the princess and her teammates.

Although, they both knew "findings" was putting it nicely, a pleasant subterfuge that kept secret what the little team truly did on the regular.

After all, if word got out that the princess of an entire kingdom was the leader of what was essentially a small group of bandits and thieves, an explanation—though there was in fact one readily available—would not be enough to sway the angered masses. Especially since Glimmer's little group had stolen from most of them.

Adora should know. She'd been there.

She groans as she flops onto the settee in Angella's study, wincing at the twinge in her leg and hoping to all the moons in the sky that the other woman hadn't noticed. "I should be out there with them. Didn't you only let me into the palace in the first place because I promised to guard your kid? Can't really do that from here."

Angella hums an amused little melody as she takes the armchair sitting perpendicular from the couch. "My goodness. I don't think I've seen as severe a case of cabin fever as your own since my darling Micah was still without facial hair. A shame you haven't allowed yourself to heal properly, I'm sure your friends want you there as much as you do."

Adora turns and pouts at her. Three years ago she wouldn't have dared show the woman anything but mature respect, and a regal composure to rival her own. Now, though, she doesn't bother withholding the frustrated snort.

"I've already been cleared for riding again so long as I take breaks. Swift Wind's fast enough that he could reach them in no time."

"This is true. Alas, I do believe your steed and my husband have run off with one another. We won't be seeing much of either for quite some time."

Adora sinks lower into the couch, grumbling, "You need to teach that man to stay away from a girl's horse."

Again comes Angella's musical laughter. "I'm afraid the kidnapping was quite consensual, the two were both spouting off some nonsense about their very own grandiose adventure and were both quite obviously thrilled with one another. Now then," she reaches over and gently taps Adora's forehead with the ombré fading pink and purple letter, "would you care to join me in uncovering more clues of my daughter's mysterious mighty heist?"

"I'd rather be with them *on* this mysterious mighty heist," she complains with all the regality and maturity of a harrumphing five-year-old, but still shuffles herself to be sitting up against the arm of the settee.

The woman smiles, clearly pleased as punch and likely amused at the blonde's petulance. She grabs her letter opener from the coffee table sat before them, slicing open the parchment and

unfolding the message. Sitting back against the plush seat, she clears her throat and begins to read.

"*Dear Mom, Dad, and Adora, we've had quite the two weeks let me just say. For starters…*"

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"…we kidnapped someone."

Bow frowns and looks up from the paper, feathered pen pausing in his hand. "We… probably shouldn't tell either of them that."

"Why not?" Glimmer shrugs, despite knowing her boyfriend was right. She'd known they couldn't say that, she'd just wanted to anyway. It was a little nuts that they'd done it, after all. She slouches over, placing her elbow on her knee and dropping her chin in her palm. "They're gonna find out sooner or later."

"Well yeah," he chuckles, then uneasily eyes the hostage in question. He was glad they were almost home, he didn't want to have to keep her tied up any longer. "But I mean come on. It sounds really bad to just outright say it like that. They think we're just after some sort of national treasure or something. They'd probably freak if we told them we'd *kidnapped* a person."

"Wow. What kind of a person would *ever* freak out over someone they know *kidnapping* a person?" Catra snarks, still laid out on her back and glaring at the sky. Her tail, the only part of her not tied up, thwacks against the ground again, twice. She clearly isn't any less outraged than she'd been when they'd first ambushed her, even if she is much more tired and put out. She rolls her eyes. "Can't believe they'd do that. Talk about overreaction. Like, where's the fire. Seriously."

Glimmer rolls her eyes in turn. "Are you *sure* we can't gag her?"

"I feel like if we haven't already crossed several lines, gagging her would definitely be one of them. Besides, you know her friends wouldn't let that slide." Bow holds up his battle-scarred arm. "Also,

I don’t feel like getting anywhere near her teeth or claws again. Also also we’re just not gagging her, period.”

“Ugh, fine. Let’s just give them the boring old recap, I guess.”

Bow nods with a smile and gets to writing.

“For starters…”

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“*…we’ve finally accomplished our mission! Consider this heist a resounding success. We’re on our way home now, with the treasure safe and secure. We’re leaving what it is a secret, for now, but we get the feeling Adora is going to flip her—*”

Angella frowns and stops reading, recoiling from the letter with the expression of someone who’d just caught a scent of something absolutely rancid. “I am not reading that out loud. Honestly, only three months of being away from the castle and she’s got the mouth of a hardened sailor.”

Adora wisely keeps quiet about how Glimmer has had a sailor’s colorful tongue for just about the entire time she’s known her, and very likely even longer than that. She clears her throat and sits up straighter on the settee, being mindful of her leg.

“What else does it say?” she asks, leaning to try and read for herself.

Angella notices her ogling the paper and smiles. She stands up only to move the chair closer to the settee, allowing Adora to see the message clearly without giving up the space to keep her leg propped up comfortably.

Still, she flushes at the action. “I could have moved,” she mumbles, much more shy than she usually was around the queen anymore.

But the monarch just smiles softly. “As could I,” she reminds. She turns back to the letter, but her free hand moves to find Adora’s now that their seats were directly beside one another. Her fingers delicately take the warrior’s callused hand, and her thumb begins to softly brush against the toughened skin.

Adora melts at the affection, and Angella keeps reading, skipping over any profanities. “‘…we get the feeling Adora is going to…’ totally freak out… when she sees what we’re bringing home.’”

Hearing Angella’s replacement words gets her to snort. “It’s so weird hearing you say something like that.”

The queen chuckles softly. “It felt a little odd saying it. But I wasn’t sure what else to say in place of… well, that.”

“‘Lose her mind?’” she offers. Angella laughs.

“Brilliant. I should have you be the one writing Micah’s speeches.”

She just smiles, too focused on the warmth of the queen’s touch to properly laugh as she normally would. “Nah. I’d just write him a huge script about leaving my horse alone.”

“Ah, I suppose we couldn’t have that.” The queen’s amusement doesn’t fade, and neither do her tender ministrations.

She holds up the letter for them both to view.

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We’re leaving what it is a secret, for now, but we get the feeling Adora is going to lose her mind when she sees what we’re bringing home.

But enough about our masterfully choreographed and perfectly executed mission. We’re only a few days away, but can’t wait to tell you about the absolute chaos these last two weeks were for us and thought we’d give you both a sneak peak.

First of all, not even a day after securing our treasure, we were very nearly robbed. In hindsight, it makes sense that others would also want our spectacular find for themselves.

"I'm coming for ya Wildcat!!"

Glimmer yelped at the sight of the beefcake of a scorpioni rapidly gaining on them on her own steed, a pigtailed woman sat behind her excitedly cackling. The princess whipped back around in her saddle to urgently coax her mount to run faster.

"How the hell did they find us?!" she cried, panic in her throat as she risked a glance at her partner in crime.

He wasn't the one who answered. Catra, sitting backward behind the princess despite still being tied up and unable to secure herself, had scoffed and casually leaned against Glimmer's back as if it wasn't going to screw up her riding.

"You really think my emotional support lackeys *wouldn't* start tracking you the second they noticed I was gone?" The magicat tutted disappointedly as her head fell against Glimmer's. She ignored the shorter girl's warning snarl. "Come on, Sparkles, you're usually so much more observant than that."

"They must have been onto us from the moment we left that village!" Bow squeaked in terror, also urging his horse to run like the wind.

"This never would have happened if you idiots actually did what thieves' guilds were supposed to do and didn't, you know, actively kidnap someone instead."

"If you hurt even *one* blade of fur on her body—!"

"They haven't," Catra called out casually to the giant, almost lax and even bored in the way she lounged. "Right now I think they're more interested in just me than in *hurting* me."

The scorpioni scoffed, a dangerous grin on her face that seemed to scare even the thieves' mounts. "Sure is gonna suck for them when I pound their stupid faces into the dirt, isn't it?"

Catra laughed, and Bow and Glimmer inwardly screamed.

That was an incredibly stressful handful of days. The pursuers simply would not stop pursuing. At all. Technically, they still haven't. But we've thankfully since come to an agreement, and have made peace with each other.

Literally not even a full day after making peace, we got trapped in a mountain for a bit due to an unforeseen cave-in.

"Why were you carrying *explosives?!*" Glimmer yanked at her hair as she grounded out the question.

"I wasn't!" Entrapta happily denied. "All of the materials I was carrying I'd been careful to ensure could not accidentally result in any sort of combustion should they combine and/or collide somehow long before I packed them. I did not account for any of those materials coming in contact with the saltine liquid coming from the stalactites, however."

"You know, I *could* find a way out of here, pretty easily in fact." Catra drawled, still slung limply over the back of the princess' horse like damp luggage. "I've gotten out of plenty of caves before. Unfortunately for all of you, including you *traitors*, I'm a little *tied up* at the moment."

Scorpia pouted, fidgeting with her claws. "Aw, come on, Wildcat, don't be like that."

"Don't freaking lecture me, you damn backstabber. What did her royal glitteryness even say to convince you to just let any of this happen?!"

Scorpia exchanged a look with Glimmer. They may have come to an agreement after the (significantly) shorter woman had explained the purpose behind this impromptu kidnapping, but they were far from being on friendly terms. As was evident by the glare the scorpioni kept leveling at the royal every chance she got.

"I don't really know how to explain without… um… spoiling the surprise."

"If we ever actually get to where we're supposedly heading and this 'surprise' is anything close to a jail cell or a chopping block, I'm taking your skin to a taxidermist."

We eventually got out, don't worry! No one was hurt, and even the horses were all okay. The treasure was still safe and secure, if a little… roughed up, let's just say.

"You *dropped* her on her *face!*" Scorpia snapped, pincers waving frantically.

Glimmer flushed. "Well I'm sorry she doesn't know how to sit properly on a horse!"

"You bound! Her *legs*!"

"…fine, we'll untie her legs."

"If even one more thing happens to her I am throwing you both off a cliff."

Thankfully, things seemed to calm down for a little while after that. There were a few more bumps and bruises along the way, there always are during missions like this, but for the most part it was smooth sailing.

And then Bow and the treasure both fell off a cliff.

"How are you *still such a nightmare?!*"

"Eh, years of practice."

"Can we please discuss this when we are not *hurtling to our deaths?!*"

With an outraged wail, Glimmer grabs onto both Bow and the person who'd just shoved him off a cliff and tagged along for the ride. Focusing all her magic, she took in a deep breath and—somehow—managed to teleport all three of them to just about a foot above the choppy waters at the base of the cliff. Catra and Bow both yelped before the three splashed in like stones.

Bow and Glimmer surfaced just fine.

Bow was the first to point out the obvious. "She can't swim with her hands still tied!"

"She just pushed you *off a cliff!*" Glimmer instantly shot back.

"*Glimmer!*"

With a mighty groan, she ducked back under the water with the archer.

They found Catra floundering in the water, panicked and afraid, but managed to get her head above water before she could fully drown. The trio sluggishly trudged back to the shore, where Scorpia and Entrapta were waiting to help pull them out.

The scorpioni's face was blank, but her eyes were haunting pin-pricks that bore deep into both thieves' souls.

"I say we just let them go and forget the stupid mission," Glimmer huffed much later, once night had fallen and they were all starting

to turn in for the night around a fire Entrapta had thrown together. "If Catra was seriously willing to kill you just to leave, I don't think it's at all worth it to keep her around."

Bow frowned. "She wasn't trying to kill me, Glimmer, she was just trying to escape. She knew you'd teleport, otherwise she definitely wouldn't have done that. Why else would Scorpia and Entrapta already be waiting for us?" He sighed and glanced over at where the magicat was curled up, pointedly ignoring any and all attempts the scorpioni made at engaging in conversation with her. "And can you blame her? We kidnapped her, and she has no idea why we're doing any of this."

"She *can't* know!" Glimmer seethed. "If we tell her, she'll just run away again and then we'll *never* get things settled!"

Bow's frown deepened. "I mean… we don't know that for sure."

Glimmer's rage faltered for a moment. She shook it off with a rough sigh and folded her arms.

"We're almost home. Let's just… do what we can. If anything else happens… we give up and let her go. That sound fair?"

Bow nods.

No one got hurt then, either, somehow, but things have been a little tense since then. We're really looking forward to finally coming home to nice hot baths and clean clothes, and we hope getting our awesome little finding home with us will make this whole complicated journey worth it. Just a few more days. We'll see you soon.

Lots of love…

• 🔪 🏹 🗡️ •

"…Bow and Glimmer.'"

Adora sighs, slumping against her folded arms. “I wish I could’ve been there for even *half* of that.”

Angella hums, continuing to run her fingers through the tired girl’s blonde hair. At some point, her touch had gravitated from Adora’s hand to her arm, then to her shoulders, then to her back, and finally as her head had slumped from the exhaustion of the day, she’d taken to lightly carding through her locks as she read.

Neither knew how to admit it, but both loved the soft moments like this they occasionally managed to steal away together.

“There will be more adventures, dear. Don’t you worry.”

Adora just sleepily mumbles another half-hearted complaint, and Angella finds her fond smile growing. Letting her fingers slowly still, she leans over and presses a kiss to the girl’s temple, before tucking away the letter and gently rousing her with a soft shake of her shoulder.

“Come, my darling. Let’s get you to bed. You’ve had quite the day, I’m sure.”

It wasn’t long after that both monarch and knight were retired to their respective bedrooms. Angella had rolled her eyes at seeing hers completely empty, a gentle laugh lilting from her lips as she pictured the wacky insanities her beloved Micah and Adora’s Swift Wind were no doubt still having the time of their lives with. Tucking herself under the comforter and blowing out the candle light, she tenderly placed the latest letter on the bedside table, before getting cozy and letting her eyes drift shut.

She didn’t know what her daughter was up to with this latest heist. She was sure Micah did, the way he’d been constantly exchanging giddy glances with their daughter and practically-already-son-in-law, but she hadn’t been let in on whatever secret they were keeping. It was for the better, she supposed. The less she knew about these missions and heists the children partook in, the easier it was for her heart to rest at night.

Still, she had some idea. One, to be precise. Whatever this mission was, she was sure it had everything to do with Adora, even without the blonde's participation. Or maybe, this heist had only been able to take place because the girl was laid up. Whatever the case may be, Angella finds that sleep comes easy tonight, knowing her daughter was so close to coming back home.

At the unholy hour of two in the morning, she finds out exactly how close when she's awoken to the familiar but unexpected buzz of magic in the air that meant a letter was materializing from teleportation. She startles fully awake just as the letter drops in her lap, and blearily she carefully tears the message open, sleepy eyes widening at what it says.

"*We got impatient because of reasons. We're coming home now.*"

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Adora only somewhat remembers what had happened as she'd fallen asleep. She remembers being with Angella, listening to her read aloud the letter as the warmth of the hearth's fire and Angella's touch lulled her into a peaceful dozing, but her memory jumps around a bit after that. She remembers Angella gently encouraging her to go to sleep, then getting set down in her bed and tucked in.

Did Angella carry me to bed?

The thought had been the last coherent one Adora had had before drifting off to sleep.

The next thought she has comes when her doors burst open and startle her awake, and was honestly less of a coherent thought and more of just a jumbled tangle of *who, what, when, where, why,* along with internal and external screaming.

The *actual* first coherent thought she has is *Why is Glimmer breaking into my roo—Glimmer's back?!*

The cause of her doors banging open, Glimmer stands heaving and exhausted in the doorway. Her clothes slightly torched from teleporting and ragged from the wear and tear of the adventure, she's definitely a sight to behold.

She jabs a menacing finger at Adora, and the blonde's words get caught in her throat before she can say them.

"If either of you make me regret this any more than I already do, I'm locking the both of you in a box and shipping you to Erelandia."

Before she could question what *any* of that meant, Glimmer's head whips over her shoulder and she bellows way too loudly for it being the dead of night, "*Scorpia!* Get her in here!"

Adora can fairly confidently say she was not expecting a towering scorpioni to come stumbling in from the hallway carrying a writhing and angrily hissing and spitting magicat in on her shoulder, muttering out a string of apologies a mile a minute that all go unnoticed by the feline, even as she carefully lowers her and snips off her restraints. As the magicat stumbles back into the room, rubbing her wrists and growling at both the retreating giant and the slightly-unhinged looking princess, Glimmer meets Adora's gaze and confidently shoves the stranger further into the room, earning another spat out hiss that she ignores completely.

Adora gawks as the stranger stumbles from the shove into the light of the moon, and she realizes very quickly that this was in fact very much not a stranger.

Catra finds her gaze, and very quickly all of her hostilities drop in exchange for sheer shock and awe.

"Happy super late birthday," the stout woman chirps, before slamming the doors shut and storming down the halls.

For a moment, Catra and Adora just stare at one another, both supremely disheveled and still trying to figure out if they were

awake or not. The moment drags on, until finally they find their voices.

Adora opens her mouth to say something, only for Catra to hold up a finger.

"Give me one second, I promise I'll be right back."

She turns and sprints out the door. Only a few seconds later, Adora hears Glimmer's startled squawk, and Catra's furious shout of "I could have *walked!!*"

A few more seconds pass, and the magicat returns. She again finds Adora's gaze, and, not knowing what else to do, Adora offers a shy, awkward, hesitant smile.

Catra returns it just the same, and Adora feels the tension and anxiety in her melt away. Disbelief, overwhelming joy, and a whole slew of other racing emotions course through her, and instead of giving voice to any of that, she just slowly scoots aside on her bed, the offer as clear as it could be.

The magicat smiles, her shoulders relaxing, and she approaches. "Hey, Adora," she mutters as she reaches her side, her smile tugging into a tired smirk as she kneels on the bed and climbs in. "Do I have some stories to tell you."

Chapter End Notes

> AKA the fic where Catra and Adora's friends team up to kidnap Catra to get her and Adora to finally meet up and talk things out but actually Catra isn't emotionally constipated for once so the kidnapping was unnecessary
>
> …I tried y'all sdflwjegkssf
>
> I couldn't figure out like *anything* that I wanted to do for this prompt as a fic so I went with the thought of like "hey what if thief but they're thiefing a person instead of treasure" and… yeah sldkfjsdf

Don’t kidnap your friends, kids

Or anyone

Don’t kidnap anyone

Can it be Post-Apocalypse week already, I want it to be Post-Apocalypse week already

Medieval/Fantasy - Political Marriage

Chapter Notes

> Tried something a little different with how I wrote this one, it won't be how I write any stories going forward but let me know what you guys think!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Clenching the missive in her shaking fists, Adora knows for certain she has never hated anyone more than she does Emperor D'riluth.

To go from a nothing and nameless Horde soldier, to being the most feared and respected person in the world in the span of a year, to being the one responsible for the takeover of nearly every kingdom on Etheria, to now this damnable letter that had sealed Adora and her kingdom's fate with words said so prettily you wouldn't assume the underlying threat was even there until it was too late…

Oh, yes, she hated her more than she'd ever hated another soul.

She could hardly read the words anymore, many hidden in the clutched folds of the parchment growing ever tighter every second, but she hadn't needed to read more than the first few lines to know what she was being commanded to do.

The wedding is gorgeous, decked out in candled lanterns and all the colors of both the Halfmoon Empire and the Eternian Kingdom, though for obvious reasons Halfmoon's fiery colors are far more prominent than Eternia's starry hues. Her gown is beautiful; a bright tangerine with more fiery-orange accents and a white heartline bodice and underskirt, little silver constellations delicately sewn into the white fabric. The emperor's attire was just as handsome; a matching white shirt with the same variety of oranges reflected on her jacket vest, charcoal gray pants and black magicat stockings, and finally a shoulder cape colored with a

teal to black ombré fade draped over her left arm, her own silver constellations dotting the darker half of the fabric.

And Adora hates all of it. She hates the look on D'riluth's face, stoic and blank even as the two seal their unity with a passionless kiss. She hates the Eternian crystal arm gauntlets she presents D'riluth, and she hates the Halfmoon headpiece D'riluth presents in turn. She hates as she turns to the gathered throng of people, many of whom her own, to show them wordlessly how their queen—no, their Empress—was forced to hang off of the arm of the one who'd finally done it, who'd finally united the last of the kingdoms under her reign, under the Halfmoon Empire that had taken over the world. She hates that she was forced to marry, to sign away her and her people's lives to someone who dared to take it all for herself, just because she felt like she could.

She hates the tears that fall from her eyes the moment no one can see them, not even her dear darling *wife*.

Stars, she even hates the word itself.

She hates Halfmoon's palace, hates having to move into it. She hates just how massive it is, how every hallway and room leave her somehow feeling both claustrophobic and small. She hates how nothing is familiar anymore, how she has to be careful not to burn herself just by walking in the wrong places, how instead of the faces of the subjects she's come to know and love she instead only ever sees the faces of strangers, magicats and other such hybrids who treat her with respect but never the familiar warmth she'd worked so hard to maintain as a queen.

She hates her new room. She doesn't share the master bedroom with D'riluth, not after having all but thrown a fit over refusing to do so, so instead D'riluth had given her one of the many other rooms in the Emperor's suite, the spare bedroom that was smaller than the Emperor's but still grander than her own back home.

Her hatred for D'riluth never goes away. She hates D'riluth's stupid little smirks and jokes, not always targeting her but still despicable

no matter the recipient. She hates how completely unregal the magicat is behind closed doors, lounging around her palace like a lazy street cat instead of the literal leader of the world empire that she truly was, even around visiting subjects or palace staff. The only times she isn't acting improperly is when she's around other royals or dignitaries, but even then it's only when she *feels* like actually behaving. She hates how the Emperor cares so little for her duties that she actively and frequently just completely skimps out on them, actively leaving the palace itself to instead run off to who knows where to do who knows what.

She hates that while she'd stopped wearing her new Halfmoon crown, her wedding band, D'riluth only ever takes off her gauntlets to sleep.

She hates that she starts noticing more and more about D'riluth, hates that she's starting to keep track of her ticks and behaviors because she isn't supposed to care. She hates that she realizes D'riluth deflates a little each time Adora ignores one of her jokes or frowns at her free-spirited laughter. She hates that she notices D'riluth's expression tightening a little anytime she's referred to as D'riluth or Emperor and not her first name. She hates that she starts to recognize when the magicat is feeling stressed, and hates that her eyes always drift to her wife whenever she starts to expel that stress, by pacing or running her claws through her mane or letting her tail lash freely behind her.

She hates that one day she wanders into a room she knows she was never supposed to see, and hates that the sight of the Emperor with her head quietly bowed before a small portrait haunts her for a week.

She hates that she feels lonely in this place. She hates that she feels lonely whenever D'riluth isn't around to bother her with another stupid pun or a teasing grin, because she shouldn't care. She hates that in D'riluth's absence she has the gall to actually miss her childish antics, the life she brought to the place that everyone seemed to recognize and love. She hates that her loneliness drives her to wander the palace aimlessly, only getting

herself more and more hopelessly lost. She hates that getting lost leads to her realizing more and more just how much these people truly adored the Emperor, because how could anyone love the person responsible for the complete and total takeover of every single kingdom?

She hates that she starts to understand their love, when she learns of the slaughter that nearly wiped out the magicats entirely, and the great lengths the Emperor went to recovering what was left and creating a place where they could be safe.

She hates that one day she decides to follow D'riluth, hates that the magicat had such a powerful grip on her curiosity and intrigue that she'd bother tailing her in secret to find out where it was she was always disappearing to. She hates that she feels a hint of concern *for* the Emperor, when the foolish thought that maybe it wasn't her choice to leave floats through the Empress' mind. She hates that it is very much her choice to leave every time, something that becomes quite obvious when she sees D'riluth skittering through her own empire hiding under a black cloak, running away from her duties and responsibilities yet again.

She hates that her heart melts when she finds the magicat romping around and playing with the children of the orphanage, laughing and rolling around and chasing and letting herself get tackled, all things that a royal such as herself would normally never be caught dead doing. She hates that her hatred softens as she watches D'riluth bring giggles and joy and pure delight to the kids, completely uncaring when an overstimulated cub bites her arm or a human girl steps on her tail. She hates that watching Catra's chest heave with laughter as she sprawls on the ground with the kids forces her to hide her face behind her hand, scarlet scrawled across her cheeks.

She hates that D'riluth continues to do stupid little things that endear her to her wife. She hates that in a dragging meeting with the stuffiest man she's ever met, Catra whispers something to her that gets her to snort. She hates that watching the Emperor greet every single magicat personally and with a genuine smile gets her

heart to pound a little harder. She hates that the bags under Catra's eyes and the stress she's under that is causing them start to genuinely concern her. She hates that she starts going to sleep wondering what D'riluth's lips felt like when they were pulled into a smile.

She *really* hates retiring to bed one evening to find an infestation of cockroaches has moved in without her notice, and she hates how D'riluth responds.

She hates how casual the Emperor pretends to be when she offers to sleep on her settee so Adora can have her bed. She hates how D'riluth explains her motives by saying she knows Adora can't stand her, and says she often fell asleep on her couch anyway. She hates that she agrees to the arrangement, and spends the first half the night tossing and turning in the massive mattress under the massive comforter while her wife snores softly on what couldn't possibly be as comfortable as her bed.

She hates that she spends the latter half of the night realizing that Catra's sleep was plagued by nightmares, and hates that despite her clear exhaustion in the morning she still gets up to get ready in her study to give Adora some privacy.

She hates the gray in Catra's mane that only seems to get thicker with each passing day. She hates the way Catra's hands shake in the morning when she thinks Adora is still asleep. She hates that Catra jumps at certain sounds and flinches at certain movements. She hates that Catra notices Adora's discomfort at a crowded party and makes up the perfect excuse to get her out, only to go right back in despite the exhaustion in her frame because the Emperor was expected to be present. She hates that Catra sometimes skips meals for a multitude of reasons.

She hates the surprise in Catra's eyes when she personally brings dinner for the two to share in the privacy of her study. She hates that Catra is shocked when she asks her how her day had been. She hates that Catra at first jerks back when she reaches a hand to untangle part of her mane. She hates the ever present

tenseness in Catra's spine, and hates how long it takes her to unwind when Adora takes to massaging her back. She hates how heavily Catra leans into her touch when Adora starts sitting beside her at dinner and lets their arms brush, and hates how deflated the magicat gets whenever even the slightest touch is taken away.

She hates how hesitant Catra is when Adora tells her to stop sleeping on the couch and just share the bed with her. She hates how Catra curls up as far from Adora as she can when the two go to sleep that night, and hates the wave of disappointment that washes over her at the distance. She hates how she wakes up in the middle of the night to find Catra clinging to her like letting go was a death sentence, hates how natural and right it felt to hold the Emperor in her arms, hates how after so many nights of listening to her wife suffer through nightmare after nightmare on the settee it was a tight embrace that finally allowed her to sleep soundly. She hates that it's the best night of sleep she's ever had.

She hates how the morning greets her with Catra ripping herself from her arms and apologizing. She hates that Catra had even felt the need to apologize.

She hates that Catra goes right back to sleeping on the settee after that night, despite Adora insisting it was fine.

She hates the constant surprise and disbelief coloring Catra's features every time she reaches for her hand or tucks her arm around her waist, or stays by her side during blessed moments of relaxation and downtime when before she'd always made it clear she wanted to be alone. She hates how something as simple as splitting her dessert with the Emperor after dinner has her gaping at the blonde. She hates how Catra refuses to bother defending herself against a violent dignitary screaming in her face and insulting everything she was and had built up, and hates how caught off guard the magicat is when she springs to her defense and nearly decks the unpleasant man in the face for his words. She hates how Catra hesitates to touch her at all anymore, when before she'd do it without a second thought. She hates how badly Catra needs and wants someone there for her but doesn't trust

Adora to be that someone. She hates that she knows exactly why that is, and hates that she wants it anyway.

She hates the concern shining in Catra's eyes when she stumbles through her day a bit more than usual. She hates how many times blue and gold eyes dart over to check on her as her skin grows clammier and hotter with the passing of every hour. She hates the sheer terror that she catches flashing in Catra's eyes before she falls, landing in soft and fluffy arms instead of on the palace tile. She hates how Catra never leaves her side as fever and illness wrack her body, hates how the comfort of her padded palm on her arm never lingers for long enough, hates how Catra's hands shake with fear while Adora shakes with sickness. She hates waking up over and over and over again throughout the night to retch, and hates that Catra's always awake and ready to help her each and every time instead of ever going to sleep herself.

She hates that it's only now when she's sick and frail and in pain that she discovers Catra can purr, when in response to her sick and frail and pained tears the Emperor clambers into bed to hold her in her comfortably warm embrace, and only a moment later lets her chest begin to rumble. She hates that it's only now that Catra lets herself be held, when she's the one holding Adora and the blonde barely has the strength to even move her arms.

She hates how overwhelming the relief in Catra's eyes is when the worst of her illness finally passes. She hates how ragged the Emperor looks, having spent days glued to the Empress' bedside to tend to her every need. Even now, she fails to leave her side for long, and Adora hates how the gray in her mane and the bags under her eyes have never been more pronounced. She hates that her tired eyes water anytime she reflects on how bad Adora had gotten, and hates that she turns away to hide the tears anytime they come. She hates that even now Catra hesitates to join her in bed, hates that it takes her softly admitting to benefitting from being held, for Catra to once more climb under the comforter with her and have her in her arms again.

She hates just how fast Catra falls asleep once her eyes drift shut.

She hates how Catra finally starts seeking out her touch, but seems scared of it anyway. She hates how the only times she's confident in asking for it are when she's worried Adora is faltering and needs a steadying hand, still recovering from being sick. She hates how Catra seems worried every single night that she's either going to hurt her or overstep literally every boundary to ever exist, and she hates how Catra tries to hide just how much she sinks into Adora's embrace. She hates how the confident, cocky, and admirably bold Emperor of the Halfmoon Empire hides just how scared, touch-starved, and uncertain Catra D'riluth could and often did feel underneath. She hates how the weight of this life she's built for people to thrive under tears away at her more and more every day.

She hates how much it reminds her of when she'd first become Eternia's Queen, and had felt herself heading towards an earlier and earlier grave until she'd finally gotten the assistance she'd needed.

She hates realizing just how much Catra has on her plate, every single day. She hates that more and more often, she stops herself from running away to play with the kids that loved her, instead trying to focus on tackling everything she'd been saddled with. She hates that even wrapped tightly in her arms every night, the nightmares start coming back. She hates that Catra's hands never seem to stop shaking.

She hates that it takes her spotting her Halfmoon headpiece in the mirror to remember that it existed in the first place. She hates that putting it on in the mirror feels so good, so right, and she'd refused to wear it sooner. She hates that Catra's eyes widen when she wanders in and sees her with it on, and she hates that seeing Catra's eyes soften and grow wet with emotion is what it takes for her to realize something important, something she should have realized much sooner.

She smiles at her, and holds out her hands. Catra slowly, tentatively, steps forward to take them in her own, warm and calloused and kind and gentle in ways that Adora never would

have known they could be before she wore Catra's mask and Catra wore her gauntlets.

Adora pulls her into a hug, and she hates how Catra's breathing hitches. She hates how her hands shake as they clutch Adora's back, and she hates how her shoulder grows damp with the Emperor's tears.

She hates that she ever hated the magicat in her arms, purring loudly and crying softly as she melts into the embrace she's needed for ages. She hates that she'd been so blinded by senseless hate that she hadn't offered this so much sooner.

She hates that she hadn't realized she'd been falling in love.

Chapter End Notes

Catra was supposed to get stabbed at some point in this btw but I didn't want to squeeze in another thousand words

Maybe some other time

Post-Apocalypse - Last Ones Alive

Chapter Notes

> Honestly, I think this is one of my favorite ones I've written thus far

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"She's *still* following us."

Glimmer barks out a curse. "How?! We've been going for miles! Undead *never* chase people for this long!"

Bow swallows and lowers his binoculars. He looks on the verge of tears, and Glimmer can't blame him.

"I can't… Glimmer I won't be able to…"

She grimaces. "We might not have to. She… she can't follow us forever. We'll take the long way back to the base, throw her off our scent."

"What if it doesn't work?" His voice is quiet, on the cusp of giving in to heartache and sobs. "What if she still follows us?"

Glimmer bites her lip and closes her eyes. Breathing in shakily, she takes his hand in hers. He squeezes back as hard as she does.

"Then we take care of it, and make sure Adora never finds out." Her voice hitches halfway through her sentence.

Bow's lip trembles. "I think I'd rather let her bite me."

Glimmer opens her eyes and frowns up at him. "Don't talk like that. Don't *ever* talk like that, Bow, you hear me? We promised her we'd survive, no matter what. She *wanted* us to stay alive. We have to."

The tears finally begin to spill down his cheeks, and she reaches up her free hand to wipe them away. He leans into her touch, cupping her hand with his, and he kisses her palm.

"I just want her back," he whispers.

Glimmer leans forward and rests her head on his chest, nuzzling against him when he rests his chin in her hair.

"I do too," she murmurs against his bloodstained crop top. It had been a gift, not long before they'd lost her, one that she'd given as a joke but that Bow had immediately integrated as part of his usual outfit of choice. He wore it whenever he could find an excuse to. "I miss her so badly."

Bow's hands clench Glimmer's jacket tighter, a slight tremble rattling them. The two are slow to pull apart, knowing they have to if they want to get away in time, but hesitant to come back to the reality that their best friend was hunting them. Bow presses a tender kiss to her forehead, and finally lets go of her, meeting her gaze as they separate.

"We need to go," Glimmer instructs softly, stepping away from the ledge where they'd spotted the lone undead in the distance. "The bikes don't have much juice left in them, but if we're careful to lose her, we can walk once they're out."

Bow nods, but doesn't move to follow just yet. He turns back to watch the staggering zombie, likely to get a good idea of how far she still was.

But then his jaw drops, his face paling.

"That's not—! Zombies can't do that!"

Glimmer frowns and stops walking away. "What's she doing?"

"She's *running!*" He yelps and startles back. "She saw us, she's running right for us! We gotta go, *now!*"

He grabs Glimmer by the arm and races for the motorbikes, terror in every fiber of his being and quickly spreading to envelop her just as fully. The two leap onto their bikes and gun it, speeding down the cracked road so fast they both nearly spin out of control.

"'Running?!'" Glimmer shouts. She chances a look over her shoulder, but doesn't see her. "I take it you're not talking about that weird hobble-lurch thing they do!"

"She was *sprinting* on *all fours!*" he wails, and Glimmer whips back around to gawk at him. "She was looking right at me and she was *sprinting* on *all fours!*"

"That's not possible! Once the infection sets in the undead aren't even coordinated enough to walk in a straight line anymore!"

He laughs, the sound edging on hysterical. "Yeah, well, guess she always was a rulebreaker! She was going just as fast as she did when she got bit and was trying to get away from us!"

"I don't… maybe it's a magicat thing??"

"I've never had the opportunity to study an infected magicat, so maybe!"

The two both have the bikes going at full speed, careening down long abandoned streets and roads and never once daring to slow down. They knew from experience that when on all fours, a magicat could easily match the default speed of their bikes, and could sometimes go even faster if they really pushed themself. They'd never tested if a magicat could match the bikes' top speeds, the only one they knew had been taken before they could.

Neither were willing to run that particular experiment right now. Magicats were already terrifying opponents as they were, with all the standard killing features of any big cat and the same level of sentience as humans, but an infected magicat? None of them had ever encountered one before, but going off of every single other

undead's tendency to become merciless bloodthirsty killers once the infection had set in, it was a pretty safe bet to assume an infected magicat was top of the danger food chain.

The day their friend had been bit and taken from them had been a horrible one, but she'd saved them all the horror of witnessing her turn when she'd ran. They owed her their lives.

It seemed like now she was intent on collecting her pay.

Bow and Glimmer both chance glances over their shoulders every few minutes, both afraid of turning to see their old friend hot on their heels. But no matter how many times they look, she's never there. It's not as comforting as they need it to be.

Turning back around, the two are met with an upcoming overhead bridge, after which lies the fork in the road. The left is the path they need to take to get back home to Adora. The right could also take them back home, but it was a much longer and much more tedious way of getting there. They might lose the zombie, but they might also lose the bikes.

Glimmer glances over her shoulder again. Still nothing. Her dread still coiling in her gut, she swallows and asks, "What if we split up?"

"*WHAT?!*" Bow shrieks. "No! Absolutely not! Why would you even suggest that?!"

"She can't chase after both of us! If we split up, she'll have to choose to either only go after one of us, or give up entirely!"

"I don't think she's giving up anytime soon, Glimmer, she's been after us for weeks!" He looks back again. Still nothing. "If we split up, it just means that whoever she catches up to won't have any backup. Neither of us can take her on alone, not even with our guns. It's too risky!"

The overhead bridge gets closer. "If she catches up to both of us we might not have a chance to beat her back anyway!"

"Our chances are still better together than they are if we're apart!" He looks again. "She… she's just one zombie. She can't attack us both at the same time!"

Darkness swallows them both up as they shoot under the overhead. "I hope you're right," Glimmer hisses. She looks back once more, just before they speed back into the light. If the zombie was still chasing them, they would have had to see her by now, right?

They're spat back out into daylight, just as Catra leaps from the bridge and hits the ground running not even a foot behind them.

Bow and Glimmer both scream in terror and *swerve* to get away. At the speed they're going, though, both are quick to lose control of the bikes, and they and all their weapons are thrown from the vehicles as the tires go out of control and the bikes topple. None hit the pavement, crashing instead into the overgrown underbrush lining the road and rolling several times before finally slowing to a halt.

Pain lances through the two of them like a barrage of stones being thrown. Groaning, Glimmer is the first to carefully and slowly pick herself up, and Bow follows suit a moment later. The two are quick to find each other and look over one another in concern, but aside from the full-body bruises and a ton of new cuts and scrapes, neither are too badly roughed up.

Which means the moment they remember Catra, they're able to both scramble (painfully) to each snag a gun and aim it at the magicat just as she leaps down to join them.

"Back off, *now!*" Glimmer commands shrilly, the shotgun shaking in her unsteady hands but still aiming right between Catra's eyes. Eyes that… don't seem as dead and crazed as they should be. "I won't hesitate to shoot!"

Just as Bow goes to remind her that Catra can't understand them anymore, the magicat surprises them yet again when her hands

shoot into the air, her eyes widen with panic, and she snaps, "Hey how about we *not!*"

Both guns lower in shock, but neither dare be dropped.

A pained sound escapes Glimmer's gaping mouth, before she grits her teeth and hefts the gun back up, her hold shaking even more.

"How are you talking?" she hisses. "Infected can't talk, and they certainly can't run! What are you?!"

"*Not* infected! I'm not infected so can you drop the damn blasters already?!" It's only now that either notice that Catra is shaking too, and panting surprisingly hard for a creature that supposedly didn't need air anymore. Then her words register in their minds, and the guns almost *do* drop.

Aside from the heaving magicat, everything goes dead silent.

Glimmer's mouth flaps like a fish. So many words are rushing through her mind, and she can't catch hold of any of them to say out loud.

Not infected?

"But…" Bow warbles, shaking his head. "But you got *bit*. We all saw it happen, we saw the wound. How… how could you not be infected?"

It's the only thing any of them have wanted for years. Its the thing all three of them have pleaded with fate itself to make true, to somehow bring Catra back as anything but a mindless zombie or a rotting corpse. They'd wished for nothing else for three long years, but none of them had ever believed it could actually happen.

They still don't.

Lungs still working overtime, Catra doesn't answer for a minute. Her hands slowly lower when neither Bow nor Glimmer move to

actually shoot, but they still tremble with exhaustion at her sides.

"I'm immune," she finally rasps, a faint, achingly familiar grin tentatively tugging at her dirt-slathered cheeks. "I didn't think I was at first, I didn't *believe* it for *months*. But I'm immune. *Magicats* are immune."

Glimmer's gun finally hits the dirt, but she stays rooted to the spot. Brow furrowed and eyes watering, hands clenched into fists and trembling, she croaks, "How do you know? How do you know that's true?"

In response, Catra rolls up her tattered and filthy flannel sleeves and tugs up her dusty black shirt, exposing her arms and her stomach, and the *multitude* of scarred over bite marks disrupting the flow of her fur.

Bow's gun drops to the ground.

Catra snorts weakly. "You know, now that you mention it, I'm actually not so certain. I mean, I've only been bit eight times, maybe the ninth time's the charm. You guys seen any more zombies around? We can always test it out—"

The rest of her frankly *disgustingly awful* tease is cut short when Glimmer and Bow *throw* themselves at her, entrapping her in their arms for the first time in three long years as tears flow freely down both their cheeks.

Catra just stands in shock for a moment, before tears begin to spill from her eyes as well and her shaking arms slowly circle around them in turn.

"Don't you *dare*, D'riluth," Glimmer finally chokes out past her hiccuping sobs. She buries her face in Catra's furry neck, and another wave of emotion slams into her with the weight of a car crash because Catra was *back* she was *actually here*. She clutches the magicat tighter, absolutely soiling her clothes with her abhorrently violent tears. "We just got you back you are *never* leaving *again*."

Bow remains incapable of speech as he just sobs helplessly, soaking Catra's other shoulder just as effectively as his girlfriend.

Catra's hands slowly come up to grasp the backs of their shirts, the hold tightening until she's clinging to them both with a vice grip. Her quiet chuckle is strained and wet, and her tears seem just as incapable of slowing down.

"Hey," her voice is as shaky as the rest of her, "no complaints here."

And then without warning, her legs give out, and the three fall to the ground with a chorus of yelps and grunts.

"Are y—" Bow winces as he sits up, accidentally disturbing about half of his newly acquired bruises. "Are you *okay?*"

Catra moans as Glimmer also stiffly sits up and eyes her with the same concern. "Fine, just… don't know if I'll be able to stand back up again for a bit."

Glimmer laughs. It wasn't funny, but the heartache and tension finally draining away, after years of making themselves at home in her chest, made her feel dizzy and lightheaded and high from the pure relief and love flooding in in its stead. She sniffs and wipes away her still flowing tears as she blubbers, "How long have you been walking?"

"Long enough that dropping into a dead sprint just now definitely was not my best idea," she hisses, her hands and feet twitching.

Still actively sobbing and trying to stop, Bow pushes himself to his feet and hurries over to the motorbikes. Scrubbing at his eyes and battling the exact same rushes of emotion as Glimmer, he looks over the first one quickly before darting over to the second. Beaming despite the mess of tears and probably snot decorating his face, he hurries back over as Glimmer helps Catra sit up.

"They're a little banged up," he sniffs, wiping his nose with his sleeve, "but both of the bikes should still work just fine. At the

very least they should get us at least close to home."

Glimmer lights up with a gasp. "Adora doesn't know yet! Stars, Catra! She's gonna be so relieved!"

Something sparks in Catra's eyes, a nervous and hopeful gleam swimming in the remaining tears making her gaze glassy.

"Adora's still alive?" she breathes out, sounding far more winded than she had after chasing them down. "She…" her ears pin. "Is she gonna actually want to see me?"

Glimmer slugs her without hesitation. "Okay, I get you've been dead for three years, but don't be stupid."

Catra frowns at her, rubbing the spot she'd just hit. She looks up as Bow steps forward and holds out his hands for her to take, and with a bracing breath she accepts and lets him tug her up. She stumbles into him immediately, grimacing at being back on her feet, but he takes her weight without complaint.

"We still have a room set up for you," he mutters with a loving smile, drawing her gaze again. She softens, and he can feel a weight lifting from her shoulders.

She presses her forehead into the crook of his neck. "You're all such idiots," she mumbles, unable to keep the swelling emotion in her tone hidden.

Despite the insult, or maybe even because of it, Glimmer just squeals and wraps her arms around the magicat, again squeezing her between herself and Bow. Seeing as how she doesn't even snap at them once to give her space, it's more than obvious just how badly she needs it.

Three years is a long time to go without a hug.

"Ready to go home?" Bow asks, the question filling him and Glimmer with the same warmth it does Catra.

“Please,” she whispers into his shirt.

With one more lasting squeeze of an embrace, the two hobble back over to the bikes, the magicat limping along supported between the two of them. They help her onto Bow’s slightly larger bike, the taller man sitting in front of her to give her something to lean against. She lets out a relieved, shuddering breath as she relaxes against Bow’s back, and he and Glimmer exchange a fond and ridiculously happy smile.

For the first time in three years, Catra was coming home.

Chapter End Notes

> Sorry for not including Adora’s reaction to Catra coming home very not-dead, just know there’s even more crying and probably some kissing and then all four of them cuddle for six hours straight

Post-Apocalypse - Bunker

Chapter Notes

> My goal for this week is I'm gonna try and respond to all the comments, wish me luck

See the end of the chapter for more notes

This place wasn't as scary as the abandoned village had been.

It was a lot smellier, a lot darker, and way smaller than the village. With the low ceilings and the sickly yellow lights, and the rows and rows of stuff and uncomfortable bunk beds, it probably should have set them a lot more on edge than it did.

But honestly, it wasn't too bad. The bed they'd been gently placed onto was still softer than the potato sack they'd had before, and neither that nor the blanket they were wrapped up in stunk like the rest of the place did. It smelled nice, like a campfire but less smoky. The two other scents mingling with the campfire smell, both faded but still strong enough that it was pretty obvious they belonged there, were familiar and comforting. They were especially noticeable on the blanket, and it helped to curl up and cuddle on the bunk with it, in the corner where the two little sketches were etched into the metal. They were warm, and had been given food rations and water without even having to ask for it. This place wasn't perfect, but it was… nice.

Still, right now all they wanted was for the magicat with the different eyes and the human with the glowy eyes to come back.

Their names were Catra and Adora. Catra's name was kind of funny since she was a magicat, but they didn't laugh at her name. Finn didn't like it when people made fun of names, especially when the person they were making fun of was so nice. Catra and Adora were both really nice. Catra was the one who'd found Finn, trapped under some rubble and unable to get out, and Adora was

the one who'd freed them. They didn't laugh when Finn was crying, in pain and terrified. Instead they'd smiled, soft and kind and caring. Adora had made them laugh while Catra bandaged their leg, and when Finn reached for a hug, Catra hadn't pulled away. She'd scooped them into her arms and held them, for hours. She hadn't put them down even though she and her team were still searching the village for survivors and supplies, and even when they all clambered into the trucks to move out she still didn't let go.

Finn was glad; they hadn't wanted her to let go. Her arms were warm and soft, she'd even taken off her armor and her jacket, leaving her in her tank top to make it more comfortable for them. While she was holding Finn, she spoke softly, even as she and Adora both gave the other soldiers commands, and Finn had finally felt safe enough to doze off, purring in her arms.

This was their bunk, and their blanket. They'd both promised Finn that they'd be back, that things were gonna be okay. Finn hadn't wanted them to leave, but they'd stayed quiet as the two adults had left. Nothing they ever said made anyone stay anyway.

Sighing into the blanket that smelled like Catra and Adora both, they carefully stretch out each of their limbs. Adora had given them some medicine before they'd left, and after some time it had helped the pain they were in die down. It kinda made them sleepy, too, though that might have just been because they were already so tired. It thankfully hadn't faded yet, what was once a persistent and overwhelming throbbing in their leg was now dulled to a soft ache, so long as they didn't move too much or put too much weight on it. They yawn, burrowing into the blanket and letting their tired eyes wander.

Just as they start to wonder about the other soldiers, what they might be like and how they got along with Catra and Adora, the heavy door to the bunker's barracks cranks open, and Finn's ears perk. They lift their head, sniffing at the air as heavy footsteps sound, but then a masculine voice laughs in response to

something Finn hadn't quite heard, and the voice wishes the other one luck before the door closes again.

They doubted that voice could belong to either of the two women they were hoping to see, but still they call out just in case. "Adora?"

The footsteps stop, then start again, coming towards them. They were heavy, like Adora's footsteps, so maybe? But even though its blonde hair and glowy gray-blue eyes that show when the soldier comes into view, it isn't her face that smiles down at them.

Well… it… kind of looks like hers.

"Hey, you must be the kid Adora was talking about!" the man says, stepping closer and flopping down on the foot of the lower bunk. His voice even sounds kind of like hers. "It's Finn, right? Nice to meet you, bud. I'm Adam."

Finn frowns. They weren't sure how to feel about this guy sitting on Catra and Adora's bed (though they liked that he wasn't immediately trying to sit right next to them), and his similarities to the blonde were still throwing them off.

They sniff the air again. "You smell like her."

Adam's eyebrows lift. "Who? Adora?" At Finn's slow nod, he laughs, leaning back on his gloved hands. "Y'know, I asked Catra once if we smelled alike. She answered pretty confidently that I stank just a little worse than she did." He pokes a thumb at himself and smiles softly at the cub. "Adora's my twin sister. Sorry, probably should have led with that, huh?"

Finn relaxes a little at that. "You're her brother?"

Adam nods. "She'd probably sooner call me a professional pain in her side, but yep! That's me!"

Finn readjusts the blanket around themself. The tentative unease that had immediately popped up when Adam had approached was

quickly fading now, and the sleepiness was slowly creeping back in. “Do you know where they are? Adora and Catra?”

Adam’s smile tenses a little, but doesn’t fade. “Yeah, I do. They’re… um…” he hesitates, trying to figure out a better way to phrase things that wouldn’t scare the cub. “They’re… out helping people right now. They probably won’t be back for a while, but they’ll be back.”

“Are they okay?”

“They better be,” he snorts as he slouches forward to rest his elbows on his knees. “They both still owe me fifty bucks each.” His smirk drops as he eyes the cub again, the tease not landing, and one of his hands comes up to rub his neck. “Which is not important, I know. Look, honestly? I don’t know how they’re doing right this minute. But I know them pretty dang well. When they make promises, they keep them. Adora mentioned they both promised you they’d be back, is that right?”

Finn nods, and Adam smiles.

“Then they’ll be back. Trust me, nothing’s gonna stop those two. They’re both captains for a reason, after all.”

The cub rubs their eyes and shifts around some more, readjusting to get more comfy.

“They’re gonna be okay?”

“Definitely.” Adam’s eyes follow the cub as they stretch out again, and his smile fades as his brow furrows.

Finn looks down at whatever made the man upset, and spots the bandage on their leg. There are some new blood spots that have oozed through, and their hackles raise at the sight, their breath hitching. That didn’t look good. Was that bad? What should they do? They hadn’t been paying attention when Catra had bandaged them, should they have been?

“Right,” Adam murmurs, his voice heavier but still soft as he shuffles to sit facing the cub, “Catra also said you were hurt.”

Finn’s ears pin, and a whimper escapes their throat. The sleepiness was being replaced with worry again. “What do I do? I didn’t think I was moving it wrong.”

“It’s okay,” the man soothes, smiling again at the cub when their eyes dart up. “She said you were hurt pretty bad. This can just happen sometimes with more severe injuries.” He holds out his hands, palms up. “Is it alright if I take a look and rewrap it? I know how to dress wounds like these.”

Finn sniffs, eyes watering again even though they really didn’t want to cry anymore. “Can you do it how Catra did it?”

“Well, she is the one who taught me, so… probably?”

The cub frowns, but still carefully scoots closer to the man as he pulls out some supplies from one of the pouches on his harness. He lays them out on the bed in between them one by one; a roll of bandages, a tube of ointment, a few pieces of gauze, and some sanitizer. He peels off his arm guards and rolls his sleeves up, then takes off his gloves.

Finn sniffs, wiping away more tears, and Adam looks up. After a moment, he cocks his head and asks, “I don’t stink, do I?”

Caught off guard, the cub trills and looks up. He smiles and holds up his hands, wiggling his fingers.

“I know I’ve been wearing my gloves all day but I promise I didn’t sweat *that* much.” He pauses, lifts his hands to his nose, and sniffs his knuckles. He peels away immediately with a gag that makes Finn snort. “Nope, nevermind, I really do stink.”

Finn giggles and wipes again at their tears, their breaths still hiccuping. “I d—I don’t smell anything.”

Adam lets out a breathy *whuff* as he reaches for the sanitizer. "*Good*," he emphasizes, earning another giggle. "You would have kicked me out if you smelt it."

Finn shakes their head as the man reaches for the bandage on their leg. "No, I wouldn't have."

"D'oh, I'm sure you would have. You would have smelled my stinky hands and been like 'eww, Catra was right, you're stinky and you smell like a moldy ration bar and fish.'" He pulls a hand away to wag a finger at the giggling cub. "I'm telling you, though, Adora smells just as bad."

Laughing, Finn shakes their head again. "She smells like a campfire, she doesn't stink."

Adam gasps, offended. "You're on Catra's side?! I should have known. Well I'll tell you what, what if I told you she was even *stinkier* than Adora and me *combined?*" He dramatically widens his eyes, humming questioningly, and Finn doesn't even notice the tug of the bandage pulling away.

"She smells like a campfire, too."

He scoffs, and Finn giggles again, their tears drying up. "Did she tell you to say that? That cheater, I can't believe she'd do this to me. She smells like *fish*, Finn. Like, right out of the pond, wet, slimy, gross, *fish*." He shudders theatrically, replacing the gauze on Finn's wound, and Finn can't even try to keep away their smile anymore.

"I like fish," they chirp, and laugh again when Adam's head whips up way too fast from where he'd been watching his hands unravel another bandage. He shakes his head pleadingly, and they nod theirs in confirmation. His careens back as he groans.

"Nooo, Finn!" he whines. "How are we supposed to be buddies if you like *fish?*"

Finn cocks their head, humming. "Well… I could eat them for you?"

The man gasps. "That's genius! Okay, *whew*, we can still be buddies." He smiles and pulls his hands away. "And… that leg of yours is all good to go again. Still feeling okay?"

Surprised, Finn trills again and looks back down. They'd barely even noticed him doing anything, and now he was tossing the old bandages away like they'd never been there in the first place.

Smiling, they look back up. "You did the same thing Catra and Adora did."

His eyes light up, and he lets out a massive breath as he swipes at his forehead. "Oh, good. I take it that means I did a good job?"

Finn nods, carefully touching the new bandage. It felt a little looser than the one before, but it was still comfortable.

"Sublime!" he cheers, hands fisted in the air excitedly, and Finn laughs again. Adam chuckles, readjusting himself on the bed to sit more comfortably. "Alright, so the leg is doing good. How about you? You feeling alright still? Do you need anything else?"

Finn's smile slowly fades. Wait, he wasn't leaving already, was he? They quietly ask as much, and his eyes soften.

"Well… I was planning on just checking in on you before heading out."

"Oh." He was leaving too. Ears drooping, the cub's head lowers, and they carefully scoot back as they again grab for the blanket. "Okay. Thank you for helping me."

Adam hums, a look of thought on his face. "Hey, I'm always happy to help." He glances at the door, pauses for a minute, then turns back. "And… I never said I *had* to leave."

Watching the cub light back up seems to reinvigorate Adam just as much, as he smiles when the kid perks up. "You don't have to go?"

"Not unless you don't want me to stick around," he says. He glances around again, then leans in close to whisper, "Don't tell anyone this, but technically I'm not supposed to head back out for another week. I was just gonna sneak out until I found you."

Finn cocks their head again. "Why aren't you supposed to head out?"

Adam makes a noise and leans back on his elbows. "Well, *technically*, I'm supposed to be 'taking it easy' to 'recover,'" he says as he curls the first two fingers on both hands. He snorts and lifts his left leg, the same as Finn's injured one, as he continues, "You and I are matching. I hurt this dang thing a few weeks ago and my sister was like 'if you sneak out one more time so help me I'm letting Catra wash your socks in the fish guts again.' And you *know* how I feel about fish."

Finn frowns at his leg. "Does it hurt still?"

"Nah, I'm alright." He lowers his leg and lets it rest on his opposite knee. "Like I said, I'm just supposed to take it easy for a little longer." He smiles, shrugging his shoulders. "I don't have to be anywhere else. Unless I'm still too stinky for you."

Finn laughs again. "You're not stinky!" they insist, rubbing their eyes again as a yawn creeps out again.

Adam chuckles. "If you say so." He tilts his head. "Still. If you want me to, I can leave."

"… what if… I don't want you to leave?"

"Then I'll stay."

Their ears pop up as they let out a sleepy, pleased chuff. As Adam pulls off the rest of his gear and his jacket, shoving them all off

onto the floor, Finn tentatively crawls forward, blanket in hand. As Adam scoots back onto the mattress, he spots the cub getting closer, and smiles even as they freeze.

"Catra mentioned you seemed to really like hugs," he says, and to the cub's delight he opens his arms invitingly. "I can't promise mine'll be as good as hers, but… do you want one?"

Finn nods, and can't stop the purr from rumbling through their chest as the man scoops them up as gently as Catra had. They curl into his chest, chirping as he readjusts the blanket around them. He doesn't even blink as they curl their claws into his shirt. His hand drapes over their back once they've settled, and the cub sighs at the warmth. He was right, they liked how Catra had held them a lot better. She was warmer and comfier than he was. But they still like his hug. It's nice.

He was nice, and funny, and kind. They like him too. They still want Catra and Adora to come back, but… they're really glad Adam was here in the meantime.

Chapter End Notes

> Catra and Adora both get back later that night, beat up and in need of a good few weeks off and a nap in bed, only to find Adam already asleep in it with the cub slumbering on his chest
>
> I don't have a dang clue where Adam came from btw, he wasn't supposed to be here, he just kinda showed up and took over
>
> Anyway I demand more Uncle Adam and Nibling Finn bonding time bc even tho neither of them show up in the show they both have my heart

Post-Apocalypse - Wasteland

Chapter Notes

CW: dead bodies, and reacting to said dead bodies

Also just for the sake of my sanity, I want to clarify something. I got a troll or a bot comment on the prompt before this, accusing me of using AI to write it and calling it lifeless and soulless. Some people in the She-Ra server helped me recognize that it *was* likely just a troll or a bot (thank you again, you freaking angels) but it still got to me and made my anxiety skyrocket for a minute. I just wanted to quickly make it obvious: I have *never* used Generative AI in anything I create, and I *never will* use Generative AI in anything I create.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra was starting to get really tired of the constant side-eyes the others were giving her.

"Can you all look at *anything* else for just… *five* minutes?" she sighs, beyond annoyed. Yes, she knew where they were going. No, she was not about to shatter like glass because of it.

She wasn't planning on it at least.

"Sorry, kid," Netossa huffs, her voice far less energetic than usual. She even looks less vibrant than normal, when Catra glances at her. "We're not doing it on purpose, I swear."

"We're just a little…" Spinnerella trails off, trying to find the right words. She's not quite as down-trodden as her wife, but it's clear she was affected by all this too.

Bow frowns. “We’re just worried about you, is all. I can’t imagine how hard this must be for you.”

Catra scoffs, turning away from them again and walking a little faster. “It’s not gonna be anything I haven’t seen before. You’re all being ridiculous.”

She says that, and ignores the way her hackles rise and her tail lashes as she watches smoke billowing up past the village’s edges. She knows none of them believe her, and for once, she’s more glad than she is annoyed (how could she be, when she doesn’t even believe herself?). She swallows, her steps faltering. Adora’s hand softly slips into hers, and she grips it tight.

“We don’t have to go in,” she mutters softly. Her eyes are tender when Catra hesitantly looks up to meet them, and she gives the magicat’s hand another gentle squeeze. “We can always send in a squadron of scouts for us. It doesn’t have to be us. It doesn’t have to be you.”

Catra swallows again, and turns away with her eyes shut tight. Breathing in steadily through her nose—she regrets it immediately, the smell of smoke and burnt flesh instantly coating her throat—she takes another step forward, then another.

“Yes it does,” she mutters hoarsely. She shakes her head when Adora goes to argue. “You know it does. A squadron won’t know what to… they won’t know.”

She hates the look of sadness that washes over her girlfriend, and again looks away to just keep moving forward.

To her credit, her steps don’t falter again until she reaches the village’s entrance, a path she’s taken dozens if not hundreds of times before. But her steps don’t just falter, they completely stop. It’s like an invisible gate had been erected, one keeping her locked out of the home she’d been trying to get back to for years, the home that had never once turned her away, and now she can’t go through. She tries to will her legs to move, tries to will

her claws to retreat and her feet to obey, but nothing does as she silently commands.

Her chest feels tighter as her eyes skim over what she can see just from the entrance. Her stomach curdles, and her ears pin, and suddenly that confidence she'd been perfectly capable of exuding the entire way here feels like it never existed in the first place. She feels just like the scared little kitten she'd been when she was first taken away from this place, except she'd had the strength and the courage to fight back then. She didn't know where any of that was now.

A gentle touch lands between her shoulder blades, and she jumps. Glimmer pulls back, shining eyes sympathetic, understanding. She blinks back the tears as she and Bow both wordlessly offer their support, and Catra hates that she needs it in the first place. She hates that she knew exactly what was waiting for her past this point, hates that she knows perfectly well that never again would it be warm smiles and loving kisses and massive hugs, all from people just like her, with her ears and her eyes and her tail and her fur.

She knows she can't put this off forever. She knows it has to be her who goes in first, who gets to what all was left of this place before scavengers and thieves came to take advantage of it. She was the only one left who had any right or claim to this place.

She hated that, too.

Her hands start to shake, all the while she inwardly screams and yells at herself to just move, just *move, idiot*. She doesn't jump this time as a hand again gently touches her back, followed by another, and then another, and another. A pincer and a glove are notably missing; part of her regrets asking Scorpia and Entrapta to stay behind, but the rest of her is grateful they had.

She didn't want anyone here for this, but they were the only two she felt like she could actually ask to stay back. The other five all

had ties to this place just like she did, most not nearly as strong, but still just as real. How could she tell them to stay out?

Stars, she hadn't even gone in yet and she was already starting to break. Had she secretly always been this pathetic?

It's only with their touch on her back that she's finally able to cross the invisible line, into what had once been her favorite physical place in the world.

Her plans to keep it together crumple apart as fast as she does. Even having just barely walked in, the signs of struggle and death outweigh any signs of life, and her tentative hopes scramble to get away from her and the wasteland lying before her.

A homely little cottage had always been the first thing one would see upon entering the village, home to the resident old man whom always *always* had a warm smile and a friendly greeting on his whiskered face. More than once, Catra had found herself being drawn in, sometimes just to say hi and exchange an embrace, and other times to actually go inside with the old man to visit, something she wasn't wont to do very often with very many people.

The cottage was little more than a few measly stones and charred wood. In what remained of the doorway, the remnants of a body lay also, as charred and blackened by smoke and flames as the house itself, hand outstretched as if grasping for help that would never come. He hadn't escaped the storm of wild flames that had followed the infection outbreak.

Catra's stomach lurches, and she only just barely keeps everything down. She is unable to suppress the tears. Not even ten feet into the village, and already she was regretting having ever even looked in the direction of this place after learning of its fate.

The man's name escapes Spinnerella's lips in a choked gasp, a hand clamped over her mouth as tears well in her eyes as well. Netossa stares in horror, unsurprised but sickened all the same.

Catra doesn't want to see what else lay in wait. She doesn't want to know who else she cared for and loved was dead. She wanted to live in ignorant bliss for the rest of her days, where she could just assume everyone had escaped and was just… very far away. That's what she should have done, instead of coming here.

But… she had to know. And she had to find… well. What they were *officially* here looking for honestly didn't matter to her nearly as much as it should have. It didn't matter as much as the people protecting it did, not to her.

"Catra?" Glimmer's voice comes out soft as a whisper. Catra's ear twitches, but she refuses to turn around. She refuses to respond.

She takes a shaky step forward instead, and just keeps going.

The tears become steady streams down her cheeks, with every shaky step she takes. The old man's cottage was only the beginning of the horrors. Everywhere she looks, every step forward exposing her to more and more of the carnage, her hopes of finding any survivors are slowly torn and ripped into smaller and smaller pieces. She feels heavier and heavier and heavier with every passing second, feels her feet shaking and numbing more and more and more, as she passes home after shop after garden after stand, every last thing and place scarred and broken from the hellish chaos that had been unleashed on the world. Gashes are left in the ground from the claws of feet and hands driving into it to run, as fast as they could go.

She only dares let her eyes linger on any of the bodies she stumbles across when they bare even a slight resemblance to the few individuals she was most desperate to never see laying still. But she recognizes every face she finds, and each time she looks a new dagger stabs through her chest and her legs, making it increasingly harder to breathe or walk properly.

Adora, Bow, and Glimmer were all struggling as well, that much was clear, but as hard as it was for them to take in, it wouldn't be nearly as devastating to them as it was to her.

Netossa and Spinnerella, however…

Catra drags her gaze away from the nauseating sight of another corpse—the baker lady, who had always been endlessly amused by even Catra's most sour and prickly quips, and who had oftentimes even indulged in a few of her own—to figure out where the other two had gone. She finally finds them, up ahead and paused in front of…

She barely keeps herself from retching.

They were stopped in front of her house. What *used* to be her house.

Both were frozen in horror at what they saw.

She hates herself for it. She really, really does. But she forces her trembling, barely working legs to cooperate, slowly taking her over to join the two. Netossa hears her approaching and looks over her shoulder—she doesn't cry, Netossa doesn't cry, why were there tears in her eyes?—and the heartbreak and dismay painted across her features almost makes Catra stumble.

"Kid," she croaks, drawing Spinnerella's attention. She shakes her head, stepping towards the magicat as if to block her from the sight. She knew as well as Catra that it was pointless to try. "Kid, don't… don't go in there, don't look. Please don't look."

But she was already looking.

She doesn't feel herself hit the ground, knees first then hands. She doesn't feel her claws curling into the stone beneath her, cracking and snapping the rock into sharp shards that poke and press into the pads of her hands. She doesn't hear the panicked and worried cries of her name, doesn't notice the gentle concerned touches landing soft as kisses on her trembling back.

She doesn't register anything but *them*.

In a few hours, Adora will find whatever they'd had to come here for. To the people waiting for them back at the camp, this whole thing will have been worth it, because they'll have secured whatever they'd needed to find. But Glimmer and Bow will make the long walk back alone.

Because even hours from now, Catra will still be wailing her heart out, as Netossa, Spinnerella, and Adora hold her in their arms.

Hours from now, days from now, years from now, it didn't matter.

Her family will still be gone.

Chapter End Notes

> And with this prompt done I'd just like to say WHOOAA WE'RE HALFWAY THEEERRRE (until I split another chapter into two for an upcoming prompt) *WHOOOOOOOOOAAAAAA*
>
> To everyone who's left a comment on any of these, or given this thing a kudos, or even just read these things as I pump them out, thank you *so much*. You have *no* idea just how much it means to me to see so many people *like* what I put out there, and I'm incredibly grateful to all of you!

Post-Apocalypse - Dystopia

Chapter Notes

The vibes for this one?

Three Day's Grace "Riot"

(It does drop an "f" bomb, so if you choose to look it up and are like me and don't like curse words there's your warning; I didn't have time to find the censored version but it's probably out there somewhere)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

She didn't deserve this.

In truth, none of them did. She knew that the people she'd grown up with would agree vehemently, knew that they were angry and struggling and hurting, while the princesses lived as though a global threat hadn't just destroyed every walk of life imaginable. What made them so different from everyone else? Why did they get to live lives of splendor and normalcy, while everyone else was left to rot? Because they'd helped bring about the end of the infection? That wasn't just them, and they all knew it.

But no one ever dared acknowledge it. Why would they?

"Reports have shown a recent uptick in break-ins to our food reserves," Angella explains, pointing out on a map the locations that had been targeted. "We have multiple eye-witness confirmations that all break-ins were orchestrated by Horde affiliates."

Adora frowns, fidgeting uncomfortably in her seat. There was probably a *really good reason* their storage facilities were being broken into. She remembers all too well how much they'd had to struggle to find anything decent to eat, even after the last of the infected were finally dealt with.

Feeling her brow twitch as one of Angella's more snobbish guests scoffs and drops a very targeted insult under his breath, she moves to stand and speak her mind.

Angella gives her a warning look that she pointedly ignores.

"I am speaking from *personal* experience when I say this," she stresses the word, eyes narrowing into a barely concealed glare that the older woman clearly doesn't appreciate. "Living anywhere but in this city was near impossible, with extremely limited resources and few places safe enough to set up a shelter. The wildlife population numbers in all the neighboring woodlands haven't recovered enough yet to allow for substantial hunting, and even though most water sources are still clean and reliable, clean water isn't enough on its own to survive off of."

Angella sighs tersely, and Adora's hands clench into fists. "As we have discussed many times before, my dear, we are aware of the struggles beyond the city limits, and have taken action to bring aide and resources to these people."

She laughs, the sound just as tight, and she spots several people eyeing their neighbor uneasily. "You ever consider that maybe those actions aren't good enough? Why else would the Horde be breaking into these places and *only* these places?"

"*Adora*," Glimmer, sitting between her mother and Bow, hisses between her teeth. Bow looks just as uncomfortable, but Adora had never *been* comfortable with the greater-than-thou air that the princesses so often displayed, and she was getting tired of staying quiet about it.

"Why else would the Horde, the very same people who gave us so much grief before and during the outbreak in any and every way they could, launch attacks on such valuable locations, stealing away with and damaging much needed resources?" The taller woman stands straighter, the disapproval in her eyes as damning as her words.

Adora refused to cower under either.

"Adora, I understand that it may be difficult for you to understand the severity of the Horde's actions. It is admirable that your empathy and compassion are so great. But you must understand the dangers present." She looks to her left and nods, and an elf woman with a scar over the bridge of her nose—Adora's pretty sure her name was Juliet?—nods back, standing to also gesture to the map.

"While the Horde's actions are difficult to fully predict, there is a pattern emerging, one I doubt was meant to be brought to our attention." She brings to attention all of the locations attacked with forceful taps on the map, and nods at the pig-tailed woman distractedly fidgeting with something or other, away from the table. "Entrapta was the first to notice it. They're continuing to plunder our food stores, and though they've attempted to keep their attacks random and seemingly unorganized…" Her tapping fingers slowly move along the locations, until they stop at a seemingly random point on the map. "This is the location of our largest storage and production facility. Looking at the locations they've targeted, especially as of late, it seems fairly obvious they've been working up to something big. This is it. This is where the Horde is attacking next."

Adora again twitches with annoyance. "We could prevent such an attack if we spent more time and energy on bettering the production numbers and availability of resources. These people aren't monsters!"

"Yeah, I'm pretty sure increasing available resources is gonna take a lot more time than…" Mermista huffs, "What do we even have before they attack? Like, less than 48 hours?"

Juliet straightens, arms folded behind her back. "Judging by the increasing frequency of Horde attacks, Entrapta has calculated that we have approximately between 48 to 60 hours before another is launched on the warehouse."

Mermista slumps into her fist and waves her hand at Juliet, almost bored as she eyes Adora. "I don't know about you, but I don't think food production can speed up all that much in less than a week. The only way to prevent the warehouse from getting attacked at this point, is to go there and stop them ourselves."

Angella nods. "Precisely." She leans forward, planting her palms on the table. "Not including those of us gathered here tonight, I already have most of our strongest fighters moving out. They will reach the warehouse in only five hours, where they will set up both surrounding and inside the building to lay in wait for any signs of this inevitable break-in attempt. The rest of us will join them, in time, but for now we will remain here in case we receive news of anything changing."

Adora goes to angrily argue some more, but is stopped by a careful touch on her arm. She looks down to see Scorpia tugging softly on her sleeve, coaxing her to sit back down with a gentle expression on her face. Gritting her teeth, she follows the prompting, plopping back down into her seat with what had to be the most undignified sulky expression ever.

She didn't care. She didn't ask to be granted a life of privilege and honor while the rest of the world suffered. If Angella and the others expected her to behave like a princess, she was happy and eager to disappoint.

Eyeing the time, Scorpia bites her lip and slowly moves to stand. Before she does, she hesitates, then leans over to whisper to Adora, "For what it's worth… I agree with you."

Adora's expression softens a little as surprise takes over. She watches the scorpioni try (and fail) to get out of her seat without drawing attention, uttering a string of flustered apologies when she very nearly bumps into Perfuma with her tail and then almost knocking into Mermista next. She finally manages to get away from the table, but Angella's eyes follow her curiously.

"Everything alright, Ms. Tenebris?"

Scorpia stops in her tracks and turns around with an embarrassed blush on her cheeks. “Sorry,” she stammers, “I didn’t mean to interrupt, I just need to step out and use the little scorpion’s room.”

Angella sighs and smiles. “Quite alright, apologies for bringing attention to it. Take a left down the hall, it should be the first door on the right.”

“Thank you!” she calls as she rushes out, almost bumping into Entrapta as she takes her leave. The short woman startles as she bumbles by, then perks up and races after her.

“Oh! Scorpia! Before you go—” The two exit the room, the rest of Entrapta’s sentence fading away the further away they get.

Adora frowns, still focused on what Scorpia had whispered to her. She definitely hadn’t been expecting *her* of all people to agree with her, she thought the towering woman hated her.

The conversation is quick to move on, circling back to the Horde and the threat it posed, and Adora’s sour attitude is even quicker to return. She doesn’t bother speaking out again, she knows no one will take into account her opinion. Slumping even lower in her chair, she lets her mind wander instead, and slowly, an idea begins to form.

She doesn’t notice Bow and Glimmer eyeing her before exchanging a knowing glance.

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She didn’t deserve this.

In truth, none of them did. She knew that the people she’d grown up with would agree vehemently, knew that they were angry and struggling and hurting, while the princesses lived as though a global threat hadn’t just destroyed every walk of life imaginable. What made them so different from everyone else? Why did they get to live lives of splendor and normalcy, while everyone else was

left to rot? Because they'd helped bring about the end of the infection? That wasn't just them, and they all knew it.

But no one ever dared acknowledge it. Why would they?

Acknowledging that the life they led was unfair would mean they'd actually have to do something about it.

And unlike Catra, and the people scrambling about getting ready for what she'd been planning for months, the princesses would never even consider inviting change to their cushy, perfect lives.

But that was alright. Catra had never needed invitations.

"How are we doing?" she asks as Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio approach. They salute, and she waves them off.

"All of the supplies have been distributed accordingly to all of the captains and their squadrons," Lonnie reports, the three falling in step behind the magicat as she keeps walking. Every individual who notices them passing by either salutes or otherwise acknowledges them, with cheers or rallying cries or even just simple nods and smirks. A smirk of her own slowly stretches across her face as the other woman continues, "So far, seven out of fifteen captains have confirmed they're ready. We're looking at maybe another thirty-five minutes before the stragglers are caught up, then all that's left is your team."

Rogelio finally fishes out what he'd been trying to grab from his satchel, and he passes the items over to Catra. She takes them without a word, and without slowing or stopping she adorns the bullet-proof vest first.

"What about your group, big guy? You guys all set?"

The caimisk looses an affirmative growl, nodding his head. "*Most are already in position. I will be joining them soon.*"

"Good. Kyle, any news from the scouts?"

Kyle nods. “We’ve received word that Angella’s forces moved out two hours ago. There were about thirty individuals, all of them people Juliet has personally trained and outfitted with special weapons and armor.”

“Princesses with them?”

He shakes his head. “None that we’ve noticed.”

Catra hums, sliding the thick trench coat on next. They walk past another captain trying to get his squadron under control, but the moment they spot the magicat any order their captain managed to wrangle from them evaporates, as they all ecstatically call out to her with a mix of encouragement, determination, and admiration. The captain salutes as they pass, begrudgingly hi-fiving Kyle when he excitedly holds out his hand.

He beams down at his palm as they move on. Rogelio’s scaly lips stretch into a fond grin.

Lonnie starts passing her the supplies she’d personally requested, and she shoves them into corresponding pockets of the coat as she does. “Have you heard back from them yet?”

Catra shakes her head as they finally reach the stairs, and turn to ascend them. “Not yet, but it won’t be much longer. You’ve seen how good they are at this.”

Lonnie huffs. “Yeah, I have. It’s almost concerning.”

She smirks, ear flicking in acknowledgement as they climb the last few steps. With the last gadget pocketed, Kyle passes her the last of her items, a pair of thick gloves with slits for her claws, and a set of specially made goggles. Leaving the goggles resting on her forehead, she pulls on the gloves and finally turns to respond. “Luckily for us, any explosions they may cause this time, accidental or otherwise, will be in our favor.”

She holds up her hands as she shrugs. “Meh. You got a point, there.”

A device buzzes in her pants' pocket. She reaches in and pulls it out, and her smirk widens dangerously as she reads the text spilling over the screen.

Lonnie's eyes light up. "Is that them?"

Catra doesn't answer, until the last of the text has stopped scrolling along.

We're in position. They don't suspect a thing.

Waiting on your command.

She chuckles darkly, and tucks the device away again. Eyes scanning over the throngs of people, all ready and waiting for her even as a few continue to hurry and get the last few preparations made, she doesn't bother hiding her own eagerness, tail thwipping side to side in a rhythmic delight.

"Lonnie," she purrs, and the woman stands at attention. "How long did you say the stragglers would take?"

"Half an hour, tops."

Catra's tail curls. "Think you can convince them to be done in the next ten minutes?"

Her pale green eyes sharpen, and her smile grows as menacing as Catra's.

"I can get them to be done in five."

Catra laughs.

"Perfect."

• 🍄 🪦 🍂 •

Stars, she thought that stupid meeting would *never* end.

Technically speaking, it still hadn't. But if she had to sit in that stupid room even a second longer, she was going to wring someone's neck.

Giving the same reasoning as Scorpia had earlier, Adora excuses herself to the restroom, and barely keeps herself from *booking* it down the halls and away from the stifling environment, peeling out onto a balcony instead.

The fresh air sends a chill down her spine, and she relaxes instantly with a moan, trodding over to the banister and slumping heavily against it. She rests her forehead in one hand, and lets her gaze fall over the peaceful, beautiful city.

The sight makes her sick.

She was never supposed to see the city from up here. She was only ever supposed to be one of the unlucky onlookers, one of the people desperate for a taste of ease and relaxation they would never be allowed to have. She was supposed to be down there, scampering through the alleyways and ruins, stealing from the rich to give to the poor, go full Robin Hood and Little John with her best friend to just maybe make a difference.

She never would have guessed that it would be easier to make a difference as someone confined to the streets than someone living at the heart of the problem.

Her hands slowly ball into fists, and her eyes narrow as she glares at nothing. She had to do something. Something other than step even a single toe into helping with the stupid plan to ambush the Horde at the warehouse.

But she would have to wait. As much as she wanted to leave now, to just launch herself off this balcony and hit the ground running until she was finally back where she should have been, she knew she had to wait.

Just a little longer.

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She couldn’t help but wonder, in these final moments before they finally set out, how different things would be if Adora were still here.

Her good mood is quick to darken at the thought, wiping away the grin and the near bounce in her step as easily as one crunched a leaf beneath their heel. But even still, the what ifs flood her mind. Adora was supposed to be at *her* side for something like this, something this *huge*. She wasn’t just supposed to be at her side, *she* was supposed to be the one spearheading something like this.

But no. She’d left her behind without a second thought. Left them *all* behind, because life as a princess was just *too* enticing to pass up.

The thing is, Catra didn’t disagree with that. The princesses had it *good*. They had it *more* than good. It was like everything and anything that could make the world they were stuck with livable and happy again had all been rounded up before anyone could object, and given to those select few. There was a reason they called them “princesses.” Catra knew—*everyone* knew—that life with or as a princess was better than anything a normal person could imagine.

The thing Catra disagreed with was that kind of life being reserved to only a select few.

Maybe it was a good thing her good mood had evaporated. Anger was a common emotion among the non-princess folk. Anger at the injustice, the unfairness, the biases and needless divide between two peoples who should be working together, but never would so long as the better off continued to cling tight to the life they’d been given. The life they’d *taken*.

Catra marches to the center of the massive room, and every voice quiets to silence. Every eye is on her, the one who’d finally decided enough was enough and had the guts to rally the unlucky

together, and *do* something about it all. She can tell they sense her anger, something that had never truly faded but now stood as center-staged as she herself did.

Fifteen captains stand waiting for her command. Fifteen squadrons stand waiting for her command. Her personal team stands waiting for her command.

And so, she gives it.

Her lips curl up in a wide-toothed, grinning sneer, twitching over her canines. She didn't bother preparing a speech. Whatever she needed to say, she'd know in the moment. The place is dead silent, and her voice rings out as she finally speaks.

"Who's ready to show these princesses a good old fashioned hard time?"

The silence is further shattered by an eruption of passionate cries.

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Honestly, she'd made it a lot farther than she'd been expecting. From the moment she'd snuck out, she'd been frantically checking over her shoulder every couple of steps, certain that Angella had someone tailing her, ready to have her locked up for betraying them or defecting or *something*. But she'd made it all the way to the edge of the city without a single disruption. When it finally happens, it isn't her getting caught that surprises and saddens her.

It's who just caught her that does that.

"You're sneaking out to go do something with the Horde," Glimmer states flatly, her arms crossed at her chest, her father's faded and torn brown leather jacket oddly fitting amidst her sparkly rainbow top and black yoga pants. Bow stands at her side, his own arms crossed over his crop top and muted green and black jacket.

Adora grits her teeth, and takes a step away from them. She says nothing.

"Were you seriously just not going to tell us?" Glimmer seethes, arms snapping down to rest at her sides. "*Us??* Your supposed *best friends?!*"

"What was I supposed to do?!" she snaps back. "I can't go along with those *stupid* plans anymore! The Horde was my family! I know they're doing some bad things right now, but I can't just stand by and keep fighting *against* them!"

Glimmer sighs, and Adora's temper flares even hotter. Until she speaks again. "No, you idiot, I got that part, that's the understandable part and that's *not* the issue here."

She can't help it. Confused and caught off guard, she deflates. "I… then what… *is* the problem?"

Bow loudly sniffs, arms still crossed, and she abruptly realizes he's about to *cry*. "You didn't tell us."

Glimmer, blessedly, clarifies before Adora can get much more confused. "We could have helped you sneak out a *lot* more subtly if you'd just *talked to us*. Freaking stupid."

She gawks, jaw dropping. "I… seriously?"

Glimmer rolls her eyes as Bow noisily wipes away his tears. "Adora, if we were going to stop you, we would have done so a lot sooner. I wasn't kidding about you not being subtle, my mom knows you snuck out."

She swallows. "And… she's not gonna stop me either?"

Glimmer grins. "She thinks that's what we're here to do. Normally she would have sent some more people with us, but I hear they're all a *little* occupied tonight."

Shaking her head, she smiles incredulously. “How mad do you think she’s gonna be?”

“Oh I don’t have to guess,” the shorter woman shakes her own head with an eye roll. “Now then. Are you going to actually tell us what you’re planning, or are we gonna have to stalk you right into the belly of the beast?”

“You guys are serious about this,” she murmurs, her smile growing wider as they both again confirm this. Feeling a surge of unexpected delight, she rushes them both and traps them in a mighty hug, squeezing them tight for a long moment before finally drawing back.

“So,” Bow grins. “What’s the plan?”

Before Adora can respond, a bang followed by a shrill whistle has them all flinching in surprise, and they turn to see a burning red flare shooting up from the center of the city.

The speed at which things fall apart after that is nothing short of impressive.

Not even a full two seconds pass from the launching of the flare before excited howls and cheers start up from all around them. In the darkness surrounding them, glowing eyes start to blink from the shadows, cackles and whoops and hollers erupting from between grinning white canines. Bow and Glimmer both squawk in alarm, but Adora just pales. Windows start shattering, explosions ring out, the smiling shadows rushing the streets in a surging wave of violence.

Screams start accompanying the wild howls and cheering laughter, and its those sounds of pure unfiltered panic that finally kickstart Adora’s legs into functioning again. She races back into the city, drawing her sword from its sheath fully prepared to swing it into a person if need be.

It quickly gets worse.

An explosion erupts right behind her, blowing her off her feet and sending her flying. She rolls as she falls and quickly recovers her stance, even if there is a slight ringing in her ears, but it's as she stands back up that a fist plows into her cheek and knocks her back again. She doesn't see who hit her, and lashes out blindly with her fists—she must have lost her sword in the blast—but hits no one. She hears more cackling, hears someone shout out "looks like some of the princesses decided to join us after all!", hears booing and hissing and then feels another blow nail her in the gut, dropping her to her knees with a winded grunt.

"Adora!" she hears Glimmer shout, before she too cries in pain. Adora sees her hit the ground hard, skidding a foot along the ground, before snarling and lifting her staff just in time to block an absolutely massive caimisk as she pounces onto her, jaws snapping eagerly. Glimmer throws her off and over her head, and thankfully is quick to get back on her feet and continue defending herself.

Adora's eyes snap up just in time to see a woman with a stun baton rearing back to ready an electrifying blow. She ducks just in time to avoid it, and charges forward to knock the woman off her feet. The baton skitters out of her grasp, and Adora stomps on it, destroying the weapon.

"Come on!" she calls out to Glimmer, before turning on a dime to race further in. She sees Bow up ahead, struggling but holding his own impressively well against a caimisk and an impressively burly elf woman. Adora leans forward and barrels shoulder first into the elf woman's lower back, eliciting a pained shriek as she bowls her to the ground. The caimisk whips around just in time for Adora to slug her in the jaw, stunning her enough that she's able to duck past them and snatch Bow by the back of his shirt.

Glimmer screams emphatically as she catches up to them. "What the—" the roar of another caimisk drowns out her profanity "—is going *on?!*"

“It’s the Horde!” Adora gasps out as they run past more and more and more chaos and destruction.

“Yeah I *got* that but how?! *Why?!* I thought they were attacking the warehouse!”

Adora didn’t have an answer to that part.

“I don’t know how or why they’re attacking,” she pants, “but I think they’re gunning for the center of the city. We have to get back there, fast!”

Glimmer cackles madly. “Mom’s gonna be so-ho-ho *pissed!*”

Finally finding a small break in the chaos, Adora yanks her friends down another alleyway, one that will hopefully help them get to the center much quicker. As the sounds of madness slowly fade while they run, she even lets herself hope they’ll get to the others in time, before it can reach them and catch them off guard. She might not be too thrilled with the way they do things, but she still doesn’t want to see anyone hurt.

“We’re almost there,” she huffs, nearing one final corner. “We’ll find Angella, get everyone gathered up, and then—”

They skid around the final bend, and freeze.

There, in the middle of the last street between them and the princesses, stood a person drenched in shadows, turned away from them with eyes trained on the main building acting as the headquarters. By the figure’s side stood another, smaller individual, a familiar one, with two massive pigtails and some kind of tablet in hand.

The smaller figure turns and looks first, and the glowing red eyes of a mask wordlessly land on them. The second figure does not turn around.

Somehow, the sight was far more intimidating than the one they’d just gotten away from.

“E-Entrapta?” Adora calls out hesitantly. “Who… w-who’s that you’re with?”

“Oh! Adora!” The short woman calls back, perking up. She pulls up her mask, and she’s beaming. “And Bow and the sparkly one! We were under the impression the three of you were still inside!” She pauses and looks to the other figure, who was still turned away. “Does this complicate things?”

The figure doesn’t respond, and Adora feels her unease steadily increasing, the growing sounds of chaos doing nothing to assuage the feeling.

“What do you mean, ‘complicate things?’” Bow asks hesitantly. “Entrapta? What’s going on?”

Entrapta cocks her head at them. “I thought it would be obvious. Was I incorrect?”

“Nah,” a second voice rumbles, from *behind* them this time, and they all whip around to see another figure step out of the shadows, slowly prowling towards them. A scorpioni tale rattles behind her, and Adora’s breath hitches as Scorpia steps into a beam of light, an impressive glare marring her features. “What’s happening right now is plenty obvious. These guys just need a second.”

The words are kind, but are delivered in almost a growl. Scorpia stalks past them all, her gaze only softening a little and for just a moment when it meets Adora’s, but then quickly shifting into a snarl again. She slots herself on the stranger’s other side.

Finally, the figure speaks. “Did they give you any trouble?”

Adora’s eyes widen at the sound of the voice.

Scorpia snickers, tail flicking again. “None. I took out who we needed, and Entrapta’s got the rest trapped inside. The rest is up to you, Boss.”

Boss. This person was behind this attack. This person was the leader of the Horde. Scorpia and Entrapta were Horde. Scorpia, Entrapta, and the person they both flanked, were Horde, they were behind this attack…

And Adora personally knew all three of them.

"You're with…?" Glimmer's voice trails off, face pale, before she steals herself and her expression melts into pure rage. "You're both with the *Horde?!*"

"Why…?" Like Glimmer, Bow's voice hardens. "*Why?!*"

The figure in the middle lifts her head, and a deep, menacing chuckle brings with it an eery silence. She finally turns around…

And Catra's eyes glare back at them. Anger and hatred burn bright as stars in her eyes, piercing blue and gold, and Adora finds she can't look away.

"Because we're long overdo for a much needed change, princesses," another familiar voice calls, and Lonnie steps from the shadows, also emerging from behind them, a stun baton drawn and sparking in front of her. She smirks, that same anger aflame in her eyes of pale lime green.

"And if you're not going to do it…" another familiar voice, and Kyle steps out opposite Lonnie, Rogelio right beside him and crouched on all fours, lips pulled back in a sneer, the same anger burning just as bright in their eyes.

Something snaps behind Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio, and Adora's gut sinks to see dozens upon dozens of glowing, angry eyes, all peering at them from the darkness. The sounds of chaos still blaze in the distance, but they've quieted.

The calm before the storm stared at them from the darkness.

Finally, Catra speaks. "We'll do it ourselves."

Like a bomb had just gone off, the shadows surge forward, the same howls and cackles and jeers and whoops and hollers reigniting, coloring the air like the snaps and crackles of fireworks exploding one right after the other. Everyone surges past the paralyzed trio of princesses, racing for their headquarters, bumping into and crashing past them without a care, but none getting even a centimeter close enough to do the same to their leader.

Their leader, her best friend, who stands and glares right at Adora, as chaos and madness and fury rage around them.

Chapter End Notes

> I find it endlessly entertaining that whatever causes the notes I left under the first chapter to appear under every new chapter makes it so that no matter what happens, someone's making out (may or may not be the characters in the chapter) and then someone runs up to them with a chainsaw

Post-Apocalypse - Galactic Empire

Chapter Notes

> This was not what I originally had planned for this prompt, but I decided I didn't actually want to do the other idea I'd first come up with, and instead came up with this all today and like it a *lot* better

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer grabs the hair atop the clone's head and yanks their head back. "You wouldn't happen to have seen a super annoying completely unable to shut up even when his life and everyone else's lives depend on it *space captain* anywhere, would you?" The dazed clone gurgles something that sounds like a negative. "No? Alright well you're useless then."

Letting go, she rears back with her staff and clocks the clone across the jaw, darting off before they even hit the floor.

"*Please* tell me you've found something?" she groans as she pivots on her heel to come back to back with Bow, the two battling off oncoming soldiers and clones as they come, going for just simple knockouts but undoubtedly killing one or two along the way. She huffs, breathless, as she smacks another drone from the air. "At least tell me those two haven't managed to stab us in the back just yet?"

"Well!" the man chirps, ducking to let Glimmer swing her staff over his head to collide with another soldier's face. "I can confirm one of those things!"

Grimacing, she glances over her shoulder. "Please tell me its not the latter—"

A blast rocks the ship further down the corridor, followed by a tirade of exasperated and slightly panicked cursing along with an ecstatic cackling. Only a second later, the frantic soldier and the

raggedy magicat they'd somehow teamed up with earlier come peeling down the hall, the feline struggling to run as she laughs and the blonde still actively cursing a mile a minute.

Glimmer grits her teeth. "I was really hoping it wouldn't be the latter," she hisses under her breath.

"Hey!" the magicat greets, still shaking with laughter. She abruptly drops to all fours to race to them even faster, then just before she can collide with them she plants her feet and pounces over them, crashing into an oncoming clone's face and sending him to the ground. She leaps off of him with the momentum of the collision, and turns back with a borderline manic grin on her face that sends a shiver down Glimmer's spine. "Where'd the two of you go? You weren't trying to lose us were you? It kinda feels like you were trying to lose us."

The soldier grunts as she thrusts her shield forward and blocks both Bow and the magicat from another enemy blow, then drives the same shield up into the attacker's jaw. "That's because they probably *were*."

The magicat blows a raspberry and leaps onto another opponent's shoulder, her weight throwing them off and causing them to stumble dangerously even as she just sits there. "Well duh, I'm not the idiot here, I knew that. I just think it's a little mean, is all, my feelings might be hurt."

"We STILL don't know that we can actually trust either of you," Glimmer snaps.

The magicat waves her off and her perch finally topples over. She launches herself off of them as they fall, and ducks down between another soldier's legs. She flips over, rakes her claws along the backs of his thighs, and knees him in the groin, all before scurrying away from him.

She snickers and flips him off as he falls to the floor howling in pain. "You know damn well what that was for, buddy!" she

remarks, rubbing at her side at what Glimmer suspected was an older injury. She was covered in them, it wouldn't surprise her.

The blonde soldier glances down at who had only moments before likely been her coworker, but instead of apologizing guiltily or getting after the magicat for attacking him, she *glares* down at the whimpering man. Storming up to him with unhurried steps, she grabs him by the hair, same as Glimmer had done to the clone just a moment ago, forces him to look her in the eyes, then rears back with her other fist and decks him so hard in the nose it cracks, a gush of blood immediately spurts out, and he falls to the floor unconscious.

Glimmer and Bow *and* the magicat all pause to stare at her as she shakes out her fist.

"That felt good," she glowers.

The magicat chuffs. "Hot," she says simply, and the soldier looks away blushing as red as the soldier's likely broken nose.

Glimmer lowers her staff an inch. "This does not help me decide if either of you are trustworthy or not."

The feline rolls her eyes, and the soldier snorts. "He deserved it," she spits, eyes falling on the magicat again and softening with a mix of concern and regret. It's a look the feline clearly notices, as she smirks and steps forward to grab the blonde's face with one hand, gently shaking it.

"I'm *fine* now, dummy," she chuckles, stepping away again but sparing another smile over her shoulder. "But I will say, it's nice to know you meant what you said earlier."

"Of course I did," she mumbles as she rubs her jaw, still blushing.

Glimmer lets her head hang and groans. "We so do not have time for this." Turning back to the only mentally sane person still present, she says, "Okay. So. No shantying space captain in this section. Ready to burn down another one?"

Before Bow can respond, the magicat's head suddenly pokes between them.

"Does that mean more explosions?" she grins, unaffected by the two bodily startling away from her. She snickers. "If it means more explosions I'm definitely in."

"That *very much* does not help your trustworthiness!"

She pouts. "Would it help my trustworthiness if I told you I heard obnoxious sea-shantying down that particular corridor?"

Glimmer whips back around to face her. "Why are you only mentioning this now?!"

A shrug of her furry, bruised shoulders. "I was blowing stuff up. I thought we were all having fun."

Feeling her fuse growing ever shorter every second she spends talking to this insane woman, Glimmer stalks away, storming down the hall the feline had pointed out, leaving Bow to sigh exasperatedly at the magicat.

"What is it with you and explosions?"

"Oh I've been wanting to blow this place up for *years*."

It goes quiet for a second, the only sounds Glimmer can make out are the echoey clomping of her boots on the reflective flooring, until she hears Bow call out to her.

"Is it bad that I trust her a lot more now?"

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"I thought you said he was down this way."

"No, I said I heard obnoxious sea-shantying down this corridor. Adora, back me up here."

The soldier sighs and rubs at her forehead.

"I don't hear you backing me up, Adora, that's not very girlfriend of you."

Immediately lighting up bright red *again*, dissolving into a sputtering illiterate disaster, Adora is quick to become just as useless to Glimmer as the magicat herself, and she lets out another guttural groan.

"If you two are serious about tagging along can you please start *acting* like it?"

"I have never been more serious in my entire life," the magicat purrs, running her tail under Adora's chin. The blonde reacts the same way she's been reacting.

Glimmer rocks her jaw, trying to remind herself that she couldn't instill the death penalty on someone she just met.

"Adora," she hisses, drawing the guard's attention. "You obviously know your way around this place. While I try to figure out whether relying on you is a death sentence or not, mind telling us where you jerks keep people prisoner?"

"I mean I could tell you that fairly easily," the magicat says, grinning. "I just came from there."

She silently wishes for patience. "Are we *going* there?"

"I mean we can certainly *start* going there, but I thought you wanted to find Puddle Pidgeon."

She was going to kill this woman. "Sea Hawk," she stresses. "His name is *Sea Hawk*."

"Isn't that what I just said?"

Adora sighs and shoves the magicat's face away. "Okay, time for you to stop." She turns back to the other two, pointedly ignoring the amused snickers coming from behind her. "Your captain… Sea Hawk? He was taken prisoner fairly recently, yes?"

"A couple of hours before we ran into you two," Bow responds, rubbing the back of his neck.

The soldier nods. "Then Catra's right, he won't be in any of the prison chambers." She glances at the magicat—apparently Catra was her name—and winces as she mumbles, "We… *they* typically interrogate any new prisoners for a good handful of hours, then keep them in solitary confinement between 24 to 72 hours to see if they'll break. After that they're finally taken to a holding cell."

Catra's ear twitches and she sighs as she straightens and faces the soldier. She smacks her in the face with her tail and complains, "Stop it with the kicked puppy look. I told you, I'm fine, I'm not some fragile thing about to fall apart because your buddies were giving me a hard time."

Adora flinches and looks away. "It was a little more than just a hard time." She mutters under her breath, "And they're *not* my buddies."

Glimmer frowns and exchanges a look with Bow, who seems to be growing just as uncomfortable.

Instead of lingering on any of that, Catra turns back down the corridor, resting her hands behind her head. "So to recap, Ocean Chicken is either having a friendly conversation with this dork's *former* buddies, or he's already gotten himself his own private little room. My bet is on the second one; if he's as annoying as you all make him seem I doubt even these jerks had the patience to deal with him for long. It would explain his yodeling, earlier."

Dragging both her hands down her face, Glimmer exhales roughly. "Perfect," she grumbles. "So can either of you actually get us there?"

Catra turns and eyes Adora, who steps towards the princess. "That… depends."

"On what?" she glares.

"On if you'll actually allow us to escape with you." She exchanges a quick glance with Catra. "We'll both help but we need to get away from the empire as much as you do."

She grits her teeth again, but it's Bow who speaks up first.

"Well, Catra is… dubiously trustworthy at best, I at least *think* she's planning on actually continuing to help us—" he pauses when Catra smirks and winks at him, and hesitantly continues, "… so long as she gets to blow something up. But we still don't know why we should trust you. No offense but weren't you, you know, literally one of them not even a full hour ago? Why are *you* helping? Why'd you defect?"

For the first time, Adora blanches because of something other than Catra. Her eyes dart to the maniac they'd all watch chuck a boot at a handful of clones, cackling, before bolting in the other direction, still laughing, less than ten minutes ago. "I— maybe— I just… felt like… it?"

"Mmhmmm, or maybe," the maniac in question flops over her languidly, tickling her chin, "it's cuz you're an idiot that went and fell in love with the person you guys were keeping prisoner, a.k.a. meee."

Blushing yet again (and also *not* denying it), Adora tries shoving her away, but she just falls limply against her again. Growling, the soldier grabs her by the shoulders and holds her away, but doesn't let go. Her toes no longer touch the floor.

"Will you knock it off already?! I'm trying to keep both of us alive!"

Catra boops her nose, a purr rumbling from her chest.

"You're so cute when you're mad, you know that?"

Adora drops her and turns away, covering her face with a gloved hand that does nothing to hide her reactions.

"This is getting painful," Glimmer sneers, hands twitching with the growing urge to throttle them both. She rubs both her eyes and chirps stressfully, "Alright! So! The two of you are stupidly in love, and you both want to run away to your happily ever after to make out in a forest on a planet somewhere and have a bunch of little demon cat babies. Good to know. In order to do *any* of that, we need to know neither of you will blow up our ship, and in order to actually *use* our ship, we need to find our ship's captain. Do you both understand what I'm saying?!"

The two both stare at her, wide eyed. This time, both are clearly flustered.

"I mean…" Catra murmurs. "The forest part isn't necessary, per se __"

Glimmer suddenly has her pinned to the wall with her throat between her fingers.

"Yep! Yes! Totally understood! No violence on the ship and we gotta go break out Pond Flamingo!" Catra smiles, hands raised in surrender. "That we can do, Boss Ma'am Lady!"

Trembling with frustrated rage, it takes Glimmer a moment to uncurl her fingers enough to let Catra slip out. The sword at her throat that she hadn't even realized was there slowly lowers, and is slipped back into Adora's sheath, but the warning glare on her face doesn't fade.

"She was asking for it," the princess seethes. Adora looks away.

"Ew, you're agreeing with her?" Catra snarks. The glare is turned on her, and again she's smiling wide and holding up her hands in surrender. "I mean go team! Yay! Friendship!"

"We are *not* friends!" Glimmer snaps as she shoves past the two. "We are two separate groups of people made up of a princess, her

partner, a Horde soldier, and a space pirate, binding together to save my husband's *stupid* ex because he is *also* our pilot, and we can't get rid of him even though he's set the ship on fire twenty-seven separate times, because the rest of us have *no* piloting experience and unfortunately need him, so just *shut up* and let's *go* already!"

She doesn't wait to see if the others follow. She just needs to get away from them all, fast, before she bashed Catra's brains out and Adora killed her for it.

Catra and Adora gawk at the retreating princess, jaws dropped and eyes wide. After a moment to let… all of that finally process, Catra turns back to Adora and smiles serenely as she holds out her wrists.

"Okay, you can take me back to my cell now."

Chapter End Notes

Catra was right, the forest part was not necessary

They successfully rescue Sea Hawk, Catra chucks another boot at someone, they make it back to the ship, and then at some point Glimmer walks in on Catra and Adora making out, and she very nearly chucks them both out the airlock

Post-Apocalypse - Immortality

Chapter Notes

TWs: Major Character Deaths; Grief

This is NOT A HAPPY ONE GUYS, PLEASE tread CAREFULLY

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Would things have been different? If she'd tried harder to show she truly did care?

They would have had to have been, surely.

The day it happened haunts her like no other. She supposes she deserves no less, to be forever followed around by the moment she let the poor girl she loved so much down so terribly. Stars, did she even know she was loved? Not just by the one who'd always been by her side, but by so many more? By her?

The question haunts her almost as frequently as that awful day, when so many things were proven to be true but her love for this girl was not one of them.

Her steps finally come to a stop as she reaches her destination. She kneels down slowly, letting her fingers delicately sink into the budding blades of grass, still struggling to grow even a year after the last fight was fought, the war finally won. This little patch seemed to be the only one strong enough, amidst entire valleys of dirt and ash, to let anything grow at all.

She wonders, not for the first time, if it was because of that day. That haunting, damning day.

Footsteps grow from the silence broken only by wind, softly padding up to her before coming to rest barely a few paces

behind her. She knows who it is. She knows why *she* is here.

The newcomer does not greet her, warmly or otherwise, and that too is because of that damned haunting day, and the mistakes she made throughout it.

"I want you to know, I hold within my heart many regrets," she tells the newcomer instead of greeting them, never turning around. She hears the rustle of fabric, the tightening of leather gloves as hands clench into fists. She closes her eyes, and one of her hands comes up to rest at her chest. It rests over her heart. "Among the biggest are what I did. Or rather, what I failed to do. Especially concerning that day."

The newcomer stays silent.

"I never got to tell you," *because you never gave me the chance*, she doesn't say, knowing she doesn't deserve to, "but I've been wanting to for a long time. My dreams hold nothing but finding you and finally telling you what I've always needed to."

Finally, the newcomer responds, snarling, her voice harsh and unforgiving. "Are you actually going to say it or are you just going to keep pretending you are?"

She closes her eyes. "I've wanted, and needed, to tell you… I'm sorry. I'm sorry for not stopping what happened, for not seeing the signs and taking action while I still had the chance to. I'm sorry for what I allowed to happen, to her… *and* to you."

She hears the sheen of a blade being drawn, and is not surprised when its frigid cold edge finds the skin of her neck.

"Do you seriously think that's good enough?" The newcomer huffs a mirthless laugh, and the blade draws closer. "Do you seriously think that a measly apology is enough to make up for what you put us through? To make up for what you put *her* though?"

"I suspect no such thing. The pain I have caused, the pain I have wrought, is far too great of wounds for my words alone to mend."

Her shoulders droop. “Truthfully, I don’t think there is anything I could do to fix things. I fear it is far too late.”

A scoff, and the blade rips away roughly enough it nicks the skin. She doesn’t flinch as blood beads from the wound, and the sword is thrown into the ground beside her.

“Wow,” the newcomer’s voice warbles, emotion crawling up her throat and squeezing. “What gave you *that* idea?”

She sighs, and shifts her head, though she still does not look up even as the other begins to pace. “I know you are hurt. I know of your hurt. I understand it. I’ve felt it.”

“Don’t *lie* to me, no you *haven’t*,” the other hisses. “You have *no idea* what I’m going through, what I’m feeling.”

“I do. My dear, I was there. I was right there, as it happened.”

“Reminding me of that right now is not your smartest move.” Another hiss. “And I’m not your ‘*dear*.’”

She hesitates, the sting of the broken skin on her neck drowned out by the sting of heartache swelling inside it. Doing nothing as tears gather in her eyes, she murmurs, “I did not want what happened to ever come to pass. If I could, I would have had it be me.” She can tell her words are only stoking the fires of the other’s fury, but how could she stop? For a full year, this has all rested dormant, a chip on her shoulder forever there, forever weighing, forever haunting. It needs to be set free. “In a heartbeat, if I’d have known what would come to pass that day, I would have never allowed anyone but myself to be there, please believe that much at least. If I’d have only known—”

Her time runs out. With an enraged cry of pain, the other bowls into her, and the two tumble to the ground. She grunts, pang rattling her spine where she’d landed hard. The other’s hands dig into her shoulders, blood seeping out from where her claws are embedded in the skin.

Angella opens her eyes to see Catra's glaring into her soul, tears spilling from her cheeks and spittle dripping from her jaws.

"You. *Knew*." The magicat's entire body shakes with rage and heartache. "You *knew* she would never just sit around while there was a threat. You *knew* she felt like she was never doing enough, never helping out enough, never *enough*." She lifts Angella's shoulders only to slam them back into the ground, releasing one just to pound a fist into her chest. "You *knew* she could never survive that place the way you could! But you still let her *go*. Don't you *dare* tell me you would have made sure things were different if only you'd known, you knew *plenty*. You *knew*, that—" her breath hitches and a sob tears from her chest, and she pounds her fist again. "You KNEW that Adora would die, and that you wouldn't, and you just *let it happen!*" She sobs again, and again.

Angella feels tears of her own dripping past her ears into her hair. "I tried to stop it," she weakly insists, shaking her head. "I tried to stop *her*. Catra I did everything I could to get there before she could, to stop her from—"

"Shut *UP!!*" Catra roars in her face, flecks of spit landing on her cheeks and forehead that she pays no mind to. "You don't get to lie to me anymore! You don't get to lie about this! If you'd really done *everything* you could to stop her, she would still…" she sobs again, her limbs shaking, growing weaker. "She would still *be here!!* You didn't *try* at all!"

Her body does not rattle with cries the way the magicat's does, but she feels the hurt and sadness all the same. "I could not have gotten there any faster than I did. What more could I have done, Catra?"

Catra bares her fangs with a fearsome thundering growl, eyes glowing with a near manic agony. "You could have done *anything*. *Anything*. You can't *die*, Angella, it should have been *you*. You *know* that!" She sobs again, and again. She tries to keep going only for another cry to steal away her voice. She hangs her head

as she wails, her tumultuous shaking only getting worse. "Don—*don't* you *dare* ask me what you should have done." Her furious eyes find Angella's again. "Don't you *dare* say that things could have only been different if you'd just known better! You already *did!!*"

Angella wonders, distantly, if Catra's limbs will give out. If she will fall onto her, sobbing and howling with grief, so emotional she simply couldn't continue to shout and scream down at her, and instead would fall down *with* her.

But no. Catra's never relied on her for anything. She's never trusted her enough to do so. If even in moments of calm and respect, before the tragedy had struck and severed any ties before they could ever properly form, she wouldn't go to the older woman for anything, why then, in a moment of sheer agony, would she turn to her in any way for any thing?

Before her body can give out, Catra shoves herself away from Angella, yanking her up by the shoulders and thrusting her away.

Angella catches herself on her hands, and looks behind her.

The magicat stands on all fours over the small patch of grass, blocking Angella from the tombstone embedded in the center of it. With a snarl, she pushes herself to her feet, and snatches the forgotten sword—it was Adora's, Angella realizes belatedly—from the ground, tearing it free and pointing it at the woman knelt before her.

The last of her emotions dull into nothingness, and she stares down the length of the blade to its master. "Are you going to kill me?" she asks. "Avenge the girl we both love, one as a daughter and one as a partner?"

Catra growls, still heaving and trembling. "Don't. Call her that. You failed her. You don't get to claim her."

Angella laughs, quiet and broken. "I've failed everyone, Catra. I've failed the living and I've failed the dead. Micah, Glimmer, Adora…

they are all gone because I was too much of a coward to risk leaving before them." She looks up, her dulled eyes meeting Catra's, seeking the warmth of the fire in them even as they burn too hot. She asks again, simple and monotone, "Are you going to kill me?"

The answer surprises her, and doesn't. "No," Catra snarls, her breaths hiccuping again. She doesn't lower the blade. "You get what you've always wanted. You get to live." She sobs again, but her hatred only seems to grow. "I'm sure I don't have to explain why that's far more fitting."

Angella closes her eyes and bows her head. No. No explanation was needed.

"Get out of here," the magicat hisses. "I won't kill you, Angella, but if I ever see you around here again, I will make you *beg* for death."

Silently, slowly, she climbs back to her feet. She towers in height over the magicat, but she doesn't doubt the threat she posed, nor the promise of her word. Before she turns to walk away, her eyes wander one last time to the grave.

Catra steps in front of it, blocking it from view as her growl grows even louder.

But Angella had long since memorized the inscription.

ADORA E. GRAYSKULL

BELOVED FRIEND
SISTER
DAUGHTER
LOVER
HERO

MAY HER SACRIFICE NEVER BE IN VAIN

As she turns and walks away, both the inscription and Catra's words reverberate through her mind like a cyclone. The numbness that had faded over her lifts just enough for the tears to return. She makes it far enough away from Catra and the grave she watched over like a guardian that she knows the magicat will not hear her as she finally succumbs to sobs of her own. She's able to make it only a few feet farther before she too falls to her knees.

Like it had never left, the grief swallows her whole yet again.

Chapter End Notes

> Like yesterday's prompt, I didn't actually go with the original idea I had for this one and came up with this right before writing it
>
> But UNLIKE yesterday's prompt, this one turned out way darker than what I'd originally come up with! Like WAY darker, the original actually had a happy resolution
>
> … :D
>
> (Also I promise I don't hate Angella, it was just her turn to be a punching bag this time)

Post-Apocalypse - Arisen Anew

Chapter Notes

> I've been re-reading (okay, technically just listening to it this time) the Lunar Chronicles lately and that may or may not have contributed to how this chapter was written
>
> Btw it was technically supposed to end differently but I needed to cut it off and end it lol it's almost midnight and I need the snooze

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"*Dammit*, Adora *grab* her!"

"NO!" Glimmer howls, her attempt to dive out the hatch before it closed foiled as Adora snares her in her arms, dragging her back into the belly of the ship. "No, no we can't *leave* him!! *Bow!!*"

Catra grunts, the controls fighting her as she pulls back hard as she can, urging the damn thing to go up and up and up. The gaping wound on her side bleeds even heavier, and she grits her teeth through the pain. "We don't have a choice!" she snaps, hands shaking with the struggling wheel. "If we try and go back down there we will *all* die!"

"He's not dead!" she shrieks, thrashing in Adora's arms. "He's not dead I know he's not! Catra I *order* you to land again!! Please!!"

"I'm not risking the rest of us for a lost cause!"

"*He needs our help!*"

Adora gags as Glimmer finally finds enough wiggle room to nail her right in the gut with her elbow. Her restraints loosened, Glimmer staggers up to the cockpit, stumbling into the wall as Catra loses control of the steering for a moment. With a growl she

fights to get it back, and almost gets it until the shorter woman rushes in and grabs for it herself.

"Sparkles, knock it off!" She tries fighting her off, but between her wound and the already stubborn controls its a fight Glimmer knows she can't win alone.

For half a second, she forgets about Adora. She manages to wrangle the controls from the magicat, almost immediately losing hold of them herself as they continue to disobey, and as she scrambles to regain her newfound control she hears Catra hiss in pain, then pounding footsteps. Before Glimmer can get them more than a few feet back down, the blonde surges in and grabs her, pinning her to the display board and smashing them both against several nondescript buttons that neither actually know the functions of.

"Glimmer, we can't!" she shouts, holding her by the wrists as the magicat acts swiftly. There are tears in Adora's eyes, but she still fights to get the girl away from the pilot. Glimmer screams as Catra again guides them away from the ground. "We can't go down a third time, the ship won't survive another try! I don't want to leave him, none of us do, but if we don't get out of here fast we're *all* going to be in trouble!"

"Bow's a lot—" Catra clamps her mouth shut and fights to keep her eyes open as her side pangs again. Swallowing hard, she forces herself to continue, "H-he's a lot tougher than he looks. If… if *anyone* could survive what just happened, it's him. We'll come back when we're better prepared, we won't leave him."

"We can still save him!" She tries ripping herself away again, but Adora's far more prepared for her retaliation this time around. "We can— we just need to go back! I'll take one of the skiffs, I'll go out and get him myself! We can get him out! We—"

Her eyes widen. With Adora's second tackle, they'd accidentally activated and pulled up several holoscreens, all of them security footage of what was directly outside the ship.

On the screen closest to her she saw Bow, laying limp on his stomach amidst the wreckage. His wounds still looked awful, even from this distance, but she could tell he was breathing.

Barely.

"*Bow*," his name escapes on a mix of a breath and a sob. Catra's eyes dart to the screen, and her mask finally falters, deep regret and longing clawing lines in her face. But she shakes it off, needing to keep control of the ship. "Catra, *please!*" Glimmer pleads. "Please, we can't *leave* him!"

"You really think I *want to*, dammit?!" she cries, slamming the dashboard with a scratched up palm, quickly replacing her hand on the steering. "Sparkles if I weren't the only other one who knew how to fly this damn thing I'd jump out to grab him myself!" She quickly and roughly scrubs her wrist across her eyes.

"The skiffs were all damaged," Adora mentions with the same strain in her tone, her tight grip on Glimmer loosening up but not enough for her to get free again. "Otherwise you *know* I'd be the first one taking one down to get him." She buries her face in Glimmer's shoulder, and it's quick to grow damp from her tears. "Glimmer there are too many people onboard for us to risk another attempt again."

"We'll come back," Catra restates determinedly. "We'll come *right. Back.*" The controls jerk away from her again and she yelps as she snatches them back, yanking at her side in the process. "Preferably," she grits out, "with a much better ship."

"We'll come right back," Adora repeats like a promise, one that almost is reassuring.

But then Glimmer spots movement on the display, and it isn't Bow that's moving.

They've finally gotten up and away from the desolate ground enough that things on the monitor look small and it's difficult to make out details. But Glimmer is able to make out, crystal clear,

as a cloaked figure approaches Bow's body, cocking their head curiously.

The figure takes Bow by the arms, and starts dragging him away.

Glimmer screams loud enough that both Catra and Adora jump.

"No they're taking him *away!!*" She shakes in Adora's hold, lunging for the screen as if it would actually stop the figure from laying even a finger on his body. Both Catra and Adora chance another look at the screen. "They can't *touch him!* He's still *alive*, they can't just take him! *NO!!*"

Strangely, as though the figure can hear them, they pause in dragging Bow away, and look up.

Glowing blood red eyes stare back at them, and all three react in shock and go limp.

The ship violently veers to the side and Catra spits out a string of curses. Obviously having had enough, she draws back her leg and repeatedly jams her heel into the dashboard, until finally with a lurch the steering snaps back into its proper place, smoothly following Catra's command, and the two figures on the screen shrink into pinpricks as the ship shoots off like an arrow.

Glimmer falls to her knees, and her wails ring through the entirety of the ship.

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"We'll come right back."

The biggest lie Glimmer's ever heard. It's been almost a month since they lost Bow, and even though Adora had constant surveillance teams and drones being sent out, they themselves still haven't gone back to see if he's somehow survived.

In Catra's defense, the wound she'd gotten was *way* deeper than any of them had realized, none of them—including herself—even

suspecting it was dangerously bad until she'd passed out from blood loss as she was trying to land, and they'd crashed the last few feet. Adora and Glimmer had both scrambled like eggs to get her to the healers before she could lose anymore, and even they'd been shocked to see how bad she'd gotten.

Glimmer hated that she was almost more concerned about getting Catra back in the pilot's chair than she was about her actually recovering, but she couldn't help it. Catra, and every other soul they'd rescued, had the luxury of recovering somewhere safe and quiet and helpful.

Bow could be dead for all they knew. He probably was. Because they couldn't just go back and get him.

"It is so not that simple," the magicat had drowsily slurred during a visit, when Glimmer had accidentally let slip some of her pent up frustration and found her friend the target. Catra hadn't even been fully lucid yet, but she hadn't been able to keep it to herself. "Th' ship was damaged, Sparkles, I could… barely get us in the air. F'we landed again… he would've only died with the rest of us."

She knew that. She really did. She knew Catra and Adora had both chosen to do the right thing in getting them all out of there.

That didn't make it hurt any less. And she knew that was true for all of them. She sees it in the way Adora can't meet her eyes, in the way Catra doesn't even try to crack any jokes anymore, in the way both stubbornly fight off tears in favor of throwing together mad plans to somehow get a dead man back.

She sees it in the guilt shining in both their eyes when Catra begrudgingly relays that her recovery isn't going as smoothly as the healers had hoped, and officially she was grounded for another two weeks.

No one gets after Glimmer for destroying half of the workout equipment later that day.

"There has to be *something* we can do," she rants to Adora as they make their way down to Catra's room again. "I get that Catra and Bow are the only ones who can fly our ship, we don't have to use *ours*. Maybe we can find another captain with their own ship."

"And convince them to fly us *there* of all places?" Adora sighs, shaking her head. "The only reason we were able to get there in the first place is because Catra's the only captain in the country willing to risk navigating that area."

Groaning, Glimmer runs her fingers through her hair. "Well then maybe… maybe she could pilot it through the computer?"

"She's been trying that every day since she woke up. The system is shot, it only has functioning *manual* controls."

"Then maybe…" she trails off, eyes welling with tears for the umpteenth time. "Maybe…"

Adora gently takes her hand, and squeezes it with the same care. They've reached Catra's room, but neither head in just yet.

"I still have teams scouting the area and the neighboring locations every day," the blonde murmurs. "Just because we're not out looking for him doesn't mean no one is."

"But none of your teams are as good at tracking as we are," she shakes her head. "If we really are to assume that he somehow isn't dead yet, that means none of them are looking hard enough. Adora, it's been a month and a half." She wipes away the tears before they can fall. "I don't think I can wait two more weeks. The scouts haven't found *anything*, not even any of his arrows. I… I don't know what to do."

"How about you losers both get inside so I can be part of the conversation?"

Biting back an unfriendly retort, Glimmer just sighs and gives into the command. Catra isn't even facing them when they walk in, she's turned to the window and sat on the edge of her bed, her

torso bandaged up and her eyes intensely focused on an old beat up trackerpad. She looks up as they approach her, and instead of greeting them she holds up the pad.

"Before you get anymore doom and gloom," she says as she carefully shifts to hoist one leg up onto the bed, "I think I have something that'll help us find our resident crop top model."

Glimmer and Adora's eyes both widen, and they're quick to join Catra on the bed. The magicat pulls up a strange looking display, and both lean in to read what it says.

"I can't control the ship with this anymore," Catra begins, "but I can still do a fair bit of tracking with it. Bow still had his own trackerpad on him, and I've finally been able to trace it back to where it is now. It's definitely been moved, and I'm pretty sure its still with him, or at least has been left somewhere close by."

"You've found him?" Glimmer whispers disbelievingly. She wants to believe it, wants to trap the magicat in a massive embrace and kiss her until Adora has a problem with it, but her fears refuse to abate.

Despite her fears, however, Catra dons a confident smirk. "I'm not 100% positive, but I know I'm at least close. His trackerpad was damaged, but I was able to briefly tap into its video feed. I wasn't able to save a recording before it cut out, but I heard him. He was talking, and he sounded a lot healthier than he was the last time we saw him." Her eyes glow with relief and excitement.

A noise escapes Adora's throat. She's got a hand covering her mouth, and her eyes are so watery part of Glimmer wonders if she can see.

The rest of her is too busy dealing with the same emotions as the other woman was.

"You… are you sure it was him?" Adora croaks.

Catra nods. “Unless whoever took him replaced him with a concerningly realistic android, it was him.”

“When did this happen?” Glimmer blubbers. “How long ago? Is he still there? Do you still have the location?”

“This morning. I didn’t say anything because I wanted to make sure I had gotten the location down properly. Even if he isn’t still there, there’s no way he isn’t still in the area at least. All we gotta do is get the ship out there and have it start scanning for warm bodies.”

Glimmer looses an overwhelmingly relieved gasp, and she feels Adora squeezing her hand again. This was actually happening. They were going to find Bow, and they were going to get him back. He was alive, and they had a way to get him *back*.

But slowly, her relieved high crashes back down.

“Our ship,” she mumbles, shoulders sinking. “But… you still can’t fly.”

Just as she feels Adora run into the same devastating conclusion, Catra scoffs, and slowly pushes herself from the bed.

“Well, duh,” she smirks once she’s standing, hands resting on her hips. “That’s why I have a ship to do it for me.”

Glimmer feels her heart skip a beat, and the happy relief slowly starts seeping back in.

“Wait, they cleared you? You’re cleared to fly again??”

She snorts. “*Hell* no. That blade almost went clear through me, you think a month and a half is gonna fix that?”

Glimmer gawks, and Adora glares.

“Catra,” she starts, clear warning in her tone, “what do you think you’re doing?”

“The same thing you did two years ago,” she snarks back, folding her arms. “Miss ‘I think I broke like half my ribs and my femur but I’m still gonna go charging headfirst into battle because I feel like it.’”

Adora sputters. “That—! That was different!”

“You’re right. What you did was way more stupid than this.”

“Catra—!”

“Look, I’m not going to keel over just because I sat in a chair and pushed some buttons and levers around,” she insists. Her expression softens. “Adora, this might be our only chance to find him. I— *we* owe it to him to try.”

Adora shakes her head and stands up too. “That’s not the part I have a problem with. Catra, what if you just hurt yourself even more?”

She shrugs. “Then we’ll make Bow drive.”

“That is *so* not the point!”

Catra sighs. “Look, if I start struggling for some reason and we all —*collectively*—decide that I need to stop piloting, you or Glimmer can swap me and I’ll just instruct you on what to do. I’m not sacrificing myself here, Adora, I’ll be careful.”

Adora still seems torn. But with a final glance at Glimmer, who undoubtedly was looking at the two like she’d just been offered all the stars in the sky on a silver platter, her expression pinches into a grimace and she finally gives in with a groan.

She jabs a finger at the magicat. “When we get back you are *not* leaving this room for the next three weeks, do you understand?”

Catra meets Glimmer’s hopeful eyes and smiles. “Ready to go get your man back?”

The only thing that keeps Glimmer from pouncing at her is the bandage wrapped around her core.

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One of his eyes glowed now.

He wasn't… really sure how to feel about that. Or how to feel about *any* of the changes he'd been forced to undergo. Eyeing himself in his new reflection, he still knew he much preferred this to, you know, *death*, but… it would definitely take some getting used to.

In more ways than one.

Slowly, still watching himself in the mirror, he runs a finger along the blue and silver plating lining the right side of his jaw, and follows the edge up to where it meets with a new segment at his cheekbone, then leading up to just above his brow bone. It curves along the back of his skull, and again meets a new segment at the base of his skull.

His hand slowly lowers to his right shoulder, where the changes continued along his neck all the way down to his fingers. A distant, almost disassociated part of himself has to admire the new build, and the secret arsenal hidden away inside that would trigger with the flick of his wrist. Experimentally, that's what he does, and just as he'd been shown would happen, two long and slightly curved panels shoot out from where they made up his arm, both now stretched out perpendicular to the appendage as the string extends next.

He curls his new hand into a fist, and takes a single step back from the mirror as he holds out the crossbow arm in front of him. He knew the bolts were stored in the bicep compartment, but he wasn't aiming to attack anything just yet, just get used to the feel of it. With his cheek pressed to his shoulder, his new eye can perfectly align with the middle knuckle. If he were to shoot a crossbow bolt this way, his aim would be precise and deadly.

His reflection certainly looked the part.

Sighing, he gives another exact flick of his wrist, and the wings of the crossbow fold back down as the build of his arm.

Bow never pictured himself becoming a cyborg.

Even on death's doorstep, it had never been an option. The life of a cripple, if he was lucky. Death, certainly. But a cyborg? Cyborgs were things of fiction, never supposed to cross the barrier between that and reality.

Then again, the same was *supposed* to be true for the apocalypse.

Resting his hands on the sink below the mirror, he lets his eyes wander over the differences. Almost half of him is machine, now, still operated mostly by his brain but powered by both that and now a neural network channeling through him. He has a mechanical spine, mechanical shoulders, a mechanical arm, a mechanical hip and leg and foot. Half his face was the same. Synthetic tissue and muscles replaced organic flesh and blood in so many places, and though part of him is grateful he even gets to experience anything at all anymore, part of him fears the changes he's gone through.

The rest of him fears what his loved ones would say if they ever saw him like this.

As though the mechanisms of the little robo-sanctuary were connected to his mind and the anxiety persistently hanging around (he'd have to check with her later to see if he actually was connected somehow) an alarm almost immediately starts blaring, one that meant they had visitors that could either be amicable or violent or even a mix of the two, and an excited and startled squawk from down the hall has him hurrying out of the bathroom and down to the lab.

"What's going on?" he asks as he darts inside, almost immediately having to duck past one of the towering robots. Its frankly quite

creepy permanent smile sends a shudder down his altered spine, and he carefully scoots past it, ignoring how it continues to watch him for way too long as he makes his way over to the one responsible for both it and him.

Entrapta cackles and claps her hands as she watches her multitude of monitors. "This is so exciting! We have an oncoming horde that's bigger than any we've seen thus far, and I'm detecting readings of a massive ship attempting to find somewhere to land nearby."

His eyes widen, and he leans in. "Zoom in on the ship. Please," he rushes to add on, though Entrapta was already doing so.

He doesn't know if his heart was also cybernetically modified or not, and the way it skips a beat or two doesn't give him the answer to that.

It does remind him just how badly he's missed seeing that banged up hull and those three achingly familiar faces staring out through the cockpit window, though.

They'd come back for him.

The heartwarming realization doesn't have long to linger, as he realizes with a jolt of sinking dread what them arriving now would mean.

"They're gonna be swarmed by the horde," he croaks, his mechanical fingers twitching. He straightens up, his steps already carrying him to the door and quickly gaining speed. "They're gonna be—! Entrapta, open the side gate entrance! I need to help them!"

She doesn't argue with him. Beaming widely and again cackling, she excitedly presses a series of buttons, and Bow distantly hears something in this underground labyrinth creaking and moaning as it opens.

“I’ll be monitoring you from here!” her voice comes through his mechanical ear (she did this a lot in the first few days after he woke back up, and it’s the only reason he doesn’t startle). “I’ll send backup if it looks like you need it, or if you request it! Remember, you have extra arsenal in your calf compartment!”

“Thanks, Entrapta,” he says as he sprints. “You’re a lifesaver.”

If she responds, he doesn’t register it. All he can focus on is the fear that finally, after what felt like entire lifetimes, his family was within reach again, and he could lose them for good this time. Flicking his wrist to deploy his crossbow, unloading a bolt to load in as he runs, he promises himself that he will not let things end the way they did last time.

He didn’t hate his cybernetics, but he’d be damned if he let anyone else join him.

And joining the horde? Well.

That was just out of the question.

Chapter End Notes

> Bow’s new threat of choice after things finally die down: “Have you ever been cuddled by a cyborg?”
>
> Listen I never said it was ACTUALLY threatening

Crossover - Isekai

Chapter Notes

IT'S CROSSOVER WEEK BABY LETS GOOOO
I'M SO EXITEEED

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The blaring of a phone going off *right next to her ear* has Catra startling awake with a yelp and tumbling backwards out of a swivel chair she most definitely did not remember falling asleep in.

She groans as she rubs her back and slowly sits up. The fabric of her shirt feels stiff and uncomfortable, and a quick glance down has her more confused than the chair just now. She's in some kind of uniform, but like the chair she has no memory of consciously adorning these things. Her nose wrinkles as her outfit rubs uncomfortably against her fur. She most *definitely* would never have chosen to put this on herself.

The phone rings again, but when she looks up to figure out if she was going to just hang up or actually answer it, her eyes widen, and the phone is momentarily forgotten.

"What the hell?" she mutters.

Before her is a simplistic desk, with several screens displayed on top, as well as a little box with labeled, lit up buttons on it, each one bearing an oddly specific number. She slowly stands up, and another glance at the monitor the box was closest to shows her that each button seemed to link to a specific interface.

Curiously, after another bewildered look around the little… office (?) space, she clicks one of the buttons, and the display switches from a dark, empty hallway, to a stage with a purple curtain.

Okay. Security cameras.

Why the hell did this place—whatever it was—need security cameras?

More importantly…

"Where the *hell am I?!*" she cries, gesticulating with her arms. Obviously, no one answered, but she felt it still had to be said.

Wherever she was, it definitely wasn't Bright Moon. Or Plumeria. Or The Snows, or Salineas, or whatever Scorpia's kingdom was called now, or…

"Did I get kidnapped again?" she asks the office monitors, still displaying an innocent purple curtain on its stage. She pokes at more of the buttons, but none of the rooms that show up give her anything to go off of. "Am I even on Etheria anymore?"

The only answer she gets is the phone ringing again. She rolls her eyes, plops down in the swivel chair to scoot it up to the desk, then reaches out to grab the damn thing.

Something like the scuffle of shoes sounds from down the hall, and her outstretched hand pauses as she cocks her head, ear perking. She glances to her right, where she'd heard the sound come from, and frowns curiously. On either side of her is a massive steel doorway, with two large buttons on a panel on the side. There's a window beside each door, too, but it's so dark beyond this odd little office that even she can barely see beyond it.

She stands and slowly walks over to poke her head out. Another hallway greets her, black and white tiles lining the floor and odd decor—were those children's drawings?—hung up along the walls. Looking further down doesn't offer much else, and the same is true when she pokes her head out the other door, just more creepy kids' drawings and posters she could barely make out.

Okay yeah. She'd definitely been kidnapped again. Somehow. Frustration and annoyance bite at her, and she flumps back down into the chair.

A poster on the wall with three robot looking animals tells her to celebrate, and she sneers.

"Yeah," she scoffs under her breath. "Celebrate being kidnapped by *another* lunatic who left me stranded in a weird abandoned building. Sure thing."

She was tempted to just pick a hallway and see where it led. Going off of the display of where the security monitors were, she could probably find some kind of exit out of this place.

But that was assuming whoever had taken her here wasn't plotting some kind of trap.

Grumbling as her tail lashes behind her, she starts messing around with the controls again, skipping between different feeds to see if *anything* caught her attention or gave her something to go off of.

She pauses when she opens camera 1A and sees the same odd robot animals that were displayed on the poster standing on a stage of their own. Well, two of them at least. The weird—purple? Blue? Indigo?—rabbit thing was missing.

Catra hums and tries to find the camera she'd noted before, the one with the purple curtain and the other stage. Maybe the rabbit guy was there? But she struggles to find it, no matter how many of the dang buttons she presses.

She hears more shuffling, and pauses in her button-pressing as she again cocks her head in the direction of the sound. Again, it came from the right.

Just as she considers sticking her head out and casually calling out to her maybe-kidnapper (because who else could it be making those noises?) she hears something that makes her jump.

A scream, and the frantic pounding of footsteps.

Before she can leap from the chair again, something darts across the camera feed she has pulled up, some kind of party room or

something.

Her jaw drops as she makes out what are clearly Adora's features, tainted with panic before she darts off screen.

Both the chair and the again ringing phone go forgotten as Catra bolts from the office and out into the hallway.

"Adora?!" she shouts, claws extended. There had to be a reason her girlfriend looked *that* panicked, and it couldn't be a good one. She reaches the end of the hallway, and it spits her out into a massive room, definitely the party room she'd seen on the cameras. She spots movement out of the corner of her eyes and turns to see a blonde ponytail dashing into another small hallway. "Adora!" She races over, about to turn down the same path she took, when the woman in question comes barreling back out and crashes right into her, toppling them both to the ground.

Adora recovers first, and her entire aura quickly shifts from terror to overjoyed relief. "Catra!" She's quick to wrap the magicat up in her arms, squeezing her tight, but she's also quick to pull away—Catra didn't even get to hug her back—and spout anxiously, "We gotta run! She-Ra's not working and *something* is alive that shouldn't be!"

"I— wha—?!" The blonde pushes off the floor into a sprint, all but dragging Catra behind her as she continues to cling tight to her wrist. "Adora, what the hell is going on?!"

"I don't know!" she shouts back. She darts past a door that read "Kitchen: Employees Only" and through row after row of tables. "Which way did you come from? Maybe we can find a way out!"

"Down that hall, but there's just—!"

Adora tears down the way Catra pointed out, and the magicat squawks in alarm. Just before they leave the main party room behind, she catches movement further in, but isn't able to get a good enough look before Adora's already yanked her halfway down the hall.

The two race into the office before Adora finally lets go, surprised to not find an exit. Eyeing the two buttons on the side, Catra slams her fist into the bottom one, and a huge metal door comes slamming down, making her and Adora both jump.

Adora whips around, spots the buttons on the other door, and does the same as Catra, and it too comes crashing down.

A monitor displaying a power usage meter shows the percentage dropping a digit.

"What is going on?!" the two ask simultaneously.

"That's what I'm trying to figure out!" Catra goes to run a hand through her mane, only to jam her fingers into the brim of a cap she hadn't noticed before. She hisses and yanks it off, throwing it on top of the still ringing phone. "I just woke up in here, where were you?!"

"Woke up sitting at one of the tables," she huffs, slumping into the swivel chair and peeling off her jacket. The word "security" was slapped across the back, same as Catra's cap. "I have no idea where we are. I thought I was here alone. I started looking around, trying to find a way out, when I saw—" her wandering eyes widen as they land on the "celebrate" poster, and she jams a finger at it. "That blue thing! It was up and walking around! A-and there was another one, um… a red guy? It started *chasing* me when I saw it!"

Catra frowns and looks back to the monitor. She clicks between a few more cameras, but doesn't see any big old bunnies or red things anywhere.

"Are you sure it was red?" she asks, her eyes wandering over to the power display monitor again. It was actually going down concerningly quick, and she grimaces. If something really was chasing them, those doors wouldn't stay down forever. She punches the other button on the door, and a light outside goes off. Not seeing anything, she hits the door button, and it slides back

open. She turns to Adora and nods at the power display. “I’ll shut it again if someone really is after us.”

Calming down some at her explanation, Adora keeps glancing between the doors and the monitors. “Oh he was red. He wasn’t with the three onstage, I think he was waiting somewhere else.”

“‘Three?’” She frowns. “There were only two on the stage.”

Adora shakes her head and points at the poster again. “Those three were all on the stage when I woke up. The blue one started moving first.”

“So like…” Catra starts clicking between cameras again, “like Entrapta’s robots?”

Adora makes an uncertain sound. “I want to say yes, but… not really. The way they moved wasn’t normal.”

Catra opens another monitor, and staring directly back at them is the blue rabbit. Adora yelps and falls out of the chair as Catra’s fur all puffs up in alarm.

“Okay, that’s…” The blue rabbit is half hidden in shadow, his visible eye looking straight into the camera, and Catra feels her ears pin in discomfort. “That’s a little disconcerting.”

“A *little?!*”

She scratches the back of her neck as she looks down at the camera placements again. The one it was on was labeled 2B, the camera closest to the office. Catra eyes the door warily and shuffles on her feet.

“Okay, um…” she keeps picking through the cameras. She finds her way back to the main stage, where earlier she’d seen the other two animatronic things.

Only the bear is still there, and her tail lashes.

“That’s… not great,” Adora mutters at her side. Catra nods mutely. The show stage was camera 1A. Keeping that in mind, and taking note of the map-like outline of this creepy place, Catra clicks on the camera in the main dining room.

“Found the chicken,” she croaks.

“I thought it was a duck,” Adora mumbles under her breath. Rubbing her face, she sighs stressfully and asks, “Okay so we know where three of them are but where’s the red guy?”

“I saw another stage on here earlier,” Catra mumbles, trying to remember which camera it was. She first finds some kind of storage area, then the kitchen (for some reason the camera was blacked out), then finally she finds the second stage again.

The starred purple curtain of “Pirate’s Cove” that had been closed when Catra checked earlier is now wide open, the sign displayed in front no longer reading “Sorry! Out of Order” like before.

Now hauntingly scrawled across it were the words “IT’S ME.”

Catra’s ear flicks as she picks up heavy, metallic footsteps, way too fast for her liking, pounding down the left hallway, starting soft with distance but getting louder and closer far too quickly.

“Shut it, *shut it!*” she barks in alarm, but Adora is already diving for the button. They slam close, just as a shadow whisks past the window and they hear a *loud* banging and scraping that makes Adora jump back in alarm and crash into Catra, who in turn stumbles into the desk and knocks the phone loose.

The ringing finally stops, and a far too calm for this mess voice speaks up.

“Hello?” the mystery voice calls. “Hello, hello?”

Neither Catra nor Adora move to respond, both still trying to restart their hearts as the pounding and scratching finally stop,

and heavy metal footsteps retreat, much more slowly than they'd arrived.

The voice continues, undeterred.

"Uh, I wanted to record a message for you to help you get settled in on your first night. Umm, I actually worked in that office before you. I'm finishing up my last week now, as a matter of fact. So, I know it can be a bit overwhelming, but I'm here to tell you there's nothing to worry about. Uh, you'll do fine. So, let's just focus on getting you through your first week, okay?"

"What the *hell*," Catra hisses under her breath, her fur still puffed up like a cactus.

"Nothing about this is okay!" Adora snaps, despite them now knowing this guy was just a recording.

And as a recording is wont to do, it continues playing out.

"Uh, let's see… first there's an introductory greeting from the company that I'm supposed to read. Uh… its kind of a legal thing, you know. Um… 'Welcome to Freddy Fazbear's Pizza.'"

A low moaning from outside the door causes Catra and Adora to both jump again. Tentatively, Catra pushes the light button, and the silhouette of the rabbit looms over them.

"'A magical place for kids and grownups alike—'"

They both meet each other's eyes as the phone guy continues.

"'—where fantasy and fun come to life.'"

Chapter End Notes

> K look I know they both literally took down a galactic conqueror and saved the universe by being gay but you can't convince me that animatronics possessed by dead children wouldn't freak em out at least a LITTLE bit

Crossover - Movie

Chapter Notes

> This is yet another chapter where upon writing it I fully deviated from the idea I'd originally written and chose something completely different and this is yet another circumstance where I'm very glad I did

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A slow smirk pulls at Catra's lips as she picks up on heavy stern footsteps prowling through the busy lobby.

Looking up from the table she shared with another Adora, she swings her feet up onto it and calls out, "Heeey, Miguel. How's it hanging?"

"I strongly suggest you of all people not talk to me right now," the hulking Spider-Man grumps as he storms by, clawed hands clenching into fists as she just snickers.

"Newbie giving you *that* much trouble?" she needles, laughing again as he just grunts and walks faster.

The other Adora smiles awkwardly as she turns back around, eyes darting between her and the clearly pissed off man. "Are you sure messing with him is really the smartest plan?"

Catra scoffs. "Might not be the smartest, but it's fun. His face always gets scrunched up like a ball of paper whenever I even *look* at him, it's hilarious." She shrugs, exuding cocky confidence and owning it. "Besides, I could take him easily."

Adora rolls her eyes, but she's still smiling. "He's twice your size, Cat. In like, *every* way. He could crush you."

"He could not. He might be as big as a clydesdale but I've got the speed and the claws."

“Doesn’t he have claws too?”

“Yeah, but mine are au naturel,” she wiggles her head as she says it as fancily as possible, and Adora lets out a snorting laugh that makes her grin. Straightening in her seat as her smile grows wider, she asks as she pulls out her phone, “Hey, wanna help me mess with my girlfriend?”

Adora hems and haws, but Catra can see the way she slowly scoots her seat over to join her. She rolls her eyes as Catra slings an arm over her shoulder and leans in, holding up her phone to take a selfie of them. Adora’s already grinning, and manages to throw in bunny ears behind Catra’s head before she snaps the picture.

“Don’t pick on your girlfriend too badly.”

Catra blows a raspberry, leaning back in her chair and pulling up her text messages. “I would never.”

Web of My Life ❤️
attached jpg.32
had a blast hanging out with you this morning <3

Dummy Fat-head Loser That I Sometimes Kiss
:O Caught you cheating in 4k, Glimmer’s gonna flip.

Web of My Life ❤️
got me an upgrade you mean
a version of you that not only actually tolerates spiders but is herself a spider? i see this as an absolute win
hey i think i saw a spider-sparkles here, i bet she’d like me

Dummy Fat-head Loser That I Sometimes Kiss
Let me know if you find another you there that’s part dragonfly, i call dibs.

Web of My Life ❤️
bih why would u want Cat-Fly u have Spider-Cat

Dummy Fat-head Loser That I Sometimes Kiss
If there's a you in there that's part dragonfly I'm sorry but she's automatically way cooler than you.

Web of My Life ❤️
rude

Dummy Fat-head Loser That I Sometimes Kiss
Not my fault you got your ass bit by a radioactive spider and not a radioactive dragonfly.

Web of My Life ❤️
leave my ass out of this

Dummy Fat-head Loser That I Sometimes Kiss
No I don't think I will. <3

Catra snickers as she pockets her phone, ears perking when the Adora across from her hums.

"Wait, who's your girlfriend?"

"Uh, you, genius." She rolls her eyes at the look of shock she gets in return. "Not *you*, you, the you back in my dimension. Why do you think I thought taking a selfie with you would be so funny?"

For some reason, Adora wilts. "Oh." Her eyes find Catra's again as she straightens. "Wait, so, she knows then? About the…" she softly flicks her wrists, but doesn't actually sling any webs.

Catra cocks an eyebrow. "Duh-doy?" She lights up and fishes her phone back out. "Hey, actually, give me your phone, I'll send you the pic so you can tease your girlfriend too. I don't think interdimensional texting will work, you probably have the same phone number as my Adora, but I bet I can airdrop it to you or something."

But Adora doesn't reach for her phone. She shrinks back in her seat and looks away, a sad frown on her face.

"I don't… have a girlfriend, Catra."

Catra's face drops.

"S'cuse me?"

Adora sighs and hugs her arms. "Can we talk about something else? Like, anything else?"

"Yeah nice try, but no. What do you *mean* you don't have a girlfriend yet? Where's your Catra in all this?" She pauses, regret ready and waiting to seep in as she tentatively asks, "Wait, she's not…"

Adora frowns, then her eyes widen and she waves her hands. "No no no, she's not dead, don't worry. She's just…" she shrugs, eyes falling downcast again. "She's… just a friend."

The regret is quick to disappear. Pinching the bridge of her nose and rubbing her eyes she grumbles, "I am so not dealing with this again." She holds out her palm, and Adora eyes her in confusion. "Lemme see your watch for a second?"

Still confused, Adora tentatively holds out her hand. With that secured in her own palm, Catra quickly activates a portal set to this Adora's home, and the blonde yelps and pulls back too late. The crimson orange portal sparks to life, and Catra saunters over to it.

"Wait wait wait!" Adora sputters, sprinting from the table to catch up as other spider-people watch the two in confused curiosity. Catra pauses right in front of the portal, eyeing her with an expectant raised brow. Adora gestures at the portal wildly and asks, "What are you doing?? What if my Catra sees you?! What if *anyone* there sees you?!"

Catra holds up three fingers, putting one down each time she answers a question. "One, I'm walking into a portal leading to your dimension. Thought that was fairly obvious. Two, we're going there to *find* your Catra, so she's probably gonna see me at some

point. And three," she lowers her hand and smirks. "I'm personally hoping Mr. J. Jonah Jameson puts us on the front page."

Before Adora can stop her, Catra sticks a leg out and tips backward into the portal. Groaning, Adora jumps in after her.

• 💥 🌎 💫 •

Luckily, only moments after the portal spits her out back in her home dimension, it doesn't take Adora long to find Catra, crouched on the side of a building waiting for her with her mask already donned. Donning her own, Adora shoots out a thread to fling herself up next to Arachni-Cat, only for the other spider-woman to webshoot away in turn.

Glaring beneath the mask, Adora quickly throws out more lines to scramble to catch up.

"What do you *mean* you're trying to find my Catra on purpose?" she stresses as she falls in line with Arachni-Cat, the two keeping a rhythm as they swing. "That's a *bad* thing!"

Even with the mask on, the way Arachni-Cat eyes her is clearly an incredulous deadpan. "Is your Catra the Green Goblin?"

"Wh— no?"

"Is she Doc Ock?"

"No??"

"Is she related in any way, shape, or form to any of your villains?"

"Not… to my knowledge??"

"Then why in the name of the multiverse would us finding her be a bad thing? Does she not *know* about the multiverse?"

"She doesn't know about *any* of this!"

Again, the incredulous deadpan. "I was *really* hoping you weren't gonna say that."

The two finally come to a stop atop an apartment complex. *Catra's* apartment complex.

Adora flips up her mask as Catra flips up hers. "How did you know where Catra lives?"

At least now she can *see* the incredulous deadpan. She flushes in embarrassment, but is quick to shake it off (even if her cheeks are still a little tinted).

"Nevermind," she sighs. "Just… *why* are we trying to find… you?"

"Because she's, for some reason, not your girlfriend yet."

Adora's jaw drops. "I—! We can't—!"

Catra smirks and turns for the roof entrance. "Oh we can. I'm not about to sit back and watch the sorry tale of Catra and Adora struggling to get their crap together and *get together* a *second* time. Once was plenty, thanks. The two of you can thank me by naming your kid after me."

"Catra, *wait!*" She scrambles to reach the door before she can, throwing her weight against it to keep it closed. "We can't do this! *I* can't do this!"

Catra just rolls her eyes again and folds her arms. "Lemme just take a wild guess at your reasons right now. Just, y'know, spitballing what some of them might be. She might not like you back. She might freak out when she finds out you are in fact *the* Spider-Woman. She might be put in mortal peril if your enemies find out you have a girlfriend." She cocks an eyebrow. "That about right?"

Adora had wilted with each question, wondering if this was a sign that those worries were *right*. Unable to help herself, she adds weakly, "What if telling her breaks the canon?"

Catra's tail flicks behind her. "Have you considered that maybe this *is* your canon?"

Her eyes widen, and she looks back up. Catra's eyes are soft, sympathetic.

"I get why you're afraid, Adora," she murmurs. She shrugs and chuckles stiffly. "I was in your shoes—only figuratively, I'd never wear shoes—once too. But I'm gonna tell you something I *really* wish someone had told me when I was still figuring the whole Spider-Cat thing out."

Adora stands a little straighter. Advice from a fellow superhero was always a nice thing to stumble across, and this superhero was another *Catra*.

"Your girlf—sorry, forgot for a second you two are both still in the 'emotionally constipated' phase—your friend is *already* in mortal peril."

Her gut drops to the base floor of the apartment complex.

"W-what?"

"Adora, what do you think is stopping anyone from kidnapping her? Torturing her? Do you really think it's the fact she has no idea who you really are?" Catra shakes her head. "Whether or not either of the two of you ever hike up your big girl pants and make the other your girlfriend, if someone finds out who you are it won't be hard to figure out who you're attached to." Her shoulders and ears both droop. "If someone dangerous finds all that out, and Catra still doesn't know, how likely do you think it is that she'll be able to defend herself?"

"S-she shouldn't have to be involved," Adora insists weakly. "She shouldn't be…"

"That's not up to you to decide," Catra states, firmly but not unkindly.

Adora clenches her fists, then forcibly relaxes them. Meeting Catra's gaze again, she asks softly, "Did… did this happen to you?"

"Not with my Adora," she shakes her head. "We were already a couple, and even though I about had a panic attack trying to tell her, I still did. She freaked out, I freaked out, we both had a very nice very cathartic freak-out, then she was chill with it. And now she's not only way safer than she was before, but half the time I have to fight *she's* the one kicking ass and taking names. But it did happen with someone else." Regret pools in her eyes, and she scuffs her claws along the rooftop. "I didn't tell either of my best friends, Scorpia or Entrapta. And when my Doc Ock figured out who I was…"

"Are they okay?"

"They are, now. But for a while, they were… very much not." She sighs uncomfortably and rubs the back of her neck. "I had to learn the hard way that they're both more than capable of defending themselves, and that, even when they're not, it's way better for them to know *about* the potential risks so they can be better prepared *for* the potential risks."

Slowly, Adora lets go of the door handle, and steps back.

"…okay." She breathes in and out deeply, and shakes out the anxious jitter in her hands. "Okay. I'll… I'll tell her."

Catra sighs, relieved. "*Good*." She wags a finger at the blonde. "And don't go thinking you can get away with *only* telling that dumb cat about the spider stuff. You gotta tell her about everything. *Including* the big stupid gay feelings the both of you have been holding onto."

Adora flinches. "Do I really have to? What if—"

"No, actually, you're right," she backs away, palms up in surrender. "What *was* I thinking? We should all just live our lives dictated by the mighty 'What-If.'"

Finally its Adora's turn to deadpan, as Catra smirks like the butthead she is (apparently it's a feature that transcends dimensions).

"Look, if you *really* need proof that you can admit your big girl feelings and the world won't explode…" Catra gestures to herself, that insufferable smirk still in place. "Telling my Adora I love her was scarier than telling her I'm Arachni-Cat. But I gotta say, it was more than worth it." She chuckles, tail flicking behind her happily. "Even if she sends me the stupidest things about spiders and cats and Spider-Cat. There are a *lot* of ways to make pizza a meme, turns out."

Adora snorts, shaking her head. Catra grins as she takes the handle, opening the door and gesturing for her to go in ahead of her.

Still, her steps pause right before the threshold. "You're sure this isn't going to be a mistake?"

"If it is, I'm always down to dating *two* Adoras."

They both laugh as Adora shoves her away. "You're *awful*."

"Oh, here we go, another arachnophobe. What, are you a dog person too?"

Chuckling, Adora turns back to the stairwell. Nerves still bite at her all the way up her spine, but…

She really does love Catra. She was always so scared to admit it out loud, even to herself, but she does. The thought of coming home after a long day of spidering, never having to lie about where she'd been, being able to be open and honest about when she's hurting from a slew of injuries and just wants to be held… getting to have Catra as more than just her best friend…

Maybe she really could have what this other Catra did.

Steeling herself, she crosses the threshold.

Chapter End Notes

Spider-Adora tells normal Catra she's a spider, Catra freaks out, Spider-Adora freaks out, they both have a very nice very cathartic little freak out (all while Spider-Catra is recording from the window), and then once the shock has faded Catra blurts out "great now I'm even more in love with you" and freezes when she realizes she had in fact just said that

They both kiss while Spider-Catra sends the recording to her Adora and they laugh over it, which means Catra notices Spider-Catra and gets a minute to gawk over spider-her while Spider-Adora frantically explains the multiverse

The first thing she does when she recovers from the shock is ask Spider-Catra if she can try on the suit

Crossover - Fandom Swap

Chapter Notes

> Hey remember how I said I was re-reading The Lunar Chronicles?
>
> Yeah I'm making that your guys' problem now enjoy!
>
> (Side note if this thing double-posts again I'm gonna figuratively toast someone's socks)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"So, this is Grayskull Mechanics. Mind helping me find one of the mechanics in question?"

The voice startles Adora away from where she'd been fidgeting with the wires of her ankle, and she bashes her head on the edge of the table when she tries to jolt upright. Grunting, she carefully sits up, rubbing the back of her head with her gloved left hand.

"Sorry," she grimaces. She really hoped that bang didn't mess with her control panel. "I can help you, just give me a sec—" she stops dead in her tracks.

The stranger, still wincing sympathetically, carefully sets her android on the table.

"Are… you okay?" she asks hesitantly, probably both because of the bashing and because Adora's jaw had just dropped to the floor. She didn't need the net link in her mind scanning this person's face to tell her who it was hiding under sunglasses and a gray hoodie—one that couldn't be comfortable to wear in this sun and with all that fur—but text scrawls across her retina display regardless, confirming what she already knew.

Name: C'yra D'riluth III
Aliases: Catra

Species: Magicat
DOB: October 28th 108 T.E.
Age: 18 years
Status: Crown Prince of the Eastern Commonwealth

A gloved hand waving in front of her face snaps her out of it, but she still gawks in flustered alarm.

The Crown Prince of the Commonwealth. The same Prince every guy (futilely) and girl and everyone in between and beyond had the world's worst crush on, the same Prince who's blue and gold eyes sent hearts everywhere a flutter, the same Prince who's devilish smirk made everyone and their mother *swoon*.

What the hell was the *Crown Prince* doing at *her* booth?!

"Are you brain damaged or something?" Catra asks, a teasing lilt to her tone that still held a trace of clear concern. "That would be really unfortunate, for the both of us I'm afraid."

Finally regaining control of her limbs, Adora shoots to her feet (well, foot, the new one she hadn't gotten the chance to attach yet still rested beside her temporarily discarded boot) and just as quickly ducks into a bow. She's *really* glad she physically can't blush.

"Y-your highness!" she sputters. "I'm so sorry, please forgive my rudeness, I had no idea you would… be down here."

She still had no idea, to be frank. Like yeah, Catra clearly had an android with her, and that was kind of Adora's specialty, but *still*.

A glance up at more rapid movement lets her see that Catra is trying to wave her to sit back down, her expression panicked as more and more eyes drift their way.

"That's honestly kind of the idea can you please sit back down?" she quickly hisses under her breath. Even her tail is tucked away, wrapped around her waist under the hoodie. Adora wouldn't have noticed if the end hadn't lashed out in alarm, momentarily

displacing itself. The blonde quickly obeys, silently grateful to be off her one foot, but still flushes when Catra—still glancing around to see if she's been caught—leans in to murmur, "I'd really rather not get swarmed again for the umpteenth time this week."

"Sorry," Adora winces, willing her heart to calm down. She frowns, what Catra said catching up to her. "Wait, it's only Tuesday, how many times have you been swarmed?"

"Enough to make me wish it was Saturday," she chuckles, relaxing when those who had glanced over turn away to continue shopping. She smiles at Adora, and she stubbornly reminds herself of all the reasons why crushing on the future emperor was a *very not good* idea. The list was extensive. "You think I enjoy this getup? I mean, I'm even wearing boots. *Boots*, Grayskull, can you believe that?"

She snorts. "Wow, you *are* desperate." She finally starts to relax a little when Catra chuckles. "And uh, I'm Adora. Grayskull's just the family name."

"I certainly hope it's more than just a name." She rests a hand on the android's head. "A name alone can't fix up my buddy, here."

Adora hums, leaning forward to run a hand along its side. It was a royal palace android, one of the older models. It was clearly well-loved, but still in surprisingly good condition. Aside from not powering on when coaxed to, it seemed like it should be working.

"What's wrong with it?" she asks. "I'm not seeing any obvious issues."

"I mean, I brought him to see an expert for a reason," the prince huffs as she leans against the table. "I don't have a clue. He's been working just fine, but then one day he just stopped. We've tried everything we can think of but…" she shrugs. "Well, Melog's been like this for a while now."

Adora hums again. Without hesitation, she brings her left hand up, and thunks it upside the model's build, causing the prince to

jump.

When still nothing happens, she huffs through her nose, somewhat disappointed but not entirely surprised. Noting Catra's shock, she smiles apologetically.

"You'd be surprised how often that works," she shrugs. Catra lets out an uncertain chuckle, but relaxes some.

"Are you sure you're the same highly recommended mechanic I've heard so much about?"

Adora laughs awkwardly, pulling at the hem of her gloves as an inner dialogue immediately starts up with every negative adjective she had in her dictionary. Considering her brain could literally hook up to the internet, there was certainly no shortage of them.

"So," the prince clears her throat and tugs at the neckline of her hoodie. Stars, she must be *dying* right now. "Think you could look him over?"

Adora raises a brow. "You still want me to?"

She snuffs, amused. "I can't pretend like I haven't done that same little trick to half of the netscreens in the palace. I guess there is one thing I never tried to get this guy working again."

Adora smiles, easing back in her chair. "I'd be happy to look him over for you. What did you say his name was again? 'Melog?'"

Catra brightens instantly. "Thank you," she breathes out, sounding far more relieved than Adora would have expected. It was just an android, there were probably countless more in the palace, right? "You have no idea how stressful it's been for me trying to get him up and running again. How soon do you think you can work on him?"

She scratches her chin in thought. "Not right away, I don't think. I still have a few other projects I need to finish first, but I doubt any of those will take me all that long."

"Of course, of course," again she tugs at her collar, and Adora wonders if she should offer a water bottle or something. "I knew you'd probably be busy. I don't mean to rush you, but the sooner you can get him back online the better. I'd be happy to pay you extra if you managed to get him fixed within the week."

"I… don't think I can promise a hard deadline, definitely not one that short, especially since you don't know what's causing this." She nods her head apologetically. "I can promise to do my best, but that's about it."

"And that's all I can ask, really," she sighs. "Thank you again for agreeing to this."

"Of course!" She sits up straighter. "I mean even if you weren't the—" she cuts herself off, and Catra smiles gratefully. "Even if you weren't… you, I'd still have accepted."

"Wow. You certainly know how to make a girl feel special," the prince teases, still smiling, and again Adora is glad she lacks the ability to blush.

"Just… doing my job," she fumbles instead. "Um, is it alright if I ask why it's so important you get Melog back so quickly?"

"Oh sure. Melog was carrying highly sensitive data that could determine the fate and future of the Commonwealth itself."

Adora's eyes snap up to meet Catra's, but she's staring down at her with a stone cold seriousness that makes her shiver. Then, Catra snorts, and the seriousness fades with her giggles.

"Nah, I'm messing with you," she snickers, then nods at the droid. "I've had Melog here since I was a kitten. I'm just anxious to get him back, is all."

Adora laughs like the sentence was relieving to hear, like she bought Catra's coverup. But the little blinking orange dot in the corner of her vision, the one that started up after Catra claimed

she was teasing, told her that the latter scenario was more of a lie than the first.

The little orange dot had yet to be wrong when it came to spotting falsehoods.

A loud clattering from the back, followed by an excited whooping, nearly startles her out of her skin, and she whips around as the whirring of a fan and the crunch of android treds rolling over the dusty floor grow louder.

"Hey Adora!" Swift Wind's perky voice calls out as he rolls into view, a can of oil held triumphantly aloft in his metal gripper. "I found the WD-62 you wanted for your new foo—"

Adora chucks her boot at the android, nailing him right in the head and sending him toppling over with an exaggerated "oof!" He buoys back up quickly, and Adora violently whips a finger up in front of her lips.

But of course, he doesn't get the message. "Well that was rude, I was just saying I found the oil you needed for your f—"

Adora loudly clears her throat and gestures at Catra, hoping that at least would be enough to get Swift Wind to shut up. "Swifty, we have a customer! Would you mind grabbing me my toolbox real quick?"

Even though he doesn't have a face, she can still feel the frown. "Don't you already have one? Right there? The one by your foo—"

"I need the other one! The other one has my better tools in it!" She quickly and desperately mouths "*shut up about the foot!*" as she subtly nods her head at the magicat on the other side of her table, who was quickly growing more and more confused.

Which, honestly, was vastly preferable to the other option.

The last thing she needed was the Crown Prince finding out she was a *cyborg*.

The can abruptly drops from Swift Wind's metal gripper as he lets out an artificial gasp, pointing right at Catra. "Stars above, is that Prince Ca—?!"

Adora's other boot is quickly ripped from her foot and also chucked directly at the android's head.

Chapter End Notes

Unrelated to the prompt literally whatsoever but if I had a nickel for every time I enjoyed some fiction where the main characters fight a semi-space battle and have a ship named Darla, I'd have two nickels

Which isn't a lot but it's weird that it happened twice

(Aka I completely forgot there was a ship named Darla in Lunar Chronicles and was reminded of such today while I was listening to one of the books again and that was freaking awesome alskdfjslkf)

Crossover - Video Game

Chapter Notes

> Okay I know this is basically another different version of the Isekai prompt but in my defense
>
> I have none :D
>
> Also tomorrow the chapter count is gonna go up again cuz I couldn't decide between two AUs of mine for tomorrow's prompt so I'm just gonna write little snippets from both cuz why not :DD

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra briefly stopped walking to sit back on her haunches and finally give attention to the scarf around her neck that had definitely not been tied correctly, cursing under her breath as her paws uselessly fumble with the fabric. She never thought she could miss a pair of thumbs so badly.

Adora laughs beside her. "Here, want some help?"

"You don't have any hands either," Catra grumbles, but lets her forelegs drop as her girlfriend floats up behind her, the tassel serving as her appendage coming up to fidget with the loosening knot. "Remind me what you are, again?"

"A 'Honedge,' I think." The levitating sword with a singular eyeball and no mouth shrugs her tassel. "At least according to Old Man Carracosta. And… everyone else here. Do you remember what you are?"

"I'm a fire cat," Catra huffs, eyeing the red and black fur covering her much smaller than usual body. "I think the old man said I was a 'Litten,' whatever that means."

"I think it means that's the type of creature you are here."

Catra gasps. “No! Really? I had no idea.” She snickers as Adora lifts her tassel to smack her upside the head. Who knew no mouth was necessary in order to deadpan?

With the scarf readjusted far more comfortably than it had been when she’d first put it on, Catra lets out a pleased chuff, tail waving in satisfaction. She takes a moment to stretch out, then yawns and shakes out her pelt.

“So, what’s on the agenda today?”

Adora’s eye squints, and Catra can hear the grin in her voice as she teases, “I knew you’d grow to like this eventually.”

She rolls her eyes. “It’s better than doing nothing. Who knows how long we’ll be stuck here like this.”

“Nevermind the fact that it’s our job to beat up people on the regular, right?”

“Well that’s just a nice bonus.”

Adora snorts, but finally pulls a list out of the sheath she carries around. “Looks like we’ve got a few missions to choose from this time. ‘Rescue a lost Turtwig,’ should be simple enough; ‘bring an Oran Berry to a winded Pidgeot,’ also fairly simple…”

Catra groans. “Simple, sure, but not *fun*. Supposedly if you fight enough then some sort of magic spell gives you a stronger body. Adora I *want* that.”

“That’s called working out, something I don’t think I’ve ever seen you do even once.”

She hisses and bats at the levitating sword, who just jingles with laughter.

Sighing, Catra grumbles, “Please tell me there’s *something* interesting on that stupid list.”

Adora hums, going back to scrawl along the note attentively. "'Find a lost Dratini'… 'bring Delcatty a blast seed'… 'help Umbreon find Espeon'…"

"Again? Didn't we *just* go on a mission with them?"

Adora shrugs her tassel and keeps reading. "'Fight a Wooloo'… 'rescue a Mankey'… 'help Vaporeon find Espeon'…"

"Oh geez. Maybe we should just find this Espeon and get things over with before we got twenty people out looking for them."

She snorts again. "You might be right. Hey, wait, this one is starred—"

"There you two are!" a chipper voice calls out, drawing both their gazes up. A rotund little owlet is waving his wing excitedly at them both, a matching scarf to the one the two wore tied around his ankle. He scurries over to meet them halfway, wings flapping excitedly but not enough to get him airborne.

Catra chuffs a greeting as he races up to give Adora a high-five. "'Sup, Arrow-Bird?"

Bow points a feather at her, beaming. "Okay, you tease, but I found out last night that my final evolution does in fact use arrows! How cool is that?!"

"Very cool," she nods, smirking. "All we gotta do now is find something that serves as a shirt in this place to get you a crop-top and complete the look."

He shrugs, smiling. "I'd wear it."

"We know."

Adora waves the paper excitedly. "Bow! Are you gonna be able to join us today?"

With an eager nod as he accepts the paper, he hoots, "I am! In fact I already starred some of the missions I thought we'd have the most fun with and also get the most out of together! Especially…"

Hopping over to be able to look at the paper with the two of them, Bow points out what he'd marked.

"This one!"

Adora and Catra both start buzzing with excitement. "There's a request from a Nidoran to take down an Electabuzz and his gang?" Adora gasps ecstatically. "I saw one the last time we went out, those guys are huge!"

"Of course you wouldn't tell me any of the actually exciting missions, dummy," Catra laughs before leaping away from them. "Let's get our supplies and go find this Nidoran! First one to the Electabuzz gets to knock him out!"

"Not without me, you don't!" Adora dons her sheath and races to catch up, Bow bubbly racing after them as all three laugh giddily.

• 💥 🌏 💫 •

Adora and Catra had both woken up in this strange new world already at each other's side, which gave them the chance to get used to their strange new forms together. Having at first assumed it was just the two of them who'd been sent here, they hadn't bothered searching for anyone else, mainly just a way to get back.

So honestly, they'd gotten pretty lucky when it came to finding Bow.

He'd already gotten plenty familiar with this weird place, learning all sorts of new things that helped the duo find their feet (figuratively, especially where Adora was concerned), including what the heck they supposedly were—Pokémon, whatever that meant—but also more importantly the knowledge that the rest of their friends were also here, scattered to the wind, though he

didn't know where any of them were. Ever since, the three of them have been both trying to get stronger, and find the rest of their friends.

Though when the Nidoran they were supposed to meet up with launches from behind a rock to crash right into Catra, none of them really consider the possibility this could be one of their missing companions.

Not until she recognizes them first at least.

"I could use a little *help* here!" Catra yowls as she tries fighting off the heavier pokémon. The Nidoran clamps her jaws down on Catra's ear, and she snarls as she sinks her fangs into her attacker's leg.

"Um?!" Adora waffles uselessly, looking back and forth between the chaos and Bow, who also is frozen in shock. "Uh, hello?! We're here to *help* you with your mission! Can you *please* get off my girlfriend?!"

"I mean help as in use one of your attacks and get her off me Adora!!"

The Nidoran's eyes widen and she spits out Catra's ear. "'Adora?!'" she yelps, head whipping around to stare in shock at the Honedge. Catra growls and shoves her off, and she bites the dust hard with a grunt as the Litten leaps back to her feet.

Catra arches her back and hisses as the Nidoran quickly scampers back to her feet, but she's not paying attention to her anymore.

"Wait wait wait wait wait, Adora?!" she repeats. "As in giant sword goddess lesbian? *That* Adora???"

Distress having quickly been replaced with surprise and confusion, Adora just blinks rapidly a few times. With a quick glance at Bow, who seems to have understood much faster than she has, she furrows her (nonexistent) brow and mumbles, "Um… yes?"

The Nidoran squeals and goes to pounce, but Catra snarls and bowls her out of the way before she can, hissing in the pokémon's face.

"Don't even think about it, Spikey!" she spits. "What the hell was that about?! You're the one who put up the quest notice!"

The Nidoran growls and butts her head into Catra's, then kicks the stunned pokémon off. "I've been attacked four times now by Electabuzz' goons, I thought that's what you guys were!"

"Yeah yeah, we've moved past that," Adora babbles, ignoring Catra's snappy "we most certainly have not!" to instead ask, "How did you know all that about me?"

But it's Bow who responds, giddy and bouncing. "Glimmer?" he hoots softly, and the Nidoran's eyes dart towards him.

"Wait…" She gasps. "Bow?!"

This time, Catra doesn't get in the way of the squealing hug, instead just rolls her eyes and drags a paw down her face.

"Of course the way we find you is by you needlessly attacking me out of nowhere."

Glimmer snorts, pulling away from the embrace to smirk at the Litten. "Well, no question who you are. Good to see you again, Horde Scum."

"You are not getting a hug from me."

She snickers. "Oh no. However will I go on? Seriously though, sorry for, you know, kicking your ass just now."

Catra rolls her eyes. She's grinning. "The ass-kicking was mutual so I'll look past it this time."

"Appreciate it. Can I hug your girlfriend now or does the ass-kickery need to continue?"

She sits and gestures with a paw for permission, and as the other two come together in another squealing embrace she just snickers and lifts her paw to start grooming down her mussed up fur.

“I’m so glad we found you!” Adora cheers when they pull away.

“Me too! I thought I was the only one who got sent here!”

“All of us were!” Bow chirps. “The four of us, Scorpia, Entrapta, Perfuma, Mermista, Frosta, Sea Hawk, and I think even Netossa and Spinnerella!”

“I still think those two got turned into that Umbreon and Espeon we keep bumping into,” Catra mumbles, then pauses. “Or maybe the Espeon is Entrapta?”

“This is perfect!” Glimmer exclaims. “Once we take down this stupid Electabuzz, I’ll be able to join you guys in looking for the others! And with you all backing me up, this guy doesn’t stand a chance!”

Adora hums. “That reminds me. Why do you want to take this guy down anyway? I’m still helping, either way, but did he do something to you?”

“Other than send his goons to beat up me and every other pokémon they run into, you mean?”

“Is he the one who stole your sparkles?” Catra snickers. “Seriously, I’m gonna have to call you Spikey from now on until you get those back.”

“Please don’t.”

“Get your sparkles back and then we’ll talk, Spikey.”

Glimmer lets out a guttural sigh and pointedly faces away from the Litten. “It’s basically just that. He’s a jerk that keeps picking on weaker pokémon just cuz he can. If we’re gonna be stuck here, might as well do some good with ourselves, right?”

Adora laughs. “Well, yes, that too, but also…”

Catra grins. “It’s just a lotta fun beating up other pokémon.”

To Glimmer’s credit, she manages to keep a straight face for a solid four seconds before she breaks and snickers. “Okay, yeah, it is kind of fun.”

“And speaking of beating up other pokémon…” Catra joshes her head at the gaping cave entrance. “Is that our Mystery Dungeon?”

Glimmer nods. “Sure is.”

“Cool. In that case…” she thrusts her paws into the dirt and takes off, cackling at the chorus of offended gasps. “Last one in gets the least amount of loot!”

“Get back here, Horde Scum!”

“How did I *not* know you were gonna do that again?! *How?!*”

Bow just laughs, taking flight to make sure he could even keep up.

Chapter End Notes

Fun fact this prompt was the first one I did art for cuz I was so excited to make these idiots Pokémon

I’ll get all of the art uploaded onto here at some point, but it probably won’t be until after Inktober is over

Anyway as for the Pokémon themselves I haven’t actually figured out what kind of Pokémon everyone would be besides the BFS but I do have ideas for two of them right now and I’ll update this with the rest by the time I have the next chapter

Catra - Litten/Torracat/Incineroar (cat; duh)
Adora - Honedge/Doublade/Aegislash (sword; also duh)
Bow - Rowlet/Dartrix/Decidueye (arrows; also also duh)

Glimmer - Nidoran/Nidorina/Nidoqueen (honestly I was tempted to go with Ralts bc of the final evolution but I feel like the Nidoran line matches Glimmer's powerful gremlin energy better)

Scorpia - Scorupi/Drapion (scorpion; also also also duh)
Entrapta - Aipom/Ambipom (this is mainly just bc of the two tail hands and Entrapta's prehensile pigtails)
Mermista - Sobble/Drizzile/Inteleon (okay this is mainly bc of Mermista's obsession with murder mystery spy stuff, lemme know if you think Walrein fits better cuz honestly I'm torn)
Sea Hawk - Quaxly/Quaxwell/Quaquaval (I couldn't think of any other Pokémon that gave off nearly the same vibes as Sea Hawk but if anyone has any ideas I'm very open to them)
Perfuma - Flabébé/Floette/Florges (flowers; also (x4) duh)
Frosta - Cubchoo/Beartic (I really wanted to give her and Scorpia three-stage Pokémon but these felt the most fitting for them)
Netossa - Taillow/Swellow (idk lol please tell me if yall have any ideas, I got none)
Spinnerella - Togepi/Togetic/Togekiss (idk it felt fitting sisbdkd)

Also she doesn't show up in this story or AU at all but Angella would 100% be Cresselia you can't convince me otherwise (unless you can, I'm flexible)

Crossover - TV Show/Cartoon/Anime (AU 1)

Chapter Notes

Hey remember when I said I'd get to all the comments haha oops

I'll get to them eventually I promise!!

Also thank y'all for commenting you guys are making my entire month ❤️ ❤️ ❤️

TW: Canon Character Death

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra spat on the ground, the saliva tinged red with her blood. That last earthbending soldier had nailed her good, she'd give him that. Still, it isn't long before he's collapsed on the ground. Dead or just incapacitated, she didn't care. This was war, and so long as she and those she cared about made it out alive, she didn't give a damn who won and who lost.

Even though right now, they were most certainly losing.

It's odd. Yes, she knew of how impenetrable Ba Sing Se was (even if she had personally breached the walls twice now on her own without notice) but Iroh had seemed so sure they could take it down regardless. And, up until a few moments ago, he'd been right. The Fire Nation had been winning, the fearsome Dragon Of The West leading them to an assured victory.

What could have happened in the past ten minutes that would lead to such a drastic change in the flow of battle? What could have been so massive and drastic that they could lose right on the cusp of victory?

Ducking past another flying chunk of earth, she stays on all fours and races across the battlefield, eyes darting back and forth as soldiers fall on both sides. She doesn't stop or slow for anyone, and she *won't* stop or slow for anyone, no one but the three people who actually mattered. Two of them she already knew were fine, they were fighting together as father and son and wouldn't fall to anyone.

But Adora had gone missing several days ago, promising a swift return and failing to deliver. The only reason Catra knew she was here was because other soldiers had reported spotting her head of genetically unusual blonde hair, repeatedly throughout the battle. How she'd gotten here of all places was beyond Catra, but she didn't care about the how.

She only cared about the *where*.

Finally, she spots her, also running across the battlefield, blonde ponytail waving wildly in the smoky winds. Veering to the right to intercept her, Catra pumps her muscles as hard as she can, and when she's finally close enough, she pounds her feet into the ground and pounces, crashing right into Adora's side just as a blast of fire blows overhead.

The two tumble and roll to a halt. Adora scrambles to get out from under Catra, shooting to her feet and lifting her fists in a defensive stance, but then relaxes when she realizes who just tackled her.

Catra snorts, a bit more bitterly than she intended. "Hey, Adora. About time you showed up again."

"Catra!" Adora breathes, winded from the sprint. "I— what are you doing here?"

"Uh, helping Iroh with his siege? Y'know, like *you* were supposed to be doing? Where have you been?"

Adora sputters and babbles, something about swords and spirits and the Avatar, before she shakes her head and reaches for

Catra's wrist instead. "Nevermind, there's no time. Catra, we have to get out of here."

She pulls her wrist from Adora's grasp, but before Adora can protest she reaches out to grab the human's hand, and starts pulling her along. "Yeah, I gathered as much. Look, you can explain all the ins and outs of where in Agni's name you've been this whole time when we're back home at the palace. I'm glad I found you, it's getting kinda nuts out here if you hadn't noticed. Let's go find Iroh and Lu Ten, then we'll—"

"You don't *understand!*" This time it's Adora who pulls away, and Catra who looks back in surprise. "Catra, we can't go back to the Fire Nation!"

Catra blinks, only moving to shift her head out of the way of another launched rock. "You're right. I don't understand. Where did *that* come from? What's with you?"

Adora gestures frantically at the battlefield around them. "Look around you, Catra! What about this is okay??" She shakes her head just as emphatically. "We can't go back to the Fire Nation because they're *evil!* Ba Sing Se is full of innocent people that are going to die if this continues! The Fire Nation is wrong for this! For *all* of this!"

Catra waits one second. Then another. Then, throwing her arms up, she cries, "Duh! I'm sorry, is this *news* to you?!"

Adora recoils, as if Catra had just struck her. "You… you *knew?!* Why didn't you say anything??"

Okay, she was honestly as baffled at this as her friend was. "Because I like the smell of burnt flesh and the sound of people screaming in blood-curdling terror helps me sleep at night. Why do you *think*, Adora?! I thought it was obvious!"

"Well not to me!!"

"Yeah, I noticed." She sighs, and gently takes Adora's arm. "Look, it doesn't matter what they do. We have each other, and Iroh and Lu Ten, and heck even Ursa's kids are starting to grow on me. That's all that matters. Now come on. Please? Let's find the old man and throw together a plan of what to do next. If we have to give up on Ba Sing Se, fine, but at least we'll be alive."

But Adora just shakes her head, and again pulls away. "I *can't*, Catra." Her eyes dart back to where she'd been running to, back where the wall still stands and the majority of the fighting is still taking place. "I've seen what this war is doing to people. I… I can't fight for them anymore."

Catra snarls, her patience fraying. "You've gotta be kidding me. You see a few sad saps shed some tears or something? You're away from home for four days and now suddenly you're willing to upend everything we know and have for… what, people you've known for less than a day?! What about Iroh? And Lu Ten? What about *me?!*"

Adora flinches, but it's clear she has no intention of changing her mind. Her stubborn scowl softens, and she again reaches for Catra's hand. Her fingers are trembling. Or maybe Catra's are.

"You can come with me. We can leave the Fire Nation! We can stop fighting for them and start fighting against them! You don't have to go back, Catra."

Catra's breaths are coming harder, the stubborn fire within her burning through her as it feeds off of the fear and disbelief and rage collecting as a storm. The patience and kindness Iroh had worked so hard to instill within her is swallowed by the flames of pain incinerating everything in their path.

Adora had been there every single time Catra was injured as "punishment" for any number of things. She had seen first hand the injustices and cruelties Catra had suffered every moment of her life until Iroh finally managed to take her in. But none of the abuse, none of the torture, none of the agony, *none of it* was

enough to convince Adora to leave Shadow Weaver and the Fire Nation far behind.

But now, she's willing to abandon everything she ever knew and loved, the people she's been surrounded by for her entire life, because *other* people are hurting, people she couldn't have known for more than a day or two at most.

An explosion rocks the world behind Catra, but she doesn't flinch even as Adora does. The wall was behind her. Explosions meant their armies were advancing, even if only somewhat. Both of them knew it.

But watching Adora grimace in panic and disgust makes Catra's gut curdle.

Lip curling, she growls and recaptures the blonde's attention. She hopes it isn't obvious how her eyes water as she snarls, "Quit being an idiot, Adora. You want this war to stop? Everyone does. It doesn't mean you have to—" *leave me, abandon me, forget about me* "—betray the Fire Nation." She extends her hand one last time, palm to the sky, and this time she knows it's her fingers that are trembling. "Just… stay with me. With us. We'll go find Iroh, and we'll… we'll figure something out."

And she can see it in Adora's eyes, the want to take her hand and go with her. She watches her fight that want, watches her squelch it under her boot and steel her spine, her eyes hardening, and Catra's last shred of hope burns to ash.

The smoke from the explosion billows past Catra, enveloping them both. Adora slowly backs away from her, further into the thickening cloud, until finally she turns on a dime and runs.

Something in Catra shatters. She thinks it might just be her heart.

She isn't sure how long she stands there. Another explosion nearby shakes her out of her stunned little trance, but she almost wishes it hadn't.

That… that had just happened.

How had that just happened?

Clenching her teeth so hard her jaw starts to hurt, stubbornly refusing to let her tears fall, Catra stiffly turns away and marches back. Her march quickens little by little with each step she takes, until she too is running, running as fast as her legs can carry her, then dropping to all fours to pelt across the field even faster, her vision blurring with her tears.

She doesn't stop, not until most of the sounds of battle have faded and she's alone amidst the ashes and embers. Even then, she doesn't truly stop, she just slows as her energy fades and her body shakes, until finally her legs give out and she crashes to a halt.

Still heaving for breath, she unsteadily lifts herself up onto her elbows, and looks up.

The tank she commanded lays ahead of her, old and rundown and abandoned.

Only moments later, it's been charred to a crisp, starburst wounds marring the metal every which way. Catra's hands twitch and spasm as she stalks away from the vehicle, spent and aching and useless after unleashing her pyre of fury.

She needs to find Iroh and Lu Ten. She… she needs them. She has no idea what to do. They always knew, especially Iroh. Her rage and anger and hurt were still burning as bright as a star within her, but now the hurt was threatening to swallow up the other two and leave her a sobbing, pitiful mess. She couldn't afford that, not here.

A distant part of herself can tell that the tide of battle is still shifting heavily out of their favor, but if she'd cared even remotely before she simply couldn't anymore. Things are dying down around her, making it both easier and much more difficult to find the Dragon of the West.

She needs him. By the sun, she needs him.

She barks commands and shouts orders at the soldiers she comes across, demanding to know where the general and his son were. She hardly sticks around long enough to listen to any complete directions, her steps still alive with a desperate speed, but she hears them and follows them just fine regardless, until finally she finds him.

She can recognize his silhouette fairly easily from this distance, even with the staggering number of wounded and dead soldiers laying around him. Her steps quicken even further as she makes a beeline right for him, an endless dialogue already on the tip of her tongue that needed nothing more than to escape and be met with his kindness and understanding and wisdom.

Adora's gone, she'd say without crying. *She's gone, she's betrayed us, and I don't know what to do. Iroh, she doesn't care. She never cared. If she cared she'd have stayed, if she cared she'd have left when we were seven, or ten, or twelve, or fifteen, or anytime before* now, *the* one *time I wasn't with her. What am I supposed to do? I hate her. I love her. Nothing has ever hurt as badly as this. How am I supposed to deal with this? What am I supposed to do? What do I do?*

Soldiers that are able to all scurry out of her way as she approaches, and she dodges those who can't. "General," she calls, masking her tears with the frustration and anger that were both just as real but not quite as overwhelming. His back is turned to her, he's hunched over something, but she doesn't register anything else. She needs him. "There you are. Listen, there's something we need to discuss—"

Iroh's shoulders hitch, and she hears someone let out a sharp, devastated sob. But… it couldn't be Iroh who made that sound… could it?

Her steps slow. "General?" her voice comes out softer. She hears another sound like crying, and her planned monologue fades to

the back of her mind. The stench of blood gets thicker and much more pungent as she gets nearer, and her dread only builds up more and more. Her voice next comes out as little more than a whisper. “Iroh?”

When still he doesn’t turn, Catra takes the plunge and steps around the man to face him.

Instantly, she pales, ears pinning flat and tail stilling in horror as she falls to her knees.

Lu Ten, the man who was closer to an older brother than any other Catra had ever known, the man who teased her and sparred with her and laughed with her as though they’d never been anything but close, is being cradled like a child in his father’s arms, his blood staining skin and hair and clothes and *everything*.

He’s dead.

Catra grits her teeth against another stab of sheer agony, of overwhelming grief and pain and sorrow, and roughly scrubs at her eyes before any stupid tears could fall.

“No,” she seethes, calling back the anger and fury and sun-sweltering rage to burn away everything that remained. Her voice cracks as she shakily chokes out, “Who did this?”

Iroh shakes his head, pressing his forehead to Lu Ten’s. But Catra can’t accept that answer.

“Who *did this?!*” she insists, her core blazing like the heart of a volcano as her anger spikes. “Iroh *tell me who did this!!*”

But when Iroh finally looks up, the grief and sorrow and heartache reflected in his eyes, held back by absolutely nothing and visible for all the world to see, Catra stops dead in her tracks. And his words…

“Killing those responsible…” his breath shudders, “will not bring the lost back to us.”

And just like that… the flames die down, leaving not even an ember behind. With nothing to hold it back anymore, Catra's tears come hard and fast, and though she tries, she can't stop it. The force of her sobs quickly has her doubled over, hunched over the body of the closest thing she ever had to a brother, her head buried in the shoulder of the closest thing she had to a father, as she wails and cries and mourns everything she just lost.

The Earth Kingdom snatches its victory from the jaws of death.

• 💥 🌏 💫 •

The time between the coronation and the failed battle of Ba Sing Se had passed in a bit of a blur. Losing Adora and Lu Ten in the same day had broken Catra in a way nothing—no burn or bruise or laceration or shattered bone—ever had. If she would have lost Iroh, too… she isn't sure what she would have turned into.

Though his pain had been as great—if not easily much greater than—her own, the old man had been there for her. He'd supported her through the pain and grief, and she'd tried to do the same for him, though she doubts she was anywhere near as effective at it. If you asked her, she lacked the natural soothing warmth the older man had, and would be a less effective comforter than the royal bedsheets. But Iroh always expresses his gratitude whenever she tries, and that on its own is enough to get her to keep trying.

He never uttered a word when one day they find that Adora's quarters had been burnt to ash and cinders, and Catra's hands were tellingly spasming and twitching and hot from the flames. He had instead taken her into his arms, and had held her as she'd cried for the umpteenth time since that awful day.

And when a servant had asked in alarm what had happened to Adora's room, he'd unflinchingly blamed it on an errant ember, and the matter had never come up again.

With Iroh, Zuko, and even Azula, the pain was lessened for Catra, and—she could only hope—the same was true for the old man. With the young prince and princess oftentimes glued to her and Iroh's sides, she found, for a time, that she was able to move past her turmoil, to instead focus on what she still had left, and cling to it with all the fury Adora had stirred in her when she'd abandoned her.

But then something happens, something that—for lack of a much better term—throws a serious wrench into the tentative new way of life they've been thrust into.

Prince Ozai is crowned the new Fire Lord, after the untimely demise of his and Iroh's father.

Normally, Catra couldn't care less about what happened with the crown, couldn't care less who's head wore it and who's didn't.

Shadow Weaver was Ozai's most favored advisor. And she loved to pin anything and everything on Catra that she could. She'd no doubt find a way to pin Adora's betrayal on her as well. She might even try to do the same with Lu Ten's death.

And now, she sat at the right hand of the Fire Lord.

A strange calmness overcomes Catra as she watches her fellow captains, other commanders, all the generals, everyone who would, did, had, and will serve the crown, step up to declare their allegiance and undying loyalty to Fire Lord Ozai. She knew she would be expected to do the same, knew that doing so would mean she'd undoubtedly yet again be exposed to torture and pain and suffering for simply not doing enough, not being enough. She knew Iroh's ability to protect her had just been drastically impaired, and with a glance at the old man she can tell he knows it too, can see it in the worry in his gaze directed at her.

She knew that, no matter what she did, the only thing she could expect in her future was more pain.

The time for her to step forward and affirm her loyalties to his majesty finally comes, and slowly she steps forward.

She will not be bowing before Ozai, that much she knows for certain. He was the one who enabled Shadow Weaver's cruelty. He was the one who would ensure it would continue.

He was not, and never would be, the man she'd ever willingly assist.

By Ozai's side stands Shadow Weaver, who sneers at Catra as she approaches. But at his other side, sits Ozai's two children.

His two children who, with Ozai's new title, were now the Fire Nation's Crown Prince and Crown Princess respectively.

Catra reaches the throne, pauses, then turns to continue pacing until she stops before Crown Prince Zuko, and Crown Princess Azula.

Alarm is as clear in the boy's eyes as it is in Iroh's and Azula's. Zuko's eyes worriedly dart to his father, to his father's advisor, but Catra doesn't dare look to them. She knows her moment of calm will shatter the moment she does.

She bows, lower than any who had bowed before Ozai, to the future of the Fire Nation.

The gasp that rolls through every single person gathered in the caldera fills her with an indescribable delight.

She almost wishes Adora had been there to see it.

Chapter End Notes

Rq Adora is NOT the Avatar that's still Aang

This AU (and the one I'm posting directly after posting this one) are two of my pre-existing AUs that I chose to write

about for this prompt, and I’m HOPING to someday do more with both of them

We shall see what the future holds I suppose

Crossover - TV Show/Cartoon/Anime (AU 2)

Chapter Notes

haha look at that chapter count go up again how delightful

I don't think this one needs a trigger warning but please let me know

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra had an unbelievably difficult time putting her finger on what it was about this kid that drew her in so powerfully.

"You're here *again?*" Eda balks, even as she opens the door wider to let Catra inside. "Whatever happened to miss 'I only stick around for the food, water, and snails you pay me?'"

Catra just smirks over her shoulder. "How do you know I'm not pillaging your cupboards and drawers when you're not looking?"

She snorts a laugh, slamming the door shut before Hooty could add his two snails. "Please. I'm a professional pickpocketing champion, and your feet are covered in mud almost every single time I see you. I'm fairly confident I'd know if you of all people had been stealing from me."

"If you say so," Catra sniffs. "That's a nice guitar thing you have, by the way. Who's 'Rainstorm?'"

Eda slams the fridge door closed and whips around so fast with eyes so wide it's a miracle she doesn't lose her head. Catra's seen it happen before (she's a little disappointed she didn't elicit such a reaction this time). The feline just smirks at the Owl Lady's glare, holding up her hands in mock surrender.

"You're on thin ice, Pawprints," she warns, jabbing a finger at her. Catra just snickers, and Eda's ears flick in irritation. Loosing a sigh, the older woman stands up straight and folds her arms. "Anyway, why *are* you here? I don't have any more daring quests for us to go on for a while, so I got nothing to pay you for." She snorts. "Unless you've reconsidered giving Hooty a bath?"

"If you want the demon bird tube dead so badly, there are easier ways to kill him," Catra says as her tail lashes through the air. Her smirk turns a shade dangerous as the claws on her feet flex into the floorboards. "Though I suppose, if you *really* want me to…"

She hears Hooty squawk in alarm. Eda rolls her eyes. "For Titan's sake, kid, I asked for a *bath*, not a *blood*bath. How Luz likes you so much, I'm not sure I'll ever know. You're just a touch terrifying."

Catra bows her head as if she'd just received a compliment. "She's actually why I'm here. Wanted me for help with some project or whatever."

Eda lifts a brow. "And you're doing this willingly? Geez, does she have a mountain of gold or something? What's she paying you to show up so frequently?"

Catra's really glad she doesn't have time to be pressured into admitting that the answer is quite literally *nothing*. The rapid thumps of excited footfalls growing closer has her turning to the living room doorway expectantly, moments before an ecstatic young teenage girl comes sprinting into view so quickly she slams right into the doorframe.

Luz' excited smile, directed solely at Catra for no other reason than she was excited to see *her*, does that weird thing it's been doing to her for weeks now where the old but massive fissure in her heart patches over just a little bit more, the ever present ever constant aching yet again quieting in the face of the warmth from this dang kid's light.

Though it hadn't been like this from the moment they first met each other, it definitely hadn't taken long for it to become the new norm.

And Catra had yet to understand any of it.

"Catra, you made it!" the kid cheers, and it's still so bizarre to her to see someone so genuinely thrilled to see her, so happy they can't help but express it physically, because there's only ever been one other person in the world who'd ever gotten close to that kind of reaction.

And she'd left Catra behind without a second thought.

But Luz… she swings her arms around Catra in a crushing (mildly, at least) embrace, something she's been trying especially hard to get away with as of late, and something Catra's never once tolerated. She still doesn't, but it takes her a second longer than usual to carefully push the kid back this time, and she can tell Luz noticed.

"Come on! I found something incredible, you've gotta see it!"

Catra groans theatrically. "Why can't you bug Eda with this?"

"She and King have lived here the longest, they've already seen it!"

She rolls her eyes, but doesn't fight the kid taking her hand and dragging her along. "Can't argue with that, I guess."

Luz beams yet again, and Catra fights her pull just a little less.

She truly did not know what it was about this kid that had such control over her. If she weren't the literal embodiment of perkiness and joy, this strange effect she had would terrify Catra. If she weren't… if she weren't Luz, if she were *anyone* else, Catra wouldn't trust anything about her. She wouldn't trust her kindness, she wouldn't trust her affection, she wouldn't trust how much she loved to be around *Catra* of all people. After all, Catra

had trusted all of that about one other person, the *only* other person who ever got close to anything like this, and all that had landed her with was a fractured heart.

She *shouldn't* trust a *thing* about this kid.

But she did. Or at least, she didn't suspect this kid wasn't genuine.

Maybe she was wrong to be kind, affectionate, caring, and appreciative of Catra. Maybe, as she pulls the feline into her room to show off her findings like an overeager dog showing off its latest treasure, she's only being a foolish idiot. Maybe Catra's the idiot, for daring to actually believe any of this.

But Luz *was* genuine, that much was certain.

And maybe that's why Catra lets her excitement infect her. Maybe that's why she lets Luz' bubbly joy corrupt her as together they explore the kid's latest discovery. Maybe that's why she actually lets herself have fun with and enjoy this, enjoy *her*.

Maybe that's why the kid is genuinely starting to grow on her.

That scares her more than anything.

• 💥 🌎 💫 •

Adora knew exactly what it was about this kid that drew her in so powerfully.

"Thank you for your assistance today, Adora," Emperor Belos' slimy voice croons, drawing her attention away from the Golden Guard as it sends shivers down her spine that she fights to suppress. Even the way he ever so subtly lists his head is so painfully similar to Shadow Weaver. "If you keep this up, I can only imagine what grand plans the Titan will piece together with you in mind."

Oh stars, she wants to be sick again. Instead she bows her head, knowing the motion would only perfectly stroke this monster's ego, as she says in return, "Thank *you*, your majesty. It is an honor to serve you, and the Titan's will."

Just as she suspected, Belos hums appreciatively, that same sickeningly pleased cadence that meant Adora was doing everything exactly as he wanted it. She would love to take her sword, for now disguised as a simple spear to match those of the rest of the guard, and jam it straight through this monster's ribcage, but she knew it wouldn't be that easy to off him. If she were to try anyway, she'd only give her true intentions away, and then she'd lose her only connection to his right hand man.

She couldn't afford that.

"I'm sure you're tired after a day like today," Belos sighs, sitting up straighter in his throne as the Titan's heart continued to beat steadily above him. "You are free to return to your quarters for the rest of the evening. I expect to see you bright and early in the morning, as usual."

She nods her head and thanks him again, and notices the Golden Guard perking up at the man's side. She meets the guard's eyes through his mask as she turns to leave, and can see him light up in the single second they have.

She'd be getting a blonde, bright-eyed visitor tonight. Good.

Adora only finally feels her shoulders relax when she's back in her room with the door shut and locked. She flumps against the wood and groans, sinking down until her butt hits the floor. Yanking off her stupid helmet, she loosely chucks it across the room, uncaring of where it ended up, and buries her fingers in her hair as she curls forward to hide her face in her knees.

She'd been able to recognize the signs so quickly this time. It was almost unfair, given how long it had taken her to realize it about herself and Catra.

The words Belos used. The way he used them. The praise that disguised the criticism, that tauntingly dangled the carrot from the stick, forever out of reach but only just barely. The carefully calculated touch, used as both the reward and the punishment.

He hadn't yet started to pit the Golden Guard against Adora, using Adora's accomplishments to only belittle and critique the boy's own, but she knew it was coming.

She only hoped she'd gained enough of Hunter's trust by that point to actually do something about it this time.

A special knock at her door startles her from her borderline spiral, and something in her chest eases. Rushing to get to her feet and shuck off her uniform, she opens the door to an eager, beaming grin, and feels herself smile at the sight. He was the only thing that got her to smile so genuinely anymore.

"Hey, you," she greets as she reaches forward to ruffle up Hunter's hair, earning a sputtered but light-hearted laugh from the kid as he bats her away. "I wasn't expecting you until later! Your uncle feeling generous tonight?"

Pushing his hair back into an orderly (no it wasn't) fashion, Hunter moves past her crime in favor of nodding happily.

"Yeah! He said that thanks to all your hard work, I was able to take the rest of the day off too! He even *suggested* that I spend some time training with you to get better myself!"

Adora hides a wince as the kid steps inside. So apparently, the comparisons already *had* started. Wonderful.

She hides it behind a forced laugh that she hopes doesn't come across as such. "Well, I'm not sure I'd be any good at training you. You're *way* better at all that guard stuff than I am."

Hunter blows a raspberry as he settles on her mattress. "That's just because I've been at it longer than you have. I mean

seriously, Belos doesn't accept just *anybody* to be such a high-ranking soldier. You're incredible!"

Adora's smile strains. She pulls out her chair and sits backward on it, resting her arms atop the back. "Don't sell yourself so short, Hunter. You're pretty incredible too. Ah-ah! Don't just wave it off, I mean it!"

Caught, Hunter sheepishly laughs and lowers his hand. He rubs the back of his neck. "You uh… you really think so?"

"I know so," she confirms seriously. "You're so much more amazing—" *than Belos will* ever *acknowledge because he's trying to keep you under his control* "—than you realize."

The boy's flush brightens, but he doesn't deny the compliment this time, and Adora inwardly breathes a sigh of relief. Baby steps. Little by little. She had to remember that. She had to remain patient.

Not knowing how to react to her praise, Hunter just segues into what they always wind up talking about during their little hangouts. Anything and everything. With Adora always acting as a patient and caring outlet, Hunter could freely babble about whatever he felt like, especially since she encouraged it every time.

As he starts going on and on about wild magic again, a part of Adora's mind wanders while the rest focuses intently.

She had to protect this boy. She had to get him away from Belos, before the beastly man could do any more damage to his nephew. Every scar on the kid made her heart ache immeasurably. Every time he flinched when she or anyone moved too fast, or he pleaded to avoid upsetting her, she felt like vomiting. Every glance she took at the bags under his eyes made her yearn to blacken Belos' eyes an even darker color.

She hadn't been able to do any of that to the person responsible for destroying the one she cared for the most. She hadn't been

able to stop any of the damage, she hadn't been able to undo any of the unjust consequences, she hadn't been able to help.

She couldn't save Catra.

But this boy, this sweet, tender hearted boy… she could save him. She could protect him. She could help him.

She was doing it already.

Maybe it should have scared her, just how quickly she'd grown attached to Hunter. Maybe it should have scared her just how quickly she'd decided she would do anything to be there for him and help him in every way she couldn't have with Catra. But it didn't. It didn't scare her how fond she was of this kid, it didn't scare her how happy it made her to see him shining, it didn't scare her to know that she cared for him.

The ever looming threat that was his uncle, the knowledge that if she faltered just once it would shatter both Belos' and Hunter's trust in her, the idea that she would fail to help and protect and save this kid…

That scares her more than anything.

Chapter End Notes

> If I had a nickel for everytime I threw Catra into an AU where she at some point gets adopted by a powerful old person with gray hair and at least one gold eye, I'd have two nickels
>
> Which isn't a lot but it's weird that it happened twice
>
> And just like the ATLA AU, I have a lot more in mind for this one too that I'm hoping to work with in the future, fingers crossed I get to it eventually 🤞
>
> Anyway big sisters Catra and Adora ftw I love them your honor

Crossover - Never Been Done Before

Chapter Notes

> I love how this week especially is basically just me exposing every single way that I am a nerd

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora's phone shakes in her trembling hand, the MetaNav app glaring up at her, ready and waiting. At any moment, the rest of the Phantom Thief Alliance would start showing up, and when they were all there they'd head into Mementos and end this. They had everything they needed. They had plenty of supplies stocked up, they'd already secured their path to the treasure, and they'd sent the Calling Card just this morning.

But stars, did she feel anything but ready.

She feels warmth press against her arm as Catra leans into her, her tail coiling around Adora's leg. The magicat isn't looking at her when she glances down to check, instead she's clutching her own phone, the same app laying at the ready, and her eyes are pinning the screen with an anxious glare.

Adora leans back into her. "You nervous, too?"

Catra's eyes momentarily flicker up to meet her gaze before they dart away again. There was fear in them. "How could I not be?" she mutters honestly under her breath instead of brushing off Adora's comment. "I've only ever known her as a monster. If we go through with this… what the hell are we gonna find?"

"I don't know. But we owe it to ourselves, and to everyone she's ever hurt, to try. Don't you think?"

Slowly, Catra nods, letting out a measured breath. "We're going to have to fight her shadow. You know that, right? There's no way

we'll be able to just steal the treasure and walk out. She's going to be waiting for us."

Adora carefully moves her arm to wrap around Catra's shoulders, hugging her close and pressing a kiss to her scalp. "I know. It's… kind of terrifying, isn't it?"

"That's putting it mildly." She shudders in her grasp, and buries her face in Adora's neck. "She's already a threat in real life. How much worse is she going to be as a shadow in Mementos?"

For a moment, Adora stupidly lets herself wonder.

They'd already faced so many threats as a team, so many shadows of so many corrupt hearts, each one more dangerous than the last. A self-obsessive teacher, a lying stealing mentor, a manipulative gang leader, and so many more. But somehow… she knew this one would be worse than all of them.

After all, all those corrupt hearts they'd stolen already belonged to people they (at least most of them on the team) didn't have emotional ties to.

But Weaver was Catra's mother. Well, foster mother. And her cruelty—not just towards her own daughter, but to anyone she ever deemed pathetic or useless—was the biggest open secret in this town.

Her shadow would undoubtedly be the most monstrous thing they'd faced to date. They'd already caught a glimpse of it inside her palace. Beautiful and graceful, natural elegance a sheer perfection, it surprised no one that Weaver saw herself as something to be admired and respected, adored… and *feared*. When drenched in darkness, the eyes of a demon opened all over her body and stared, bloodshot and crazed with fragmented pupils.

And on their way out, after securing their route to her treasure, those eyes had found them, and unholy screams graced them on their way out.

Catra hadn't stopped shaking for an hour.

Adora clenches her eyes shut, suppressing the crawling feelings of dread and fear. "I don't know," she finally murmurs in response to Catra's question. "I don't know what's waiting for us. I don't know what to expect from her." She presses another kiss to her mane, and pulls back just enough to meet her frightened gaze, cupping her furry cheeks between her hands and gently bringing their foreheads together. "But I do know that neither of us are gonna be alone. We have the team, remember? They're all gonna be right there at our sides. Catra, we won't let her hurt you again."

Catra slowly reaches up to cup one of Adora's hands, securing her gentle touch and leaning into it needily. "I know you won't," she sighs. "And I'm… I'm really glad I have all of you backing me up. But… I don't think I'm going to stop freaking out until all of this is finally over. I don't think I *can*."

From the moment they'd discovered that Weaver had a palace, Catra had been on edge. She'd been so jumpy and frantic as they'd made their way through the place that she'd jumped at every sound and attacked anything that moved. She hadn't slept a wink since they'd secured their route and escaped, and *everyone* on the team had noticed.

"I think you're right," she says as she softly kisses the bridge of Catra's nose. Quickly pocketing her phone, she reaches her now free hand up to the back of Catra's ear, and gently begins scratching her nails into the furry cartilage. "Good thing it's almost over, huh?"

Catra nods, but aside from leaning a little into the ministrations, she remains as tense as a stretched rubber band.

Before Adora can say much more to reassure her, a loud and energetic cheer splits the air.

"Who's ready to kick some shady shadowy *ass?!*" Glimmer whoops, pumping the air as she and Bow stroll into view, with

Scorpia and Perfuma not far behind. Bow waves as they approach, the hood of his cropped hoodie wriggling around until a small furry head pokes out.

"I most *certainly* am ready!" Melog cheers as he frees himself from Bow's hoodie, leaping up onto the man's shoulder. Clearly not patient enough to wait for him to get closer, the cat jumps down and races over to get to Catra and Adora first, pouncing back up to perch on Catra's shoulder instead. "If I don't get to tear apart the real deal's curtains, I *need* to do so to her shadow's. I didn't do it the last time we went in, I *must* make up for that *now*."

Adora chuckles, lifting a hand to ruffle the cat's ears. "Glad to hear it. I was thinking her place could use some remodeling." She turns her smile on Catra, and is glad to see her relax at least enough to smile back.

"I keep forgetting we have a talking cat," Scorpia chuckles awkwardly as she too sidles up to join them.

Melog huffs. "I'm still not a cat. Don't let my beautiful whiskers fool you."

Glimmer smirks. "You're even more of a cat than Catra is, buddy. Sorry to break it to you."

The very-much-definitely-a-cat sighs and looks down to meet his perch's eyes. "Your friends just don't understand me."

Catra snorts, and Adora isn't the only one to smile at the sound.

Unfortunately, the temporary mirth is quick to fade, as Perfuma, who's eyes had quickly been drawn to the looming sanctum entrance, finally shatters the illusion of peace with a simple, "Is everyone prepared?"

Just like that, the underlying tension resurfaces. Catra's smile fades, her body tensing up again, and the others are quick to adapt the same way. Uneasy looks are exchanged between the

seven of them, until one by one, every pair of eyes lands on Adora.

She can't help but swallow anxiously. She didn't want to waste time, none of them did, but even still, she wished the moment of ease hadn't shattered so damn fast. Sucking in a deep breath through her nose, then letting it out slow through her mouth, she steps up to the entrance, and pulls out her phone.

The red MetaNav app stares up at her, ready and waiting for her to press it. She doesn't want to.

Her thumb presses down, and reality around them begins to warp and shift nauseatingly.

When the distortions die down, with nothing left of them but a hazy red silhouette echoing any and all movement, the sanctum's entrance has disappeared. Now standing before them lies the drawbridge entrance to a palace, tall and looming and menacing against a clouded purple sky. Black clouds like billowing smoke circle above the palace itself, and liquid darkness oozes from corners and cracks only in the peripherals. Turning to catch them, no matter how fast one looks, wipes them from existence completely, as if only ever imagined.

The ground before them suddenly ripples like the shimmer of a disturbed puddle of water, until the center coils, dips, and springs up, raining back down as shadows already screaming and violent. The creatures of darkness surge forward without warning, and Adora and her teammates all brace for impact.

She slides one hand into Catra's, and with the other she reaches for the golden mask that had formed around her eyes. Just as the shadows reach them, she tears it away, and screams out the only word she needs.

"*PERSONA!!!*"

The mask dissipates, and with the phantasmic golden and blue figure now looming behind her, she throws her hand forward, and

with a golden blade it lunges forth and strikes.

Chapter End Notes

> Listen if there HAS been a She-Ra X Persona 3/4/5 AU no there hasn’t I did it first 😤 (if someone else has done this already please send me their way I wish to stand in shock and awe)

Crossover - Cross Universe Ship

Chapter Notes

I’m taking a lot of creative liberties with this one lol

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“AAAAAAHAHAHAHAAAAAAAA!!!!!!!”

The portal snaps closed behind the ship just in time. Sea Hawk has never been more grateful that though he currently piloted what was primarily a *space* ship, it still functioned just fine across water, as with the closing of the gateway his ship skips like a tossed stone across the ocean they’d stumbled upon. Slowly, the vessel slows to a halt, leaving him clinging to the steering with a white-knuckled grip.

For a moment, he simply stands there, staring out at nothing. Then, the corners of his mouth and mustache curl up, until he’s beaming bright as the sun they’d rocketed past. Letting loose another victorious laugh, he swings his hands into the air in celebratory fist pumps.

“Yet another grandiose, daring, and perfectly executed escape at the hands of the mighty Sea Hawk!” he whoops, slapping the controls as though congratulating another a job well done. And he was. “Well done, my darling dragon! Such a feat would not have been possible without you!”

Though the Dragon’s Daughter XIV doesn’t usually respond (he isn’t sure that’s one of her features), it’s only fair to dish out credit where credit is due. And speaking of…

“Don’t you worry, my dear,” he coos as he turns to exit the cockpit. “Rest assured, I shall ensure that before our next daring endeavor, we will first take to treating you to your own night of luxury! I promise you that!”

His next destination is the crew deck, where he's certain most if not all of his comrades will be posted.

He pokes his head in, and grins. He can't say he was expecting half of them to be sprawled across the floor, but at least he'd correctly assumed their whereabouts.

"What ho, my friends!" he cheers as he struts in to a chorus of nauseated, unamused groans and curse words. "Here's to yet another stellar escapade! You all did marvelously, truly!"

"Remind me who let him be captain?" Catra groans, her voice echoing from the trash can she'd crawled over to and buried her head in. Her fur puffs up as she retches, and several of the others grow even greener.

Mermista, the only one not splayed helplessly on the ground and instead shakily clinging to the doorway, is the only one to respond. "We were all too busy fighting for our lives to stop him."

"Bow," Glimmer grumbles from the floor, face up and no doubt containing no small amount of indescribable fury, "You're hereby banned from ever leaving the ship's cockpit again."

"I second that motion," the queasy cat calls.

"What did I do, again?" Bow mumbles, his voice muffled from the floor his face was smushed into.

"Nothing, you're perfect, but we need someone to pilot who isn't Sea Hawk and you're the only one qualified."

He sluggishly lifts a thumb into the air, then lets it drop moments after. "Glimmer, Catra; flying lessons. Starting… as soon as the world stops spinning."

Adora finally lifts up her own head. "Hey, whaddabout me?"

"*No*," comes the immediate response of Catra, Glimmer, Bow, Scorpia, Perfuma, Mermista, and even Entrapta. The only one who

actually says and does anything else is Sea Hawk, who encouragingly flashes her a double thumbs up.

Sufficiently cowed, Adora pouts with a sigh and lowers her head again, eyes closing.

Mermista drags a hand down her green-tinged face. "Can we put up a sign or something? One that says something like 'Allowed To Pilot' that has three sections labeled 'allowed,' 'not allowed,' and 'fully banned until further notice?'"

"Ooh!" Scorpia pops up, pallor already back to normal somehow. "And then we could have cute little magnetic pictures of all of us that we can put on the board! Kinda like the chore chart!"

"Y'mean the same chore chart half of you guys ignore?"

Adora pouts. "I missed cleaning the engines one time, Glimmer."

Sea Hawk just laughs, ignoring the seven glares immediately sent his way. "My dear sweet Mermista, that's a wonderful idea! I'll check in with Netossa and Frosta in the cargo bay, perhaps there's some scraps in there we could use!"

He darts out of the room before anyone can stop him. As his footsteps recede further into the ship, Adora slowly pushes herself to sit up, frowning in confusion.

"Did… did he miss the part where we all agreed he's no longer allowed to pilot?"

"Shushie," Glimmer shushes her. "We all just almost died, again, we all just very nearly crashed and almost died again, again, like four separate times, the obnoxious loud man is finally gone. It's quiet time now."

Mermista groans as she slides down the wall and leans her head back, eyes closing. "I'm good with that."

“Someone who’s not me should message the team moms and tell them to keep him occupied,” Catra gurgles. “And also turn off the damn lights.”

Entrapta groggily extends a pigtail and flips the light switch with one strand of hair while the other punches the intercom. Perfuma, who sat closest to the small woman, sighs and sits up to speak into the mic when it becomes clear that Entrapta wasn’t going to talk.

“Main bay to cargo bay,” she calls, rubbing her forehead. “Can you guys keep Sea Hawk… um… occupied somehow?”

“That depends,” Netossa gruffly responds, also sounding fairly winded. “By ‘occupied’ do you mean I have permission to lock him down here while the three of us go find a place to nap?”

Every set of eyes turns to find Mermista, who stubbornly keeps hers closed even as she frowns at the attention. After a moment, she finally groans and peaks an eye open just to roll it.

“Yes, fine, whatever. I’ll go let him out in an hour.”

“Works for me.”

And then finally, blissful silence rains down on them all.

• 💥 🌎 💫 •

“One hour was definitely not enough,” Catra grumbles sourly over her bowl of stew.

The sentiment is silently echoed across nearly every other crewmate gathered in the ship’s cafeteria, all hunched over their own bowls and all nursing the exact same headache.

“Ooh! Perhaps the Star Trot Galaxy next!” Sea Hawk offers with the same ecstatic energy he’d been displaying since their collective near-death experience. He stands at their holoscreen, scrolling through the assortment of universes they’d charted and

cataloged. “Or no, wait, this universe looks much more enticing! Supposedly, the majority of species here are all dragons! And they’re sentient!”

“Yeah, because we’ve only ever had *good* experiences with sentient dragons,” Adora grumps, eyeing the fresh bandage on her leg that hid a nasty burn from view. It would heal just fine, but she might be adding a new scar to her collection (not that she was opposed).

Sea Hawk hums. “Ah, it appears this universe has several planets made entirely of water! Mermista, what do you think?”

Mermista eyes the now completely spikey puffball growling over her stew. “I think you’re gambling with death, right now.”

“A gamble we all make on the regular,” he chortles, but dutifully swipes away that particular suggestion. The spikey growling puffball slowly returns to her normal, not quite as spikey or puffball-y state. He lights up yet again. “Oo-hoo-hoo! A universe where the elements are channeled through entire nations and not just one individual! That sounds like a fabulous time!”

Eyeing the man over her shoulder as he continues to babble on endlessly about adventure after adventure, Perfuma leans in and whispers to the rest of the table.

“I strongly suggest that our next adventure includes nothing but us returning home and sleeping for two months straight.”

“Oh thank the stars someone said something,” Scorpia quietly moans with relief, slumping beside her bowl. “Yes please, I like that plan.”

Entrapta, face flat against the table, lifts a finger and softly utters the first real words she’s spoken all day. “I agree with that motion. No more universes please.”

“The only universe I want right now is our universe,” Frosta mutters under her breath, rubbing her temples and glaring into

her stew.

Netossa flumps against Spinnerella's shoulder. "I second… all of that. I want our bed back."

"Same here," Spinnerella murmurs as she rests her head against Netossa's.

"Oh, please tell me this decision is unanimous," Catra pleads, clasping her hands in front of her face. A reverberating tired mewl sound from under the table as Melog echoes the sentiment from where he's curled on Catra's lap.

Adora eyes the still excitedly babbling Sea Hawk. "I don't think that's going to be possible."

"He doesn't get a vote," Glimmer grits out through the fakest smile she's ever mustered.

Sea Hawk crows so loudly everyone jumps.

"I've got it!!" He steps aside and shows off his newest pick. "This universe experiences the strange phenomenon that we simply must go and see for ourselves! Miniature black holes, on! Planet!"

Everyone, one by one, turns and glares at the man, who only barely shrinks back at the clear disapproval reflected in every single person.

Except Entrapta, who remains face down on the table.

"What if…" Perfuma hums, her patience clearly fraying. Honestly, it was a surprise she hadn't yet snapped. "We just went back home for a few months instead, dear?"

Sea Hawk's mustache droops, and he again emphatically gestures to the holoscreen.

"But—! My friends! Think of all of the adventures we still have yet to experience—!"

"Which will still be there waiting for us after we've taken a break," Mermista interjects, eyeing him warningly. He goes to insist yet again, but with the simple raise of her eyebrow, his mouth closes again.

He takes another glance around the table, and finally, he gives in. Sighing mightily, he shuts down the holoscreen.

"Oh," he heaves another breath. "Very well. I suppose our grand adventures… could be put off for sometime longer."

Everyone else heaves a great big sigh of relief, but Mermista just frowns.

"I suppose, um…" he moves to shuffle out of the room, readjusting the ascot around his neck. "I suppose I'll go ensure our things are all still… secured and ready for… um… for takeoff."

"Well, have fun with that," Catra grumps. Adora smacks her and she just shrugs.

Mermista sighs. As Sea Hawk moves to slump past her to get to the doorway, she reaches out and snags him by his jacket sleeve. He glances over, then his eyes widen as she yanks him down and snatches a kiss from him. He hums, happily surprised, and by the time they pull away from each other he's grinning sheepishly and no longer slouched.

She smirks at him. "Quit pouting, you doofus. There are still plenty of adventures to be had in our universe."

Slowly, his exuberant energy makes a return. "You're right," he says, at first still soft and caught off guard. Then, he straightens, and his boisterous bravado is back. "My dearest Mermista, you are right! I must be off to make plans! Ooh, there's so many places to uncover for you and I!"

With a renewed bounce in his step, he speedily makes his way back out into the corridor. Mermista shakes her head, but her smile is still present.

When she turns back to the table, everyone is gawking at her.

"I think I keep forgetting you're like *actually* in love with him," Catra mutters.

She just shrugs. "Fair enough. I keep forgetting why people tolerate you."

Adora immediately lasers in on her with a deadly glare, but Catra just snorts, cackling.

"Eh. Your guess is as good as mine."

Chapter End Notes

> Okay listen LISTEN I KNOW this is obviously not what the prompt was supposed to be about
>
> But like
>
> It technically still fits?
>
> It's a *ship*
> That *crosses universes*
>
> :D
>
> In my defense they're all too in love with each other to be in love with anyone else I'm sorry I just couldn't do it 😔

Alt. Canon - X00 Years Earlier

Chapter Notes

> Shoutout to my sister, who brainstormed with me until I managed to come up with this literal moments before scrambling to write it all down and get it posted in time

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It had taken her a little over five days to stop bursting into tears at random. She got the feeling her new… um… teammates? She got the feeling they were all secretly relieved, though none of them ever said anything.

Adora missed her brother. And Mom, and Dad, and Teela… she missed them all so much. She didn't understand why she'd been taken away, or where they even were anymore. Hordak—apparently he was a lord??—never told her anything, and Shadow Weaver seemed nice enough but she wouldn't say anything either. All she ever said was that Adora was destined for great things, but she didn't know what that meant either.

She feels the tears welling up again as she curls into the corner of her new bed, significantly less comfortable than the one she'd had back home in the palace. She'd stopped sharing a room with Adam when they both turned seven last year, and her bed had been *huge* and plush and *sooo* comfy. It was big enough that her whole family could fit on it, and just a few nights before that weird light and the giant spider had taken her away, that's what they'd all been doing, sleeping over in her room and laughing over a funny story Dad was telling them.

He'd left it on a cliffhanger, promising to continue the tale the next time they had a sleepover.

What if now, she never got to know how Dad's story ended?

What if she never got to see Dad again?

What if she never got to see *any* of her family again?

"I don't want to be here," she chokes out to the empty room. Her chest seizes, and the tears begin to fall yet again. She curls up even tighter into the thin blue blanket left on her bunk, her new bed for the next… however long it would be, in a cold, scary room that would house so many other people that she didn't know, and didn't want to get to know.

She just wanted…

"I want to go *home*," she wails, her voice bouncing off the walls. "I want to go home I want my Mama and Papa! I wanna go *home!*"

But no one was there to hear her. No one was there to dry her tears and hug her, or whisper to her that the bad would go away eventually and the good would replace it, then things would be okay. No one was there to sing to her until she calmed down, to make her laugh once the tears were spent. No one was there to hug her, to stroke her hair as she slowly dozed off.

And she worried no one ever would be.

None of her new roommates are too thrilled when they get back to find her crying her heart out yet again.

• ✨ 🌈 🚀 •

After the third week of being in the Horde, Adora finally came to accept that her family was gone, and this was her new norm.

But something interesting had caught her interest, something that kept her mind from lingering too long on the knowledge that she'd officially lost everything and everyone and was never getting them back. Yes, her new training was doing a pretty good job of that, but it wasn't what intrigued her.

Rumors of "The Stray" haunting the Fright Zone were doing that instead.

Okay, "haunting" was maybe pushing it. But with how other cadets, soldiers, and even captains went on about The Stray, there was a chance it wasn't too far off.

"Didja see what happened to Captain Octavia?" Lonnie, one of Adora's new roomma— new *squad*mates, leans in to whisper as they line up for their midday rations. Rations were disgusting, absolutely nothing like the full-course meals the chefs cooked or even just the homemade sandwiches that Mom made, but she'd learned the hard way that it was ration bars or starve. She'd… rather not do that. So, absolutely disgusting ration bars it was. At least the gray kinds weren't quite as bad as the rest. Still, if she ever made it home, she'd never complain about eating veggies ever again.

In response to Lonnie's question, she shakes her head. The other girl snickers, but goes quiet as she receives her handful of rations, and waits for Adora and the small caimisk boy behind her—another in their squad—to get theirs as well. As they go to sit down with the scrawny blonde boy that had been in front of Lonnie—the last of their squad—Lonnie turns back to grin at Adora.

"Okay okay, so you know how she's been super absent lately?" At Adora's nod as they sit down, Lonnie excitedly continues, something of a feral grin spreading across her lips. "She's in the infirmary right now. I heard that jerk had another run in with The Stray, and The Stray finally decided to get revenge."

Adora pauses chewing, eyes widening. With her mouth still full, she mumbles nervously, "What… what happened to her?"

"I heard The Stray leapt up into the rafters, where Octavia and her tentacles can't reach cuz she's too fat to get up there, then The Stray kept swiping at her with knife-sharp claws, until finally they pounced, and…" Curling her fingers into something resembling claws, Lonnie drags them along one of her eyes while making a squelching sound with her tongue, and Adora shudders and drops the rest of her ration bar.

Lonnie starts cackling. “Look at her face!” she elbows the blonde boy, who just sort of smiles nervously. “I told you the newbie wouldn’t have the balls to stomach that story!”

“N-no way!” Adora insists, leaping to her feet with palms flat on the table. “That didn’t scare me, Lonnie! It didn’t scare me at all!”

“Yeah, right,” she grins. “Maybe its a blonde thing. Kyle’s heard that story a million times now, everyone’s talking about it, and he *still* looks like he’s about to piss his pants.”

“I d-do not!” the boy squeaks, folding his arms. The caimisk sitting beside Adora—she thinks his name is… Rolland? Rodrigo?—gurgles something in his own language, one Adora definitely hasn’t had the chance to learn yet, but Kyle seems to get at least some of it. He gestures his arms at the other boy and insists, “See? Rogelio knows I wasn’t scared!”

Rogelio rolls his eyes, but no one acknowledges it.

“If you say so,” Lonnie rolls her eyes and shoves the last half of her second ration bar in her mouth, chewing quickly and swallowing even faster. “You two scaredy-cat blondes are gonna wanna hurry up. We only have five more minutes.”

Eyes widening, Kyle scrambles to finish his rations. But Adora can only think of what Lonnie just told her, about Octavia and her eye… and The Stray.

The time for midday rations comes to an end, and Adora has to throw away the rations she couldn’t choke down this time.

She doesn’t know if she’s imagining the evil glowing eyes following her from the shadows.

• ✨ 🌈 🚀 •

The longer Adora spends here, the more she hears about The Stray, and the more terrified she gets. Every day is plagued with worry that she’ll be the next person The Stray pounces on from

above, her eyes the pair The Stray goes after next. Rumors had quickly spread that The Stray went after eyes because they wanted to find a replacement for themself, a new one to finally give them a matching pair as opposed to the two differing ones they currently had. And the more stories Adora hears about The Stray, the more certain she becomes that she's next, even if no one's reported missing an eye since Octavia was attacked.

She sees The Stray's eyes one day, and her terror only skyrockets.

The Stray had one yellow eye… and one *blue*.

If they really were going after people to try and get themself a new eye to finally have a matching pair, Adora's blue eyes would make her the perfect target.

She starts screaming anytime she hears creaking in the walls or vents, but even though it annoys other people, she just can't contain her fears. She doesn't want to lose her eyes, she doesn't want to be attacked.

She wants her Mom and Dad and Adam. She doesn't want to be here.

Unfortunately, being terrified of a creature that most people never even saw was not a good enough reason to excuse her from training, or interacting with other people, or… any of this crazy new life.

And missing her family wasn't a good enough reason either.

But just like when she'd first learned of The Stray, things start to change again when she actually *meets* them.

Because of how drastically she'd been falling behind in her training (regardless of her reasons for falling behind) she's saddled with two straight weeks of janitorial duties. She hates it, hates it more than anything, because being stuck on janitorial duties not only meant she had to clean the bathrooms all by herself (and had to do it perfectly, at that), but she had to clean

her entire squad's quadrant, even the outer sections where The Stray had been spotted time, and time, and time again.

Including the platform where Octavia had been attacked.

Every night before bed, Adora trembles and shakes as she hurries through her duties, constantly eyeing the ceiling in fear of an oncoming ambush. Her terror only grows with every night that nothing happens, because that only meant it could happen some other time. She wasn't safe here. She wants her parents, and her brother. She wants someone to hold her and hug her and *help* her. She wants…

She wants…

…

She wants a friend.

No sooner does she have this thought, on the sixth night of her first week of janitorial duties, does she hear something… violent happening down the hall, and she jumps at the pained screams she can hear.

Against her better judgment… the moment her legs start to work again, she quietly shuffles towards the noise. Her shaking gets worse the closer she gets; further down this path lies the landing where Octavia had been jumped. Was The Stray back? Were they attacking someone? She hears another cry of agony, the voice young and scratchy and… stars, they sound *terrified*, just as terrified as Adora feels.

But then she hears another voice, one that was somewhat familliar, but…

"You little *rat!* Get back here and just *die already!!!*"

Adora had never heard Shadow Weaver sound like *that* before.

She hears a sound like electricity zapping, then hears another young scream, just as she reaches the entrance to the landing and tentatively sticks her head out.

Her eyes widen at what she sees.

A small, furry child, with cat ears and a cat tail, naked but for a tattered pair of shorts that were too small for them and had clearly been fished out of the trash, bounds across the platform on all fours to evade another blast of red lightning, just barely ducking out of the way of a surge of shadows next. There's a large, ugly, and bleeding gash carved into her side that stretches along the curve of their ribs, and there are even more lacerations along the rest of their body, albeit much smaller. They have an unkempt mane of wild brown hair, the same color as their tail and the ridge of fur along their spine…

And when they turn on a dime, Adora gasps at the sight of The Stray's blue and gold eyes.

Wait… this child, who couldn't possibly be older than Adora herself, who was small and scrawny and scared and pretty badly injured, was The Stray.

This was who had the entire Fright Zone on edge and paranoid? This was who had Adora convinced her sweet young life was surely over, or at least her career as a person with perfect vision was?

Shadow Weaver straightens, and for the first time tonight Adora gets a glimpse of her normally peaceful and serene mask.

And her stomach plummets.

In the past month that she'd been here, she'd come to think of Shadow Weaver as a strict but at least trustworthy person, one who always showed her favor and kindness and showered her with praise when she did something right. She's never heard the woman raise her voice, has never seen her wield the magic that supposedly had granted her the position of the Horde's second in

command, had never known any reason to mistrust or fear the woman… until now.

Its the exact same mask it always was, but now the red crystal on the forehead glows so bright it bathes the face in unholy red. The black of the mask seems to reach out with shadows, and the whites reflecting her eyes seem like mere pinpricks amidst the sea of darkness.

Adora's terror resurfaces, but for once, it wasn't because of The Stray.

It was *for* them.

"I will have your *head!*" Shadow Weaver wails, lashing out with another whip of shadow and sending a current of red lightning coursing through it, and though The Stray manages to avoid the brunt of it, it still clips them across the shoulder, and they cry out in pain again as they stumble to the floor, their momentum skidding them across the green panels and leaving a large streak of blood in its wake.

Adora flinches, clasping a hand over her mouth to keep from making a sound.

The Stray recovers surprisingly quickly, heaving for breath, and only just barely manages to dart out of the way of another attack. Clearly growing desperate, eyes wide and panicked as they heave for breath, they frantically look for any way of escape, their gaze bouncing back and forth to look for *something*.

Adora didn't know how Dad's story ended. It was a story of a brave hero, one who saw someone in need, and despite her own fears decided to act. She didn't know if the hero in the story saved the person in need. She never would.

But she could imagine.

Gritting her teeth, despite the terror threatening to drown her out completely, Adora chooses to act, and sticks herself further out

from her hiding place.

Shadow Weaver is turned away from her, but The Stray spots her, and their eyes widen.

Adora holds out a hand, and The Stray makes a decision.

Shadow Weaver lunges with a cry for the kit, and they leap backward to push off of the wall and launch themself out of the reach of her clawed fingers, landing on her back. They thrust their paws into the witch, driving themselves forward and her tumbling to the ground, and with her momentarily stunned they scramble up the landing to reach Adora's side.

Adora doesn't flinch when The Stray skids to a halt in front of her, panting so hard their tongue lolls from their jaws, but her hand does drop a little. Hearing Shadow Weaver groan on the landing resparks her moment of courage, and instead of waiting for The Stray to take her hand, she reaches forward and gently takes hold of theirs.

Their paw pads are hot and damp to the touch, but Adora doesn't care. The panic in their eyes has dimmed, and shock and tentative hope have for the moment taken its place.

Adora finds herself much preferring that expression.

"Get… *back… HEEERRREE!!!*" Shadow Weaver shrieks, the end of the hallway suddenly growing dark with shadow.

Adora squeezes her mop in one hand, squeezes The Stray's hand in the other, and *runs*.

Chapter End Notes

> So like I said in the first set of notes, I only JUST BARELY came up with this AU, but now I'm in love with it and want to make it it's own thing in the future

I REALLY want to explore this further so maybe once Inktober is over I'll be able to do something with this! I doubt it would be a super big AU, probably just a lengthy one shot, but we shall see! Maybe I'll accidentally develop it way more than I want to and it'll be a whole thing sksbdkdn

Alt. Canon - Lasting Impressions

Chapter Notes

First of all, thank you guys for being so patient and understanding with the chapter delay, I truly did appreciate that a lot

Unfortunately, I only have yesterday's chapter actually complete, despite initially wanting to have both yesterday's and today's done

Yesterday's chapter FOUGHT me and it fought d i r t y

I kept writing and rewriting and re-rewriting until finally I gave up on the idea I'd managed to scrounge together and came up with this, but by that point I was too tired to do much with it, and didn't have time to get two chapters done like I'd wanted

So unfortunately, there's another chapter delay

THE GOOD NEWS HOWEVER

I figured out what I want to do for the next prompt! It was a struggle trying to figure out what I wanted, but while I was writing with my friend I managed to figure something out! I'm really looking forward to writing it, and hoping that these last few prompts will be a breeze to get through

Thank you all again for your patience and kindness!

Woe, new chapter upon ye


See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora had fairly easily come to terms with the fact that Catra was just different now.

She would never agree with the others, who all pointed and laughed at Catra, calling her crazy. She knew she wasn't, knew that when she near violently insisted that she was telling the truth, she was. She knew that, for as far fetched of an idea as it was that this could be reality, Catra wasn't lying, or stretching the truth, or just making things up to get people off her back.

Catra wasn't one to flaunt anything she didn't actually have, for no other reason than she didn't see the point. She'd never given Adora any reason to doubt what she was saying beforehand, even if every time she hissed out "I'm fine" the blonde believed it less and less. But this? Oh, she believed this.

And in part, it was because there simply was no other explanation for the odd things that had been happening to her since she was around nine years old.

Catra got picked on and bullied a *lot*. Even more than Kyle did. Adora had long since lost count of all the times they'd huddled on her bunk, with the kit sobbing and shaking in Adora's arms as the blonde wrapped stolen bandages around her bruised gashes all received from people who incorrectly assumed they were far superior to her, who assumed she was worth nothing and assumed that meant they should remind her of such. Constantly.

But one day something changed, something Adora still didn't fully understand even years later. Catra was being ganged up on again, she herself was trying futilely to save her friend, and then out of nowhere the temperature began to climb rapidly, climbing higher and higher and higher until in a matter of seconds it felt like they were all inside an incinerator.

Adora remembers looking back to her friend, and seeing instead of panic a strange, almost enchanted peace. Not calm, not joy, but instead some sort of mix of confusion… and relief. Something else that was strange; Catra's eyes almost seemed to genuinely be glowing. They focused not on Adora, but on something just above Adora's head, confusion and relief and surprise and—strangely—hope shining in them.

And then those eyes darted around following something the blonde couldn't see, as one by one the people attacking her all started screaming in pain and scrambling to get away from Catra as fast as possible. Parts of their clothes were incinerated and actively on fire, but Adora and Catra were fine.

Catra had seemed shocked, but… not surprised.

Adora hadn't asked, and Catra hadn't explained, but ever since that day… it was like she could see something that wasn't there. They'd be talking, or laughing over something, and then Catra would just stop and look past Adora, and a strange expression would cross her face.

Catra was ganged up on again a few days later, but the exact same thing happened. The burns that her attackers got were severe enough they were submitted to the infirmary. All of them.

That time, Adora *had* asked. But Catra still hadn't answered. She'd almost seemed… anxious.

It happened again several days later. It happened again a week after that. Eventually, it got to the point where if anyone who wasn't Adora even tried approaching the kit, regardless of their intentions, the temperature would spike. It wouldn't take long for the strange heat to start distorting the air around them. No one was sure what was happening, no one was sure why it was happening, no one had any idea what was causing it, but everyone figured out pretty quickly that the fastest way to experience the damned invisible flames was to mess with the alienated kitten.

But finally, after almost a month, an explanation was given.

"It's ghosts," Catra had murmured to Adora one night as they were supposed to be turning in for bed. "That's why things have been… kinda weird lately. There's a few ghosts hanging around, now. I think I'm the only one who can see them."

Adora had shot up, staring at the kit in alarm, but Catra hadn't been looking at her. Her hand had been extended, her eyes clearly focused on something that Adora couldn't see, and she'd been calm. That was almost more terrifying than her statement; Catra was never calm. And… ghosts?

"Catra," Adora had nervously began, and with that alone the kit had tensed and the blonde had known she'd already messed up. She'd almost rushed to explain that she believed her, that the idea that it was ghosts made perfect sense actually, but she didn't actually manage to say any of that. The fear inside Adora that had long since tied itself to ghosts steeled her tongue, and all she'd managed instead is, "I don't… are you sure?"

She'd felt the peculiar heat before, but never had it stung *her*. The moment she challenged Catra's experience was the first time she'd felt the invisible fire and was actually harmed by it. Catra had glared at her, and the air around them had quickly begun to distort and waver from the heat. The very bed itself had suddenly felt like embers licking at her skin, and through the distortions she'd for only a moment seen four lifeless pairs of eyes hovering around her friend. She'd flinched back from the heat and the scare so hard she'd fallen off the mattress, landing hard on the startlingly cold floor. Catra had quickly leapt over to help her up, but was clearly still upset.

"Look, I get it," she'd huffed, tail lashing angrily as she'd pulled Adora back onto the bed, then quickly let her go to fold her arms and glare away from her. "To you it probably just looks like I'm going crazy. But I'm not! The ghosts are real! They're real, and they're… they *like* me, they like *helping* me, and… and I like them, so you better not—"

"Are there four of them?" Adora had quietly interrupted, and Catra's eyes had widened as she'd whipped back around.

"Can you see them all too?"

She'd shaken her head. "No, but… for a minute, I thought I saw…" She'd sighed and tentatively reached for Catra's hand. Catra hadn't pulled away. "I wasn't calling you crazy. Of course you're not. And I believe you when you say there's ghosts. I just… the only ghosts I've ever heard of are the ones in the stories, and… and those ghosts are…"

Catra had relaxed and rolled her eyes. "Dummy. *Those* ones *are* fake. There's no such thing as the Weeping Princess or the Headless Princess. And even if they did exist, I bet we could beat 'em up." She'd looked up, again relaxing to that oddly calm state. "Especially with these guys on our side."

Adora had looked up, too, trying to see them again. But, aside from a brief waver in the air roughly where Catra had been looking, there was nothing. She must have wilted, momentarily disappointed, and Catra had seen it.

"Being able to see ghosts—especially nice ones—sounds *so* cool."

Without uttering a word, Catra had turned away again, and reached out a pawed hand. She'd wrapped it around something Adora couldn't see, and lowered it down to where Adora's free hand rested. Her fingers had loosed whatever she'd been holding…

And then the feeling of a large, warm hand gently took hold of Adora's, and she'd gasped softly. She'd tried to squeeze back, on instinct, but without a physical hand there to hold, she was slightly out of luck. That didn't stop the warm and gentle hand from squeezing back, and it also didn't stop the ghost from reaching out with their other hand to cup Adora's cheek, their thumb brushing over her skin with the delicate touch she'd only ever dreamed of receiving.

Then another, almost hesitant touch, one that hadn't been as clear as the first two but was still obviously there, rested for a moment at Adora's back. This hand hadn't been as large as the first, but it had been just as gentle, if not more so. The hand had

slowly shifted, to pull both Catra and Adora in for a hug at once, and the other two touches had joined in, with the fourth not clear enough to be felt physically but still very much there.

And suddenly, from that moment on, the blissful calm Catra had begun exuding made perfect and total sense.

Turns out, she'd been right. There were exactly four ghosts, according to Catra, and each one had their own distinct presence and clear personality, even if she'd only been able to clearly identify two of them thus far. She hadn't figured out their names yet, but she had figured out what letters started off the names of the two she'd identified.

The ghost who had cradled Adora's hand and cheek so tenderly, the one most responsible for helping both herself and Catra feel that blessed calm even with everything going on around them, was "L." The ghost who was responsible for the protective fiery heat, the one that defended the kit as fiercely as a mama bear defended her cubs, was "C." The other two ghosts Catra hadn't managed to figure out all that much about yet, but even with what little she had figured out, Adora even began to recognize and differentiate which one was present and when, even still without seeing them.

They officially meet "M" when Shadow Weaver finally strikes again.

In all the chaos of the ghosts and the defensive invisible fire warding off any threats, they'd both kind of forgotten about her. That was their first mistake. And their worst. Somehow, Shadow Weaver had come to the conclusion that the fault of the burns so many soldiers and cadets had reported receiving was to be placed all on Catra.

And no matter how hot the room got, nothing was able to stop Shadow Weaver's lightning.

“Please, stop!” Adora cries as Catra wails in agony. “Stop it, it wasn’t her fault!!”

Patches of flames eat at Shadow Weaver’s clothes and skin, but with a wave of her free hand a wash of frigid cold darkness extinguishes the fires before they can do much more than sting. It was equally as chilling how calm the witch’s voice was even as she continued attacking the kit. “My dear, am I to assume it was *you* who burned our fellow soldiers? Of *course* it was this rat, Adora. Every single victim said the exact same thing, said that it was this pathetic runt that burnt them and forced them off duty.”

“It wasn’t her!” Adora insists. “It was ghosts!”

That successfully got Weaver to stop, letting Catra crash to the floor seizing, but suddenly all of the witch’s fury was turned on Adora, and she felt herself yearning to shrivel away and hide. She forces herself to stand tall as her mentor looms over her, icy claws of darkness digging into her skin as the cruel but steady hand grips at her face.

“You should know better than to lie to me, child,” Weaver hisses.

She doesn’t torture Adora the way she does Catra. She never *ever* hurts Adora the way she hurts Catra.

But that doesn’t mean they aren’t both shaking and sobbing by the time night has again fallen and the two are curled up tight on Adora’s bed. L’s gentle touch helps to soothe them some, and C’s fire is tender and controlled as an attempt to warm them both. The terror and the pain still remain.

But then a third presence, a third set of hands, comes to gently rest on Catra’s raised fleshy wounds. She hisses, tensing, but then seems to slowly relax, sinking into the mattress and Adora’s careful hold, as the third set of hands begin to dance in a steady rhythm over where the pain is at its worst. Before Adora can wonder too long what the third presence was doing, one of the ghost’s hands moves to rest on her back, and almost like magic,

the pain starts to die down, replaced by something like a golden warmth, almost like a mix of L and C's presences.

This was the ghost that had started the hug when Adora first met them all.

"'M,'" Catra mumbles, her teeth still chattering as her body continues to shake, even as the pain continued to die down. Even the wounds themselves didn't look as bad anymore. "Your… your name starts with 'M.'"

For just a fraction of a second, Adora almost thinks she sees M's silhouette. But then she blinks, and the image is gone.

Curious, though, she asks as she cuddles closer to Catra, "Can… can you see them?"

Catra nods, still stiff, but not as bad as she was earlier.

"Does M… does she have a ponytail?"

Her eyes widen. "Y… yeah. It's not like yours, it's longer and… different, but I don't know how to explain it. Are you sure you can't see them?"

She shakes her head. "Not like you can. I can sometimes see a little bit, but only for a second or two. It's never usually long enough to actually see what they look like."

Warmth envelops the two children. The soothing calm washes over them. The healing embrace scoops them both up. Slowly, achingly slowly, the two children begin to be lulled to sleep.

"Can I tell you what they look like?" Catra asks quietly.

Adora grins. "You better. It's not fair that only you get to see them all the time."

Catra smiles back.

She starts to tell Adora everything she can about what the ghosts look like, about how three of them look like *her*, how the fourth has the same eyes as Adora. She tells her about what colors the rest of their eyes are, tells her about how pretty their fur is, how pretty the one human is even without fur. And Adora listens, soaking it all in and wishing she could see the ghosts just as clearly, wishing it was more than just their touch that she could register.

The fact that she'd so confidently stated that ghosts were involved and responsible will come back to bite them. Cadets and soldiers alike will mock and jeer them, targeting Catra especially as always, no matter how many times they're burnt or feel their ears ringing from haunting ghostly screams. But it won't matter. They have each other, and the ghosts seem all too happy to do everything in their power to keep it that way.

And for now… it's enough.

Chapter End Notes

If this one read a little more messy than usual I apologize, like I said before I had to FIGHT this one tooth and nail

Despite that, I've accidentally created YET ANOTHER AU that I want to flesh out at some point

Again the question is if I'll be able to do anything with it or not, but we shall see!

I genuinely hope you guys enjoyed all of these so far!

Alt. Canon - Unused Character Backstory

Chapter Notes

> Two chapters for the price of one babyyy (I'm sorry this is so late that was not intentional)
>
> BUT I ACTUALLY DO HAVE BOTH CHAPTERS READY THIS TIME, NO MORE DELAYS

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Kyle doubted anyone actually remembered the scouting trip their squadron had taken just a few months ago. After all, aside from him, no one had found anything worthy of remembering. Well, Catra claimed to have found a cool animal that very nearly bit her eye out, but other than that, it was a fairly lackluster expedition.

For everyone but him.

He was pretty sure the outing was less of a scouting practice run and more of a punishment for not meeting stupidly high standards. It was a suspicion of his even before they'd been loaded into the back of a Horde transport truck and dropped in the middle of absolute nowhere in the woods, but he was fairly certain everyone else held the same suspicions and so stayed quiet. He didn't super feel like being grilled for stating the obvious again.

Luckily, it doesn't take long for things to start happening, as Adora quickly takes charge of the situation like she'd known all along what to do.

"Okay. We're treating this like our first ever official mission, which means we need to prepare for at least one or two nights spent out here. First off, we'll do a perimeter check to make sure the area is secure, then secondly we'll split up to gather supplies for food, fire, and shelter. Catra, Rogelio, you two have the best eyesight out of all of us, so you two are on perimeter check."

Rogelio nods with an affirmative grunt, but Catra just rolls her eyes.

"Ugh, perimeter check sounds so *boring* though," she grumbles. Her eyes light up mischievously, and before anyone can react she leaps up into the trees, disappearing from sight completely. With the rustling of a few branches, she's gone.

Lonnie sighs, rubbing at her eyes. "Well, we all know *she's* clearly not gonna listen to instructions. What do you want the rest of us to do?"

Shaking her head but unable to help a somewhat amused tugging at her lips, Adora brushes her hair back and turns back to the others. "I guess… let's all assist with the perimeter check. Its not too dark out just yet so we should all be able to see just fine. Don't wander too far, keep an eye out for anything that can be used as kindling or tinder, and… I guess we'll figure out what to do for food whenever Catra gets back."

Kyle, Rogelio, and Lonnie all salute, and with a nod, Adora turns away from them, picks a random path, and sets out. Once she's been out of sight for a full minute and they can no longer hear her, Lonnie grits her teeth and clenches her fists.

"One of these days, I'm going to skin that cat alive."

The three of them had split not long after that. Kyle wasn't *thrilled* to be heading away from everyone else, especially in a location *none of them* had *ever* been in before, but… He could do this! He could totally do this! The other four always made fun of him for not being able to do *anything* right, so… He could totally do this. It was just patrolling anyway. Anyone could do it.

He turns in a tight circle, trying to figure out which way to go and getting lost in indecision. When he turns a very specific way and feels something… almost calling to him, he tentatively makes a decision, and heads down that way.

He tries to pay careful attention to his surroundings as he stumbles through underbrush and ducks beneath low-hanging branches. Some of the trees look like they have bark dry enough to peel off and use as kindling, maybe he could get some of that on his way back. There are several areas thick with a special kind of moss he'd read about, one that would be beneficial in keeping the bugs off of them when they went to sleep that night. There are a number of trees with branches far too heavy for the tree to keep up and healthy, maybe Rogelio could break them off and they could use the wood for a fire or shelter. He keeps regularly whipping out his compass, probably more times than necessary, but he did *not* want to get lost out here, and each step he took he was more and more certain that that was exactly what was going to happen.

A random bird he doesn't know the name of squawks overhead and he yelps, startling. It doesn't help that the branches rustle menacingly afterward, like something big and dangerous was up there. He jogs to get away from the area, and only moves faster when he hears a deep growling sound. Okay. Predators. Adora would probably like to know about that. Maybe, if Rogelio and Catra both rested while the others built the shelter and took care of food, the two of them could stay up tonight and keep an eye out for any dangerous animals.

He honestly isn't sure how long he's been at this. Time gets weird when you're all alone in the freaking woods. The strange calling feeling, one that isn't uncomfortable or even really disconcerting but is still definitely strange, continues to urge him past large roots—those could potentially be edible—and over small mounds and hills, subtly growing stronger and stronger with each step he takes. There's a really good chance he's being an idiot by listening to it, but he's so curious to know what this is that's calling him. He isn't really sure he knows how to describe the feeling, but for some reason…

He feels like the feeling is silver? Like, in color?

"What the hell does a *silvery feeling* even mean?" He mumbles to himself, brushing aside another low-hanging branch. The feeling suddenly sharpens, coaxing him to turn and press forward through two strange trees. The sudden sharpening throws him off a little and he stumbles, but surprisingly he recovers his footing decently fast, and steps towards the two trees. It's lighter past them, he wonders if he's somehow reached a clearing or even the edge of the forest.

He steps through, the feeling magnifying yet again, and he freezes.

He didn't find a clearing or the edge of the forest. Instead, he found a sharp, jutting out rock, the top of a cliff he hadn't realized he was high enough up to stumble across.

And buried close to the edge, lies a massive blade with a silver handle.

It was glowing, and something like a million tiny whispers were circling around the blade.

"Whoa," he whimpers, swallowing nervously. "This is… this is *definitely* magic."

His voice cracked about seven different times as he spoke, but he for once pays it no mind. For some stupid reason, despite knowing how dangerous and unstable magic was, he finds himself slowly approaching the blade, drawn in more and more as the blue glow flares with each step he takes.

He's right beside it before he even realizes.

"I… I definitely should not grab this," he says, before reaching out and grabbing the hilt.

The world goes white. Well, it goes rainbow. Slices of a life he knew but at the same time didn't flash through his mind's eye, all of them going by far too quickly for him to make heads or tails of any of it. But then, images start to clear, words emerge from the

chaos, the sight of a man larger and stronger than any he'd ever seen stands before him with piercing blue eyes, offering Kyle the hilt of the blade.

He takes it, the man coaxes him to speak, and so he does.

Something explodes. It might have been him. The lights fade, bringing him back to reality with the sword still gripped tightly in his hands.

Hands that… were suddenly much… *much* bigger. And thicker. And…

He looks down, and his jaw drops.

Rippling pectorals and chiseled abs bulge beneath his huntsman furs. A glance at his arms shows shoulders and biceps and forearms even larger than Rogelio's, leading to gauntleted hands that could cleanly crush stone. Further down, he sees thighs that could snap tree trunks, calves that could smash through buildings, feet that could take him around the world.

A name echoes through his mind, and tentatively he speaks it aloud.

"I… am… He-Man." He lifts the sword up, and sees his reflection in the blade. His face is no longer skinny and gaunt, instead he now has a jawline so sharp it rivaled the strength of Catra's claws, cheekbones so perfect any man, woman, or anyone in between would swoon the moment they saw him, perfect eyebrows and piercing green-blue eyes, with a perfect mop of golden hair atop his head. He begins to smile, and the smile widens until he is beaming up at himself. Thrusting the blade into the air, he cries, "I am He-Man!! I have the *power!!!!*"

This was *amazing*. Holy *everything* this was *amazing!!*

He could feel it. For the first time in his entire life, he was *strong*, probably even *stronger* than anyone else on the squad. Maybe even in the entire Horde! He gasps, cupping his mouth. He

wondered… maybe he was stronger than Hordak. Maybe he was stronger than *Shadow Weaver*.

He could finally be useful. He could be helpful, he could be the best teammate his friends had ever seen! Holy crap, he could feel the power racing through him, he could *feel* the mighty energy begging to be loosed.

Giving into temptation, he swings the blade forward, and it flows naturally in his grip. Letting out an excited giggle, he swings it again, and again, and again. The sword felt like an extension of himself, like for as long as he'd been alive he'd been missing a limb that finally he'd reconnected with.

I could save people with this, he realizes, and his excitement grows. He slashes through the air again, laughing exuberantly. He's dancing on the edge of the cliff, but for once he trusts his feet to keep him from tripping on nothing. They maneuver beneath him like they were programmed to be magnificent, and his giddiness only surges more and more. He peers out over the drop, but the sheer distance to the ground doesn't frighten him. Something inside him tells him that, even if he were to fall, his new body would support him, protect him.

He felt *invincible*.

Kyle Hagget, professional nobody, official butt of every joke, was finally *somebody*.

He lunges with the sword again, striking an invisible enemy down, and he feels another laugh bubble from his massive chest.

He felt like he could take on the world. He felt like he could single-handedly defeat the Rebellion, or… he could take down the Horde. He could take himself and his friends to the top, could single-handedly drive them to complete and total success, could protect them all from anything and everything, he could—!

Something races past his heels through the trees shriek, and he startles back with a high pitched scream of terror, fumbling his

grip on the weapon. Something very clearly even bigger than whatever screamed also surges through the underbrush, and again he yelps and startles.

Time seems to slow for just a moment, as he scrambles to juggle back control of his sword. It slows even further, and he watches in horrified silence as the blade slips from his fingers, and tumbles over the side of the cliff.

Paling, he leans over the cliff face and watches the blade tumble through the air, getting smaller and smaller and smaller as it falls further and further and further away from him, until it disappears from view completely. Light explodes around him again, and when he blinks the spots out of his eyes, his new musculature is as gone as the sword.

…

…Um.

…….Well.

That was… very not great. Probably.

Definitely not great actually.

"Kyle!"

He jumps and whips around. Slowly prowling out of the shadows on all fours, a panting Catra steps into view, and he flinches with a strangled cry. There's blood smeared along her chin and caking her hands, but aside from her heavy breathing she's smiling proudly and seems fine.

That was definitely not her blood.

"Hey, stupid, get over here. I found dinner for us and you're gonna help me carry it."

Still thrown off by… everything, Kyle slowly points a finger at the cliff face.

"Did you… there was… I was… did you see…?"

Catra raises a brow at him. "What? Did a giant bird almost mistake you for prey and now you're too scared to move? Seriously, Kyle, I can't carry *all* of this. You might as well make yourself useful *somehow*."

With that, she turns back into the trees, not even waiting to see if he follows.

For a moment, Kyle just stands there, unsure of how to proceed. At *all*. For some reason, dropping that sword felt like more than just a lost opportunity for him.

It kinda felt like he'd just done something world-shatteringly wrong.

With shaking, unsteady footsteps, he plods after the pleased feline, hoping his gut was just churning because of the stench of blood and not because he'd just accidentally doomed all of existence.

• ✨ 🌈 🚀 •

It's been four months since Kyle both found and lost his sword, and the feeling that he messed up worse than ever before hasn't gone away.

I… really should tell someone, he tells himself, pacing in the locker room and fidgeting with the bandage around his wrist. The rest of the squad—well, Adora had gone missing, so it would be the rest of the squad minus her—would be coming in any minute to discuss some super important news concerning the new eight foot tall glowy princess. If he was going to bring up his own sword, now would… *probably* be the best time.

Well, no. The best time would have been four months ago when they'd all been gathered around a fire the day he'd lost the sword, eating the animals Catra had hunted down.

But this would be the second best time.

If they could go back out and find *his* sword, maybe… maybe this new princess wouldn't be such a scary threat? He could help. He could be beyond useful. He could—

The door to the locker room shoots open, and Lonnie storms in, looking for all the world like a woman about to commit manslaughter. Barely a second later, Rogelio shuffles in, not nearly as murderous but still clearly upset if the low growling was anything to go off of.

Kyle swallows, and lifts a finger to tentatively propose his plan, and finally reveal the secret he's been lugging around for ages.

Lonnie surges past him so violently she almost bowls him over as she nears her locker and rips it open.

"Adora found a *stupid*—" she slams her fist into the lockers, drowning out her probable cussing while also leaving a massive dent for some other soldier to find later "—sword in the middle of *absolutely*—" the dent grows bigger "—*nowhere* and it turned her into that *stupid golden princess* that's been wreaking havoc."

Kyle immediately yanks back his hand and purses his lips as tightly as he can manage.

Maybe, he thinks to himself as Lonnie's rage starts to burn so bright it's honestly shocking she doesn't light anything on fire, *I should just… pretend like… my thing never actually happened.*

And so, he does.

Chapter End Notes

I was STRUGGLING for an idea for this AU prompt and then remembered that whole “what if Kyle was actually He-Man” thing and THEN thought up “Kyle is He-Man; he knows this; no one else does; he loses the sword”

And I knew I had to do that bc me and my friend both died laughing at the idea

Alt. Canon - What If?

Chapter Notes

> I wrote this one and edited this and the previous chapter all while watching the Epic: The Musical's livestream
>
> The Vengeance Saga was truly EPIC (lol) and IT RELEASES TOMORROW YOU SHOULD GO GET IT BC I CERTAINLY AM

See the end of the chapter for more notes

They all just.

Kept.

Barking.

"How do we get them to *stop?!*" Scorpia warbles, pacing anxiously in front of the three very snarly and bitey animals they'd only just barely managed to smuggle in here. "If Catra finds out there's no *way* she'll let us keep them around!"

Much as she hated to say it, Entrapta wasn't much help. With her hands clamped down over her ears, she yells above the barking, "I have no idea! I've never worked with canines before, and anytime I attempted to research them I'd always get sidetracked!"

Scorpia laughs, a little unhinged and a lot stressed out. This… wasn't great. She and Entrapta (and Emily) were out scavenging an abandoned princess town, one that Catra assumed might have supplies they could make use of. It was a creepy old place, and when Catra said abandoned she *meant* abandoned, which, in Scorpia's opinion, only added to the creepiness. A lot. But she'd been wise to suggest the place. They'd found all sorts of supplies that would be more than beneficial to the Horde's forces; crates full of exported materials, trinkets that Entrapta had ecstatically lit up at upon seeing that she'd been confident she could use in her

inventions and experiments, food stores and leather working supplies…

And in the middle of it all, three unconscious and roughed up dogs, two female and one male.

Obviously, they hadn't been able to just *leave* them there.

But she got the sneaking suspicion Catra would definitely not feel the same way.

"I promise promise promise we're not going to hurt you!" Scorpia shouts over the barking. If they kept this up it wouldn't be just Catra who had a problem. "We just wanted to help you! We're plenty friendly! We can take great care of you!"

"Try feeding them again!" Entrapta cries, shoving a bowl full of dog food (they'd been really lucky with all the stuff they were able to find in that place) into Scorpia's pincers with her pigtails, her hands still pressed against her ears.

Smiling in an attempt to come off as un-threatening as possible, Scorpia hurries the food over to the dogs and places it down before them.

The smallest of the three lunges with a frenzied snarl when she gets close enough, and attempts to sink her teeth into Scorpia's pincer. She fails, and just keeps snapping and biting at her until finally she stands back up, raising both pincers in the air.

"See?! We're not going to hurt ya! We're just trying to help you!"

But all three dogs fully ignore the kibble, and instead just continue snarling and barking. One of them, the muscley golden dog, even angrily shoves at the bowl with her snout, sending its contents flying all over the room before she keeps snapping and lunging at Scorpia. All three of them are yanking at their restraints, and Scorpia wondered worriedly if any of them were strong enough to snap them.

“There’s gotta be some way to calm them down!” she worries. “If they keep yanking at their restraints like that, they’re gonna hurt themselves!”

Entrapta makes a concerned sound. “They turned down both the water and the food?! What else do dogs need? Affection?”

Even just the word seems to aggravate them further, and Scorpia leans away. “I don’t think they want me petting them right now!”

“Try… eh…”

Scorpia lights up. “Maybe I can sing to them! They might like it enough to calm down and realize we’re not their enemies!”

Entrapta beams up at her. “Anything is worth trying once!”

Turning back to the dogs, Scorpia sucks in a deep breath—

Only for it all to come rushing out of her as she hears the doors to their enclosure shoot open as Catra storms in.

“What in the name of Etheria and its twelve moons is causing all that racket?!” the feline shouts, and Scorpia wilts at the anger and frustration in her tone. She stomps into view, fury in her eyes. “I can hear that all the way down in the galley! What the hell are you two do—”

Her eyes find the dogs, and widen as her feet suddenly stall.

“Look okay wait I *know* this doesn’t look great!” Scorpia scrambles to explain before the wildcat could say anything. “But you gotta understand, they needed our help! They were *abandoned*, Wildcat. We think they used to belong to the princesses, and whenever they left behind that village town thing they also left behind these poor guys!” She thinks she sees something soften in Catra’s eyes when she emphasizes this, and so surges ahead just in case her mind *wasn’t* playing tricks on her. “I know they’re a little rowdy right now, and I *swear* we’re doing everything we can think of to get them to calm down, and I know that once we

figure it out they'll be the sweetest sweethearts ever, and dogs are super loyal so I bet we could train them to do all sorts of things, we just gotta get 'em calm first and then we can—!"

"You're never gonna *get* them calm if you keep freaking out like that," Catra scorns, before reaching out her hands to grab both Scorpia and Entrapta by the shirts and yanking them away. She drags them almost halfway across the room before finally letting them both go and folding her arms. "Seriously. You're both stressing *me* out. It's no wonder those things are losing their minds." She looks back at the canines over her shoulder and smirks. "And would you look at that, they're already way quieter."

Scorpia blinks in surprise and watches as the feline slowly stalks over to the open bag of dog food, all three dogs eyeing her warily. They… *had* calmed down. The smaller one was still growling, but the other two were… *just* watching.

Huh.

Catra grabs at the thrown bowl and carries it over to where the food resided. With it filled to the brim again, she takes it—careful and slow—back to the dogs, but stops when she's a few feet away to slowly fall to her knees. She pins her ears back, though it doesn't seem like it's out of fear. She slowly pushes the bowl to the dogs, and though all three remain defensive and wary, they don't lunge for her like they had with Scorpia. Well, the smallest one does, sort of. She steps forward and growls even louder, barking a few times to ward Catra off.

When Catra slowly retreats, respecting the dogs' space, the barking stops again.

Catra slowly straightens once she's several feet away and rolls her eyes when she sees the other two gawking at her.

"Did either of you even try paying attention to them? They were all pretty clearly saying 'hey, don't come near me, I feel uncomfortable and scared! Stay away or I'll rip your throats out!'"

She pinches the bridge of her nose and sighs, rubbing at her eyes. "Can't really blame them, either. If they *were* princess dogs, this is probably the most abrupt change of pace there is to be had."

Scorpia audibly coos in awe. "You're amazing, you know that?"

Catra gives her a look. "It's just body language. All three of them had their ears pinned and tails tucked, all three of them were being as vocal as can be—to my knowledge, animals like these guys usually *aren't*—and they were all trying to get away from you. The more you pay attention, the better off you and the animals will all be."

"How do you know all of that? I didn't think you've ever had a dog before."

Catra gives her another look, a different one that feels a lot more annoyed and exasperated. Both of Catra's ears flick, and her tail lashes behind her. "Gee. I wonder why I, of all people, would understand that body language is important and needs to be respected. It's a mystery."

"…so you *did* have a dog?"

It almost feels like even the dogs sigh in exasperation.

• ✨ 🌈 🚀 •

All three of them sigh in exasperation.

"She's not… is she serious?"

Adora huffs and finally gives into the desire to sit. "How the hell are these the same people that we've only just barely secured any of our victories from? Seriously. How."

"I don't even *like* Catra and I still understood immediately why she was the one to get the hint and leave us alone."

“I miss being able to talk,” Bow whimpers, flumping down and ignoring the dog food. None of them were all that enthusiastic about eating it. “I wanna thank her for getting the other two to stop, and then beg them for help.”

Glimmer scoffs and turns to scuff her paws at the trio. “Even if they could hear us, why would they help? If they ever figure out who we are, that’s the end of the rebellion. You can’t tell me Catra wouldn’t pounce on that opportunity faster than a cat with a mouse.”

Adora doesn’t respond. The moment Catra had walked in, her entire focus had been entirely on her. She’d been too freaked out between becoming a dog and waking up back in the Horde to realize that being back meant she would see Catra again, but with her so close…

She wasn’t surprised that the feline was so kind with them. To her, they were just a random bunch of dogs. Dogs weren’t manipulative. They couldn’t pretend to be one way and actually be another. They weren’t cruel or monstrous or cold. Dogs were just dogs.

Catra had no reason to hate dogs.

Adora hates that she all of a sudden feels stupidly jealous over these three dogs despite being one of them.

She hadn’t realized the Horde soldiers had continued past Scorpia’s blunder and continued talking until the scorpioni and the scientist had turned back to continue watching them. They both looked terrifyingly excited.

“So…” Scorpia shares a smile with Entrapta. “Can we keep them, then?”

Catra turns back to eye the dogs. Once again, her eyes turn soft as she looks them all over. All of her softens, in a way Adora hasn’t seen in what felt like years. Maybe it had been that long. Seeing the way she watches them, with clear calm and

consideration and *care* in her eyes, makes Adora's heart ache. She knows those eyes would be cold as ice if she knew the truth.

Part of her still wishes she knew anyway.

"You said they were abandoned by the princesses?" Catra hums. Scorpia nods.

"Sure looked like it. That place has been empty for months."

Slowly, Catra smirks, but the rest of her remain soft. "Well then. Sounds like they'll fit right in with the three of us."

Glimmer groans and Bow sighs mournfully… but the tip of Adora's tail tentatively wags.

Chapter End Notes

> This is ANOTHER one of my pre-existing AUs that I really want to flesh out and do in fact have more plans for
>
> It is also HEAVILY inspired by an ALTA fic I found and fell in love with where the Gaang are turned into turtleducks and accidentally wind up in Zuko's care even as he continues hunting them down (I don't remember the name right now but I will update this with the name and author as soon as I do)
>
> I wanted to do that but with Catra and the BFS instead and am REALLY hoping I find time to do more with this AU, she picks out names for them and everything
>
> Dog Person Catra ftw 🙌

Alt. Canon - Back In Time

Chapter Notes

HAPPY HALLOWEEN GUYS GALS AND NONBINARY PALS

Honestly, I don't have much else to say that I haven't already said a thousand times

Thank you all so SO incredibly much for any comments, kudos, or any spec of attention you gave these little prompts, all of whom were inspired by the AU-ctober prompts made by the amazing ZullieFomx

This was such a fun experience, and being able to successfully get a prompt written every single day, no matter how hard it was to do so, was so worth it

I hope you guys enjoy this last prompt, and I hope you'll tune in to any future projects I write

Happy Halloween!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

She was beginning to truly doubt that all of this was legitimately necessary.

Hefting the (already pretty full) bag over her shoulder that Razz had lent her, Mara sighs and looks back down at the list she'd also been given. She'd gotten a handful of items secured already, checking them off as she went; echovian ivy, sap from a hollow blackwood, a basket full of river berries, another basket full of vine-grown berries (along with explicit instructions to keep the two types of berries as separate as could be), seven thick strips of indigo bark, five hefty bundles of wood for the fire, and finally a few starhorned rabbits.

Indigo bark had given her a surprising amount of trouble, somehow even more than the river berries and the rabbits. She really hoped it was one of the genuinely necessary items and wasn't just some kind of special spice or something for dinner tonight. Even if it was, she likely wouldn't be upset for long—it wasn't just the two of them, after all—but… still.

She still had a few more things she needed to collect before she could head back, but this latest one was getting close to giving her as much trouble as the bark had.

Razz's list showed a picture of a pumpkin. Or… some kind of… blue pumpkin. It was *probably* a pumpkin, at least, but it was a little different than the ones she'd seen on Eternia. The list said she needed to collect four of them, for… something. She wasn't quite sure what. Maybe it would be for more tonic stuff? Their little guests were both doing significantly better than they'd been in the early days, but neither were at 100% yet. Mara knew that's what at least a handful of these supplies were for, but the pumpkins were a little bamboozling, she had to admit.

Especially since she *had* finally found *something* resembling the picture, but couldn't figure out if it was actually a match or not.

Razz hadn't said if *all* of these pumpkin things were blue, or if they were *supposed* to come in different colors. The patch that she'd stumbled across had some that were as blue as the image, but there were also several that were closer to green, some that were purple, and even a few that were maroon. After looking between the image and the patch for a few seconds, Mara just sighs and shifts her sword into a knife. She'd just get a few of each, and if needed she could come back. Or… keep looking if she was wrong entirely and these weren't what Razz wanted.

With the gourds secured—one maroon, one blue, one purple, and one green—she again hefts the bag, and turns to keep looking for the last of the supplies she hadn't found yet.

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Three of the nightmoons have taken place in the sky by the time Mara makes it back to Razz' hut. She smiles when she steps into the clearing and finds the boar she'd befriended snoozing on its side close by, peacefully twitching in a dream. The beast stirs as she approaches the hut, but every single eye it has lights up as soon as it recognizes her. Unable to help herself, Mara smiles and takes a quick second to step over and give the beast some loving pets and scratches, and she laughs as it groans happily and leans into the affection.

"Mara?" Razz' voice softly calls from the entrance. Mara turns to find the old woman poking her head out, waving expectantly at her once she can see the motion. "What are you doing, silly girl? Come inside! We have much to do!"

Mara quickly gives the boar just a few more pets before following Razz in.

She lets out a pleased sigh as she finally shucks off the bag and lets it plop to the floor, carefully setting everything else that hadn't fit into it down beside it. She stretches out her back with a gentle groan and lifts her arms above her head. She could carry a lot without issue, but even she couldn't go hours on end without feeling a little sore afterward.

A hand whips out to speedily cover her mouth the moment she opens it to speak. She startles, but Razz doesn't move away. Mara raises a questioning eyebrow, and in response Razz lifts a finger to her own lips, urging her to stay quiet. Confused, she nods, and the old woman slowly pulls back with a pleased hum.

"The children are finally asleep," she mumbles with a smile, giving Mara an answer before she could even ask her question. Her mouth forms an "o" and her shoulders relax. For a moment, she'd worried there was trouble.

"How are they doing?"

A giddy twitter. "Come see for yourself, dearie."

The hut was a cramped little space, but even still they'd somehow managed to set up another few mattresses beside Razz' once their little guests had shown up. Despite herself, Mara softens at the sight of the two of them curled up, obviously on the same mattress and cuddled so tightly together that it was almost impossible to tell the two of them apart.

Mara slowly walks over to sit beside the two. "They're looking a lot better. That's good. How long have they been asleep?"

Razz hums as she begins exploring Mara's findings. "Not long before you got back. Honestly, Mara, could you move any slower?"

She snorts and rolls her eyes. "Just following the list. That should be everything. I gotta ask though, what are the pumpkins for?"

"For carving, silly! A delightful activity for all four of us, don't you think?"

Mara laughs softly and nods in agreement, her fingers gentle as they trace down the younglings' cheeks. Two months ago, doing this would definitely have had them both shooting awake, bright eyed and panicked and ready to rip whoever dared touch them to shreds. Now though, the only reactions the tender touch elicits are a happy hum from the blonde and a sleepy trilling purr from the brunette.

If one had told her even just half a year ago that two of the most important figures in Etheria's future would one day be dropped into her care as children with absolutely no warning, she wouldn't have believed it. The warning would have been nice, though, it might have staved off the panic attack she'd suffered when all of that had in fact happened.

Catra and Adora. The two who, supposedly, were meant to one day save the world.

The two who were supposed to fix the mistakes she was doomed to make in trying to save it herself.

Her smile fades, as it always does anytime she lets her mind linger on what their arrival, what their *existence*, meant for hers.

"Ooh!" Razz cheers by the entrance. "You found the starhorns! Well done, dearie, that will be the perfect surprise for those two to wake up to!"

Mara hums. Her eyes don't leave the kids, even as the old woman continues blabbering excitedly about her plans for everything Mara had gathered together. Her words begin to blur, as Mara's focus wholly centers itself on the two girls.

She hadn't… meant to come to care for them this deeply.

When Razz had first revealed them to her and she'd managed to get past her terror, she'd learned the hard way that neither of them were exactly all that trusting of adults of any kind. Especially not magic ones. Both of these facts made helping both of them with their staggering number of injuries *much* more difficult…

But it had been worth it, taking the time to earn their trust first. Almost too much. They had some length to go still, before Adora and especially Catra trusted them completely, but they'd already come so far. The kids were healing, even without Mara's magic. Whatever had brought them here couldn't have brought them sooner. Whoever had been raising them hadn't actually, they'd been torturing them. Every time Mara saw either of them take another step towards being healthy and happy, she only grew that much more attached.

And that much more terrified of what it would mean for any of them.

"You keep worrying about the future so much, and you're going to miss the present."

Mara glances back. Razz is watching her, a soft, sad smile on her wrinkly old face.

“It is understandable that you are afraid,” she hums as she hobbles over to rejoin the other three. She rests a hand on Mara’s tired shoulder. “And I am not cooky enough to dare suggesting that there is no good reason for that fear. But… I do suggest that, for now, you simply try living in the moment. Be with the girls. Be there for them. Let them be there for you.”

Mara sighs again. “You’re right, and I know you are. But I can’t… I don’t know how to stop being afraid.”

“You can’t stop it,” she shakes her head. “And it is not meant to be stopped. The more you try, the more persistently it will cling to you.” She laughs. “Much like young Catra whenever we try keeping the blueberries away.”

A laugh bubbles from her chest, and though it’s quick to fade, a hesitant smile remains. “What do I do, Razz? What am I supposed to do?”

Razz’s other hand comes up to rest on her other shoulder, and she feels a gentle kiss being pressed into the side of her head.

”Let the feelings come and go as they please. They will only stay as long as they need to.”

Taking in a long, slow breath, Mara nods.

And she tries.

Chapter End Notes

> Shoutout to anxious mama Mara, we stan our absolute queen of queens 👏👏👏
>
> I’m REALLY hoping the notes thing is fixed now that the fic is complete, we’ve had so many people making out and getting interrupted with a chainsaw smh 😔 that was only supposed to happen once

End Notes

they start making out in the corn maze right as a guy with a chainsaw runs up to them

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!